What Became of the Likely Lads?

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What Became of the Likely Lads?

by alozizam

Summary

Years after securing victory on the Astral Fantasia stage, Phainon and Mydei have become successful figures in Amphoreus's music scene. Separately, but still successful. Amphoreus is big enough that they never have to run into each other, and they're too busy to ever think much of it.

With the incoming 10 year anniversary of their winning song, a decade long streak might meet its end. Surely they can be adults about the whole thing.

Chapter 1: Side A

Chapter Notes

> This was supposed to be a one-shot published before 3.3. Best I could do is multi-chapter around the 3.4 drop, chief.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A bouncy synth line yowls in the background of the news report, accompanied by footage of a busy stage. The newscaster's voice is a diminutive buzz next to the music; not by any fault of the sound mixing, no, but by the sheer audacity of stuffing woodwinds, guitar riffs, and early electronica into a single caffeine-addled pop song.

"…marks almost a decade since our last Astral Fantasia win. That's right, Euphrosyne by Sun and Thunder is turning ten this year, which also means it's been ten years since Amphoreus has podiumed-"

The song teeters between unpleasant and frustratingly catchy, staying in the middle just enough to be considered 'refreshingly novel'. Truthfully, it's not a complicated thing to play. If you listen past the riffs and the licks, there are only four chords used in the entirety of *Euphrosyne*. Nothing flashy either. No diminished chords or major sevenths or anything so ambitious. It was kept simple to match the lyrics: a banal 3 minute campaign urging crowds to get up and dance.

Perhaps if it had been sung by the usual suspects, it wouldn't have gotten nominated to join an international competition, let alone crowned as its best song. Instead, the clip showed a teenager performing his soul out on stage, donning a grin so boyishly charming that you could have heard the hearts of every teenage girl in Asdana break. He should have been a spokesman for a sports drink or something like that; extolling the benefits of electrolytes as he ran up and down the stage, sweat flinging this way and that with each backflip he attempted.

The most impressive part is how the teenager managed to sing above the din of the band behind him. His voice was a paradoxically sweet tenor, clear and invigorating, like a glass of cold water. It cut through the noise and tethered each meandering instrument into a single cohesive melody. There were the occasional flubs of course, with him dancing all over the stage, but nothing so disgraceful as a full voice crack.

Another voice occasionally joined in, perhaps a contingency plan in case a bad somersault took their main singer out. The energetic frontman never stayed in one place for too long, but if he had to, he'd settle down next to the other teenage boy on stage, who stood rooted in his spot. It would be difficult for him to move in the same manner, being preoccupied by his guitar and all.

His voice wasn't any much lower than the other, but it was raspier, as if he'd forgotten to drink the entire day. The teenage girls that would have scoffed at the first one for being too clean-cut would have swooned at the sight of the second. He glared at any camera that pointed at him, but his teenybopper sensibilities declawed any threat he could possibly embody.

It was all a precarious balancing act, one that's beginning to show its age. As the two boys harmonized into the same microphone, the sound of stifled laughter cut them off.

"Aw for Kephale's sake Cyrene, do you have to watch that?"

A full blown laugh bursts out of Cyrene's mouth as her brother strides into the room and callously shuts off the television. He pulls a baleful face to let her know how disheartened he was, but since Cyrene isn't a dog, the sight of a grown man pouting only exacerbates her guffaws.

"It's not everyday you're on the news," Cyrene says once she weans off the laughter.

"Hey, knock on wood! I don't want to be on the news. You know how celebrities get on the news? Career-ending scandals and lawsuits. Or like, death or something."

Point taken. Still, you can't blame Cyrene for trying to take her little brother down a peg. Even now, in the sanctity of their parents' home, Phainon is dressed in colors that only match with chromatopsia. No matter what basic sense dictates, he insists he pulls off the purple pants, that it's more Prince than Wonka. Up top isn't any better. His pastel turquoise polo plunges into a deep V-neck that makes Cyrene wish for a lobotomy, and all the extra fabric gets wasted into giving Phainon a collar that makes him look like a cartoon supervillain. It's like he doesn't know whether or not he wants people to look at his neck, and it would have stayed a mystery if not for that orange-as-hell tattoo.

Hmm, then again, Phainon's never been much of a dresser. Did Cyrene ruin his chances at a normal life when she had that Cheetah Girls phase and decided that her brother should match with her?

No. It was the fame that did that. Cyrene is only a victim of this cruel system, while Phainon… well.

Over the past years, Phainon has carved out a home in the top charts, only being absent from the top 50 when he's on a break between albums. Turns out, the *Astral Fantasia Music Festival* had only been the start. After that, anything with his face or name on it sold like hotcakes, and his vocal cords went on to be insured for an amount that Cyrene cannot possibly fathom. Phainon is a sensation, and the masses will never get enough of him.

Of course, only in Amphoreus.

But nationwide stardom is still big shoes for a village boy to fill.

"I don't like how you're looking at me," Phainon says, crossing his arms. Thank god. That should give Cyrene a minute of freedom from his nip slips.

"Just thinking," Cyrene replies.

"About what?"

"'Bout that old acquaintance of yours," Cyrene says. "You know, about yay-high, strawberry blond, looks like this?"

Cyrene does her best blue steel impression, but it falls more like Marlon Brando in the first Godfather. Phainon rolls his eyes.

“Ha ha,” he deadpans. “No, really, what’s on your mind?”

“Okay, I was thinking that, maybe, we *shouldn’t* dress like a gigolo when we celebrate mom’s birthday,” Cyrene says.

Phainon frowns as he gives her a once-over. “But you’re not dressed like a gigolo?”

“Really now? Did you turn into a vampire?” Cyrene asks, squinting. “Are mirrors not working for you or something?”

“Your mom said I look nice!”

“Mom’s from the seventies! You should run if she says you look nice! You’re going to be in photos next to Aunt Evi in her mumu and you’re going to look like the ghost of her dead boy toy-”

Later, when she’s two bowls deep in stew, Cyrene remembers her brother’s wandering attention span, and how easy it usually is to re-direct him from the topic at hand.

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The television turns off, and Krateros turns to the man reclining on the couch.

“What do you think?” Krateros asks, something expectant looming in his tone.

The other man simply scratches his head. “I think the new song needs some cowbell.”

Krateros sighs. “You know that’s not what I’m talking about, Mydei.”

Mydei hums, but offers nothing else. What is there to say about news correspondents discussing an old song? Must be a slow news day if that's what they're broadcasting.

"It's been ten years since the Fantasia win," Krateros prompts. "That's ten years since you've been out of the spotlight."

"I'm aware," Mydei answers.

"Don't you want to… try coming back? See if you still got it?"

"I'm not interested in petty cash grabs." Mydei says, getting straight to the point. "And I was never interested in performing in front of a live audience."

"Right. I understand."

Krateros drops it, but he continues to avoid Mydei's gaze. A melodrama plays on the older man's face, his features twisting into grief and pity between forced intervals of stoicism. As funny as it was, it's no laughing matter when it's at Mydei's expense.

Mydei sighs out loud. "I'm telling the truth."

"I believe you." Krateros keeps the act up for a brief second longer, only to crumble when Mydei adds a touch of force in his glare. He lets out a sigh of his own. "Isn't it unfair? That boy gets to ride out the success you paved for him, while people forget you even contributed at all…?"

"I consider that ideal actually," Mydei says. "I've seen what the attention gets him. It's not like my songs aren't popular either."

"The *songs* are popular. The songs rise right up to number one and get all the air time they deserve, but never with your name. They're always attached to some pop star or a minute-fourteen singer who can never hold a candle to the original demo."

"You can always find my name on the ASCAP listing."

Judging from the look Krateros gives him, Mydei was beginning to grate on his nerves. Fortunately for him, Krateros always has some patience set aside for bullheaded songwriters.

“I think you deserve more credit than you’re currently getting,” Krateros says. “You’ve got a bunch of drafts in your back pocket that you never pitch. Like that one, about the ankles-”

“I’ve never written anything about ankles.”

“You know which one I mean. You didn’t even want to play it in full in front of me.”

“Because it was incomplete.”

“But it was great! Unfinished or not, it was way better than the throwaways you’ve been giving away,” Krateros says. “Are you telling me, that there’s not even a tiny part of you that wants to be proud of your own work?”

Mydei could readily say that he always takes pride in his songs, but even when he’s playing the fool, he understands Krateros’s words all too well. Ah, no matter. Even with the implications of Mydei’s silence, Krateros wouldn’t act on it. What is there for him to do, other than to proselytize on online music forums?

Instead, Mydei hums. “A cowbell between the hook and the chorus could give the transition more oomph.”

And because Mydei’s agent has never been anything less than supportive, Krateros holds back his grumbles. “Do you want me to search for a physical cowbell or do you have one already?”

As he plots the additions to his percussions, Mydei allows himself to wonder. What would taking advantage of the anniversary look like? It is true that Mydei was a part of that victory, but he didn’t achieve it on his lonesome. Nor was he the one in high demand. To release an acknowledgement on his own would be like chucking a pebble onto a typhoon; insignificant, and more effort than it’s worth.

Still, he can’t help but imagine. If Mydei would ask, what would Phainon say about a reunion?

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“You’re kidding.”

“Do I look like I’m joking?” Anaxa asks. Frankly, he looks like he just stepped in dog doo-doo, but that’s just his default expression.

“I thought Lygus said it was ‘tacky’,” Phainon presses, leaning forward on Anaxa’s desk. “That it would ‘muddle the brand’ if we did something with Sun and Thunder?”

“Then that should tell you that Lygus wasn’t the one who made this decision,” Anaxa says matter-of-factly. He gives Phainon a sneer that makes Phainon feel like a regressed species. “The higher-ups thought it would be - *ugh* - “‘fun”’ to have you cavort with your old playmate on a morning show or two. They dubbed it an ‘era of reflection’, whatever that means.”

“But, like, we’re not even signed to the same label.”

Anaxa’s patronizing tone deepens. “I know you’re Grove’s show pony, but surely you know you can collaborate with anybody, right? There’s no clause in your contract stating you can only work with the other sycophants.”

Phainon does know that. He did that one feature an eon ago with that rapper from Belobog, and the song was enough of an ear worm to see rotation in some niche clubs. As far as Phainon was aware, the feature was a success, but nowhere near as successful as *Grove Records* hoped it would be. Everyone learned then that the international market wasn’t something so easily breached, and any plans of joining forces with other musical acts got shelved for the foreseeable future.

Perhaps they’ve finally ventured into the unforeseeable future then? Or maybe there really is money in being tacky and pandering. Go figure.

“I don’t think Mydei would agree,” Phainon says. God, it’s been ages since he’s said that name proper. The muscles that sound out the syllables must have atrophied, because it comes out in a stuttered choke.

This moment of weakness will bite him in the ass one day, as they always do when Anaxa is watching, but for now, his manager extends him a rare mercy. “We’ve already reached out to his handlers,” Anaxa says. “And they gave us the green light.”

“But what about Mydei?”

Anaxa leans back in his chair. “He said something interesting, which is why you’re standing here instead of getting shoved into a recording suite without prior notice.”

“…He told us no?”

A twisted smirk creeps onto Anaxa’s face. “He told us to ask Phainon.”

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Four months sounds like an ample period of time, but they still need to decide on the scope of the project, on the studios and session players to book, of the venues and sponsors to prioritize. If it was a deadline that can be pushed, then perhaps it wouldn’t be so dire, but there’s only one day out of all the days in the space of forever that marks *Euphrosyne*’s tenth anniversary.

There is definitely no time for both central figures to play hot potato with the final say, pushing the responsibility onto the other through a chain of increasingly tedious e-mails. The local fruit basket industry has never seen such a meteoric rise in their commerce. Dictionaries and thesauruses have been run ragged in the quest for new, innovative ways to say ‘maybe’.

This game of chicken comes to a head one cloudy afternoon, in the underground parking lot of Mydei’s workplace. He spots a shock of ivory

hair half hidden behind a concrete foundation and the expletive shoots out of his mouth before he could stop it: “Son of a bitch.”

“Actually, it’s Phainon,” the demon says, a million dollar smile magically materializing on his face. “What should I call you, stranger?”

Mydei doesn’t respond, opting instead to leg it to his car a little faster. He doesn’t openly run because that would be admitting defeat, which ironically proves to be his downfall. Unlike him, Phainon is amenable to going into a full sprint indoors, so Mydei inevitably finds himself playing point guard to Phainon’s defense.

“I’m busy,” Mydei says as he attempts to step around Phainon, who hops right into place in front of him.

“So am I, but I can’t get any work done until I get either a ‘yes’ or ‘no’,” Phainon explains.

Mydei looks around to find neither hide nor hair of Phainon’s security detail. This is bad. Mydei can’t be alone with Phainon like this. He feigns left to pass around him, but the bastard blocks him in time with an outstretched leg.

“My side called last,” Mydei argues.

“Oh yeah, because ‘close affirmation’ is such a conclusive reply,” Phainon drawls.

“And ‘it’s schedule determinant’ isn’t?”

“It’s a reason.” Phainon shoves Mydei back when he tries to brute force his way through. “I told you, I’ve got things to do. I can’t go forward with any of them if I don’t get a confirmation.”

“Then confirm it, dumbass.”

“I’m being considerate to your schedule.”

“My schedule? You think I’m more booked than the guy selling out arenas?”

Mydei catches Phainon’s wrist when the pop star goes for another shove, and Phainon retaliates by grabbing Mydei’s arm. “You literally just said you’re busy,” Phainon points out.

“Because I have a *job*,” Mydei growls. “Same as you. Same as everyone you’re screwing over because you can’t make up your mind!”

“The fuck?” Phainon laughs in anger. “The pot calling me indecisive?”

Mydei pushes back against Phainon’s lunges. “Aren’t you? You could have ended it all with one word.”

“Oh you’d like that, wouldn’t you? So I get blamed if shit goes sideways?”

“Who gives a shit? The Okhema times? Sorry if the headlines don’t personally suck your dick this one time.”

“That’s fine with me. If you’re lucky, maybe you’ll get a shout out in the article. Aww, baby’s first mention in anything relevant ever!”

“Fuck you.”

“Stole the words right out o- mMPH!” A palm shoots out and covers Phainon’s mouth, fiercely gripping onto his jaw as if Mydei wanted to smush the bone underneath into jam. Phainon starts punching at Mydei’s arm for freedom, and when that doesn’t work, he reaches under and plucks a pinch of Mydei’s armpit hair.

“Shit!” Mydei immediately draws back.

“That’s what you get for wearing a muscle shirt to work,” Phainon says. “You don’t have good air circulation in here or what?”

There was no need for further heckling, because Mydei is back on Phainon in a flash, fists and elbows everywhere it could land. Phainon blocks as

many hits as he can between his own occasional punches, making sure that wherever he strikes, it would sting like a bitch.

They were surprisingly even in strength, despite Mydei having worked his physique into idealistic proportions. Phainon, for all his jumping and gyrating on stage, had developed a practical set of muscles that functioned as good as they looked, and they were holding their own against Mydei's brutal pounding.

Eventually it devolves once more into juvenile shoving and pushing, and when a particularly forceful thrust topples one onto the ground, the other follows suit with a straddle. The two of them continued to tussle on the floor, collecting scratches from rolling to and fro on the asphalt.

"Hello? Excuse me?"

The sound of a new voice forces Phainon and Mydei to look up. An elderly security guard stands there, tutting at the sight of of them. Understandable. There's nothing dignified about Phainon sitting on top of Mydei, his hands holding tight to fistfuls of stained blond hair while the man underneath tries to kick his spine in.

"Is this really the best way to handle this?" The security guard asks. His voice is soft and wheezy, as if he's perpetually out of breath.

The two men immediately jump up from the ground, frantically dusting off whatever debris they've accumulated. Phainon was the first to interject: "He started it!"

"So you should stoop to his level?" The guard chastises before turning to the other grown adult. "And Mydei. I know you never let emotions get the better of you. How could you do this?"

Mydei's skin takes on a reddened flush. "I didn't ask for a fight! If he'd just lea-"

"None of that now," the guard cuts him off. "The 'if' isn't important when it already happened."

Mydei's shoulders slump. "Sorry."

"I'm not the one you should be saying that to. What if a car came over and couldn't see you? You two could have gotten seriously hurt!"

"We won't do this ever again, sir," Phainon sheepishly promises. "It just got a little heated there for a moment, is all."

The security guard shakes his head. "No matter how badly you disagree with each other, you should never let it get physical. Why, the wife and I have had plenty of arguments over the years, all more serious than whatever this tiff could be about. Not once have I ever thought of laying my hands on her."

Phainon stammers. "I mean, she's your wife-"

"Now more than ever, we need to practice kindness towards our fellow man," the guard preaches. "Male, female, neither, both… Whether she's your wife or your mortal enemy, everyone loses when we take up violence."

"Agreed," Mydei mumbles.

The guard crosses his arms. "If you really agree, the both of you would apologize to each other."

That fails to earn a single twitch from either Phainon or Mydei.

"Go on," the guard coaxes. "If a car were to drive into one of you and fatally injure him on the spot, the remaining one would regret not saying anything right now."

At that ominous warning, the two grown men in front of him stiffly turn to face one another. With each second that passed without a single word being uttered, the old man's disapproving stare grew heavier and heavier until Mydei broke.

"Sorry," he spits out.

“Me too,” Phainon grumbles. “Sorry.”

That gets the security guard nodding. “If that doesn’t bury the hatchet, then there’s this café, two blocks down towards the city center. It’s got good soup and better sandwiches. You go there, and you order the mezze platter, the one with the big sharing portion. I’m talking stuffed grape leaves, grilled shrimp, and a huge blooming onion. You get that, and you come out of there the best of friends.”

The next few minutes pass in a haze, where the two of them were listening to directions in one moment and sharing an elevator in the next. They’re way out on the street by the time they come to, toddling along side-by-side in silence. Mydei glances to the man next to him, only to find him glancing back.

That’s when the confused laughter breaks out.

“What the hell?” Mydei asks through his befuddled snickers.

“I don’t know,” Phainon says, also sounding very confused and giggly. “I don’t know where we’re going.”

It seems they’re going to a café. Thankfully there weren’t too many people out on the pavement, and the few that were didn’t recognize the man cackling boisterously through layers of grime. The cafeteria itself was somewhat busier, but Mydei tactfully uses his size to shield Phainon from as many eyes as possible.

They settle down at a booth tucked near the back, placing them precariously close to the restrooms. As they wait for someone to serve them, Phainon fishes out a ratty beanie from his cargo pockets and plops it on his mussed hair, fulfilling the joint purpose of indiscretion and vanity. It takes a good while for a server to notice their table, but Phainon and Mydei make it up by ordering before the server could take out the menu.

Silence is generally an awkward thing, but neither men had minded it on their trip to the cafeteria. Maybe they were busy thinking of the right thing to say, or maybe they’re steeling their courage to propose the wrong thing.

Either way, they're on the same page, and both seemed to agree that this silence is starting to get a little too long.

This time, Phainon is the one who starts. "So…"

"So," Mydei echoes.

"…Are you planning something in the next few months?" Phainon asks. "Like do you have another recording to do, or…?"

"Nothing," Mydei says. "What I do on a day-to-day basis is up to me. I might have a few mixes that need some refining, but nothing set in stone. You?"

"Brand deal," Phainon answers, slumping on the table. "Can't get into it, NDA stuff, but they probably won't mind nudging it a bit if we did the…"

Do the what? No one knows what they were even pestering each other about. *Grove* had their ideas, naturally, but as the negotiations dragged on, they stressed that they were open to accepting suggestions from Mydei. It seemed that the important thing was to get *Sun and Thunder* in the same room again, and then they can take control under the guise of everyone's tacit consent.

Mydei didn't dare think that *Grove* was actually going relinquish some of their authority, especially if it's to let him go wild on a project that had their biggest star attached. *Grove* might have been a welcoming no-name label back when Mydei was signed with them, but they've always been ambitious for more. With Phainon securing their growth year after year, Mydei suspects they're a little more comfortable with slinging their power around.

If they're really curious about what's planned for them, then there's an easy way for Phainon and Mydei to find out. It's just that once they agree, there's no backing out.

The sharing platter arrives, and as the server places it down, she makes eye contact with Phainon and lets out a small gasp. Phainon responds with a

wink, short-circuiting the poor server as she makes her escape back to the kitchen.

Mydei watches her as Phainon digs in. “Any time, any place, huh?” Mydei comments.

“For these meatballs? Absolutely.”

That security guard was right. It would difficult to be angry when there’s a dozen delicious little morsels to distract you. The dish came with a bevy of dips and sauces, and finding out which tastes best with what mezze is half the fun. That’s probably why it was made to share, for friends and family to discuss new culinary findings. Phainon and Mydei decided they’re better off with their own game, in which one pretends they haven’t paired together the most disgusting combination on the plate while the other tries to gulp it down without flinching.

The platter is soon reduced into crumbs and sad swipes of sauce, and the conversation that they deemed far too difficult to broach is no longer as daunting. As the plates and glasses get cleared away, Mydei decides that it’s better to rip the bandage clean rather than continue going around in circles.

“It wouldn’t be the worst thing to work with you again,” Mydei admits as they wait for the bill.

“Hffomp?” Phainon says, accidentally stabbing himself in the gums with a toothpick when he hears Mydei speak. He tries again once he disposes the toothpick into a piece of tissue. “You’re agreeing?”

“…Sure.”

“Really? *Really*, really? You mean it?”

Mydei shrugs. “If you’re not too busy.”

“Hmm, let me double check with my calendar…”

Phainon takes out his phone and begins to scroll, watching the way Mydei’s brows furrow from the corner of his eye. When Mydei’s lips also starts

curling downward, Phainon flings his phone to the side.

“Yeah, I’m free,” Phainon announces. With his elbow on the table, Phainon rests his chin on his palm and grins at Mydei. “What do you think we should do, big guy?”

Mydei’s looks over to the rest of the cafeteria, which is still very much bustling with customers. “I don’t think we should talk about that here.”

“Why not? Leaks hype people up don’t they?”

“Not this early it doesn’t,” Mydei says. “…Shouldn’t you have security guards telling you this or something?”

“I would have, usually, but I thought this was going to be a quick visit. Then you started punching me.”

“I didn’t start it.”

“To-may-to, to-mah-to.” Phainon waves Mydei’s excuses off. “The important thing is that we got things done, right?”

“Yes,” Mydei sighs. “Now the hard part begins.”

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There’s only one perfectly working eyeball between the two of them, but somehow, they manage to stare a hole into Phainon.

If there was ever a time for Phainon to use his God given good looks, it was now. He subtly tilts his head low - an angle that every photographer is obsessed with him holding still - and sweetens his tone as he asks, “Is something the matter?”

Across the meeting room table, Aglaea pinches the bridge of her nose. “You want to re-record Euphrosyne?”

“Yep.”

“And write a new song?” Anaxa asks.

“As Sun and Thunder, yes.”

“You might have gotten your wires crossed,” Aglaea says. “We’re not looking for a full reunion. Just a small bit of recognition for the fans who stuck with you from the beginning.”

“Yeah, and what better way to do that than to release something from the vault?”

“You specifically said it was going to be new,” Anaxa points out. “Also, if you did have an extra song lying around, I would have known about it ages ago.”

“It’s not with me,” Phainon explains. “And it would be new to the fans.”

Aglaea is shaking her heads before Phainon even finishes. “Sorry, but I don’t think anyone would agree to this. Please tell Mydeimos that we can’t meet his demands.”

“Whoa, hey now. I didn’t say it was only Mydei who wanted this.”

“Why would *you* want this?” Aglaea levels him with another scrutinizing stare. “Is Anaxagoras not bidding on enough songs for you?”

“I got him an army of producers on speed-dial, keep my name out of your mouth,” Anaxa remarks.

“Would it be so bad to have one more?” Phainon suggests.

“We planned for one song,” Aglaea points out. “The idea was to go big with marketing, getting it into advertising, soundtracks, remixes- Whatever fits with whatever you end up with. Another song means splitting our efforts.”

“They can already do that with Euphrosyne now. Wouldn’t it be easier to have a second one to widen the net?”

“It doesn’t have to be a remake of Euphrosyne if you’re so opposed.”

“But Euphrosyne is the Sun and Thunder song.”

“That’s why I’d prefer it to be the song you work on,” Aglaea says, a touch sterner. “A new song would be lovely, but our projected budget works best with one release.”

“So I’ll fund what’s missing,” Phainon proposes. “Tell the board that I’ll pay for it right out of my pocket, then you can let it slip to a journalist or a blogger that I’m personally financing a portion of the process. People will spin it as like, me investing in it so much because it’s a passion project, which would be a even bigger honor to the fans. It’s more exposure *and* we reduce the reviews calling us sell-outs.”

Aglaea’s mouth hangs very slightly agape. She glances at Anaxa, who looks affronted to meet her gaze.

“What are you looking at me for? You’re the one that taught him all that,” he says.

As Phainon’s publicist, it’s Aglaea’s job to make sure he looks good regardless of what he does. It is *not* Phainon’s job, because ‘looks good’ means figuratively and literally. Phainon’s taste for bright jerseys and rubber clogs would not mesh well with that requirement. His only saving grace is his above-average appearance, which turns every sartorial faux pas he makes into a fashion statement, much to Aglaea’s anguish. It is Aglaea’s deepest wish to never see him calling the shots from her position.

Nevertheless, Aglaea finds some joy in knowing that her words and actions have taught him to be a little more shrewd. “I will admit that you present a compelling strategy,” Aglaea says, adjusting her glasses. “However, it relies too much on optimistic risk assessment. There’s a real possibility that people might view you as a try-hard instead.”

“How? You’re really good at controlling the narrative,” Phainon says.

“Flatterer. Although I can’t promise I will always be so infallible."

“I think that still means it’s worth a try,” Phainon insists. “At this point, why not challenge ourselves?”

Aglaea and Anaxa exchange a look. Consensually this time. They appear doubtful, but the fact that they’re taking the time to think about it bodes well for Phainon.

“It’ll take some arguing with the bigwigs,” Anaxa warns Phainon before he gets too excited. “We might have some pull, but the executives don’t like taking risks like these.”

“How is it risky?” Phainon says. “We’re doing what they asked for and doubling it.”

“Let me ask you this.” Anaxa steeples his hands. “Do you think you’ll be able to make a good song? Better yet, do you think Gorgo’s brat can write a good song?”

Had Anaxa stopped at the first question, Phainon would have hesitated. It is to his luck that his manager continued, so Phainon can answer with the most affirmative nod he can muster. “Absolutely. Mydei can definitely write a good song.”

“Is he already writing one? Have you heard a snippet?” Anaxa questions.

“No, but he’s the one that wrote Euphro,” Phainon states. “He’s gotten ten years of experience since then, so I know he can pull it off.”

“In half a month, mind you,” Aglaea reminds him.

“He can do it. Just listen to the songs he’s put out, you’ll know he can do it.”

“God,” Anaxa sighs and rolls his good eye. “He’s gone full gaga for this guy.”

Phainon only smiles, because he doesn’t have to tell them *everything*.

—

Writing two songs in three weeks is impossible, but it was the hand he was dealt with, so Mydei grunts and bears it with grace.

For once, he's glad for his collection of abandoned songs, because now there's a way out of this hole. Sure, there's years of incomplete music to sift through and he doesn't remember all of them, but he's certain that he's got something stowed away for this exact occasion.

"Found anything yet?"

Mydei is folders deep in his computer when Phainon enters the room holding two mugs. Figgy takes this chance to weasel in, nearly bowling Phainon over to get to her spare dog bed. Without any more spontaneous mountain dogs to ambush him, Phainon decides to leave the door open to concentrate on transporting the mugs safely. He sets one down beside Mydei and squints at the screen, as if it could help him hear what Mydei's Sennheisers are playing.

This is another complication with the project. Since *Sun and Thunder* means Phainon and Mydei, the superstar apparently needs to be present for the conception of their new song. It means that sometimes Mydei has a babysitting job to do, and that sometimes he's got an extra laborer to exploit. Personally, it doesn't feel great to have Phainon listening in on his half-baked melodies, but at least he's got someone to deliver snacks for him.

"I haven't found it yet," Mydei says before taking a sip of his drink. It tastes of black tea, grenadine syrup, and clumped protein powder, which isn't good, but it's what Mydei deserves for taking advantage of this monkey's paw.

"What about the one you played before I left? I thought it was okay," Phainon chirps.

"It's okay but it's not amazing," Mydei says.

“Couldn’t we… make it amazing? Like maybe it just needs some tweaking?”

Mydei shakes his head. “We can do better.”

Easy for him to say. Phainon has no idea what Mydei thinks the definition of ‘better’ is. First of all, Mydei isn’t even letting him listen to all of the tracks. Phainon only gets permission to listen to the demos that Mydei deems worthy, which could be anything really.

Then, every time he asks for Phainon’s opinion, Mydei vetos Phainon’s approval and says that there’s a ‘better’ option somewhere. It’s gotten to the point that Phainon wonders if this is Mydei’s way of telling him that his music taste sucks ass. Phainon wouldn’t put it past him, but Mydei’s not the kind of guy to play around in a professional setting.

Come to think of it, the setting is not that professional. They were working in Mydei’s two bedroom apartment, which appears to have been converted to a one-bedroom-one-music-studio apartment after Mydei signed the lease. The home studio is cozier than what Phainon is usually used to, but it’s as well-equipped as any production house worth its salt. There are keyboards and drum pads standing by in one corner, while the opposite corner has three guitars hanging on the wall. Phainon guesses they must be replicas of more famous guitars, because he recognizes one to be Serval Landau’s signature Misa Kitara.

Underneath the hanging guitars is a lineup of guitar cases, and next to it is a set of shelves filled with pedal boxes. A hefty upright bass sits by the amps and monitor speakers looking out of place, but not as out of place as the panpipes proudly lounging out with Figgy. Every instrument that Phainon can name is probably in this room, and those he can’t find is likely to be in the computer’s gigantic VST library.

Out of boredom, Phainon starts absentmindedly rummaging through the cabinets while he nurses his mug of red bull. No, it’s not snooping. There’s nothing to find in here other than loose equipment- or so Phainon thinks until he opens the second last drawer.

In it lies stacks of sheet music: far from pristine, but still reasonably put together. Phainon can’t sightread, regardless of how hard he tries, but he doesn’t need to read the notes to know that these are the scores for Mydei’s songs. The titles match with his known releases, though there’s not enough sheets to contain all of Mydei’s discography. Maybe he only makes these once in a blue moon, like if people ask for it, or if he’s struggling with a song and has to work it out like a math problem. The latter becomes more probable with how Mydei’s writing litter the margins with bullet points. His comments are blunt and unforgiving, no matter if it’s directed at a band or Mydei himself.

Near the end of the third stack, Phainon finds something curious. Between volumes full of neatly printed staves lies a single page of notebook paper, scrawled on with blotchy blue ink. The other sheet music were all as traditional as it gets, as if they were the first pass at an orchestral arrangement. This scrap paper - while technically counting as sheet music - barely even has a title. It only has three letters hanging clumsily above the notation, giving the impression that Mydei had given up on writing mid-stroke. Phainon doesn’t match the consonants to any of Mydei’s songs, so there’s a good chance this is a new one.

Mydei continues scrolling through his files, even as Phainon grabs one of his acoustic guitars and trades his mug for that piece of worn paper. Unlike the rest of its frumpy siblings, this song was written down in tabs, making it something that Phainon can actually play on the spot. As his fingers strum the first note, however, he notices a problem. He has no idea about its timing or strum pattern, having never heard the song before. He attempts a guess by looking at the gaps between each note, but his fingers don’t quite glide along the nylon strings. Through his experimental strums, Figgy stares at him judgmentally, but it’s a given considering her owner.

Phainon is in the middle of working out a chord when the guitar is snatched out of his arms. “Hey!”

His cry goes unheard as Mydei grabs the guitar and the tattered page. He carefully places the guitar back in its place before crumpling the sheet of paper into a ball and tossing it into the top drawer of his desk. The drawer

gets locked too, and the key gets thrown into Mydei's pants which is… not where Phainon would have said is the safest place.

If it were an appropriate time, maybe Phainon would have shown Mydei how secure his Lululemon joggers really were, but this doesn't feel like an appropriate time. There's a tense energy in the room as Mydei wordlessly seats himself back into his chair, one that Phainon hasn't felt since the last time he got grounded. It doesn't get any better when Mydei yanks his headphone cable out of its port with enough violent ardor to nudge his entire set-up forward.

Phainon gets the terrible vision of Mydei doing the same to his arms. Luckily for him, all Mydei does is twist his volume knob and say, "Listen to this."

The order comes out gruff, from anger maybe. Phainon obeys without further ado, because as funny as they would be, he really doesn't want to test out his theories. Even as he takes note of how Mydei's neck has gone peony pink, Phainon keeps mum and does as Mydei tells him.

The headphones stay unplugged for the rest of the day.

—

"No, wait, play it back! That one sounded pretty good."

"It sounds like dogshit."

"No it doesn't!"

"It doesn't sound good either."

"Maybe not *good* good, but I like how the bridge opens the second chorus. I don't know if the glockenspiel is our sound, but-"

—

Human ears weren’t meant to be listening to rough, inscrutable cuts of music on a 24-hour loop, so by the second day of their increasingly grim search, Mydei reluctantly steps back. For now. Just until everything stops sounding like white noise.

“You said you were taking a break,” Phainon says, exasperated. “What about this is a break?”

Mydei pauses the recording. “I needed a break from going through those songs. So I’m getting a head start on Euphrosyne.”

“That’s not a break,” Phainon whines.

It seems the only thing he’s taking a break from is Phainon, because Mydei brushes him off to dive right back into song production.

Mydei is a smart man, maybe one of the smartest that Phainon knows, but he must have missed the memo about how working on a song requires a significant amount of listening. This is even worse than simply sorting through his unfinished catalogue, because now Mydei has to listen to individual tracks over and over again until he gets an idea on what to improve.

They might have agreed on remaking Euphrosyne, but it was under the context of doing it together, and Phainon doesn’t remember agreeing to Mydei working like a dog. With his wellness in mind, Phainon grabs the back of Mydei’s roller chair and pulls him away from his computer, earning him a shout from the cranky workaholic. Phainon does as Mydei has been doing and ignores his protests as he unplugs Mydei’s guitar from the computer. A loud pop rings from the speakers as the jack is flung halfway across the room, but Phainon powers on to undo Mydei’s guitar strap, skillfully evading Mydei’s open palm and freeing him of the guitar.

“What the hell do you think you’re doing?” Mydei growls, jumping out of the chair as Phainon attempts to push him out of the room.

“Showing you what a real break is,” Phainon says.

Mydei tries to march back to the computer, only for Phainon to crouch low and scoop him up into a fireman's carry.

"What the fuck?!" Mydei exclaims. Once again, he is reminded of the hard work Phainon does to be one of the nation's most sought out eye candy, because Phainon hauls him around the apartment as if Mydei was no heavier than a sack of tangerines.

Upon seeing her owner in peril, Figgy barks and hops around Phainon to stop him, but his legs are too long for her to be an obstacle. Perhaps realizing this, she lays down into a sad puddle of fur and whimpers.

"Aww. Sorry girl, but I have to borrow your master for a sec," Phainon apologizes.

"The hell you don't!" Mydei thumps a fist against Phainon's back.

Phainon pats his flank in return. "Not in front of the baby, dear."

"Let go of me!" Mydei demands, growing more fearful the closer they get to the front door. "No. Don't. Don't you dare. You will not step a single foot out of here. You God forsaken hyena, don't-!"

It had been precisely 5 minutes since Phainon had entered Mydei's house, and he's already walking out of the door. After ensuring that the door is nice and locked, Phainon pulls his mask back up and takes a jaunty trip downstairs. Mydei mentally swears at the salesman that sold him that electronic lock. More secure, his ass.

Usually, when people see a man in a mask and a dark hoodie carting a person off, they would make the quick connection to something nefarious and attempt to help in any way they can. Alas, society is yet to divorce itself from orthodox thought, for no one bats an eye at the burly man hurling insults at his unmoved kidnapper. Mydei flails about enough to make himself dizzy, and he is *still* nowhere near breaking free of Phainon's grasp.

"Fuck!" Mydei screams in frustration. The only person who reacts is a mother who hastily covers her son's ears. She gives Mydei a crazy stink-

eye, but why is her son even out of school on a weekday afternoon?

Despite Phainon's iron grip, Mydei finds himself gradually sliding out of place. Maybe if it helped him get out of this situation, he wouldn't mind, but all it does is move Mydei's ass so it's resting right on Phainon's forearm. Mydei tries to jump up and adjust himself, which accomplishes nothing but polish his crotch against Phainon's shoulder, so he's not doing that again.

Mydei pitifully ragdolls over Phainon. "…Fine, I get it. Put me down."

"Huh?" Phainon asks. "You say something?"

"You win," Mydei says through gritted teeth. "Now put me down."

"No can do. What if you run back home? It was a *loooot* of work getting you here as it is."

Mydei can hear the effort it took from how Phainon responds to him in halting breaths. As evidently strong as Phainon is, even the fittest of lifters would be drained lugging around a weight for as long as he had. Especially if it's anything near as heavy as Mydei.

"I won't run," Mydei swears.

He feels Phainon shake his head. "Can't trust you to keep your word."

"*Haikas*," Mydei snarls. "You're doing this to humiliate me."

"It's okay. No one's going to remember this."

"They're my *neighbors*."

Phainon drums a beat on Mydei's thigh. "Hmm… alright. I'll put you down on one condition."

Mydei sighs in resignation. "Anything."

And that’s how Mydei finds himself standing in line at a hot dog stand with Phainon’s arm wrapped around his waist, the pop star's hand seated firmly in Mydei’s front pocket. He suggested that Mydei should mirror him by stowing away his hand in Phainon’s own pocket, but Mydei refused to play conjoined twins with him. Phainon claimed he could always stick it into his back pocket instead, and got a disdainful look for his troubles.

At this time of day, the park mostly consisted of tourists and truant teenagers, all of whom were too busy with their own business to notice the two men playing tug of war with their private space. When it’s finally their turn to order, Mydei takes on the onus of ordering for the both of them.

“Two veggie dogs fully loaded, two chicken with ketchup and mustard, one medium cola, and a small bottle of water,” Mydei says.

He feels a tug on his shorts, directing his attention towards the perpetrator. The mask and hood covered everything except Phainon’s eyes - his most dangerous feature. Mydei has no idea how Phainon can dilate his pupils at will, but 3 seconds of looking at his damp gaze is more than Mydei can reasonably handle.

“And a small cup of vanilla ice cream,” Mydei begrudgingly adds.

Being a well-practiced stall with pre-cooked hot dogs, their order comes out fairly quick. Mydei would have preferred to eat on one of the tables, but Phainon steers him away from the logical choice and herds him towards a bench facing a landscaped portion of the park. Phainon withdraws his hand as they sit down, thankfully not commanding Mydei to feed him while his hand is out of commission.

The chicken franks tasted and felt like they were boiled to high-heaven, but it was something to do while Phainon takes his sweet time nibbling on his meal, somewhat hampered by his increasingly messy mask. Mydei wasn’t hungry at all when they arrived, though he might be by the time Phainon finishes a single hot dog.

“Any day now,” Mydei prompts.

“Why are you looking over here anyway?” Phainon says between sips of soda. The vendor had given them two straws, both of which Phainon used to suck up his flat coke. “The splendor of nature is right front of you, but you’re too busy negging me? Should I be flattered?”

Mydei clicks his tongue and averts his eyes. What splendor is there in a public park? What Mydei thinks of as nature is sharp, steep, and shadowed by wilderness. It is a sandy trail through a rocky outcrop, a swaying weed reaching out from a crumbling boulder, a nest of snakes in the hollow of an old olive tree. It is not… a piece of topiary shorn to resemble a cluster of grapes.

The dull thrum under his skull ebbs out into silence for the first time this week, leaving only a pulsing heat in the back of Mydei’s eyeballs. He rubs at his eyes to alleviate some of the pressure, unaware of the airplane full of vanilla ice cream descending towards in his mouth.

Mydei almost knocks Phainon’s head clear off his shoulders when the spoon goes in, but the sweet cream hits his tongue right after, and it mellows him out into a civilized person again. Phainon swiftly retracts his spoon from the danger zone, only to find Mydei too tired to engage with his antics.

“…I want to go home,” Mydei groans.

“Soon,” Phainon says as he digs into his ice cream.

“I never want to go with you anywhere ever again.”

“This wouldn’t have happened if you took real breaks. You got this weak in like two days.”

“Shut up.”

“When I was feeling you up, I could have sworn you lost muscle definition…”

Mydei covered his head to tune out Phainon's voice, and Phainon rewards him with the most annoying laugh to have ever endeared itself to him.

—

"What about combining the verses on four with the breakdown on seven?"

"What key would it be in?"

"I dunno. I can go pretty high if you need me to?"

"Let's avoid doing falsettos if we can."

"Hey, I pulled off a killer falsetto on Scapegoats. Wanna hear?"

"No, sto- *Haikas*! Don't scream in my ear!"

—

Finding a good song in Mydei's bin of rejects was a crapshoot from the beginning, but *Euphrosyne* made up for it by being a sure thing. Phainon and Mydei decide to pivot for now, hoping they could reboot their senses with a new task. When Anaxa calls for updates, Phainon nonchalantly tells him that it's going great, and when Anaxa offers to add more producers and songwriters into the mix, Phainon conveniently finds himself driving into a tunnel.

Currently, a sheet of printer paper stares back at Phainon, with the words 'what works' circled several times. A few bubbled words float around the central question, citing things like 'pop sound', 'youthful image', and 'sick piccolo section'.

"I don't think 'cuteness' was a factor in us winning the Fantasia," Mydei says in regards to Phainon's addition.

"If you don't consider how much of the audience demographic are middle-aged moms," Phainon says.

“Ew.” Mydei grimaces. “I hope that wasn’t it.”

“Not in a perverted way, jeez! Get your head of the gutter,” Phainon exclaims. “I’ve just had a lot of fans say I’m like a son to them.”

“We already covered ‘youthful image’.”

“Yeah but like. We’re also kinda good looking.”

“So it was a pervert thing,” Mydei says as he flicks the pen onto the paper. “And not anything about the music.”

This entire discussion only emphasizes how accidental *Euphrosyne*’s success was. The title itself sounds like patriotic peddling, which isn’t something that typically gets far in *Astral Fantasia*. It makes the actual content of the song sound insulting in comparison, especially since it wasn’t even written in an Amphorean dialect. There was no call to action or soulful romance to be found in its lyrics either, as if it was purposefully trying to defy the winning formula.

If you asked Mydei, it was probably because almost all other songs were ballads that year, though he’s really been trying to be nicer to his 16-year-old self.

The two of them ruminate in silence, with Mydei seated by Figgy’s bed and Phainon cross-legged on the floor across from them. As he mulls things over, Mydei runs his hands over Figgy’s hair, brushing out the milder tangles and giving her gentle pats. She responds by continuing to snooze on, a reminder that some dogs are easier to handle than others.

“…What if we strip it down?” Phainon says.

Mydei was prepared with a rebuttal, ready to tear into him for suggesting something so insipid as an acoustic rendition, when Phainon hurriedly explains, “We could have it start out with maybe a drum intro, and we add in the bass guitar after a bar, and then the piano, and then-”

“-Build it up,” Mydei finishes for him. He muses over the idea, trying to imagine the sound as he get up and walks over to the computer.

A duplicate of the song’s mix was already open on his DAW, and without even sitting down or listening to it, Mydei starts working on the track. In the span of a quick minute, an adjusted intro is produced, and all that’s left is to beckon Phainon over to be its first victim.

The song plays. It sounds exactly as Phainon thought it would, except Mydei made the decision to start with the vocals instead. His teenage voice opened the song, bare save for a subtle modulation to round it out. It makes him sound smaller, like it’s trying to convince the listener that this turn-of-the-millennia party jam has some pathos to it. The drums enters shortly after, then the bass, then the piano with the rest of the instruments following closely behind.

“Hm. Maybe that part where they all come in should be more abrupt?”

Mydei re-adjusts the multi-tracks and plays it back once more. The jump after the build-up is slightly satisfying to hear now, though Mydei’s twitchy hand tells Phainon that he’s thinking of more.

“I like it,” Phainon says, smiling.

“It’s not bad,” Mydei admits.

The change is nothing spectacular. *Crazy Train* did it better. It’s not groundbreaking stuff, nor is it the most fitting improvement. What it could be, however, is a conversation. A catalyst to break through the block.

“It’s a departure from the actual song,” Mydei says.

“I think it’s good to freshen it up. The song’s been around for a long time. Wouldn’t be surprised if some people are getting sick of it.”

“I just don’t want to alienate the fans.” Mydei’s nose scrunches up as he says it. “Does it even have fans?”

“You’re asking me as if we’re not remaking the song because of demand.”

“A demand from your label,” Mydei points out.

Phainon shrugs. “Haven’t seen them do something that never earned money. Speaking of money making ideas, what about those horns on the second verse?”

—

“What’s this?”

“Leftovers. You can have it while working.”

“Whoa, really? All this for me?”

“Don’t drop anything on the floor.”

“I won’t, I won’t… Wow, this is some soft bread for day old leftovers.”

“…Didn’t say it was from yesterday. Now be quiet and pay attention-“

Chapter End Notes

> I couldn't resist extending certain parts, and now the pacing is crazy as hell. It's okay, that's just how the Amphoreus patches are going. I'm just gonna send it so I can stop thinking about this chapter yippee!
>
> Thanks for reading, hope to see you soon!

Chapter 2: Side B

Chapter Notes

> The preview for Phainon's animated short makes me wish I wrote them as a hair metal band instead ahhhhhh well that's for the version of me in the next cycle to write I guess

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Experience has sharpened Mydei’s senses over the years, and nothing makes it more obvious than hearing him recreate his old work bit by bit. He’s learned some restraint since then, no longer relying on overlays-upon-overlays when a single polished track would suffice. The melodies that his younger self struggled to bring to life were whipped into shape on his first pass. He combed through *Euphrosyne* with the methodical regard a general would have towards his infantry’s defenses, quick to pick out its failings and even quicker to act upon them.

Some things never change though. Mydei’s soft spot for elaborate productions hasn’t disappeared, only moving on from grand, sweeping pads to gritty new wave distortion. He still immortalizes each new iteration of his projects into its own file, still paranoid about needing the synths from three versions ago. When his mind wanders while he has a guitar hanging from his neck, his hands still automatically ghost over a chromatic scale, even when the tuning has changed.

“The *duh-duh-duh-duh*,” Phainon sings and mimes the melody. “It needs to match the *bum-bum-bum* on the next line, but not as wet.”

“Like the room is getting bigger,” Mydei says through his focused haze.

“Yeah, yeah! Oh, and remember, the gain-”

“I got it, I got it.”

The clacking of Mydei's keyboard and mixer could be mistaken for a part of the song. He moves as if his mind is paces ahead and his body is desperately trying to catch up. Phainon stands behind him buzzing with energy, his eyes zipping all over the computer screen in an attempt to follow Mydei's alterations.

Mydei mashes the ctrl and S keys several times before replaying the verse from the top. The end result sounds like *Euphrosyne* in the modern world: tighter, cleaner, less brute force on the sound. There's still a shadow of dissatisfaction on Mydei's face when he looks up at Phainon, and it might be wishful thinking, but Phainon thinks the doubt melts away when he flashes Mydei a grin.

Mydei doesn't reward with that same courtesy, so Phainon will have to settle for his prolonged eye contact, another excuse to admire the golden shine of Mydei's hazel eyes.

"Good job," Mydei says, breaking through the spell Phainon had been trying to cast on him.

Phainon laughs. "I thought you were going to say you did all the work."

"I did," Mydei says. "But good job on loitering and looking pretty."

"Aw, can we go back to when you were praising me?"

"Take it or leave it," Mydei tells him as he turns back to the computer. "Go, report this to your manager. I'm going to export the demo."

Rather than do the sensible thing, Phainon decides to linger for a *teensy* bit longer, which unfortunately ends with him getting blindsided by the sound of the front door opening. Mydei might not be alarmed by the fact that he's getting burgled, but Phainon is. Even as the stranger walks into the studio, Mydei remains unperturbed through Phainon's mini panic attack.

"I swear, De, if you don't put me on your will after my incredible act of selflessne-" The man freezes in place when he makes eye contact with Phainon. "Whoa, okay. He's actually here."

“Is there another way to read ‘don’t come, I’m working with Phainon’?” Mydei asks, completely deadpan.

“I wasn’t born yesterday, I’m not going to fall any random lie,” the man says, his eyes flitting every so often to Phainon, mirroring his astonishment. “I guess it’s not a lie, but I haven’t seen you by the gym lately. I thought you were just too embarrassed to admit you got sick.”

“I don’t get sick,” Mydei says. He checks on the export one last time before turning to the unnamed man and continuing the conversation in Kremnoan.

The alarm bells haven’t stopped ringing in Phainon’s head. If anything, they’ve gotten louder. In front of him is a long haired pretty boy decked out in athleisure, carrying a whole 6 pounds of protein powder with one hand. He acts as if he’s not conscious of Phainon’s presence, casually conversing with Mydei in perfect Kremnoan while Figgy, Mydei’s beloved dog, excitedly hops up his leg to be petted. Whatever the man is saying gets Mydei to abandon his laconic character altogether, turning him into some blushing maiden through some manner of witchcraft.

“Hi,” Phainon suddenly interrupts. “I’m Phainon.”

Both Mydei and his mystery man look taken aback to hear him. At least they have the decency to look embarrassed.

“I know,” the man says, holding out his free hand for Phainon to shake. “I’m a fan.”

Smiling, Phainon holds the stranger’s hand in both of his. “And by what name should I call my dear fan…?”

“Hephaestion,” Mydei answers as he stands up. “Don’t tell anyone about this.”

Phainon was about to scoff. Is he so untrustworthy that Mydei has to give him a disclaimer? Why would he relay any of this to anyone else anyway? It’s not his business to care about.

Then the man called Hephaestion answers, and Phainon realizes that Mydei was addressing someone else all along. “Don’t worry, I got you,” Hephaestion says, patting Mydei’s bicep. “I figured this has to be one of your secret songs, else I would have heard about it by now.”

“Does Mydei usually tell you about his ‘secret songs’?” Phainon probes.

Hephaestion laughs. “This guy doesn’t tell me squat. I would have probably found this out on social media *months* after, and only because you’re so popular.”

“They’re secret projects for a reason,” Mydei says.

Yet, Hephaestion only gets a warning for stumbling into one. What does that say about his relationship with Mydei? Phainon supposes it says something about Mydei’s trust in the man. Makes sense, seeing how he clearly knows the code to Mydei’s front door. Although, so does Phainon, a person who Mydei hasn’t interacted with in years. Was the code given freely to Hephaestion, or did he have to puzzle it out like Phainon did?

He could be Mydei’s roommate, but there’s only one bedroom. Full days of bumming around in Mydei’s house, and Phainon only catches sight of Hephaestion now. Perhaps he was Mydei’s roommate back when this was a proper two bedroom shindig, but what would Mydei need for a roommate if he could shoulder the costs for the apartment on his own? Where would Mydei have even kept his musical equipment?

There is too little of Hephaestion in the house to be a partner. There’s nothing extra to greet him; no extra slippers, no special mugs, no diversity in the brands that Mydei keeps stocked in the refrigerator. Mydei’s closet doesn’t have a single piece of clothing smaller than his size, and his nightstands are free of lube, condoms, and other such perversions. Mydei’s phone doesn’t titter with any tidings of love, nor does erratic jealousy clutter up his notifications. A new lover wouldn’t be this trusted or absent in his life. A new lover wouldn’t know exactly where to store the protein powder he brought over.

Must be a friend then. Not that friendship means there can't be any other feelings simmering under the surface. Objectively speaking.

"Do you want anything to eat?" Mydei asks Hephaestion, belatedly extending the question to Phainon. "Or I could make you guys something?"

"I'm good," Hephaestion answers from where he's sitting with Figgy. "I just dropped by to see what was going on with you, maybe drag you to the gym if you're doing okay."

"I'm free to go now," Mydei says.

"Wow, and here I thought you were too busy to spare some time for me," Phainon sighs dramatically. He pouts at Hephaestion. "Did you know? He's been bragging about his kimadopita recipe but not once has he tried to offer me one."

"Do you think I have the time to make that right now?" Mydei asks.

"I think he was only bringing it up to make me hungry," Phainon tells Hephaestion.

"Just buy some phyllo from the store, De," Hephaestion chides. "Stop starving Amphoreus's Deliverer."

Mydei splutters. Huh, Phainon's never managed to make him do that. Catching himself, the blond tries to slink back into his insouciant self, but the damage is done. Is it really such a pain to be cute in front of Phainon every once in a while?

The three of them - well, four with the dog - have moved to the living room at some point. Hephaestion, who says he only meant to 'drop by', is suddenly too busy with Figgy to leave, entertaining her with baby talk while planting loud smooches on her snout. Phainon finds that the longer Hephaestion stays, the more conscious Phainon becomes of Mydei's choice of clothes.

Due to the amount of items stuffed into the room, Mydei's homemade music studio doesn't have the best ventilation, and Mydei already runs warm as it is. Hence why Mydei prefers to wear light clothing when he's working, with 'light' being a generous description. The songwriter had abstained from appearing too casual on the first few days, but his waning diligence had resulted in the longest striptease anyone has ever been subjected to. Now Mydei sits around shirtless, wearing shorts with an inseam that would have gotten him banned from respectable establishments. Phainon refrains from pointing it out, because who is he to deny someone comfort in their own home?

Is it too much comfort though? Between the three of them (four, once again with Miss Figgy), only Phainon seems to mind. Is it because Mydei and Hephaestion go to the gym together, so they're fine seeing each other in different states of undress? How much of Mydei has Hephaestion seen? Could Mydei just be an exhibitionist?

When Mydei shifts and the hem of his shorts rucks up, Phainon blurts out, "Could I hit the gym with you guys?"

That startles Hephaestion for some reason. "Did I hear that right?" He says."You want to go to the gym with us?"

Phainon shrugs as casually as he can. "It's been a while since I've had a good workout. I remembered after you guys brought it up."

"You're telling me you don't have a personal trainer to remind you of that?" Mydei asks.

"No offense, but this-" Phainon gestures over the length of his body. "-comes naturally to me. I don't need someone to bug me about working out. I just do it."

Disgusted, Mydei looks over at Hephaestion. "I'll kill him, you start digging, okay?"

"Hey!"

“I’m not doing that,” Hephaestion says, peacefully stepping back. “If I play my cards right, I could get him to play at my wedding. I’m not killing my wedding singer.”

“I’ll do it for free if you jump Mydei instead,” Phainon offers.

“Then who’ll be my best man?”

“Worry about finding someone to marry first,” Mydei grumbles. “We’re not going to the gym with this guy. I can’t afford the lawyers to sue the paparazzi.”

“Hmm, true,” Hephaestion concurs, scritching the underside of Figgy’s chin. “Unless someone wants to invites us to his private gym…”

“Without Leonnius? He’s going to be pissed when he finds out,” Mydei comments.

“It’s what he gets for leaving us behind during that last triathlon,” Hephaestion says. “Besides, Peu’s the one that’s going to be jealous.”

“Thought he hated Phainon’s music.”

“I have a working theory that hate begets love-”

When Mydei talks about these unfamiliar names, his voice takes on a lacquer of sarcasm, something so unnecessarily antagonistic that it parts the curtain. A man raised on etiquette and apathy could never be so seditious, unless it was the safer, more familiar alternative. Watching him speak the same way to Hephaestion - who snipes back in return - it looked like fun.

Phainon chuckles. “If you’re looking to dodge the paparazzi, then I’m afraid my house isn’t the place to do it.”

“Oh.” Hephaestion sighs. “When will it be my turn to get my own home gym?”

“Never, if you’re going to spend all your time here smothering my dog,” Mydei says.

“Smothering, he says. Look at her tail going wild,” Hephaestion says. “When’s the last time your owner took you out of the house for walkies, huh girl?”

“I’m the one who walks her these days,” Phainon sadly reveals.

“Oh dear, sounds like someone’s been a neglectful father.”

Mydei scoffs. “Are you going to leave, Hephaestion, or are you still working up the courage to ask Phainon for an autograph?”

Hephaestion laughs a little too loudly. “What? No, I would never!”

As it turns out, Phainon is happy to indulge his request. The happiest he’s been this whole visit, maybe. Mydei calls him a narcissist when he proposes an impromptu photoshoot for Hephaestion’s sake, and Phainon doesn’t hold back his snicker.

Phainon watches as Mydei rolls his eyes at Hephaestion’s gushing, the beginnings of a fond smile on the blond’s face. Something warm makes its home in Phainon’s chest, suddenly made aware of how different things are, of how even that standoffish, sour tempered cretin of a boy can grow and mature.

It’s only when that fond smile meets his that Phainon fixates on the things that have stayed the same.

—

“It’s completely different.”

“No it’s not,” Phainon insists over the phone. “This is what the song would have sounded like if we knew what we were doing back then. It’s a rework!”

“The agreement was that you two remaster Euphrosyne,” Anaxa sighs. “The understanding was that it gets re-recorded, not re-written.”

“We wanted to re-introduce it to the fans. A new Euphro for a new decade.”

“Re-get your asses in the studio,” Anaxa grits out. “You promised you’d concentrate on the new song first, not remake your damn debut from the ground up! How the hell do you expect me to convince Caenis to release a rock single?”

“I- Just make her listen to it, please.”

“The only thing that woman likes listening to is the sound of her own voice. Dammit, Phainon! Can you get your act together for one second? We don’t have time to be playing stupid games!”

“… I understand.”

After Anaxa presumably slams the phone down in anger, Phainon turns to Mydei and shoots him a praise-hungry grin. Mydei, with his mouth full of lamb, shakes his head.

“Is this how things are done at Grove?” Mydei asks once he'd swallowed.

“Nah, it just makes it easier,” Phainon says before tucking into his own plate. “I think Anaxa just does it because he wants more chances to cuss me out. It’s tough for him cause I’m kind of like the perfect act?”

Somehow, Mydei doubts that. The thing about *Grove* tightening their apron strings is that it raises some unscrupulous little shits. Case in point this ridiculous charade Phainon had to act out on the phone. Like Mydei, the intended audience had been eavesdropping through speakerphone, likely nodding smugly when Phainon pulled out the pathetic sad puppy voice to beg. Phainon and his team has long learned of *Grove*’s penchant for shutting down their initial ideas, an act that Phainon described as a ‘power move’. Apparently it’s supposed to make their stars more docile, more malleable when doling out future assignments and contracts.

In retaliation, Phainon would occasionally switch his first submissions with a dud, sometimes even pantomiming a fight with his management like he did moments ago. This way *Grove* can feel like they’ve accomplished

something, and with them believing the idea to be theirs, Phainon gets to do what he wants looking as compliant as ever.

Mydei doesn't know if this is a good thing for the singer, but Phainon looks happy enough. Meddling might only upset him.

Despite Mydei's consideration for his feelings, Phainon still has the nerve to droop over Mydei's dining table. "Is it bad if I was kinda hoping they'd accept the draft?" He says.

"Yes," Mydei answers. "Do you think we were working on the real song as a joke?"

"No but like-" Phainon gestures vaguely. "If Sun and Thunder was still a thing, that's what we would sound like, right?"

The fake demo was conceived and performed in under an hour. It feels like Phainon is trying to offend him. "Eat your damn lamb shank."

"You don't think so? You don't think Sun and Thunder wouldn't have evolved their sound?"

"I think if Sun and Thunder stayed together, you would have been choked to death by now," Mydei says.

"I think we would have made a good prog album," Phainon sidesteps the threat to continue spinning his fantasy. "You got that version down quick. You can't tell me you weren't itching to play that riff."

"It was fun," Mydei admits as he takes a swig of his whey-grenadine-tea concoction. He's developed a taste for it in the days he's spent with Phainon, and it may be the worst thing the pop star has ever inflicted on him. "But it's always fun to try something different."

"See?" Phainon grins again. "We would have probably made a prog album. Maybe after the ska one."

Mydei stuffs another forkful of lamb into his mouth to keep himself from getting infected by Phainon's expression. The truth is, Sun and Thunder

would have never made a single progressive rock song. They would have immediately faded into obscurity after *Astral Fantasia*, if not stifled in *Grove*'s possession. Maybe they would have done alright being washouts, but it's more likely to be fight after fight after fight, persisting until the only option was to never see each other again.

When Mydei made his choice to walk away after their success, he had a future in mind, and years later that future came into fruition. Today, Mydei is free to do as he likes and Phainon gets as much adoration as he deserves. What more could he ask for? If there is such a thing as another life, Mydei wouldn't have done anything differently.

Though he has to admit, sitting here, sharing a meal in his kitchen, Mydei doesn't mind hearing Phainon prattle on about what could have been.

—

"That last song was *fine*."

"We can do better."

"For fuck's sake- You're being unreasonable. Literally any of these songs would do-"

"It's not the right fucking song."

"Then find the *right fucking song*-"

—

Hour sixteen of their standoff and the atmosphere has plummeted to catastrophic lows. Mydei has to put in effort to ignore the man on the other side of the room, lest he does something that sends at least one of them to the hospital. Phainon's jaw might never recover from how hard it clenches, and his teeth might be ground to powder before this night is over.

It was a mistake to put off writing the new song. It was a mistake to agree to *Grove*'s demands, and it was a mistake to take on two new songs in such a short time frame. It was a mistake to accept the offer of a reunion, and it was an *especially* huge mistake to ever let Phainon into Mydei's life again. Mydei wouldn't call himself a particularly smart man, but he never thought he'd be lacking so much basic common sense.

Grove had given them an extension over the weekend, an ultimatum disguised as charity. If Phainon and Mydei choose to continue dicking around, then a legion of ghostwriters would apparate at his doorstep the very minute the deadline passes, and *Sun and Thunder*'s true ownership over their songs would be lost to the wind. There's no contesting it either. *Grove* has already been so gracious as to lend them more time, so Phainon and Mydei are left choosing between which end of the spit to skewer themselves with.

With a click of his tongue, Mydei cuts off the demo he'd been listening to and moves on to the next. In his concentration, he fails to notice the man skulking up behind him, leaving an opening for his mouse to be wrenched away from his grip. Mydei tries to wrestle it back, but Phainon had secured his upper hand long enough to close out of the music program.

Mydei can only glower at him with the force of ten thousand furies, knowing that opening his mouth would be akin to tossing kerosene into a grease fire. It frustrates him that Phainon knows what he'd say anyway, because the warm, boy-next-door wonder that lights up his features freezes over when he looks down at Mydei.

"Just write a new song," he says, simple as day.

"It's not that easy," Mydei shoots back. He jumps up to snatch the mouse back, but Phainon holds it up out of reach.

"It's been two weeks. It's got to be easier than this," Phainon states. He sounds tired, and even his stage make-up would struggle to hide the darkness bleeding out from under his eyes.

"You don't know how I do things," Mydei says.

“Yeah, but I rather you actually *do* something than whatever this is.”

“Call your manager then,” Mydei urges. “Why waste your time with me if you can get a writer who does things?”

Phainon shakes his head, still pretending to be the rational one even when he’s playing ‘keep away’ with Mydei’s belongings. “Stop twisting my words. I’m trying not to waste anymore of our time.”

Mydei almost laughs at that. “So go home. No need for *both* of us to waste our time here,” he spits out.

Phainon’s eye twitches as his gaze falls to the floor. “They told me to be here…”

“Who the hell is keeping tabs on you at-” Mydei glances at the time. “-twelve thirty am? Leave, I can do this myself.”

Mydei holds his hand out for the mouse, but Phainon only continues to stare angrily at the floor, his fist tightening around hard plastic.

“If you just-” Phainon pauses, perhaps hearing the rising anger in his inflection. He tries again, calmer this time. “Just tell me what you’re looking for.”

“A good song,” Mydei answers plainly, but it seems that it’s not enough.

“Define a good song,” Phainon pleads. “Cause I’ve been telling you, all of these are good songs-”

“Being honest won’t kill you,” Mydei snaps.

“I am being honest! Why would I lie to you? We’re working on the same goddamn project!”

“You can’t possibly think half of these are any good.”

“Kephale save me- I’m not trying to argue with your weird complex, okay? I’m trying to work with you.”

“And it’s not working out,” Mydei scoffs as he finally spots a chance to nab his mouse back.

In panic, or maybe in fear of Mydei leaping out of nowhere, Phainon flinches and elbows Mydei in the chin. The loud crack tells Mydei that Phainon’s elbow didn’t escape unscathed, but neither did his chin, which feels a few centimeters out of place.

“Mydei!” Phainon exclaims, immediately rushing over to check on him. Mydei pushes the singer aside, because the last thing he needs is for a 6 foot something man to crowd his space.

Fuck, his back hurts too. When Mydei went down, he managed to land right on top of his keyboard and fuck up his spine. Somehow, he also happened to press the right combination of keys that would start playing his saved files, so not even Mydei’s dignity would be spared this evening.

Once the pain subsides, Mydei looks up at Phainon - to scold or barter, he doesn’t know - only to find him staring at the computer. The song blaring from the speakers is one of the first that Mydei had struck from his consideration. It was too indulgent, too silly even for a pop duo named *Sun and Thunder*. The intention was for the song to sound like war drums echoing over the crest of a dusty hill, but it just sounds like empty tin cans getting knocked over in a kitchen cabinet.

Phainon’s expression is equally as silly. He stands there slack-jawed, lips parted far enough for Mydei to see where his snaggletooth used to be, but not enough to see that irreverent tongue. His eyelids have pulled back some, because he never grew out of the habit of listening with his eyes, and it’s in those eyes, with the pupils blown so wide they mute the cyans, that Mydei spots what he’s been looking for.

Ah, it’s this one.

“We’re working on this song,” Mydei announces as he seats himself back into his chair.

“What? Did I hit your head or something?” Phainon asks, unease seeping into his tone. “Stop working and let me see.”

Mydei finishes saving a copy of the file before abruptly turning to Phainon. “Do you like this song?”

“Huh?”

“I asked if you like this song,” Mydei repeats.

Phainon looks too dazed to answer, yet he obediently replies, “Yeah. I think it has potential.”

Mydei nods and swings back towards the computer. “Then we have a day to make sure it gets there.”

—

Anaxa’s interlocked hands cover his face from Phainon’s sight, but he knows his manager is facing down with his eye closed, like he’s always done when he’s focusing on a song. Phainon doesn’t usually think much of the habit, unless maybe when he’s feeling a little mischievous and brave. Maybe then he’ll think about imitating a sound effect in the middle of the demo. He never acts on the impulse though, still preferring to keep out of Anaxa’s hair so he can get dismissed earlier, good song or not.

This is the first time Phainon has felt nervous to see Anaxa listen to a demo. It’s never occurred to him before that Anaxa, an exalted record producer in his heyday, knows exactly what to hear to know if a song is good or not. It only really sunk in now, when he’s a chorus deep in a demo Phainon had finished recording 40 minutes ago. Phainon resists the urge to shout his excuses: ‘oh, it sounded good live’, ‘oh, the file transfer messed up the syncing’, ‘oh, it was 4 in the morning’, and so on. He nearly bursts into apologies when he hears his voice in the playback, sounding like a bag of gravel spilling onto bone dry cobblestone.

At least he’s not alone. Mydei stands beside him, his back standing so straight that Phainon wonders if he confused Anaxa with a drill sergeant. It’s not Mydei’s first rodeo, as Mydei had reassured him on the terrifying drive over, so it’s kind of comforting that this so-called professional is trembling in his boots watching his work go under the microscope. Phainon preens at the idea that Mydei might think of their song as highly as he does, though it’s difficult to be proud when there’s someone dissecting your work in pin-drop silence.

But so what if Anaxa hates it? Phainon was right to trust Mydei. He created something beautiful in a matter of hours, and Phainon liked that he had a hand in it, even if it was only a negligible part. The song was already half-formed when Phainon came around - he just put a nice hat on it and sent it on its way.

The song ends, but Anaxa’s head stays bowed in place. Needless to say, the silence is unsettling, and Anaxa lets the two simmer in it long enough to make Phainon believe he was trying to come up with the most devastating insult he could give them. Phainon had already formulated the start of his opening rebuttal when Anaxa raises his head to level them both with a stare.

“Serviceable,” is all he had to say. High praise considering, well, everything.

Phainon tries not to jinx it with a smile, but fails immediately. Just for that, Anaxa looks over at Mydei and says, “Horrendous demo though. You’re better off vocalizing the song to me next time."

“I apologize,” Mydei says.

“We had some trouble with the mic,” Phainon justifies.

“You had more trouble elsewhere, but sure, if that helps you sleep at night.” Anaxa crosses his arms as he gives them a once over. “If you ever go to sleep. You had a few hours left. Surely you two could have spared some for a power nap. Or for a bath.”

“We wanted to have time to adjust stuff if we needed to,” Phainon says.

“What more could you have done in six hours?” Anaxa questions. “It would have been more productive if you took the effort to prevent my office from reeking like a high school locker room. Look at the state of you both. Mydeimos’s shirt is on backwards.”

Mydei looks down. “Oh.”

Anaxa holds up a hand when Mydei starts to correct the problem. “Stop. Refrain from doing anything that might implicate me.”

Mydei drops his hands from his shirt. “Sorry.”

“I’ll have someone show you to a bathroom later,” Anaxa tells Mydei. “And Phainon can go to Aglaea to get lasik for his bloodshot eyes or what have you. We’ll be in contact when it’s time to record, which I estimate to be around the weekend by the latest. If there’s anything you want to specify - about the personnel, equipment - you can get in touch with us any time.”

“I’d like to be involved with the prep,” Mydei confesses. “But I do have some work that I’ve put off. I’ll be fine knowing that Phainon can look after the song.”

Phainon laughs, suddenly feeling bashful. “Don’t worry, I’ve picked up a thing or two from bothering you.”

Mydei shakes his head, but Phainon’s demon manager cuts in before Mydei could continue speaking. “What have you two named the song?” Anaxa asks.

Oh, that’s what they forgot. The two men glance at each other, wondering if the right answer is to bluff or to admit the truth. As Phainon gazes into Mydei’s eyes, the answer becomes crystal clear.

“Amber Dawn,” Phainon pries his attention away from Mydei. “…Is the name of the song.”

Anaxa raises an eyebrow. “As of two seconds ago, I presume?”

“Come on, isn’t it more impressive that I came up with it so quickly?”

“If I were your teacher I would have failed you twice already,” Anaxa says, tutting. “But as a business man, you’re passable as long as you’re profitable.”

A polite knock on the door stops Phainon’s sleep deprived self from fake bawling at Anaxa’s words. Anaxa orders the interloper to enter, and in comes the most pleasant part of Anaxa’s office.

“Got some more forms for you, sir,” Anaxa's personal assistant cheerfully declares as she hands Anaxa a folder, her pink curls bouncing delightfully with every step.

“Thank you, Hyacine. Before you go, I need you to take Mydeimos here to the restrooms,” Anaxa points at the man in question.

Hyacine perks up. “Sure!”

“Get him a coffee too. He looks like he’s about the keel over and die,” Anaxa follows up as Hyacine tugs Mydei’s arm.

“I’m good without the coffee,” Mydei insists, letting himself be dragged off by a girl that barely reaches his shoulders.

“Are you sure? I make a mean cortado!”

“… I haven’t eaten anything yet.”

The door closes behind before Phainon could eavesdrop on the rest of their conversation, though he’s sure Hyacine would bring up the carrot muffins she hides in her desk. That would tempt Mydei any day of the week, even more so when he finds out they’re decorated to match Hyacine’s Shetland pony.

“What is it that you want to say?” Anaxa asks, tearing Phainon away from his daydreams.

They've worked together long enough to know when the other wants something. For example, Phainon doesn't usually hang back in Anaxa's office. Too reminiscent of a principal's office, he says. Anaxa had mocked him for getting called up by his principal enough times to be traumatized over it, which is also something Phainon's principal probably said back then.

He digresses. Point is, Anaxa is right. "Mydei wants to be there for the recording," Phainon states.

"I sure hope so," Anaxa says, leaning back into his chair. "It would be a shit record if we only got half of the duo we paid for."

"I mean he wants to be there throughout the entire recording," Phainon clarifies. "Supervising."

"Did he say that or did you say that?"

"*We* said it," Phainon says. "I guess it'll depend if he's free but…"

Anaxa searches Phainon's face as he fumbles for a reasonable excuse. The fatigue must be making him loopier than he thought, because the only thing he comes up with is a shrug and a timid 'ehe'.

"We'll take note of it," Anaxa says flatly.

"Please? It would really mean a lot to him."

"Ugh, I'll try if you stop with the cutesy façade." Anaxa grimaces. "Are you two trying to co-produce this song under my nose?"

"Me? Nah, producing's not my thing," Phainon quickly denies. "I'm more of a big picture guy than a detail… person."

"Is that what Mydeimos said?"

"He wouldn't say that! I mean he gets kinda asshole-ish sometimes, but he won't say that kind of thing out loud."

“Hm, I suppose it won’t be farfetched for him to think highly of your talents,” Anaxa says. “He did borrow you for help on the song after all.”

Phainon rubs at his eye to avoid his manager’s own. “Hah, yeah.”

—

It took the whole week before *Grove* got back to Mydei about the recording session, though they did update him extensively on the song’s progress. It was best not to think much of it, because he might end up wishing for more control over Amber Dawn, and that’s not exactly a dream rooted in reality.

Still, that doesn’t mean he can’t be pleasantly surprised when he steps into the studio and sees that they’ve adapted some of his suggestions. From his own experience with audio engineering, Mydei knows it can be a pain to accommodate unfamiliar requests in his own process, so he can’t help but feel slightly apologetic towards Phainon’s team.

The fact that they’re recording in their in-house studio also renders some of Mydei’s recommendations moot. He’s familiar with most of the recording studios in Okhema, even the ones with more prestige than he can afford, but he has never been invited to *Grove*’s studio before. It didn’t exist during *Sun and Thunder*’s tenure, and Mydei distinctly remembers having to record in a rented booth that smelled of thick cigar smoke. It’s nice to know that Phainon’s lungs are safer now. And the studio isn’t half-bad either.

Mydei stops strumming as the audio engineer gives him thumbs-up behind the soundproof glass. Before heading back to the control room, Mydei mutes his amp to reduce feedback from his Stratocaster while he waits for the rest of the band to show.

Truthfully, the most logical thing to do would be to carry out most of the recording one by one, considering the tight schedule and the amount of instruments needed. But when they brought up recording the bulk of the songs live, Mydei couldn’t find it in him to refuse. He knows that it’s more effort, that it’ll take up more of his time without necessarily improving the

production. A wanting feeling had possessed him when he agreed to their decision, and try as he might, he couldn’t muster a single ounce of regret.

The door to the console room swung open, and a flood of elated greetings welcomed Phainon into the room.

“Hey, Cal,” Phainon greets his producer with a low-five. “I have to say, I didn’t believe in going low carb, but that diet is working wonders on you.”

“Did you hear the new Winterlands album yet? You should. Easily this year's top ten.”

“You didn’t tell me you had a tournament match last Friday. I had to hear it from Iris, and she was mad you messed up her betting pool.”

“I read that Hertacoin is on the up these days. You should cash out while you still can.”

Sound guys, session musicians, housekeeping - no matter who, Phainon greeted them warmly. Idle chatter naturally flowed from his silver tongue as he moved through the procession, donning the pleasant smile that won him the title of Amphoreus’s ‘sunshine’. Another corny name in Phainon’s long list of epithets, though not one that Mydei can wholly disagree with.

Mydei, of course, doesn’t get up to slobber over Phainon with the rest. He’s too busy scrolling through his chat log with Hephaestion, amusing himself with old banter about oblique twists instead the commotion by the entryway. He ignores what he sees from the corner of his eye. What does it matter if Phainon walks pass him with nary a word? It’s not like Mydei acknowledged him either. This can only be a good thing. Maybe they’ll get on with recording earlier and Mydei can leave in time t-

The sharp sting of cold glass nips at Mydei’s neck, causing him to jump out of his seat to glare at a certain irradiative nuisance. It fails to deter Phainon’s innocent smile as he holds up a bottle of grape soda towards Mydei.

“How’s it going?” Phainon asks.

Mydei grabs the bottle from Phainon. It’s not even a twist-off. “It’s alright,” he grumbles. “You?”

“Better now that you’re here.”

Mydei scoffs, but he fails to inject enough snark in it and it comes out no different from a normal laugh.

Around them, the studio comes to life. With Phainon in the room, people jump to their positions, triple-checking even the most insignificant of factors. Mydei is unsure of how much of the effort is from Phainon’s star power, and how much of it is from Phainon’s affability. Even the most professional of Mydei’s colleagues wouldn’t trip over themselves to buff out Mydei’s mic stand. Mydei would have complimented Phainon on his management skills, had he not been so sure that it would offend Phainon instead.

With everyone and everything else occupied, the two of them are left standing around in silence. To say that Mydei has nothing to talk about would be incorrect. In the same way Phainon’s entrance had summoned a cavalcade of greetings, Mydei’s head is suddenly awash with dull nothings he wanted to share with the boy wonder. Things like how the piano reminds him of the finish on his ancient Kawasaki bike, or how Figgy had started waiting by the apartment door every afternoon, or how he wondered whether Phainon remembered what a proper breakfast was without Mydei to cook for him. It just feels unnatural to say these things outside his apartment, where they’re a little more than Phainon and Mydei.

Despite his aversion to keeping his mouth closed for longer than 5 minutes, Phainon looks content with keeping quiet today. The absence of his voice doesn’t make him any less expressive though, and Mydei, having been long fluent in Phainonry, reads him with ease. Right now, the side-to-side motion of his feet says that he’s excited, while the incline of his head gives away the smallest hint of nerves.

Mydei shoots him with a smirk, and Phainon’s swaying develops a tiny bounce.

“Alright,” the producer calls out. “Places, people!”

With one last glance at each other, Phainon and Mydei allow themselves be herded into the live room. Naturally, the first song they decided to record is *Euphrosyne*, because they can mess up the other song as much as they want, but God forbid *Euphrosyne* sounds even the *tiniest* bit off.

As the name implies, *Sun and Thunder* is a duo, not a band. They had a revolving door of touring members back when they were in action, but there was never really a permanent line-up. If any of them are in the studio, Mydei wouldn’t know. Not that it’s going to be a problem; the average demographic of this room would have been in high school when Euphrosyne debuted. The old band was well in their twenties by then.

That doesn’t mean Mydei doesn’t trust the musicians he’s recording with today. It’s a four-chord pop song that’s been around for a decade, and they’re professionals sought out by known record label. Even without practicing together beforehand, they should be able to cinch the song in an hour, tops. All they need is a warm-up to get them all on the same speed (a customary thing, Mydei doesn’t need to justify his suggestions) and when everyone feels like they’re solid, the producer steps up behind the mixer and signals for them to start.

As novel as it was, Phainon and Mydei’s initial rework of the intro didn’t stick around for long. It made the whole section drag, which is a cardinal sin for a song trying to make people groove. So they compromised, kicking off instead with a frantic burst of sound before crashing into immediate catatonic silence.

Then, it launches back into full blast, demanding the utmost energy the band can provide. During their rehearsals, Phainon would practice with them by reciting the lyrics with a sing-song lilt. Now his voice booms through the room, crisp and resonant even as the music competes with him. Without shouting or raising his volume, Phainon’s singing cements itself as the strongest instrument there.

The band follows relatively well for their first serious session. Everyone plays as if they would follow Phainon into battle, even when he sings that

embarrassing line comparing the dance floor to a chess board. Regardless of how hard Phainon and Mydei had tried, there's only so much they can improve upon a base like that. Mydei, for example, had desperately wanted to minimize the piccolo's overwhelming presence, only to be informed that it had gained a cult following over the years and that Mydei would be shanked on the street for even thinking about it.

At least the piccolo break gives Phainon a reason to step back. As he takes the opportunity to drink some water, Phainon's gaze automatically locks on to Mydei. Above the trill of that dinky flute, their eyes meet, and Phainon takes advantage of the moment to reward him with a wiggle of his eyebrows. The corner of Mydei's mouth twitches, but he manages to hold in his snort to show Phainon how to hold down a barre chord with a middle finger. It never fails to surprise Mydei how easy it is to make the singer laugh.

Phainon saves the recording by transitioning right back into song, but Mydei's not sure if that'll fly next time.

The song winds down, and as the final note rings out the producer is quick to jump in. "Beautiful. Absolutely fantastic. For the second take, let's try the synth with less swell. Yes, like that! Very nice. I also noticed the bass lagging on the verses, can we get a handle on that, please-"

As the producer gives them a run down of his notes, Phainon skips all the way over to Mydei to place his water bottle down next to his unopened grape soda. Mydei frowns up at him. *That's a bad idea*.

Phainon pouts. *Some exercise won't hurt me*.

Alas, Mydei couldn't shove the bottle back into his arms, can he? It would be rude to make a commotion when someone is in the middle of announcing something. Phainon hits him with a wink when he senses Mydei's resistance wane, and Mydei wonders if it's too late to give him a kick in the shin.

"-get that? Great, let's give it another try from the top. On three-"

—

On the second day of recording, Mydei is welcomed into the studio by a bright flash. The cameraman responsible hastily squeaks out an apology, but Mydei's default frown is too scary to appear anything but furious. Naturally, the poor cameraman escapes into the live room while his colleague explains their presence.

"We're taking some behind-the-scenes footage for the press kit," the man's colleague says. "We'll pop in every now and then, but I promise we won't get in the way."

True to their word, camera crew was a scant sight throughout the day, though there's only so much the average person can do to ignore a camera pointing right at them. Being performers, the band is used to that kind of attention, but it's an entirely different thing when a director comes up to you in between takes to ask for your thoughts. Even if Mydei gets out of it by dint of his comportment, it's still a hassle to wait for his co-workers' interrogations to end.

In spite of that, the day ends with the team making significant headway into *Euphrosyne*, close enough to call it done if it weren't for the decision to record some extra stems. The camera crew kindly warns them that they'll be back, and Mydei wonders if that's a sign that he should put in some overtime and get a head start for tomorrow. Recording a single song shouldn't have taken more than a couple of hours, and yet-

A flick to his forehead ceases that thought. Grimacing, he looks over at Phainon and wonders the best way to take him to court over this.

"You don't have to look at me like that," Phainon says, stepping back. "I just wanted to let you know that they're locking the studio in twenty minutes, so unless you want do an all-nighter, you better skedaddle."

"I'm going, I'm going," Mydei grumbles.

Most of their co-workers have clocked out by now. The ones that are left are those with unfinished business in the building. There's nothing in the studio that Phainon has to pack up with him, and even if he did, he'll have to bring it back in the morning anyways.

"Do you still have some work to do?" Mydei suddenly says.

"Huh? Oh, yeah, I need to approve photos with Anaxa later," Phainon answers.

Mydei hums in acknowledgment before swiftly heading for the door.

"Whoa, whoa, whoa," Phainon says as he grabs Mydei by the arm. "Why'd you ask?"

"…You still owe me for the hot dog."

"The what?"

The hot dog from how many weeks ago. Never mind the fact that Phainon has been ordering and paying for the entire team's lunch these past few days. Mydei needs to be reimbursed for that sad, mushy excuse for protein.

"That lunch we had in the park," Mydei says succinctly. "You need to pay me back and I don't feel like cooking today, so…"

Phainon stares at him with the comprehension of a newly born goldfish, making Mydei regret ever saying anything at all. So he shrugs, cool as cucumber, and says, "You're busy though, so nex-"

"No, no! I'm free," Phainon insists.

"But your manager-"

"Okay, to be honest, I don't think I'm even needed there," Phainon admits. "I mean, I have no idea how to pick out the PR disasters from the normal stuff anyway. That's why I have all those departments working for me, right?"

“Right…” Mydei concurs. “But you should still be there. It’s your face.”

“I trust them,” Phainon says. “Way more than I trust me. Besides, I don’t like being in debt. The interest stacks up.”

“I’m not charging you interest.”

“That’s what they all say,” Phainon sighs as he pushes Mydei out of the studio. He nods at the security guard standing by the reception and leads Mydei all the way out to where Phainon’s car is parked.

“I can’t leave my car here,” Mydei protests in the elevator.

“I’ll pick you up tomorrow,” Phainon says. He retracts the offer when he gets a frown in reply. “Don’t worry, I’ll get people to handle it.”

The ‘people' in this case ends up being Phainon’s chauffeur, who looks so used to this behavior that he doesn’t even try to dissuade his client. He simply takes the keys from Mydei and bids them adieu. Phainon dismisses his security personnel too, citing Mydei’s gym routine to convince them of his safety.

“And you call me spoiled,” Mydei comments as he straps himself down in the passenger seat.

“Aren’t you? I just let you borrow my driver because you didn’t want your Camry to feel left out,” Phainon says. “Now I have to get him a rideshare, or he’ll be stranded at yours. Where’s my thank you?”

Mydei shakes his head as he pulls out his phone. The click of Phainon’s seatbelt is followed shortly by a small *ding*, prompting him to take out his own phone and groan at the sight of it.

“It does not take that much to get a taxi from your place to his,” Phainon nags, swiping away from the notification informing him of a kind donation to his digital wallet.

“Then you better make this a good dinner,” Mydei says. Phainon gives him a petulant moue of woe before turning back to the wheel with a haughty

sniff.

Grove Records' headquarters is nestled in the heart of Okhema's media city, and being a somewhat prolific character in its music scene, Mydei is well-acquainted with all the ins-and-outs of the district. So imagine his surprise when he can't recognize the route Phainon takes him down. The scratchy rembetiko album playing on the overpriced car stereo clashes with the modern shapes of the new world architecture outside the window, a step off from the stumpy studios and benign beiges of the music quarter. Skyscrapers sculpted from glass and metal litter the dustless streets, looming over the bustle of people all clad in the same shade of business casual.

Phainon parks inside a comparatively nondescript building, warning Mydei to keep his doors closed until he says so. Mydei complies after a little begging, watching in silence as Phainon hops out of the car and jogs straight towards its passenger side. As Phainon rounds the corner, Mydei opens the door himself and steps out.

Phainon huffs at him. "That was part of the experience, you know."

"Should have been faster," Mydei gloats.

Oh how Phainon pouts at that. It gives Mydei a difficult time resisting the avuncular urge to pinch his puffed up cheeks.

Remembering his role as a gracious guide, Phainon wastes no time in leading Mydei through the building. Mydei vaguely recognizes the name on the signs directing them in, but it's not until he sees the restaurant in the distance that Mydei understands the danger he's in.

Mydei pulls Phainon to the side before they could reach the entrance. "You can't be serious," Mydei hisses.

Phainon blinks at him. "You wanted a good dinner."

"Steak and eggs at an IPC franchise would have been good dinner. *This*-" Mydei gestures subtly to the restaurant behind him. "-Is overkill."

“Don’t be silly, it’s just your run-of-the-mill eatery,” Phainon says, complete with a fake posh brogue.

The run-of-the-mill eatery he had described had been the titleholder of Okhema’s best fine dining establishment for the past 3 years. Mydei of all people should have known that Phainon is not one to meet a challenge half-heartedly, and yet here he is, conveniently ignoring the chandeliers and expensive art plastered all over the corridors to follow Phainon to what he called a ‘nice place for good eats’.

“A private table please,” Phainon calls out to the maitre d’, who had been standing a touch too far for Phainon to address in a polite volume. They haven’t even entered the restaurant yet, and Mydei is already mortified.

Despite Mydei’s expectations, the lady standing by the front of house only smiles at them. “Welcome back, Sir,” she says as she elegantly beckons them in. “Please, right this way.”

Don’t be fooled by its empty vestibule: *Aurum* has been fully booked since its opening, lacking the capacity to even entertain walk-ins. The amount of times Mydei has failed to secure a reservation attests this, but apparently Mydei is free to saunter in anytime if it’s at the behest of a beloved pop star. He doesn’t know if that makes it less or more embarrassing when he’s walking pass the sea of occupied tables. Mydei feels it should be embarrassing, seeing how everyone else is dressed in smart formals while he barely has sleeves on.

The maitre d’ shows them to a quiet aisle of closed booths and kindly seats them at one with a nice view of Okhema’s skyline. She hands them two menus made from pressed paper before disappearing with a bow.

Being a humble aficionado of food, Mydei is aware of what he’d find on the menu in front of him. *Aurum* specializes in Xianzhou fusion cuisine, and the photos never fail to lead Mydei to another unsuccessful booking. The smell of the restaurant is beyond divine, with spices familiar and foreign wafting through the air like temptation manifest.

“Found anything yet?” Phainon asks as he peruses the menu.

“…A glass of water.”

“You know, the fermented cod here is pretty good. It’s fresh and tangy and it’s got a crazy kick at the end. Pretty good with rice or some pita honestly.”

“Hm.”

“I bet you’d love the bean curds though. I don't know how they get it so crunchy under all that sauce. They serve it with some yogurt in case it’s too hot for guests, but I could take it either way.”

“Ok.”

“And check out this chicken stew! They actually use the same broth for the soup dumplings, and it’s wild how changing the shape makes them taste so different. It goes so good with the fish and-”

Phainon continues his running commentary on each and every item on the menu, but Mydei holds strong. When the server comes to take their order, Mydei places a single request for bottled water and nothing else. He’s foolish to think that’s enough to make a statement when Phainon is free to order an entire buffet to their table.

“Deliverer.”

“I’m telling you, it’s Phainon,” Phainon tells him.

“It’s *Deliverer*,” Mydei grounds out. “Because you’ll have to take up delivering groceries to bounce back from this.”

Phainon laughs at the idea of his own bankruptcy. “It’s not that bad!”

“The hot dogs costed me five balance coins.”

“And you hated them,” Phainon says. “Good food costs more than five bucks. Live a little, why don’t you?”

It’s hard to live with the weight of a month’s salary disappearing in the span of a single meal. Mydei doesn’t think he can’t forget the price tag so easily,

but his resolve shakes the moment the first dish is placed down. Once the line of food has finishes making its way over to their table, the concept of numbers has completely vanished from Mydei's head.

So yeah, he takes a bite of some fried wontons, after wringing the shit out of his fancy mineral water.

Phainon puts on an act about accidentally ordering too much and not knowing what to do with the excess, but Mydei folds too fast for the theatrics to be necessary. Once he popped that wonton into his mouth, it was game over. There was no winning here; everything tastes too wonderful to keep up the fight. The food is so good that Mydei allows Phainon to feed him his recommendations by hand, regardless of how cumbersome the table between them made it. When the pear crumble comes out, Mydei nearly cries.

Mydei manages to hold in his tears, though it was a close call when the bill came.

The smug bastard has the audacity to grin at him. "Was dinner okay?"

"Can it, *haikas*," Mydei mumbles. He'd been joking about Phainon being in his debt, but Mydei didn't think the night would end with him being in real debt to Phainon instead.

Phainon seems to know what's running through his mind, because of course he does. "If you're feeling that bad about it, why don't you treat me to dinner next time, huh?"

Mydei gives him a sidelong glance before grunting, "I know what you're doing."

"And?"

A few crisp banknotes appear in Mydei's hand, disappearing a second later into the check holder. "And you forgot to tip, Mr. Big Shot," he says.

Neither of them remind the other that they have access to each other's bank details, too busy finding out who could melt their complementary mint the fastest.

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All in all, *Euphrosyne*'s revision takes 2-ish days to record, a process that felt both too fast and too slow. Too slow because Mydei normally finishes up a new song in a couple of hours. Too fast because he hadn't gotten sick of it by the end. Maybe it was the change of pace after how the writing had gone, or maybe there's really something in the grassy fragrance they spritz all over the building.

Today's recording is dedicated to finishing up any isolated tracks they might need. Mydei only had to be in to record vocals and some lead guitar, but the producer had offered to let him stay and watch the rest of the recordings. Apparently, being the co-writer of the song gets you some privileges - or extra labor, depending on the perspective. Mydei respectfully declines, despite his interest. It's just best that he avoids stepping on any toes while working on this project.

He does step on Phainon though, which is a given with how the pop star sits sprawled out by the studio door.

"Oww," says Mydei's sulky rug. "I think you punctured my liver."

A good samaritan would apologize and maybe fuss over Phainon a little to help him recover faster. Mydei breaks the mold by physically hauling Phainon to his feet with the delicacy of a rampaging bull.

"I didn't know there was something wrong with the chairs in here," Mydei says sardonically.

"I didn't want to risk missing you," Phainon reasons. When he realizes how that sentence could be misconstrued, he adds, "Honey."

Mydei grimaces as he pushes that grinning face away from him. "Gross."

“You hate me,” Phainon whimpers under his palm. “You want me to die.”

“If you’re going to die, do it after this,” Mydei says, turning away from Phainon. “Let’s go.”

Phainon happily obeys, falling in step with the man in front of him. With a stride like his, Phainon catches up all too easily, so Mydei continues to quietly speed up faster and faster until they’re both awkwardly trotting through the office building during working hours.

Phainon smacks his hand down on Mydei’s car hood. “I win!”

“Win what?” Mydei says, trying to downplay his panting. “Was there something we were doing?”

Phainon squints at him, but Mydei jumps into his car to avoid his whingeing. The engine revs soon after, and Phainon has to rush to get in before Mydei drives off without him.

During one of their breaks, Mydei had mentioned a certain girl with a case of the blues, and Phainon hypothesizes that she would be cured with an immediate dose of his TLC. This is proven the moment Mydei’s door is opened, and Phainon immediately topples over to the force of 90 pounds of dog.

“Who’s the good girl?” Phainon coos through Figgy’s frenzied kisses. “Is it you? Are you the good girl? Yes you are!”

“You two weren’t like this before,” Mydei says as he nudges both man and dog clear of the door.

“Sometimes you don’t know what you have until it’s gone.” Phainon sniffs. “And while you were busy giving me the cold shoulder, Figgy was there for me.”

“I can see that.”

It also helps that Phainon has a baggie of freeze dried beef in his pocket. Phainon rewards her with a couple of cubes, and Figgy pays him back with

another fusillade of slobbery kisses.

As Mydei disappears to get Figgy ready for her walk, Phainon starts working on his appearance. Wigs are too much of a pain to be working into a disguise, but as *Sun and Thunder*'s secret reunion draws closer, some vigilance would be much appreciated, especially with the glaring beacon that is Phainon's hair. Aglaea provides him with a decent piece that isn't too hard for a schlub like him to figure out, and with his clothes being as plain as they can be, Phainon could almost pass for his own cousin.

The real test is how far Mydei jumps. Mydei takes a step and a half back when he lays his eyes on Phainon, which isn't too bad.

"I'm surprised you didn't put colored contacts on," Mydei says as he leashes Figgy. "You didn't even go for glasses."

"Being kind of different is better than being totally different," Phainon preaches.

"I don't know, I see your face everywhere," Mydei says.

Figgy shakes to settle the fur under her collar. With her all dolled up, Mydei stands up and hands Phainon a tube of cream.

"What's this?" Phainon asks.

"For your ribs," Mydei explains. "So that they don't bruise."

Mydei's kick didn't actually hurt, but he doesn't have to know that. "Are you going to put it on me or…?"

"Handle it yourself," Mydei mutters, walking away and leaving him to his own devices. Rude? He has no appreciation for such a natural opportunity to behold Phainon's abs.

Phainon thinks about putting it on anyway, timing it so Mydei still catches him with his shirt up. Maybe if it wasn't a waste of medicine. Perhaps he could pretend he's putting the ointment on…?

In the end, Mydei returns not to the sight of Phainon oiling himself up, but to a man trying to teach his fully grown dog how to jitterbug. Phainon would have loved to show Mydei his progress with Figgy, but the ungrateful man doesn't let him speak, wasting no time in shoving Phainon's head through what feels like a tight ring of terry cloth.

"Hey, what the hell?" Phainon splutters as fabric slides over his mouth.

"Stop moving," Mydei orders, holding him into place.

Phainon frowns, but allows him to continue his work. There's a lot of tugging here and there as Mydei tries to work the headband over Phainon's wig, his hands shockingly gentle as they brush synthetic hair out of Phainon's face. To keep himself from being too aware of their distance, Phainon focuses on Mydei's braid, his eyes tracing the embossing on the cuff dangling over the man's sculpted clavicle.

Mydei steps back, finished with his fiddling. He slaps Phainon's hand out of the air when he tries to feel up Mydei's work, so Phainon toddles over to the bathroom to check on his appearance.

A red sweatband sits where the wig meets Phainon's forehead. Pieces of his artificial fringe hide most of the vibrant band, blending it further into his ensemble. It's not what Phainon would have worn, but that's the point, right?

"The hairline was giving it away," Mydei says. "Don't worry, it's been washed."

Phainon had the option to choose a sweaty one? "We sorta match now," he says instead.

Whether accidentally or not, the blond wig and the red sweatband nicely paralleled Mydei's fair roots and coppery hair. Ever the cynic, Mydei scoffs at the comparison. "You *are* colorblind."

Figgy barks to demand respect for those with difficulties perceiving color. Or perhaps to remind them of their greater purpose. As an apology for

neglecting her, Phainon and Mydei immediately drop everything to get her downstairs as quickly as possible, breaking out into a brisk jog as they hit the ground level.

The usual route takes around half an hour to walk, but since this is Figgy's day, Mydei allows her to savor her time with a longer trail. Instead of rounding back to the apartment, the three of them make a detour towards the street market further down the road.

For a weekday afternoon, there's more people at the market than Phainon and Mydei had anticipated. Even with some stalls being devoid of customers and others missing their vendors, there are enough people milling around to make Phainon conscious of his disguise.

"Stop messing with the wig," Mydei quietly scolds him.

"But it feels kinda loose," Phainon says.

"It's not. You're just making it obvious by pulling at it like that."

Mydei gets yanked out of their conversation by an excited Figgy, who has found a new playmate in a bushel of freesias. Mydei steers her away from the flowers before she gets too worked up, offering an apology to the vendor when they pass by.

While there are no more fresh produce at the market today, there *are* kiosks selling all sorts of snacks; be it homemade cookies or deep-fried-somethings. Oily food doesn't interest Mydei very much, but Phainon stares at them yearningly as if he's peering through the mists of Shangri-La. A by-product of Phainon's celebrity diet, maybe. Mydei indulges him by purchasing a few cholesterol bombs for him to do as he likes, although Phainon wastes half of it on Mydei, insisting that street food is made to share. As the dog happily exercises, the humans stuff their gob with everything that catches their eye.

"Season three had good moments, okay?" Phainon argues as he tosses an empty fry container in the trash. "Yeah, the show shouldn't have lasted that long, but at least it went back to what people loved about season one."

“Because they literally went back into prison,” Mydei says.

He would have said more, but Mydei pauses their debate about *Prison Break* when he spots a speck of sauce on Phainon’s cheek. He automatically moves to wipe it off with his thumb, interrupting Phainon’s rant about kingpins in fictional jails.

“Ugh,” Mydei grunts at his sticky fingers. “I need a napkin.”

Phainon pats at his pockets. “Crap, I think I left my wipes in my other pants.”

Mydei doubts Phainon’s pants ever had wipes or pockets, considering how form fitting they are. There’s no need for Phainon to fret though, since Mydei can always find a use for him.

“I’ll be back,” Mydei says as he hands Phainon Figgy’s leash. “Don’t go anywhere.”

Phainon salutes proudly. “Aye, aye, captain.”

After strolling about the market for roughly an hour, Figgy’s energy had finally been satisfied, allowing her to sit contently beside to Phainon without a fuss. Mydei had left them by the flower stand they encountered by the entrance, and since he doesn’t want impede their business by hovering menacingly, the least Phainon could do is to play the part of a curious customer.

A perfunctory look at the stall’s selection tells Phainon that they’re accomplished floriculturists. The flowers are all lush and vibrant, with varieties that aren’t exactly easy to grow in this region of the country. Little placards also accompany each pot with key information about their care and expected growth, though Phainon mostly skims through to read the fun facts at the end.

One flower in particular piques Phainon’s curiosity at first sight. A stout little pot sits half-shaded by the stall’s canopy, and in it lies a squat plumage of flowers. They’re still quite young, but Phainon can tell they’ll grow into

tall cascade of lush bells. That along with how their soft yellows fade into vermillion remind Phainon of a certain lock of braided hair.

“Are these bad for dogs?” Phainon asks, pointing at the flowers.

The vendor jerks in place, as if she hadn’t expected him to speak up at all. “Huh? Oh, naw, you’re all good. Snapdragons aren’t harmful to most household animals.”

Phainon makes the decision to buy the flowers shortly after that. The vendor kindly teaches him the essentials of taking care of his new plant before taking the pot away to be wrapped. As Phainon waits, a tap on his arm grabs his attention.

“Excuse me,” a charming voice hesitantly calls.

It’s embarrassing how two words are enough for Phainon’s stomach flip over, but he nevertheless greets the question with an amicable smile. “Yes?”

The girl in front of him gives him a shy look that Phainon has become quite familiar with by now. Especially when she pairs it with a coy twist that lightly swishes her sundress in the wind. “… Could I pet your dog?” She asks.

Ah, she’s curious about something else. Phainon’s instincts instantly back off. “Sure!” He answers cheerfully. Mydei wouldn’t mind, right?

The girl bends to stroke Figgy behind the ears. Mydei’s dog is pretty ambivalent to strangers, but she’s too much of a sucker for rubs to be hostile to the girl. At best, Figgy stares at her in confusion.

The girl doesn’t seem to notice. She smiles up at Phainon. “Is it a girl or a boy?”

“She’s a girl,” Phainon answers, snickering at how Figgy moves her head to guide the girl’s hand to the right spot. “Her name’s Figgy Stewdust, but we just call her Figgy.”

The girl gasps. “That’s so cute! That’s like the perfect name.”

“Thank you, I came up with it,” says a voice behind her.

The girl whips around to see Mydei, lifting her head in panic when she accidentally makes eye-to-pec contact. Behind her, Figgy breaks out of Phainon’s hold to run up to Mydei, reminding Phainon that he’s the side-piece and that Mydei will always come first.

The flowers also finish up at the same time, so Phainon trades in the dog for an armful of plant.

Mydei looks up from appeasing Figgy with scratches to ask about his new acquisition. “What is that?”

“I wanted to try raising some flowers,” Phainon says.

“You? You have time to take care of a plant?”

“Yeah, well. I thought it would look nice by your balcony.”

Mydei shakes his head. “*Haikas*…”

“Um,” the girl cuts in. Her hands cover her mouth in some type of emotion that matches her wide eyes. “I’m so sorry! I didn’t know!”

Mydei’s brow furrows at that, but the girl keeps going. “This is so embarrassing. I would never- You two are so cute, and your baby is so adorable. I wish you all the best!”

The girl turns to leave, but not before stopping to baffle the two men and their dog one last time. “I’m an ally,” she declares, her palm pressed against her heart.

Then she runs off to what is presumably her group of friends, who appear to laugh in consolation as she recounts the incident to them. Phainon doesn’t say anything that Mydei’s incredulous look doesn’t already convey, but he does burst into laughter at his shellshocked expression, which only pisses Mydei off.

“I left you for a few minutes-”

“I didn’t do anything!” Phainon says in defense.

“Now I have a plant and allegations… Did you do something in a past life to be this troublesome?”

“First off, it’s my plant-” Phainon tries to argue, but Mydei stops him smoothly plucking the pot out of his grasp.

“Let’s try to keep it alive first, then we can talk about who’s got custody,” Mydei says, briskly walking away. Phainon stands there watching the flex of Mydei’s well-formed lats before the theft finally registers.

“Hey! My flowers-!”

—

Barring a tiny hiccup during set-up, the recording for *Amber Dawn* has been pretty smooth so far. At the very least, Mydei feels they’re progressing faster than they did with *Euphrosyne*. The songs could probably go live by next week if they keep going on at this rate.

Becoming acquainted with the rest of their improvised troupe could have also contributed to their increasing efficiency. After days of collaborating together, Mydei can now recognize the girl trotting up to Phainon as one of their technicians.

“It’s the cord, I think,” Phainon says, tapping at his mic’s connector.

Cynane sighs. “I’ll have to check our spares, but it’ll take a while.”

“Then maybe it’s not?” Phainon says. He must have noticed Mydei watching him, because he’s quick to call him over. “Come here for a sec, we need your help with something.”

Placing his guitar to the side, Mydei gets up and walks over to the troubled pair. “I don’t know how to fix that either,” he admits.

“I know. I was just wondering if we could sing into the same mic instead,” Phainon says. “Like old times.”

“Please don’t,” Cynane says. “I don’t want to piss off my boss by recording you two on one track.”

Mydei looks over at their producer, who is shaking his head at the mixer. “What if I give you guys my mic instead? We can record the back-up vocals later,” Mydei suggests.

Cynane shuts this down too. “It’ll get messy if we start mixing up the sources. And Mister Phainon said the problem is in the cable.”

“I said it could be in the cable,” Phainon clarifies.

The trumpet player pipes up, “We could use the spare drum mic.”

“The drum mic is completely different from a regular mic,” the other guitarist helpfully supplies.

“Yeah, but we can use the cable, no?”

“I just said I didn’t want to mix the sources!”

“Guys,” the other sound technician calls through the intercom. “We fixed the signal interference. It was just the connection on our end! Please don’t touch the drum mics.”

With that, Phainon cheerfully waves Cynane off. “Thanks anyway, Arty!” He says.

Okay, so maybe Mydei needs some more practice telling Artakama and her sister apart. He’s still not too far off. Mydei doesn’t typically fraternize at work, especially with people he’s just met, but a certain busybody had taken it upon himself to turn this professional workplace into a convivial get-together.

Mydei supposes it’s not too bad. Conversations with people who understand his work can be enlightening. Like Mydei, the band and some members of

the sound team work freelance, but they have obligations to prioritize certain labels. Mydei himself has an agreement with *Phagousa Entertainment*, but more often than not he's producing something with the indies. From what he's gathered over the last few days, *Grove Records* is clingier than he suspected, because everyone he's talked to mostly mentioned artists signed to *Grove* and not much else.

As everyone in the control room finishes up solving what needs to be solved, the producer, Callinicus, cues them in for another take, "We're almost there. We just need one more perfect run."

With every compliment *Amber Dawn* gets, Phainon visibly brightens, to the point where it's almost blinding to see him smile. Mydei, who stands a meter or so away from the singer, is nearly incapacitated when Phainon shoots the band an encouraging thumbs-up.

The recording sign flickers on, and Phainon's playfulness recedes to something tolerable. The rhythm section opens the song alongside a soft sigh of a melody. That limp drum roll that Mydei once cursed has been reborn as a robust beat on a timpani - a nightmare to configure in tandem with the band, but worth every effort once Phainon opens his mouth.

If the drums are meant to be the bellow of a hillside battalion, then Phainon's voice is the breeze blowing through the valley beneath. Without the specter of a past song to pursue, Phainon and Mydei are free to experiment with whatever, and the result is a reflection of how their tastes have developed since then, a microcosm of the passing years. It's calmer sound, as if *Sun and Thunder* has embraced the adage of 'less is more'. When he's feeling more subjective, Mydei wonders if he just grew up to be boring.

The roar of the guitar assures Mydei that he's still somewhat interesting, as do the oscillating synths. Krateros had once asked him if he finds his songs too safe to claim as his, to which Mydei had jokingly denied ever siring an orphan. The truth is, his artistic pursuits are only palatable when there is something to bridge the gap, and there's only really one thing that Mydei has found that works.

“I kinda messed up the last verse on that one,” Phainon says as the take ends. “Sorry guys!”

The band jokingly boos him. “We should draw and quarter this guy,” the bassist says.

“Aw, don’t,” Phainon says, laughing. “One lozenge and I’ll bounce back, promise.”

“There’s too much sugar in those,” Mydei remarks. “It’ll dry up your throat faster.”

“If you say so,” Phainon concedes. “You’re sweet enough for me, anyway.”

“*Haikas*, are you asking to be punched?”

“Mom and dad are fighting again!” Someone tattles.

Callinicus buzzes in. “Don’t fight, please. We need to get this record done this month.”

“Can dad get me in the divorce?”

“What do you mean dad? They’re both dad.”

“Yeah, that’s the point.”

Mydei groans, but Phainon’s laughter pulls him back in. If that's not enough, Phainon ensures it by flashing him a plump heart formed with his hands, a sight that gets Mydei to misplay on their very next take.

Chapter End Notes

> I keep thinking that the 'slow burn' tag is inaccurate but this was such a yapacious chapter only for nothing to happen. I pray for the word count of this fic
>
> Thanks for reading, hope to see you soon!

Chapter 3: Side C

Chapter Notes

> I got E0S2 Phainon in 110 pulls so I've been busy touring him around the end game modes haha... The 3.4 patch also made me so sad that I had to keep going back and forth making sure this chapter isn't too heavy oh Shaoji when I get you.....

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The baking dish comes out of the oven swathed in plumes of steam, filling Mydei’s apartment with the smell of warm aromatics. The scent is a lot closer to what Mydei had envisioned, making him a little more optimistic about this attempt.

Mydei peels back the aluminum foil and gets a good whiff of those spices. Yeah, definitely closer. Everything else also seems to be intact. Mydei had accidentally fallen asleep waiting for the dish to finish baking, but it appears he made it in time. In fact, the additional 2 minutes might have made it slightly more tender.

The apartment is cast in darkness, save for what the oven light illuminates. Under its incandescent glow, Mydei places the baking dish onto the counter prods at it with a wooden spoon, feeling the give of each vegetable. Once he’s satisfied, he picks up a spoonful and tentatively gives it a taste.

He chews on it for a good long second, despite immediately knowing it’s all wrong. The taste is decent and he’d made the right choice with the charring, but the texture is still off. Some parts are too mealy, while others are too tough. It’s as if half the ingredients were only added midway through cooking.

With a beleaguered sigh, Mydei grabs the notebook on the counter and jots down another note on parboiling. He leaves the dish on the counter to cool as he cleans up, ready to be Mydei’s breakfast come morning.

—

“On three. One, two-”

Demos are like what a script is to a film. Without it, the film has no structure to work on, no sense of coherency or chronology. Even the most laissez-faire of films have a basic outline planned before going into principal photography. Like a script, a demo serves as the backbone of a song, the very thing a song is built-on.

And like a film, the end result of a song almost never sounds like that first draft. Who cares if the script called to be filmed under red LEDs? The cinematographer thinks it’s more dramatic in the dark, as well as ever so slightly cheaper on the electric bills.

That’s where the band finds themselves. *Amber Dawn* has been beaten into their muscle and instincts by the third day of recording, yet they harbor no complaints as they play on. For the sake of their paycheck, yes, but also because each new day breeds another variation of the song. Everyday, a new arrangement awaits them in the studio, with changes just fresh enough to be worth being curious about.

It’s clear that there’s a sound Phainon and Mydei are chasing after, one that they couldn’t capture in that rushed demo. They can’t describe what it is, but its form comes to them in heuristic increments of imperfect vocalizations.

The timpani slows as the song reaches its climax. Somewhere along the way, the outro had changed from an old school fade-out to a solemn reprise of the intro, and it has stayed that way since. As the mallet falls for a final time, Phainon repeats that first line once more, softening his voice to match the slow descent into silence. Everyone holds their breath to the decrescendo, letting its ending steep.

The click of a camera shutter fractures the silence. Someone snorts.

“It’s okay, we got it down,” Callinicus reassures everyone. The room collectively sighs.

Callinicus calls for a long break, and the live room empties out in what feels to be a matter of seconds. Phainon makes to depart with the rest, but the peace sign he flashes to the camera sends a bit of a mixed signal, leading the cameraman to take it as permission. The camera goes in for a closer shot, and as the production crew starts fishing for a reaction, Mydei wonders to what extent Phainon really tolerates the attention.

As if reading his thoughts, Phainon hooks an arm around Mydei's neck before he could make himself scarce. There's a million ways Mydei could have broken through Phainon's loose grip, but there's a total of zero that would have been acceptable on record. Which means that Mydei has to give the camera his best smile.

Phainon nearly jumps out of his skin when he sees Mydei's face. "Are you okay?" He asks, concerned.

A pinch at his hip revives Phainon's superstar grin. "Sorry," Phainon says to the camera. "Mydei over here gets a tummy ache sometimes."

"Yes," Mydei says through his crumbling impression of a normal human smile. "Too much air-conditioning."

"This guy's the real heart and soul of the songs," Phainon says, ignoring the insinuation that the air-conditioning is pumping straight-up miasma into Mydei's stomach. "He's the one that comes up with all the beats, the solos, the remixes-"

"I wouldn't have come up with them if it wasn't for Phainon," Mydei says truthfully.

"I just say things to him and he takes it from there," Phainon counters. "As you know, I never formally studied music-"

"-But good music doesn't only derive from the learned."

"That's a good line. What is that, Shakespeare?"

Mydei shakes his head. “I think it’s more impressive that Phainon doesn’t know what he’s doing. Music is purely intuition to him, so he works harder to bring it to the real world. That’s what makes it special.”

Phainon lets out a perfect laugh. “Modesty, folks. That’s the real secret.”

The crew thanks them for their input before leaving them be. Phainon and Mydei stand there playing the part of bosom buddies before Mydei decides that the arm around his neck is getting heavy.

“Why can’t you be this nice to me all the time?” Phainon asks.

“I’m plenty nice to you,” Mydei argues.

“Yeah, but there’s nothing wrong with giving a guy a compliment every now and then,” Phainon says.

“I say all those things so people can get to know you better,” Mydei elaborates, crossing his arms. “I shouldn’t be saying anything you don’t already know.”

“See? That’s what I’m talking about.” Phainon thumps a fist against Mydei’s shoulder. “Now say ‘Phainon is the strongest and handsomest in the whole wide world’.”

“*Haikas*.”

“You’re missing a couple syllables. Or do you want me to start? Mydei is the strongest and hands-”

“How are we *both* the strongest and the most handsome at the same time?”

“We tied, but if you want to step down, be my guest.”

“Hah, maybe after you’ve beaten me in arm wrestling at least once-”

—

It’s been a while since Phainon’s been the target so many disdainful stares. The last time was probably during that album cycle where he tried to pull off a 60’s pastiche. Or that time when he was pictured standing next to a popular actress outside a nightclub. Phainon appreciates Aglaea for drilling extensive media training into his soft-shelled brain, but he wishes she’d also teach him the etiquette of getting to his seat in the middle of a fully-seated theater.

“Sorry. My bad. Excuse me. Sorry-”

Would it be fucked up if Phainon admits that it’s a little exhilarating to be glared at by a bunch of dusty curmudgeons? Don’t get him wrong, he feels bad stepping on their toes, but it’s nice that he doesn’t have to overthink it for once, and that an accident can just be an accident. Phainon still tries to avoid stomping on their feet though; a broken toe is no joke.

After trudging through a trench of legs, Phainon finally reaches the seat assigned on his ticket. Naturally, Mydei is already seated beside Phainon’s spot, and as Phainon settles down without a single glance or ‘hello’ from the blond, he wonders if he’d left Mydei waiting for far too long.

His fears are unfounded as Mydei leans in and beckons for an ear. Phainon obliges him, allowing Mydei to whisper, “I told you to come early.”

“Couldn’t get out of the shoot fast enough,” Phainon whispers back. “This guy’s really popular, huh?”

Other people might take that as a low blow from Phainon. A popular pop singer would have seen whole stadiums filled better than the half-empty theater before him. Mydei, too used to the inner workings of Phainon’s mind, retorts, “You could use the competition.”

“No need, I’ve already got my hands full with you,” Phainon says, shifting in his seat to get himself comfortable.

The action catches Mydei’s attention. He turns his head to give Phainon a proper once-over. “…Hm, you dressed up to match the occasion.”

Neither Phainon or his stylist had intended to match him to *The Dawncloud Theater*, although Phainon supposes the bowl cut and the round frames makes him look the part. He fits in better than Mydei does, despite the turtleneck and the blazer doing wonders for Mydei's scholarly affectation. It does delight Phainon somewhat to see Mydei's navy turtleneck match with the subtle indigo of his wig; like a teenage girl getting giddy at the sight of her prom date's matching corsage.

When Mydei brought up his extra concert ticket, Phainon didn't know what to expect. He's attended a number of theater shows in his lifetime - even genuinely enjoying a few - but this might be the first time he's watching one from the mezzanine floor. He didn't think it would be any different from sitting in a theater box. It's fascinating how seats that seem so close could turn out to have completely different views.

Calloused fingers reach under Phainon's chin and pushes his mouth shut. "A bug is going to fly in," Mydei warns.

"The orchestra looks so tiny from here," Phainon says, almost reverent. "It's hard to believe we'll be able to hear anything this far back."

Mydei's chuckle comes out as a huff. "These seats are considered to be close to the stage, you know."

"I know, I know," Phainon says. "It's more like- I knew the place was big, but didn't think it was so… open."

"You should watch more shows here then."

"*You* should invite me to more free shows."

"Shameless." Mydei shakes his head. "What kind of economy makes a concert ticket unaffordable for you?"

A smattering of courteous applause interrupts them as a tiny tuxedoed figure exits the wings. That must be Peucesta. Phainon was curious to see the friend Mydei spoke so favorably of, but it's tough to get a good look from where they're sitting. He can only make out the vague shape of a man

walking over to the front of the stage to give the audience and orchestra a bow. As the clapping subsides, he steps behind the grand piano and waits for the conductor to give her signal.

Mydei mentioned that the concert might help them with recording their song, but as Peucesta launches into a beautiful display of finger dexterity, Phainon couldn't be any more confused. Did Mydei want him to add more piano to *Amber Dawn*? Is he saying Phainon should learn how to play one? Should they interpolate Tchaikovsky somewhere, or did they already misappropriate one of his themes by accident? Phainon tries to figure it out by maintaining a critical ear, but he's more of a lover than a critic, and it doesn't take long for him to get lost in the concerto. Despite not knowing much about this area of the music world, the song is too lovely for Phainon to treat so clinically, and it reverberates in the theatre with such veracity that it sweeps Phainon off his feet with ease. Even the company Mydei keeps is unnaturally skilled.

In spite of the orchestra's enchanting performance, Phainon's attention could only stand firm for so long. There are people out there who can handle prolonged periods of physical inactivity, who can sit hours on end without any kind of stimulation. Phainon had never counted in those numbers. He's too much of a plebeian to be fulfilled by cerebral pursuits alone, and against his better nature, Phainon grows more and more restless the longer the concerto plays on.

Something suddenly takes hold of Phainon's hand, stilling his jostling knee. As the clarinet serenades the tinkling piano, Phainon identifies the culprit. With his hazel eyes fixed firmly on the stage, Mydei draws lazy circles over Phainon's thumb, a diversion from how the rest of his fingers shyly slot themselves in between Phainon's.

It takes a moment for Phainon to recognize what the pressure on his thumb means. He quickly withdraws his trapped digit from Mydei's hold, giving the blond an indignant look at his childish behavior. Mydei pretends to be too invested in the performance to pay him any mind, but as Phainon tries to pin his thumb in return, Mydei's hand avoids him too readily to be uninterested.

The music escalates into an organized cacophony of keys and strings. Their placement isn't conducive to thumb wrestling, but if Mydei can evade Phainon while keeping their palms together, then Phainon will chase his thumb without breaking their hold. It was obvious they were tied in thumb strength, although the real challenge here is to carry out their game without visibly fidgeting or making a sound. The disgruntled lady sitting on Mydei's far side indicates that they've failed to some extent, but Phainon's got bigger fish to fry. As the movement reaches its apex, so does Phainon's assault, timing his chance perfectly to catch Mydei on a downbeat.

Phainon shoots a cocky grin at Mydei, who only rolls his eyes.

They very clearly agreed that Phainon had won, but their hands remain interlinked through the rest of the concerto, occasionally testing each other with surprise attacks. The last part of the concerto might be Phainon's favorite. He's a pop star, so he's a sucker for a bright sound. It was quite cinematic too, with Peucesta's hands ricocheting up and down the keys as the song rises in intensity. Phainon tries to eke out another win in the middle of it, and almost breaks his thumb in the process.

The concerto ends magnificently, leaving Phainon with slightly more admiration for classical music as they exit the theater. He's still not sure he understands though - either Mydei's homework or the music itself.

"What did you think of the show?" Mydei inevitably asks.

Mydei had taken Phainon to the hall that leads to the theater's backstage, where they wait for Peucesta to emerge. Phainon had been pondering that question way before Mydei had asked, but he's still not sure what Mydei wants him to say.

"It sounded like Celine Dion," Phainon says.

"Okay…" Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Anything else?"

Phainon has to really wrack his head for something, because the observations he comes up with don't translate well into words. He could move his hands around, use motion and mouth sounds to express how the

blabbitybibbity evoked *dippitydah* in the refrain, but that would only get him a spanking new straitjacket.

Maybe Phainon could start with how he felt. “It sounded like a funeral dirge.” Okay, maybe that’s too honest.

Still, it catches Mydei’s attention. “Really now?”

“I mean only at times,” Phainon starts. “And maybe it’s not something that would actually play at a funeral. It just sounds like something along those lines. Like someone was mourning and it sucked.”

“So it was sad?”

“Not really. It’s more like that feeling you get when something slips from your hands and you try to catch it.”

“Panicky.”

“No. Maybe. It’s like, you didn’t manage to grab it in time, and you’re annoyed that it made you feel bad,” Phainon elaborates. “I guess it’s kinda sad throughout, but I’d probably say that about most classical songs.”

“The second movement didn’t sound as sad.”

“The what? Oh, I think it was sad,” Phainon says. “It’s the thing the song is sad about, like looking back on the good times. I think it’s- I think it’s really, uh…”

“You think it’s what?” Mydei presses.

The flickering lightbulb in Phainon’s head stabilizes into a steady light. “I think… we need to change the hook,” Phainon proclaims.

“Huh?”

“The hook on Amber Dawn is too mopey,” Phainon says. “What if we dial it back, so it doesn’t get lost in the song?”

“Hm.” Mydei thinks it over. “I think I get what you mean.”

“Do you think Cal’s gonna be mad if we tell him we have to rewrite that whole part?”

Mydei shakes his head. “I don’t think we have to. What if instead of following the melody, you went-” He hums a line for Phainon, substituting the dip at the end with a higher note.

“Hey, that might be it,” Phainon says. How sinister of Mydei, to excite him for work when he’s on a day off from the studio. “Er, what about you?" He asks Mydei. "What did you think about the concert?”

Mydei shrugs. “I don’t know. I never paid much attention to the classics.”

“Too late to be humble now,” Phainon teases, lightly elbowing the other man, whose humorless expression remains unbudged. Phainon waits for a reaction, but the longer Mydei stares at him, the more Phainon thinks he’s missed something. “…Wait, you’re dead serious.”

“Yes? Why would you think I’m authority in traditional music?” Mydei asks, sounding genuinely confused.

“Because you told me I *have* to watch an orchestra perform?”

“It was a suggestion,” Mydei corrects.

“You literally said it would help.”

“Inspiration can strike from anywhere,” Mydei says. “And it did. Congratulations.”

Phainon replies with a punch to Mydei’s bicep, which earns Phainon nothing but a fistful of sore knuckles. “Why’d you even ask me to go with you?”

“I had free tickets.”

“So take Hephaestion or something.”

“He can go straight to Peucesta if he wants. As if Hephaestion hasn’t seen him play countless of times, with or without me.”

“Couldn’t you just have said all that from the start?” Phainon groans. “Here I was, thinking this was a business trip or something.”

Mydei crosses his arms. “You wouldn’t have come if I didn’t say so.”

“Hm? And why is it so important that I come along?”

Mydei’s wit fails him, and even as he recovers in mere seconds, Phainon already considers the upper hand to be his again. The blond grunts, “…I thought you could benefit from some culture. Don’t overthink it.”

With his arms crossed over his prodigious chest and his flushed face angled away, Mydei embodies the platonic ideal of every conflicted heroine in Cyrene’s trove of awful romantic comedies. Except here, instead of cringing and gagging, Phainon is unreasonably enthralled by the sight.

An indulgent thought creeps up on him. Could it be, that Mydei meant this outing to be a d-

“Peucesta,” Mydei suddenly calls out.

The man of the hour approaches the two, dusting a stray petal off his shoulder. Unlike how he had been on stage, the Peucesta in front of them walks leisurely at a gait that matches the vacant look on his face.

“Congratulations on another great show,” Mydei says.

Peucesta nods slowly, appearing neither shy nor arrogant.

“Any plans to do something else from Rachmaninoff’s catalogue?”

Peucesta shrugs.

“After your work with the youth orchestra then.”

Peucesta nods again. Phainon is in the midst of deciphering their conversation when Peucesta's gaze slides over to him. As with his slouch and his unhurried movement, Peucesta's droopy eyes communicate a haggard kind of tiredness, something of a running theme amongst virtuosos. Phainon supposes that's the reason why Peucesta turns away before snapping back to Phainon with full awareness.

"This is my colleague, Kevin," Mydei introduces Phainon with the thinnest cast of feigned innocence.

"Nice to meet you," Phainon says, playing his part."That was a great show."

"Um." Peucesta tries to speak, skeptically glancing at Mydei. "Colleague…?"

"Yeah, we work at the same studio sometimes."

"I… see."

"I told him a lot about you, so he wanted to see you in action. He really enjoyed it."

"Oh…"

Phainon has never been too great at reading people like Peucesta, but he knows what starstruck looks like, all wide eyed and slack-jawed like the pianist currently is. Peucesta stares Phainon down like a hawk, perhaps matching his face to the one in his memory. And to think Phainon actually put in effort in hiding his identity this time.

Mydei continues to practice his sadistic bent. "Do you recognize who this is?" He asks.

Peucesta shakes his head profusely.

"Shame," Mydei sighs. "Hephaestion already got an autograph."

Peucesta looks up at Mydei in surprise.

“He was pretty happy about it, though I think he’s planning to sell it online…?”

The pianist lets out a horrified gasp, which he covers with a well-mannered hand. He steals a few more glances at Phainon, as if he’s desperately trying to confirm his suspicions.

Mydei pretends to look down at his watch. “It’s nice to see you again, Peucesta, but we have an early day tomorrow, so I think we better head out soon.”

“Wait-!”

Peucesta calls out, despite neither Phainon or Mydei moving an inch. They wait for the rest of his orders, but Peucesta only stands there, frozen. It takes an awkward while before Peucesta clears his throat and reverts back into a world-class pianist.

“My mother is a fan,” Peucesta patiently says. “If you may be so kind to humor a request…?”

“Sure,” Phainon answers.

Peucesta excuses himself as he trots back to where he came from. Mydei waits for him to disappear around the corner before snickering.

“I can believe he recognized you,” Mydei tells Phainon. “I guess Hephaestion was right. He *is* a fan.”

“Yeah,” Phainon says. “I guess.”

The limp reply causes Mydei’s smile to drop into a puzzled frown. “What’s the matter with you?” He asks.

“Nothing,” Phainon mopingly responds. He jumped the gun and ended up shooting himself in the foot, is all.

It’s not unreasonable for Phainon to sulk, right? Like yeah, Phainon gave Mydei the go-ahead and they never signed any NDAs or something, but

surely there's something to justify his upset. Like Mydei's bad acting. He could have tried harder to conceal who Phainon was. Why couldn't he have just said that Phainon was… a friend or something? Oh, maybe Phainon should be mad for real. Maybe Mydei really did wrong him when he-

"I'm not ticklish," Phainon states bluntly as Mydei tries to tickle his ribs.

"You were when you were a kid," Mydei says, aiming for his armpits next. "There has got to be some part of you that remembers how to be tickled."

Mydei runs his hands everywhere - the junction of his neck, the length of his torso, and even all the way down to his knee - but Phainon remains unaffected. Unaffected in the ways that Mydei wanted, perhaps. The fingers that play his favorite songs and the hands that bake his favorite pies caress Phainon so enthusiastically that the warmth of his palms bleed through his designer dress shirt. There's no well of anger deep enough that would have allowed Phainon to remain so frigid.

Phainon grabs Mydei's wrist. "You should have told me you wanted to set up a meet-and-greet," he says, unable to make himself sound like anything but a moody child.

"Is that why you're grumpy?"

"It would be nice to know in advance," Phainon murmurs. "It's kind of a jerk move to spring it on me like that…"

"So you would have done it if I said so?"

"I wouldn't mind at lea-ow!"

Mydei cuts Phainon off by pinching his nose. "Are you a clown? Do you think I'm hiring you for a kid's birthday party?"

"Ack! Quit it!"

Mydei gives Phainon's head a rattle. A few stagehands must have seen them while they hustle about, but the cowards run off to mind their business. Fair, Mydei's nerd get-up does nothing to diminish the grandness of his muscles.

“Get this one thing straight,” Mydei begins sternly. “I don’t give a shit about who you are. You could be a council elder or a bus boy or a trailblazer from bumfuck nowhere, I’m not going to take precious time out of my day to parade you around Okhema like a handbag. Whatever dumbass conclusion you convinced yourself is happening here, erase it from your mind right fucking now.”

The irony here being Mydei’s own misguided conclusion, but Phainon prefers that over the pitiful truth. “I will, I will. Can you jus- Ow!”

Mydei releases Phainon, who nearly stumbles over his own feet from the momentum. He checks the bridge of his nose for a broken bone and finds not even the start of a swelling. “I’m sorry,” Phainon says pathetically.

Mydei clicks his tongue. “I’m supposed to be saying that.”

“Then say it.”

“I’m sorry you think too much.”

Phainon rolls his eyes. “You’re such a pain in the ass.”

“Glad to know it’s mutual,” Mydei says, stepping back. “…Peucesta is a dear friend of mine, but don’t forget, you’re here with *me*.”

…Dammit. Phainon must be a masochist to have that work on him.

Peucesta reappears, because a professional musician knows all about good timing. He returns with a marker and a brochure for today’s show, both of which he passes off to Mydei. Presumably because he’s too nervous to hand it to Phainon himself.

“Who should I sign it for?” Phainon asks, popping the marker cap off.

“Just make it out to Peucesta,” Peucesta says. “Uh, it’s P-E-U-”

It would be difficult not to know the spelling with his name plastered all over the theatre. Phainon signs the emptiest part of the flyer with more care than usual before returning it to its eagerly neutral owner.

“My mother would appreciate this, thank you,” Peucesta says, as though Phainon and Mydei don’t see him tenderly embracing the brochure to protect the ink from smudging.

Mydei rewards Phainon on Peucesta’s behalf by patting his head and mussing his hair up. It must be the first time a human has ever been jealous of a wig.

—

The microwave dings, and Krateros opens its door to the mouthwatering smell of roasted tomatoes and peppers.

The break room can only spare one table, and before Krateros could even reach it, he’s already shoveling in spoonfuls of vegetables into his mouth. The way Mydei watches him fills Krateros with empathy towards the judging panels of county fair cook-offs, so he decides to pour his all concentration on his meal.

“It’s good,” Krateros says.

“What else?”

Krateros looks down at the tupperware for help. “It tastes identical to yesterday’s.”

That makes Mydei’s shoulder deflate just the tiniest bit. “I chopped the squash a bit wider.”

So he did. “Sorry, I didn’t notice it changing anything,” Krateros says, pushing around his food to unearth more zucchinis. “Honestly, I liked it better when you were cutting them into flowers. It was cute.”

“Presentation is secondary,” Mydei mumbles. “But thank you for the feedback.”

“Sorry, I wish I could help out more.” Krateros may not know what he’s helping with, but he still wishes to provide an accurate assessment. Anything, as long as he can help.

Mydei shakes his head. “You’ve helped out a lot already. It just means that the recipe is as good as it can get.”

“Don’t sell yourself short. It’s beyond fantastic,” Krateros praises. He takes another large bite. “You know, your mother used to cook something like this on a grill. She’d throw everything into some foil and rest it over some coal for an hour.”

There, a smile. “I don’t see how it could cook evenly like that,” Mydei says.

“It didn’t,” Krateros laughs. “But I liked it anyways.”

—

A fender bender had befallen brave Callinicus this morning, if his tableau on the group chat is to be believed. It would be hard not to believe him when he’s got a picture of his car sitting bumper-to-bumper with another car. Unfortunately for him, the people waiting in the studio have a taste for good stories, and without their producer to tell them off for shirking work, they’re free to speculate as they please.

Callinicus promises he’ll be there an hour after the scheduled timing, which is ample time to leave the studio for a quick bite. Phainon and Mydei abstain when asked, their reason being a mix of diet and diligence. At least, that was the plan. They fully intended to work on *Amber Dawn*, but purpose eludes them without a band to boss around. Without greater urgency, the two wind up more or less goofing off in a studio that costs somewhere in the thousands to rent for a day. Phainon swears he knows proper decorum, but if he’s stuck in a room with an unattended piano, then by God he’s going to try and play chopsticks on it.

Mydei points at his hand. “It’s B.”

“I know, I know. I heard you the first time.”

Phainon’s finger lands on A again. Mydei snorts.

“You jinxed me,” Phainon accuses.

“I was helping you,” Mydei insists. “I’m telling you, use your ring finger instead of your pinky.”

The piano plays another flat note.

“The ring finger is the fourth finger, by the way.”

“I don’t see how that’s going to help,” Phainon says, frowning at his hands. “That’s just gonna stretch my hand out.”

“You’re landing short because you need to stretch your hand,” Mydei points out. “That’s why you’re hitting the wrong key.”

“That can’t be how that works,” Phainon says. “Why don’t you motivate me with a reward or something instead? Like a real teacher.”

Mydei narrows his eyes. “A reward like what?”

“Like… doing whatever I tell you to,” Phainon suggests.

“Slavery is a reward now?”

“Okay, wiseass,” Phainon huffs. “What about doing *one thing* I ask for if I get it on the next try?”

“If you get it right now?”

Phainon vigorously nods.

Mydei smirks. “Sure, go for it.”

Phainon hits him with one last smug grin before turning back to the keys. He begins to play slowly, but not slowly enough to be considered cheating. Just sufficiently paced for him to play a perfect little ditty.

“Son of a bitch.”

“Language, Mydeimos.” Phainon laughs.

“You knew how to play it this whole time, didn’t you, *haikas*?” Mydei sneers.

“Purely incidental,” Phainon swears. “And don’t think I don’t notice you chickening out of our agreement.”

“A Kremnoan never ‘*chickens out*’,” Mydei scoffs. “I’ll do whatever stupid favor you ask.”

“You promise?” Phainon presses. “Really, *really* promise? No matter what I say?”

Mydei sighs. “I promise.”

Phainon hums, gently tapping his fingers over the piano keys. “Then, could you play me a song?”

“What song?”

“The one on the shitty paper that you locked up.”

The unfearing Kremnoan noticeably stiffens, an indicator of his incoming refusal. Phainon’s not delusional enough to think that Mydei would actually agree to *anything* he asks for, but he’s been thinking about that song since he saw it sitting in that drawer. No matter what Mydei would answer with, Phainon would consider his curiosity quelled.

Lo and behold, a miracle shines upon Okhema as Mydei obediently complies with Phainon’s request - no argument, no snide remark. Only an acoustic guitar in his hands and a quiet cue for Phainon to follow him. Phainon almost trips over the piano stool to get to Mydei, who briefly eyes the recording booths before settling for a far-off corner in the live room.

The two of them sit down, half-hidden from the rest of the stragglers by a stack of chairs. Mydei plucks a string, and the courage instantly leeches out of him. Phainon thinks that might be the end of his favor, but Mydei valiantly screws his eyes shut and presses on.

Mydei plucks a tidy pattern of notes, just as Phainon remembered seeing on the tab. When Mydei plays it though, it seems natural, as if the song is nothing more than reflex. Phainon schools his shock when Mydei starts singing under his breath, keeping his volume so low that he's practically eating half the words.

Pop has always been Mydei's weapon of choice, so there's no shortage to love songs in his repertoire. From what Phainon could hear of its lyrics, this song must be one of them, though its sobering melody gives him pause. That might be because of Mydei's voice, so purposefully dry against the earnest music, but even through the most vile acts of sabotage, Phainon can't help but think-

"How much is it?"

Mydei had ended the song awkwardly noodling away, much like how its tabs had ended halfway through the page. He looks up at Phainon's question and eloquently responds with, "Huh?"

"If I said I wanted this song in one of my albums, how much would you charge me?" Phainon asks.

It's not often that Phainon discombobulates Mydei. He even forgets to glare at Phainon in his confusion, but he manages to recover with a resolute answer: "It's not for sale."

"I'm not gonna do anything to it," Phainon promises, holding his hands up in surrender. "I'll do exactly as you say. Hell, you can produce it. You can produce the whole album for all I care."

Anything, as long as Phainon never hears another living being sing this song in his place. Phainon dreads to think of it, and he has no idea why. The song is nothing special. It's not a particularly outstanding tune from Mydei, nor does it resonate with Phainon's own body of work.

But of all the songs in the world, please, *please* let this be the one to belong to Phainon.

“I’m not producing Phainomenon two,” Mydei deadpans.

“*No one* is making Phainomenon two,” Phainon stresses. “I mean, we haven’t decided what the next album’s gonna be like.”

“So you don’t even know if this would fit in.”

“No, I’m saying we can put anything on the album,” Phainon amends his statement. “Or maybe it can be it’s own single, if that’s what you’re thinking of.”

“I wasn’t thinking of selling it at all,” Mydei says. “It’s nowhere near finished and it’s going to stay that way forever.”

“Okay, but what if you decide to finish it one day? Can I have it then?” Phainon pleads.

Mydei looks exasperated, which granted, is his usual reaction when it comes to Phainon. His crinkled nose is supposed to come off as intimidating, but it only makes him look like a disgruntled kitten.

“I’ll think about it,” Mydei eventually yields, but before Phainon could celebrate, he follows it up with, “But get your wallet ready. I’m not giving you shit for free.”

Phainon laughs. “Did you forget who you were talking to? Name your price, I’ll double it.”

“Nothing less than seven figures.”

“The hell? Are you trying to get a head start on your retirement fund?”

“You said you’ll double it.”

“If you just wanted me to provide for you then you could always marry me, you know-? Why are you getting up? C’mon, don’t go! You can’t divorce me before we tie the knot-”

Callinicus arrives before Phainon could wheedle Mydei into some kind of shotgun wedding, but it's alright. The flush of red on Mydei's face persists long enough to satisfy Phainon for another day.

—

Phainon holds up an 'ok' gesture with his hand, as if the grin on his face isn't enough to articulate his enthusiasm. On the other side of the soundproof enclosure, Mydei starts the recording as Callinicus blasts *Amber Dawn*'s last take on Phainon's headphones.

After days of second guessing and fretting this and that, they've finally gotten *Amber Dawn* where it needs to be. The relief that fell upon the room was quickly put on hold however, when Artakama (?) brought up the timpani haunting the individual tracks. An imperceptible thing, but once they noticed it, it became the only sound anyone could hear.

So another day, it seemed. Again, getting paid is motivation enough to goad everyone back to work, and Mydei could only be happy to use up the studio time *Grove* so kindly offered to *Sun and Thunder*. Not terrible in the grand scheme of things, though someone is bound to complain if the song keeps stalling.

In the recording booth, Phainon starts to sing. Without the rest of the band and a guitar to tangle with, there's nothing to distract Mydei from the sound of Phainon's voice. It is infuriatingly similar to the quality of his teenage self's, except puberty and training has emboldened it and made it into a hardy force. Mydei has heard detractors say that Phainon's voice lacks character, that it's too indistinct in today's pop landscape, where strong singers are a dime a dozen. Mydei has always taken it to mean that Phainon's voice is flawless. Phainon could sing a ballad or yodel indoors or hit up a jazz scat, and he would sound right at home.

"Shit," Phainon suddenly swears right into the mic. "Sorry, could we try that again?"

Phainon didn’t do anything that warranted such an abrupt stop, but Callinicus pays it no mind and winds the song back at his request. “No worries, we have all day.”

“Thank you,” Mydei says on Phainon’s behalf. It occurs to him a little too late that there are people whose weekends they’re disrupting. Callinicus most of all, considering his role.

The producer waves off Mydei’s gratitude as he replays the track for Phainon. “No need for that. I love doing what I do.”

“You could always kick us out,” Mydei points out. “Or leave it to your people. I don’t know many producers who oversee entire recording sessions.”

Callinicus laughs. “Don’t worry, I’m not this hands-on all the time. I know how to keep a good work-life-balance.”

At that, Callinicus digs into his pocket and takes out his phone. “Look over here,” he says, unlocking it to show his home screen over to Mydei. “This here is my wife. She- hey, keep your paws to yourself, mister.”

Mydei quickly pulls his hand away from the phone. “Sorry.”

“Normally I wouldn’t mind people getting a close look at her, but you’re too big for me to fight off,” Callinicus chuckles. “I kid. She’s not the type to look twice at another man, even if they are the young strapping kind."

The photo is shaky at the edges, but Callinicus’s wallpaper still captures the woman’s smile with care. The child in her arms has a head lush with the same brunette hair and a minted 45 clutched in their tiny hand. All 3 of Callinicus’s great loves must be in this photo.

“You’re a lucky man,” Mydei says.

“I know,” Callinicus agrees. “She’s kind, intelligent, and she lets me come home to her. Someone could win the grand prize at a lottery three times in a row and I’d come out luckier.”

Callinicus hides his phone back in his pocket and turns back to the mixer. “She’s also Kremnoan,” he tells Mydei. “I like to think that she’d appreciate it if I worked a little harder on this song.”

Mydei looks down at the console. He didn’t think people could tell that easily.

In the years they were apart, Mydei had imagined a million different ways to use that flawless voice, quietly believing he could do better each time he’d hear one of Phainon’s songs in passing. Yet, when the opportunity came, Mydei could only relent. He had forgotten something important about the nature of songwriting, and *Amber Dawn* was barely in its embryonic stage when Phainon had caught on to it in his stead. Somehow, without even consulting Mydei, Phainon had wrangled those lost feelings into words far better than Mydei ever could.

Turns out only the perfect voice can write the perfect lyrics. Who would have known?

—

The sun hangs low over the horizon, and with its descent blows a cold, careless air.

Stalks of grain brush against him as he wades through the sea of wheat, occasionally disturbing the loose bits of chaff and depositing them into his clothes. Uncle Linos would have his hide if he found him wandering into his field, but better it be Phainon than the boy crouched amidst the high grass.

Phainon reaches the divot of disturbed wheat, and before the boy hiding within could be alarmed, Phainon greets him with an ungraceful roar. The boy responds with a panicked holler, then with a flimsy fist to Phainon’s chest.

“Cheater!” The boy accuses.

“Am not!” Phainon says.

Phainon approached with every intention to tell the boy off. How many times does Phainon have to remind him that the crops are off-limits? Is he going to keep doing this until he reaps severe consequences? A strongly-worded reprimand had marched its way to the very tip of Phainon's tongue, but one look at that little face scrunched up in anger and the rebuke dissipates. It's not fair. Someone so small and adorable should not be this difficult.

"You're the one who's cheating," Phainon finds himself saying instead. "Your hair looks just like our wheat!"

"Cyrene told me to use my head!"

"That's not what she meant!"

Eventually, Phainon takes the boy's hand in his and leads him out of the field. The sun's heat continues to fade with its light and the wind blows even harsher, but the friction between their knobby fingers is more than enough to stave off the cold.

Phainon's grip tightens. "I'll take you home, Mydei."

*

Blue eyes snap open. A groan follows.

Of all the embarrassing hedonistic dreams… Phainon supposes that's what happens when he sings about forgotten provinces day in and day out. Regularly seeing Mydei after an eternity of abstinence probably has something to do with it too. They've come together in the middle of the night to torment him with visions of impossible childhoods, a tribute to the greatest hits of Phainon's Twisted Psyche.

And yet, after all his grousing, Phainon is struck with grief as the dream begins to fade from memory. Phainon quickly lays his head back on the pillow in the futile hope he'll be back in those fields when he shuts his eyes. He lies there for about half an hour, startlingly awake and no closer to the

past. Perhaps there's a lesson here to be learnt, if only Phainon was lucid enough to grasp it.

Phainon's phone rings. "'mello?" He mumbles into the speaker.

"Phainon," Aglaea's voice greets him. "Are you at the studio yet?"

"Huh? I finished up the new song yesterday," Phainon says.

"Is that so? Why are people telling me that you're still recording?"

"Probably because they're still working on the new song," Phainon explains. "But the vocals are all done with, so-"

"A pity. The camera crew managed to rent out some decent lights today, so they were hoping you'd be available for an interview."

"I can be there in twenty," Phainon says, jumping out of bed.

"No need," Aglaea tells him. "They've been filming you for quite a bit now. I imagine it would be a hassle to have you come into work for a superfluous appearance."

"It's no trouble," Phainon assures her as he shimmies out of his pajamas.

"Phainon, I have your schedule with me right now. If you're not required at the studio, then you can take the day off."

"Yeah, but it's no biggie. I woke up early anyways."

"…Rather diligent of you."

"It's only one day," Phainon says. "It's basically a Sunday. Who relaxes on a Sunday?"

"If that's what you really feel," Aglaea surrenders. "I just want to remind you that we can take this literally any other time should you wish it."

Phainon laughs. "No time like the present, right?"

—

“Good work today, Mydei,” Krateros says, clapping a hand on Mydei’s shoulder.

“Hm,” Mydei grunts.

The hand slips off and Krateros sighs. “It’s nice to have you back for a bit. Sorry about… you know.”

It’s not fair for his agent to cushion the fallout of Mydei’s mood, so Mydei tries a little harder. “It’s okay. It’s not a big deal.”

Krateros gives him another consolatory pat on the shoulder before they leave their separate ways. Neither of them have been any good with words, but at least they’re not letting it fester.

They say you should find a job you like, so you’ll never have to work a day in your life. Mydei likes music. He likes writing and playing music. At the end of the day, he still feels like a working man.

His recent meeting was… not bad. Mydei prefers clients who are upfront with their needs, rather than people who come back with an entire catalog of changes *after* telling him to go wild. The thing that irked him was the request itself. They played him a song - a popular, highly acclaimed song - and told him in no uncertain terms to re-write it for another performer. When Mydei took issue with it, they laughed and simply said that this is how things are done. How else would the people they approach know their vision? It’s just a framework, a reference if you will. They didn’t want to phrase their ideas like so anyway, the whims of corporate has their arms tied behind their backs.

They went round and round until Mydei could no longer find fault with the task. Even if that wrongness remained clear in his mind, it was beyond Mydei’s abilities to verbalize. Worse still, Mydei sees a valuable exercise in the challenge it posed. To write something with the same essence in someone else’s style… it’s interesting parameters to work with, to say the least. He’s no better than the sterile management he’d been contending

with. For the price of a single song, maybe Mydei should learn to rationalize a little more.

Mydei lets the frustration out in one long exhale, his hands flexing around his steering wheel. He's sitting in his parked car, almost ready to go home. Whatever emotion plagues him is best left here, so he takes a moment to himself, feeling silly about feeling anything at all.

He drives out thinking of the things to do at home. Mydei has to wash his whites today and get started on dinner. Figgy needs a walk. She hasn't been to the park lately, and she's about due for a bath. The bathroom needs a proper cleaning too, but maybe it's better to wait for the weekend for that one. There's that detective show Ptolemy and Leonnius have been pestering him to watch. Mydei could catch an episode or two with Figgy while he's still relatively free. He doesn't know what *Grove* plans, but if it's about a live performance…

Lost in his thoughts, Mydei doesn't remember exactly when he'd taken the wrong turn. He was recalling what Phainon said the other day about a new billboard going up by the freeway. Phainon said he never got the point of blowing up photos of people into such huge displays. He said it makes it look like the city's being attacked by giants, which is a strange thing for Amphoreus's media darling to be unaccustomed to. So strange that Mydei has to see it for himself.

The billboard makes Mydei laugh immediately. You know what, it *does* look like Phainon is about to snatch people up and devour them whole, though the direction of the photoshoot seems to emphasize on a different kind of devouring. It makes Mydei laugh a tad bit more, enough to warm his cheeks. The general public seems to have gotten it in their head that Phainon is a figure of passion, sultry through his sophistication. The black and white filter certainly casts him as someone with sexual gravitas, and the undone buttons of his shirt show enough of his décolletage to titillate.

It's definitely different from Mydei's impression of Phainon - a man who prefers to buy toothbrushes with printed-on cartoons over toothbrushes that actually fit in his grip. It's funny to see him as an ambassador for cologne, especially one labeled as *intense*. Phainon has never liked strong perfumes.

There was once an instance where he and Mydei had to share a cab, and the scent of the air-freshener's artificial oranges had left Phainon so dizzy that he was cranky the whole day. Mydei wonders if that expression on the billboard is seduction or irritation over the cologne bottle he's holding. Perhaps if Mydei had been a target of Phainon's flirtations, he would have known the difference.

The minimum speed on the freeway is too fast for Mydei to examine the photo any further. Once he passes the billboard, Mydei is struck with the frivolity of his actions. He imagined escalating it further, texting Phainon to casually inform him that he's seen the billboard. He would have told Phainon that he laughed, that the singer looks good even as a titan overseeing the city. Phainon would have responded with an emoji or a sticker that evokes his stupid pout, and he would ask Mydei if it made him want to buy the cologne. Mydei would say no, but if he was honest, he would say it made him curious.

Mydei never picks up his phone, of course. It would make him too obvious. The most he can do is dream of it on the long road home.

—

Phainon's flight had been delayed longer than he had anticipated, but that doesn't stop him from arriving at Mydei's door at the agreed upon time. He forgoes tapping in the password for a knock, playing it politely in case Mydei made good on his threats to install a deadbolt. Phainon's manners reward him with the door opening to the sight of Mydei's frown.

"Why are you so sweaty?" He asks Phainon.

"I got used to Aidonian summer while I was up there," Phainon responds as he lets himself in. He wipes his face with the long scarf he used to cover himself with, another likely perpetuator of his unsightly dampness.

"Nothing to do with the fact that your plane landed forty minutes ago, I'm sure," Mydei says, throwing him the tea towel in his hands. "You should have gone home first, *haikas*."

“But I’m hungry,” Phainon whimpers. “Airport food sucks.”

“It used to suck,” Mydei corrects him. “Nowadays it’s pretty decent.”

“Yeah, well, it’s not as good as what you’ve got cooking,” Phainon says, sniffing the air. Mydei stops him before he could step foot in the kitchen.

“It’s not ready,” Mydei says. He looks embarrassed underneath his blustering, and rightly so because Phainon would never pass up the chance to rag on him.

“You’ve been tearing into me about being late,” Phainon says with a disapproving tut. “And yet here you are, slacking off on dinner.”

“I wasn’t slacking,” Mydei defends himself, jabbing Phainon in the ribs for good measure. “I thought I could fix up something extra since you kept texting about your late boarding.”

“Excuses, excuses. You had extra time, you know,” Phainon teases. “We postponed this for *days*.”

Tonight was planned to be a relaxed dinner to celebrate the end of their recording sessions. Unfortunately, their busy lives forced them to put it off for over a week, and now it seems more fitting to celebrate the songs’ release date instead. Not that the public knows about their collaboration yet, though Phainon’s been told that the news is bound to drop any day now.

“Okay, next time I’ll start cooking three days in advance,” Mydei says drily.

Phainon likes the sound of ‘next time’ coming from Mydei’s mouth, although something tells Phainon that he wouldn’t like hearing that. “That’s more like it. I look forward to your croquembouche, my good sir,” Phainon says, if only to explain the sudden onset of his grin.

“Go and wait then,” Mydei says, shooing him off.

“I’m *starving* and you’re asking me to wait? When your house smells like this?

“So go take a bath. You’re unbelievably nasty right now,” Mydei remarks. He wipes off his hands on his apron for emphasis, though it only brings Phainon’s attention to the baby chimeras printed on the fabric.

“But I sent my luggage home,” Phainon says, a touch more weepingly to guide Mydei’s answer. “What am I going to wear?”

Mydei doesn’t bite. “You left back-up clothes here, remember?”

Dammit. Past Phainon might have been a little too prepared.

“You should really take your stuff back before you forget,” Mydei continues to drive the knife in further. It seems Present Phainon may have also hoisted himself with his own petard.

New clothes or not, Phainon still takes Mydei’s offer of a warm shower. The flight had only been an hour long, but Phainon understands what Mydei had meant. He’s sticking to his clothes way too much to be comfortably called clean. Phainon tries not to be too much of an egregious creep by using Mydei’s soap as sparingly as he can, though he might have been too eager-handed when it came to Mydei’s shampoo.

Ten minutes later, Phainon exits the bathroom with renewed vigor. The scent of dinner has only gotten stronger since then, leading Phainon to follow its trail to the kitchen, where Mydei is diligently plating their meal. Mydei glances at Phainon over his shoulder, and Phainon fights the urge to shout out something trite. Something like ’honey, I’m home!’.

A grumble from his stomach thankfully speaks up for him, earning Phainon a soft laugh from tonight’s executive chef.

“I’ve got expectations,” Phainon says as he sits himself at Mydei’s dining table.

Mydei shakes his head. “If I knew you were going to be this demanding I would have gotten take-out instead.”

“Don’t say that. I’m sure whatever’s on the stove is edible.”

As if to prove a point, Mydei begins placing down dish after dish on the table, each one more tantalizing than the last. The pièce de résistance comes straight out of the oven, warming the house with the smell of earthy spices. Mydei looks like the kind of man who lives and breathes chicken breast and broccoli or medium-rare steak served on a chopping board, but his real preferences run closer to a grandmother's palette, all cozy and home-cooked. The spread in front of Phainon would not look out of place at a potluck full of ruddy-cheeked aunts, and there's enough to make him wonder if Mydei is expecting anyone else to drop by.

"I'm paying off my debt," Mydei explains, peeling off his oven mitts. Also chimera-themed, Phainon notes.

The singer chuckles. "Then it *really* better be good."

Mydei says nothing more, only gesturing for Phainon to have his pick of the lot. Phainon obeys, taking hefty scoopfuls of this and that. He pretends he's not waiting for Mydei to settle down in front of him, though he caves in when Mydei threateningly wags a wooden spoon at him. Phainon takes a small nibble to placate his angry server, not expecting for the very first bite to stop him in place.

Mydei notices the change from across the table. "Are you alright?"

"Yeah," Phainon answers as quickly as he can, nearly choking on his food in his haste. Mydei winces as he clears his throat.

"It's good," Phainon finally says. His voice is steady, his tone is light. "It's really good."

Mydei looks down at his own serving. "Glad to hear it."

Phainon takes his time eating, dissecting its contents and savoring every crumb. It must look odd to Mydei, who tells him, "You don't have to force yourself to eat it."

"I'm not!" Phainon insists. "I like it, okay? I like- I like it a lot. I just…"

There’s a dish Phainon’s mother used to make in summer, when all the vegetables become fat with sweetness. The ingredients depend on the harvest, but it always contained tomatoes and squash, even in the years where the bounty had been less than stellar. She always served it on the cooler side of lukewarm, not piping-hot like this. He remembers her saying it tastes better that way. He remembers, because she always used to chase his dad out of the kitchen whenever he’d try to sneak an early taste. She would stand guard until the steam subsides, then she would slather it in oil just as generously as the portion Phainon had taken just now, if not more.

Chewing further brings Phainon’s attention to the mix of rice and… something. Spelt maybe. It has the same pop of husk as the grain his mother would use. She always insisted on saving money by buying the crop that were harder to thoroughly thresh, but she always spent a little more to get yellow bell peppers for Phainon. Phainon adores yellow. His dad always said it didn’t matter what was used as long as it was grown in their village, because only in Aedes Elysiae did they enrich the soil with their fishermen’s scrap. It wasn’t until Phainon moved to Okhema that he found out it wasn’t the case. That never stopped him from agreeing with his father in private, that nothing ever tastes as good as what their village had to offer.

Mydei gets close. Mydei gets so close, Phainon doesn’t mind calling it good too.

“… I’m just appreciating it,” Phainon says. “Must’ve taken you time to whip this up, huh?”

Mydei scoffs. “I threw whatever in a pan and stuck it in the oven.”

“Oh.”

“-But I think I remember how it’s done,” Mydei adds. “I could write it down for you.”

“I’m not that good in the kitchen.”

“Get a personal chef or something to make it. Or I can teach you if you want,” Mydei proposes. “We can call it even after that, right?”

What would happen if Phainon said no? Would Mydei allow himself to stay in his imaginary debt? Would he continue to cook for Phainon as long as it takes, years down the line, long after their collaboration has finished?

“We’re even,” Phainon says. “You know me, all about forgiving and forgetting.”

Mydei snickers. “You’re a terrible moneylender.”

“That’s because I’m a pop star, not an accountant,” Phainon huffs. He goes for another bite, but finds something interesting instead. “Oh hey! Check this out!”

Mydei lifts his head to see a piece of carrot on Phainon’s fork. “It’s kinda shaped like a heart, don’t you think?” Phainon says.

“Interesting coincidence,” Mydei says stiffly.

Phainon searches his food. “I wonder if I can find more.”

He might have dug out some more pieces, had Mydei not dumped another serving out on his plate. Phainon laughs at his awful attempt at damage control, and for once in his life, Mydei lets him.

—

Phainon shares cryptic post, sparks speculations for new album

Fans of Amphoreus’s Deliverer were in for a surprise this afternoon as a new photo on Phainon’s Weaver page hints at an upcoming project in the works.

The image, which depicts a golden number ’10’ against a black background, left many in confusion. Phainon’s last album, *Atlas*, was released only 6 months ago after a year and a half in development. This has

lead some to anticipate another single from Atlas, with ‘Evernight’ and ‘Little Lion’ being fan favorites.

Others believe it to be a completely new release altogether. One Weaver user comments, “there’s already 4 singles from Atlas, give it a break already” while another brings up the photo “having different vibes” from any of Phainon’s solo albums.

The usage of the number ’10’ also received some interest, especially as Phainon has only released 7 albums since his career launched. A popular theory is that it’s a countdown to a special date, but it’s also a possible visual for a new album roll out.

At this time, Phainon is yet to post a statement. An anonymous source, however, claims that Phainon “is very excited to share what he’s been working on”, further implying the release of new music sometime in the future.

Comments (11)

beano098
no shot hes already got something cooking

kestrelsound
Oh my God please PLEASE be the Gardenia outtakes PLEASE. Its EXACTLY 10 unreleased tracks from the Catharsis era EXACTLY 10 months away from the anniversary WEST WIND IS ON THERE LET IT OUTTTTTTT

spanoNiki
Phreaks getting fed so soon… I love greed

antonioudora5
Journalism is so infuriating these days. Why is this written like any of this is fact? The photo could literally mean anything.

diamondgold
ok but they got paid and you didnt loll

phaiphaiphantasy
Awh I hope it’s a new album but I also hope Phainon isn’t overworking himself :(

skylanderscollection
My Deliverer!!!!!!!! He’s delivering content!!!!!!!!!!!!

livywashereee
it’s been 10 years since he won on astral dream maybe he’s announcing that he’s joining again this year?

47crush
phainon sex tape in 10 days #believe
  ButterEnjoyer
  Man come on

m4cad4mianut
new song to save this bum af summer pls

—

For all his dislike of their purpose, Mydei has to commend Grove’s public relations department for being so effective.

Okhema Tonight is a late-night talk show that has been running for decades now. The overlap between its audience and Phainon’s fanbase isn’t significant, and the show’s fluctuating popularity means they rely on Phainon to draw in big numbers instead of vice versa. It’s not the best use of his idol following, but *Euphrosyne* is an older song that appeals to a different time. Phainon’s marketing team made the astute call to double down on its nostalgia, made evident by the fact that this was the show where *Sun and Thunder* made their television debut.

They’re also observant enough to book an appearance where the performance is scheduled before the interview. As familiar as Mydei is with the pop charts, it’s been a while since he’s paraded himself in front of the masses. Playing the guitar is at least something he can pull off reliably, somewhat of a needed confidence boost to get Mydei through the night.

To ensure he doesn't make a fool of himself or declare international war on television, *Grove* had sent their best spin doctor to coach Mydei. She now stands imperatorially behind the songwriter as a make-up artist touches him up for the countless cameras soon to be aimed at him.

"And what do you say if they ask about your solo career?" The blonde woman continues to quiz him.

"Nothing," Mydei answers, holding in a sneeze from the sudden assault of setting powder. "That's none of their business."

"Aptly put, but do try to let them down gently," Aglaea advises.

Mydei tries again. "My solo career is not interesting."

"Less self-depreciating, please."

"I've been… laying low. Working behind the scenes."

"Better," Aglaea decrees. "You've left yourself open to a leading question, but I trust Leo knows when to pry."

The make-up artist decides at this point that Mydei has been sufficiently suffocated, so she dutifully turns his chair to present her work to Aglaea. The publicist leans in to examine him, getting close enough for him to see the slight cloudiness of her pupils. It takes some of the unintended intimidation out of the moment, though being under the harsh scrutiny of a beautiful woman is always cause for some stress. Even more so when she's dressed in a glamorous pantsuit that elevates her from the rest of the rabble, appearing more like tonight's special guest than Mydei does in his tattered leathers.

To his relief, Aglaea nods in approval. "You make a splendid canvas, Mydeimos," she says.

"Thank you," Mydei replies, unable to tell how much of her tone is meant to be taken as a joke.

“Had you been under my counsel, you would have had fashion houses by the throat begging you to represent them,” Aglaea muses out loud. “Or perhaps I’d monopolize you for our own line. Your distinct appearance could carve out a unique identity among today’s haute couture. To pioneer a new niche, perhaps?”

“That’s nice and all, but he literally asked us not to make him more famous.”

Phainon steps into the room, finished with his own styling. Aglaea shakes her head in response to his words. “I was only thinking of it. You alone remain to be my greatest accomplishment.”

“Good. I was starting to get jealous,” Phainon says as he slings an arm around Mydei’s shoulders.

There’s no need for Phainon to be jealous, not when he cuts such a dashing figure in comparison. The singer is clad in a simple combination of a dress shirt and slacks, with enough deliberation in the pairing to look unflattering on anyone else. The shirt is thin - not enough to be sheer, but enough to cling onto his torso like water. The slacks are appropriately classy, though the snug fit around his thighs are decidedly not. His hair, one side swept back and the other artfully messy, shows off as much as it can of Phainon’s face and the prowess of his make-up team. A nice mug like his doesn’t need much, but tonight they’ve placed some emphasis on the roundness of his eyes and the apples of his cheeks. Again, *Grove*’s PR team is betting on nostalgia to do their work for them. Young Phainon was when *Euphrosyne* first released, thus young he will look for its second coming.

Mydei shrugs Phainon’s arm off. “It's all yours,” he tells the pop star. “I don’t need to be pampered like you do.”

“You hear that?” Phainon asks Aglaea. “He’s going to be a difficult one to work with.”

“An interview with a rock magazine and a visit to a children’s hospital.”

“It’s scary how fast you proposed that,” Phainon comments.

Aglaea waves off his unsaid concerns. “It only works if he makes good music. The next ten minutes should be a good litmus test.”

Mydei almost asks what’s so special about the next 10 minutes. A production assistant thankfully stops him from looking like a dunce, kindly informing them that they are to head backstage soon to prepare for the show. Aglaea wishes them both good luck, and Mydei wonders if he could get away with pretending to be mute. Probably not, considering he’s singing backup.

He feels calmer once his guitar is in his hands. It’s a shame a roadie already tuned it for him, because Mydei would have appreciated having something to fiddle with as they wait to go on. Phainon fares better with the idle time, being accustomed to bigger shows and hobnobbing with miscellaneous stage crew. The sight of him happily entertaining a small crowd reminds Mydei of a little queen bee being swarmed by her conscientious workers, a thought that Mydei is annoyingly charmed by.

Once the intermission ends, the host begins magnanimously introducing their act. Mydei supposes it’s a part of his job to build anticipation, but ‘much awaited reunion’ is a bit of a stretch. *Sun and Thunder* is regarded as a curious possibility at best and sound pollution at its worst. The deluge of praises only conjure more butterflies in Mydei’s stomach, but a single smile from Phainon dispels them immediately. That might be the worst part of it all.

The spotlights flash open, bathing the band in a pearlescent glow. Mydei’s body is in action long before he becomes cognizant of his surroundings, plectrum slamming down on his strings with brusque fervor. *Euphrosyne* takes hold of the studio and breathes disco into it, audience preference be damned. Mydei doesn’t look up to check for their reception. If it’s not coming from his in-ear monitors, then Mydei will be ignoring it.

The only thing maintaining their favorable impression might be Phainon, who takes to the stage like fish to water. He projects pure merriment into the song with his voice alone, while the sway of his hips guarantees the audience’s attention is arrested on him. Mydei’s position may only afford him a view of Phainon’s back, but he knows the bold expression that

Phainon wears when he’s performing, and Mydei doubts that anyone in the room could find it less than spellbinding.

Phainon’s presence shields the rest of the band from the weight of the audience’s gaze, but there’s a moment in the song where he turns to look at Mydei. A silent question flitters between them, and Mydei thinks he’s better off refusing. Mydei’s not built to be seen, to be observed by the thousands of strangers wishing he’d been someone else. But Phainon was like that too, once upon a time. Frozen and scared witless, he spent their first concert with his eyes closed the entire performance, unable to stop trembling hours after they’ve left the stage.

Mydei shifts to the side. Phainon takes the opportunity to fill the space Mydei had provided, beaming widely as he begins to sing with his lead guitarist. Looking either at Phainon or the audience would spell out death for Mydei, but what’s he doing pretending he’s ever had a choice in the matter? He’s not sure if he’s even capable of looking at anyone else.

Their mics force the two to maintain a certain amount of distance, but the strength of Phainon’s stare makes it feel as if they’re standing chest-to-chest, breathing in each other’s breaths as they sing in harmony. Not one to lose, Mydei glowers back at Phainon to match his intensity, quietly praying for his foundation to hide whatever redness might seep through. The downside of having practiced the song so many times is that Mydei can play it without much thought, leaving his greater faculties room to fixate on the man in front of him. Mydei swears that Phainon’s make-up artist must have had a partnership with a lip gloss brand or something. The way his lips shine under the lights as if spit-slick and bitten… that can’t be Mydei’s imagination, right?

Phainon turns back to the audience as *Euphrosyne* reaches its climax, timed perfectly to make Mydei paranoid about his thoughts being too loud. He has to re-convince himself that telepathy doesn’t exist before he gets the courage to look up from his guitar again, which he only manages when the performance comes to an end. Raucous applause punctuates the last line of the song, though Phainon’s presence and the big red ‘please clap’ sign above the audience grounds Mydei’s ego. He only accepts the customary

amount of flattery, this time ducking away from Phainon's attempts to bring him over to the front of the stage.

In the end, Phainon gets his way with an exaggerated gesture towards Mydei, who remembers his role as *Sun and Thunder*'s second member long enough to give the cameras a pathetic wave. The host closes them out amidst the clamor of the audience, introducing them once more before reminding viewers at home to come back after the commercial break. The studio falls into another intermission, in which Phainon takes the opportunity to thank every one involved. He goes up to the studio's crew, the host, the band and gives his thanks in that calm, unhurried manner that expresses his sincerity.

When it comes to Mydei, Phainon can only afford a fleeting glance before they get ushered into their separate dressing rooms, but the beatific glint in his eyes makes Mydei's shrug look like treason.

"Well done," Aglaea says when she reappears in Mydei's room minutes after her make-up artists have accosted him. "You've proven my hypothesis beautifully."

"…Thanks," Mydei says, embarrassed by how gruff he sounds. "You probably should've saved it until after the interview."

"I disagree. Praise can serve more than one objective."

"That explains why Phainon's always asking for some."

"Phrasing, my dear."

"I won't do that out there," Mydei promises.

"Try not to, but it would be no problem to me if you did," Aglaea assures him. "I can weave a pretty tale with just about anything."

She says that with the confidence of a woman who has gotten away with murder. It's good to know that Phainon has someone he can trust with corpse disposal.

“Please keep in mind the points we’ve discussed. Even I can’t tell what would happen if you mention the Ladon incident.”

“Yes, Ma’am.”

Another PA stops by to lead Mydei back to the sound stage, and Mydei feels like he’s about to puke before he even gets to the couch. The stage where all the musical acts perform is placed by the live audience’s off-side, whereas the part that serves as the talk show is dead-set facing the crowd. It’s not elevated like the performance stage is either. The area is left low for a better viewing experience, leaving the stands to tower over the guests at all times.

Mydei sits next to Phainon, looking away from the crowd almost pointedly. He tries to imitate Phainon’s casual posture, but it’s as if Mydei’s limbs had locked up and left him hostage in his own body. He sits crumpled up as if its his first time encountering a chair. How did Mydei do this when he was a kid? Not very well, if he remembers correctly. The videos Mydei had studied beforehand had taught him nothing but shame, but at least young Mydei had the stones to sit comfortably; his obnoxious manspread notwithstanding.

A closed fist appears in front of Mydei’s face. He traces the arm up to its silver-haired owner, who levels Mydei with a serious expression. “I’m going to play scissors,” Phainon declares.

Mydei looks down at Phainon's hand before raising his own. After a count of three, their fists unfurl to reveal two scissors.

“You *really* don’t trust me,” Phainon says.

Mydei scoffs. “If that were right, I would have done paper.”

“I don’t even know what that’s supposed to mean,” Phainon admits.

“I could not be any more straightforward.”

“Now you know that’s not true.”

Neither of them have lowered their hands yet. Mydei watches from the corner of his eye as Phainon's scissors closes in on his, realization only dawning on Mydei moments before the webs of their fingers meet.

"*Haikas*!" Mydei swears as he pulls his hand away. He glances surreptitiously at the audience, searching for scandalized faces. He finds none, with most audience members too engaged with their phones or conversation to watch the stage.

It occurs to Mydei then that majority of the people here are watching for the other guests or the show itself. The negligent percentage that here to see *Sun and Thunder* are only really here for Phainon, and he's been sitting out on stage long enough his mysticism to wear out.

Slowly but surely, the tension in Mydei's shoulders loosens. "Don't be inappropriate," he scolds Phainon.

"I wasn't," Phainon says, chuckling. "You just have a dirty mind."

"Sorry if I was paying attention to your PR lady's crash course on rude behavior," Mydei says, not sounding sorry in the slightest.

"It's not rude," Phainon argues. Mydei notices his gaze flickering briefly to where Aglaea stands. "It's ruder to call Aglaea my 'PR lady'."

"What is she to you then?"

"Oh don't be jealous, Mydei. She and I are just co-workers."

"Wh- Your head's got a loose screw."

"What a rude thing for you to say."

The other guests return to the stage before Mydei could christen the studio with its first televised strangulation. Phainon, of course, greets both guests in that naturally disarming way of his, and in the case of one guest, brings up a joke from the last time they've run into each other. Mydei attempts to look half as welcoming, just to further separate himself from the word

‘jealous'. He doesn’t pull it off, Mydei thinks, but he doesn’t dare try any harder, still stinging from Aglaea’s brutal honesty about his fake smiles.

The show resumes once the host returns. Verax Leo is not the person who interviewed them all those years ago, but he did inherit the mannerisms and methodology of his predecessor. He employs the same kind of jokes and teases that leave Mydei on edge, while possessing the same journalistic instinct to know when to pull his punches. Mr. Verax may have introduced Mydei as the ‘bad boy’ of their duo, but he never tries to bait him into breaking character or pretends as if the stage persona reflects reality.

No, that honor goes to Phainon, who bears the brunt of the banter with an easy smile.

“So Sun and Thunder is getting an overhaul?”

“Hm, it’s tough to say,” Phainon starts. “We’ve been out of action for a while now, so we don’t really know what people are expecting. *If* anybody’s expecting anything at all. Worst case scenario, we’ll stick with what works and do our best to make it better.”

What a neat answer. Candid, informative, *and* noncommittal. Mydei imagines what it would take to get him that suave. Surely more than a rushed afternoon session with a publicist.

Mr. Verax holds up a hand. “Speaking of what works…”

Mydei tries not to have a visceral reaction, really, but seeing photos of those god-awful outfits being *literally* dug up on television makes Mydei wish for a black hole to swallow him up. Someone with a shoe-string budget had the brilliant idea to dress up two teenagers in the throes of puberty as venerable figures from mythology. The results ended up exactly how it sounds, and though Mydei can see their strained grins just fine, the distance between the photos and the camera would only make it seem as if Phainon and Mydei had wore them with pride. Mydei has to settle with sinking deeper into the couch to hide his shame, but he’s still holding out for that black hole.

“Is this something we’ll see on tour?” Mr. Verax asks.

“I don’t think so,” Phainon answers with a laugh. “But as the saying goes, never say never.”

The audience eats it up, cheering as if they’ve just witnessed their home team score a hat trick. The host taps the cursed photos in his hands. “Let’s hope for never, because it looks like it’ll be a tight fit.”

That might be targeted at Mydei, but Phainon is thankfully conceited enough to tank it for him.

“Is it?” The singer asks, craning his head to better examine the pictures. “I didn’t get any bigger, did I?”

“No, you look great!”

“Maybe I could squeeze myself in if I hold my breath,” Phainon says. “It could make the show interesting.”

Phainon speaks as if he could be persuaded to put on that ugly Lunabis costume again when he’s its biggest victim. The stuffy foam armor and the rough seam lines stretching rashes when it meets skin… Mydei is sure that costume violates a labor law.

Mr. Verax continues speaking. “It comes in a set of two, so I think that would depend on what Mydeimos has to say-”

“I’d rather go naked.”

The thought of having to dress up as frat party Solabis again spooked Mydei so much that it momentarily stripped him of his filter. Thank God people laughed immediately after. He imagines he would be found dead in the parking lot if they hadn’t. He’s still very much at risk of a concussion, but the startled snort Phainon lets out is amusing enough to make him forget that.

“That’s one way to make the show one of a kind,” Mr. Verax remarks.

“Last of its kind, more like,” Phainon says, shaking his head. He glances at Mydei disapprovingly, as if Mydei can’t see the twitch of mirth in his

trained smile. “You’re breaking our stylists’ hearts out here.”

“I didn’t say a word against them. They’ve never tried getting me into spandex.”

“Careful, you’ll give them ideas.”

“They’re too professional to go for low-hanging fruit.” Later on Mydei will regret this, but as long as his mind hasn’t caught up, Mydei’s mouth will continue to run. “Maybe you’re the one defaming them.”

“I trust they’ll do whatever it takes to make us look good,” Phainon says. “If people want to see us in tights then we’ll get in the tights.”

Someone in the audience lets out a ‘whoop’, and it doesn’t take long for everyone else to follow with a holler of their own. Everything about this mortifies Mydei, but he can’t shut up. “I’ve seen what you wear during your concerts. No one’s asking for me to be in a pantsuit.”

“I think that’s a lot of people asking for you in a pantsuit,” the host kindly cuts in.

“You raise a very interesting point,” Phainon tells Mr. Verax, sounding far more elated than Mydei would like. “More importantly, Mydei, you just admitted that you go to my concerts-”

“The clips are on the internet.”

“-You click on videos of my concerts, which I assume has me in a pantsuit or something similar in the thumbnails, correct?”

Mydei finally shuts his trap, but not in a way that’s good news.

“And, feel free to correct me if I’m wrong, you do that on your own volition, yes? That in of itself is proof of a demand for me in a pantsuit. And since Sun and Thunder is two peas in a pod-“

“I’ll take the old costumes, thank you,” Mydei hastily concludes.

Were he a wiser man, Mydei would have pointed out the fallacies in Phainon's statement and dispatched him with a swift riposte. Unfortunately, the jeering spectators and the blindingly bright headlights has robbed Mydei of all intelligence. Maybe Mydei is thick-skinned enough to live with being wrong, but the smug air coming from Phainon almost too dense to bear. Suddenly, Mydei wishes that interview would last for another two hours. Or until Phainon forgets the last five minutes.

It ends right on time, of course, with Phainon still sitting loftily atop his high horse. He bats his lashes cartoonishly at Mydei as they step backstage, and Mydei makes a mental note to look up the success rate of lobotomies once he gets home. He's only searching it up later because his next encounter with Aglaea might solve his problem altogether; when she solves *her* problem of Mydei's existence.

She thankfully doesn't club him to death, but she *does* laugh in his face. "Another solid showing," she congratulates. "I daresay you might be a natural at this, Mydeimos."

Even the way she laughs is poised and elegant, which makes Mydei's confusion compound further into a headache. "I'm sorry, I don't understand," he says. "I messed up in the middle."

"Perhaps, but showbiz is not an exact science," Aglaea says. "The most I could ask is for you to not insult the millions of people that could potentially see this show. If it takes insulting one to entertain them instead, I would gladly take it."

"You're hurting my feelings again," Phainon says.

"Sorry dear, but I did so enjoy the interview," Aglaea consoles the poor pop star. "Thanks to you both, I have plenty of new avenues to pursue. There's some publications that I specifically think would suit your rapport."

That's scary. "…I'm happy to hear it," Mydei says anyway.

Aglaea takes her leave then, to ring up the news outlet she was talking about or something like that. This means there's no one left that could stop

Phainon from speaking to Mydei. In fact, he can sense Phainon already opening his mouth to say something inane.

“This is my dressing room,” Mydei preemptively says.

He tries to escape inside and close the door behind him as fast as possible, but a production runner happens to exit right at the same time, leaving an opening wide enough for Phainon to slip in. Now they’re trapped in an enclosed space together. With *witnesses*, so they can’t even duke it out in a fight.

“You know, Mydei, if you wanted to watch me so bad, I could have given you tickets for free,” Phainon sighs.

“Hold on,” Mydei grumbles, rummaging in his pockets. “I think I’m getting a call.”

“It’s not even vibrating,” Phainon says.

Mydei turns away from him to take the call. “Hello? Uh huh. Yeah, that’s me.”

“I would have given you a VIP ticket,” Phainon continues talking as Mydei occupies himself with his phone. “It doesn’t even have to be a concert in Okhema. I would take you out wherever you want. Carmitis? Janusopolis? I’d even take you to Styxia if the lizards would stop being an issue for one second.”

“Yeah. Uh huh. Yes, I understand.” Mydei pulls the phone away from his ear. He politely covers the speakerphone before somberly telling Phainon, “It’s the buttface police. They said they have a warrant for your arrest.”

“Are you five years old?”

“They also said you stink and they’re tracking you by your giant stink lines.”

“Okay, give me that.”

Phainon tries to grab the phone away from Mydei, and in the span of a few familiar motions, the two find themselves grappling each other instead, phone lying neglected on the floor. Everyone else in the room jumps to break them apart, mistaking the glee in their faces for unbridled animosity.

Apparently, Phainon's clothes were lent to him for the show's taping. Aglaea does her best to make Mydei understand what that means.

"Next time," Aglaea mutters as she fixes a wrinkled collar. "Wait until he's naked."

They both choke at the same time. It seems this fight ends with a tie.

Chapter End Notes

> Got 2 more Phainons and Tribbies before the banner ended, thank you Chuu! I hope your pulls also went well, and if not I hope the universe pays you back ASAP
>
> Thanks for reading, hope to see you soon!

Chapter 4: Side D

Chapter Notes

> I thought there was only 3 scenes left but in actuality it was 3 chapters??? I didn't want to update anything until I got everything finished, but I also didn't want to end the year without anything to show for it so here's around half of my hell document! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

rockefort @hold0nsugar
wtf was that lmaooo

> **kyria** @girlnoodle05
> ikkkkk cause like why is he embarrassing me lowkey…
> **rockefort** @hold0nsugar
> doing ts when hes been edging us w/ the ichor b-sides for years,,, hes so unserious

> **Irini saw Phainon on 04/16 !!!** @umphoricMorn
> It’s so disappointing because this is just going to delay Phainon’s 8th album unless he’s not going to get a break this year
> **rockefort** @hold0nsugar
> like was he bored? literally no one asked for this fshjsfdkj

---

Number 1 Ionic Pillar Fan 🏛 @jumpjiinkies

My parents rolled their eyes when I said I wanted to borrow the TV to watch Phainon but guess who were the ones telling me to turn up the volume before the song even started!!!!!

Freska @ily456ver
@Phainon_Gr The rent cannot possibly be this high brother

Honey Bunches @rosiesandposies
no shade but that other guy is so scary kgdfmkdm

Phainon’s legal team @deardestruct
my man sounds sooooo good on that stage but omg begging someone on the sound team to mute the second mic aint no one tryna hear some fuckass grunting 😭

> **tala** @phainShizz
> legit can you imagine spending 200+ on a ticket to hear mid
> **Phainon’s legal team** @deardestruct
> i cantttt omfg not another gr*ve scam
>
> **angel** @deliverfrmchaos
> it made me so mad bro like people heard this and was like yeah sounds good lets do it
> **Phainon’s legal team** @deardestruct
> @GroveRecords fire everyone responsible now please

Chu Chu @phainonsense

Did anyone under 45 like that show or like….

---

iki @revolutionarrie
the other dude was kinda hot until he opened his mouth

> **Lazz** @Cl0udieDaze
> He’s still kind of hot even if he doesn’t sound that great…
> **iki** @revolutionarrie
> LOL i meant he was being a rude tryhard and it rubbed me the wrong way
> **Lazz** @Cl0udieDaze
> Oh yeah omg he was trying too hard to show up Phainon and it got embarrassing

---

Xenia @dutifulDayDreamer
seeing lots of snt slander on the tl today… open the schools

> **gav** @puresplosion4000
> pretending sun and thunder wasnt THE BLUEPRINT like hello???
> **Xenia** @dutifulDayDreamer
> posers everywhere I see where the real lovers at?
>
> **monina** @coughesyrup
> phainon antbindling when he sees people don’t fw the 2 week talking stage situationship that changed the course of his life forever
> **Xenia** @dutifulDayDreamer
> this is frying me wtf are you saying
> **check your dryer lint drawer** @fuddybuffy
> She’s welcoming back Fleetwood Mac

RENA @Fortune_bringer
ran out of ideas so he went back to his old shit and fraudnon fans still ate it up

---

aaaaaaa @disphaissession
Ngl the interview did make me laugh… they should cancel the concerts and schedule a stand up comedy tour

---

Ophelia @minnietruther
Phainon really said ‘lets not forget the hags now’

☆★**Hanabi**★☆ @PhaiNocturnal

Is it just me or is this mini tour weird to anyone else…?

> ☆★**Hanabi**★☆ @PhaiNocturnal
>
> Likeeee I love having more Phai but I feel like they’re stepping on his fans to cater to a totally different audience. It’s kind of misogynistic

because his fans are mostly made up of young women and the Ok Tonight show was a total rebrand >.<

---

echooooo @toasticrustina
Phainon’s fans really said ‘let’s forget about the hags now’.

Raf @Saintsaran
My classmates called me gay slurs all throughout high school because they saw me buying the Sun and Thunder album. If they’re not for the girls and they’re not for the boys, then who are they for?

> **2 wubbubus and a mocha** @d34thblowj
> the mute button
> **Raf** @Saintsaran
> Trueeeee
>
> **double decker sandwich** @cremedellacreme
> always makes me laugh… the teenage boy alt pop group not being for the girlies… girllllll
> **Stream INSIDE** @swy2mbtncsms
> maybe it was back then but now? ill fight off a hundred women to climb That Man like a tree hubba hubba
> **Raf** @Saintsaran
> Security! Get this guy away from me!!!

Et tu, jstor? @polarinstant
In Amphoreus you can’t shill to revive your flagging sales without a rando saying you hate women

> **nifty** @agayanwaterss
> He’s misogynistic but he LOVES old people he’s a #CougarAlly #ThatsMyGOAT

Phainon’s Jockstrap @eteRnITywu
I’m a Phainon fan AND I thought the Euphrosyne show was awesome. It looks like hell on my tl [photo]

> **Esphur** @bakaratroach
> you’re just bisexual
> **Phainon’s Jockstrap** @eteRnITywu
> Cut Me Some Slack. P;ease

Corr @saltspring34
They just redid a 10 year old song so they can charge money for it again lmao this is so low effort I can’t

---

auo @destinationova
STOPPPP STOP SAYING EUPHROSYNE SUCKS STOPPP

auo @destinationova
euphrosyne is legitimately too good to be discourse pleaseeee phainon loves that song so so much thats why it rules he and his 2 week situationship put all 2 of their braincells into euphrosyne and i cant have you all putting this much disrespect into it grrrgrrr
lila @wiredaNdtired
helpppp not people calling him the 2 week situationship does anyone even know his guitarist's name??
mydeimos sun and thunder are you single? @phaimousphaces
yes his name is My Husband
lila @wiredaNdtired
did you change your pfp to the guy's crotch helpp
Princessa @ heiressof_song
blurry af photo too 4k hd imax release when?

---

soPHia @phaisarmveins
oomf is locked in battle with some old guy over mydeimos in the replies of the ok tonight show

soPHia @phaisarmveins
and she's losing.

mud time @atlasshagged
that old guy has been fighting everyone calling mydeimos mid and honestly I respect the grind
soPHia @phaisarmveins
me in the retirement home defending phainon after he starts selling asbestos to single mothers

---

P @PhainonPatrol
Stop that. Respect Phainon's roots. #SunAndThunder

Eagle Eyed @mOOngiver
damn even the phainon update pages are hopping on to say smt phreakwvr in shambles rn

---

Mr Reca Release The Director's Cut Please @alabastarding
Im in tears I thought this email notif was from my boss but its just a notification telling me that the blog I followed like 10 years ago just updated her fic???

> **Trainspotter** @magmasoup
> i was going to say its strange that happened to me today too but… is it n1ce_casper?
> **Mr Reca Release The Director's Cut Please** @alabastarding
> LMAO dont out me like that twin
> **Trainspotter** @magmasoup
> dsdsfkjfsd im not im just saying im not surprised we were in the sun/der trenches together
> **Mr Reca Release The Director's Cut Please** @alabastarding
> Ikr nicecasper doing more to hype up the reunion than phainons marketing team

---

Jaye @KremFreche

euphrosyne is gas when you have no debt

---

memi @PhiLia093
This reminds me that I got my first girlfriend by showing her my limited print Sun and Thunder EP [photo]

> **Francie** @awochimchim
> Sun and Thunder for lesbian rights
> **memi** @PhiLia093
> !
>
> **jana** @33riecomplex
> they only released that in taikiyan omg you're so lucky
> **memi** @PhiLia093
> Heehee :D
>
> **pk** 🎗 @neikos00000001
>
> I thought I lost that record have you been using it to hit on girls this whole time?
> **memi** @PhiLia093
> Love you too!

---

shackshuka @bbbideinflames
Cryingggg these before and after pics of mydeimos [photo] [photo]

> **shackshuka** @bbbideinflames
> What a keto diet does to a mf

5 time dreamy slots victim @baldingrage
they fed him nothing but tomahawk steaks for 10 years

agrippa @scentuari
I need his testosterone dealer zamnnn
iley @sugardrop
waiter get me the testosterone with a side of mega sauced protein please!

Vern @optimisticpos
Visual representation of the market turning Bearish

---

barking respectfully @logarthimik
Come watch my Mydeimos fancam [video]

Lo-fi Beets to Shake Up Your Salad @354bowhouse
was the slow mo on his pecs necessary?
barking respectfully @logarthimik
“Come watch my Mydeimos titty fancam” was too wordy

mydeimos sun and thunder are you single? @phaimousphaces
you saved my life thabk you

phainon’s mauve socks @goIdphinery
I think I get it now.

yeowch! @EverMornincj
dan mydi your bobbie s

The initial onslaught of apprehension doesn’t seem to be letting up any time soon, but Phainon has too much trust in Aglaea too much to fret just yet. Negative feedback upsetting to see, yes, but there’s at least a few lone souls out there with good taste. It takes a small amount of searching to find them, and as… tawdry as the posts are, it’s proof that there’s an audience Mydei can appeal to.

Did Phainon make a new private account specifically to archive all the posts about his mysterious new guitarist? No comment. Is his phone storage suddenly weighed down from all new photos and videos taking up precious space? Purely research, Phainon insists.

“Does the creepy collage of his hands count as research too?”

Phainon isn’t proud of the sound he made when he felt a sudden whisper in his ear, but Cipher is. Her Cheshire grin serves to taunt him further, as if Phainon isn’t used to her brand of mischief by now. It’s a good reminder that Phainon shouldn’t be talking to himself in a corridor accessible to hundreds of employees.

“Hello, Cipher,” Phainon greets her placidly. “I didn’t know Aglaea was coming in today.”

“She’s not,” Cipher says, brushing off her thick coat. Phainon suspects she keeps her guard uniform in impeccable condition simply for the irony. “That’s not going to make me forget what I saw on your phone, by the way.”

“I didn’t think you’d want to talk about it.”

“You’re right about that,” Cipher groans. “Those photos need to be powerwashed out of my brain, *blech*.”

Phainon smiles. “I hope that taught you a lesson on peeping.”

“Why's that my fault now? You’re the one looking up creep shots of your coworker in the middle of a busy office,” Cipher says, jabbing Phainon in the chest with each accusation.

Phainon inconspicuously glances around the hall as he gestures for her to zip it. No one is probably listening in, though if they were, they would have a hell of a hit piece to knock Phainon down with.

“It’s for research,” Phainon insists, hoping that saying it even louder would make it ring true. “I can’t help it if that’s what people are posting about the guy.”

“An academic now, are you?”

“It’s true,” Phainon insists. “Aglaea was worried about him.”

“Hm. And here I thought she was happy with the little prince…”

“She is,” Phainon swears. “But you know Aglaea, always coming up with contingency plans. I mean, I wouldn’t be the one looking this up if the rest of her team wasn’t so busy.”

“Sheesh, leaving their main star with the grunt work,” Cipher says with a shake of her head. “This dump gets lousier by the day.”

She’s too adept at sarcasm for Phainon to detect any, but most people know not to take her words at face value. Phainon’s sure that Cipher would have continued teasing him anyway if the subject matter wasn’t so mutually appalling. He takes the opening to circle back to the beginning: “So why aren’t you with Aglaea anyway?”

“‘Cause you’re not as slick as you think,” Cipher says. She picks on a hangnail, sounding half-bored. “Your bodyguards have some awfully fat pockets for a pair of bozos missing in action.”

“There’s not a lot of action when I’m working on a song,” Phainon points out. His heart hammers in his chest, held back by a flimsy mantra that’s more delusion than truth. *She’s bluffing. She doesn’t know. No one knows. How would she know?* “And I didn’t want them to go broke because I keep sending them home.”

“See you say that, but I smell something fishy brewing in that clever little head of yours.” Cipher squints at Phainon as if she’s spotted something to crack the case wide open. Then it’s gone in a flash, too serious for Cipher to care about for more than a second. “You’re lucky I don’t give a damn. I had half a mind to give you hell while I’m temporarily assigned to you, ‘cept it’s bad karma to shit on a kid just ‘cause he’s a suckass.”

“Oh.” This is the first Phainon’s heard of this reassignment. “Who’s with Aglaea now then?”

“Barty, obviously. No one’s gonna mug her anytime soon, she says, so she’s making do with that bum and a taser gun.”

“I guess… that’s not too bad?”

“Speak for yourself,” Cipher huffs. “Aglaea goes to spa centers and fancy tailor shops that give out refreshments for free. *You* go to the sweatiest stadiums out in the ass end of Amphoreus.”

“I have to be honest, I don’t feel very protected right now.”

“Have some faith, wise guy.” Cipher elbows him. “I’ll do whatever it is they’re paying me for. I’m just saying, it might look like there’s too many middlemen to keep count, but that doesn’t mean you don’t have eyes on you.”

Oddly more threatening than enlightening. If Phainon didn’t know better, he would have assumed the arrest on her record had something to do with racketeering, and not petty thievery.

“You’ve been watching too many mafia films,” he says.

Cipher throws her hands up. “Hyacine was the one who chose Mean Streets last time, okay?”

“Really?” Phainon asks, pulling his phone out. “Not a slasher?”

“Not even a Kalevalan comedy,” Cipher reports.

Phainon opens his phone. He's been neglecting the movie night group chat due to his busy schedule, and he estimates that he's at least 3 movies behind the current assignment. He would have checked the exact number if his phone hadn't automatically opened to Weaver and blasted a discriminating video out loud.

Phainon swiftly turns the screen off. He glances at Cipher, who appears to have gone through some kind of harrowing experience. Not a fan of armpits, Phainon reckons.

She grimaces at him. "Are we going to do this the whole time I'm with you, or…?"

"Absolutely not," Phainon says, immediately hiding the phone away in his jean pockets. He thinks of it for a second longer. "Don't tell anyone."

"You're *really* not helping your case here, hotshot."

Phainon takes out a 50 from his wallet and places it in her waiting hand.

"You're suspiciously quick with that," Cipher remarks. She pulls her hand away before Phainon could rescind his generosity. "Wasn't complaining. Just admiring."

"You know how the smallest things become the worst rumors," Phainon says.

"If you were really worried about that, you wouldn't be jerking it in the open, would you?"

"I wasn't jerking anything-"

The sound of a door swinging open interrupts their conversation. Literally, because the door is situated right in-between the two of them. Phainon steps back from its trajectory to see Anaxa scowling at them both from the doorway, doing a poor job of hiding them from the rest of the meeting room's occupants.

“Is there some kind of half-wit convention happening in the corridor?” Anaxa sneers. “Did they make it illegal to have silence when people are trying to hold a discussion in peace?”

“You told me to wait out here,” Phainon argues. It’s the wrong thing to say, judging from the furrow of Anaxa’s brow, but it *is* factually right.

“If you’re so adamant to chat, you should go to the lounge or the cafeteria,” Anaxa sidesteps the accusation. “Or a fire escape or a bathroom. Go anywhere, as long as it doesn’t disturb the people trying to stay gainfully employed.”

He fixes his judgmental eye on Cipher, still displeased. “I told them to fix up Phainon’s security. Why is it that *you’re* the one who comes calling?”

“Wasn’t my decision,” Cipher says with a shrug. “I’m just filling in for now ‘cause it’s short notice.”

“Cerces help this sinking ship of a company,” Anaxa mutters.

“That’s what I said!”

“Just keep an eye on him,” Anaxa tells her. “I don’t care about what you do as long as you do a better job than the no show parasites leaving us high and dry.”

He shuts the door after that. The middling thump it makes is either an attempt to restrain his anger or the best slam his feeble arms can muster. And to think he always refuses Phainon’s invitations to work out…

“Man, you have these people under some Jedi mind-shit,” Cipher says, striding down the hall.

“I don’t know what you mean,” Phainon replies as he follows her out of Anaxa’s hair. “I just keep it honest, is all.”

Cipher cackles. “You’re in the entertainment industry, kid. You gotta keep some cards close to your chest to strike it big, and you’re not exactly a small-fry, are you?”

Pearls of wisdom from a lifelong cynic. Phainon thinks he's got too much joie de vivre for Cipher's preaching to land, but there are times where her experiences are too universal to shrug off.

"It helps to help people," Phainon puts it simply.

"And that's why you're cyberstalking someone on company time."

"I'm starting to think you're doing this on purpose."

"Took you forever to figure that out, genius."

—

"-You're listening to thirty three point three FM and that was 'Had I Not Seen The Sun' from Robin's new album, 'Inside'!"

As one red-headed sister makes her announcements, another presses a button on the soundboard to summon a sound bite of noise makers and cheers. The last is busy flipping through a set of handwritten notecards, perhaps revising their questions for the segment to come.

A radio show is more like Mydei's speed. There's less witnesses for one, which means there's no dress code that requires Mydei to be professionally groomed for an hour straight. It's also closer to Mydei's interests, with its old-fashioned set-up supplemented by state-of-the-art equipment. The console must be at least twenty years old now, whereas the Rode mic pointed at Mydei's face was only made available for purchase a month ago. Mydei is predictably amused by the living history at play.

The one thing that leaves Mydei at a loss is the radio hosts themselves. He's known since forever that the hosts of *Janus's Table* are a set of triplets, but it's sort of a non-sequitur when listening to the show, where their distinct voices keeps them recognizable. If not for their hairstyles, the three sisters would be indistinguishable from one another in person. Mydei could just about tell them apart from their clothes, but their matching names stumps him completely.

“Welcome back to Janus’s Table!” One sister roars into the mic. Her hair is the shortest of the three, with an undercut so severe it almost comes off as a mohawk. “We’ve got a guest today that might be familiar to most of you-“

“-And a guest that we’re proud to re-introduce to new listeners,” adds the second sister. She has a perfect bob that bounces with every girlish giggle. “Together they make one of the bands that influenced the pop boom in the late aughts! Let’s all give a warm welcome to Sun and Thunder’s Phainon and Mydei!”

The three hosts forgo the soundboard to manually shower Phainon and Mydei in applause. Mydei is slowly re-learning the staples of a press tour, but it might be a long while before he gets used to the outrageous claims about their one-note boy band.

Phainon’s response, as always, is to laugh it off. “Thank you, thank you. A pop influence, huh? I don’t hear that everyday.”

“You definitely did something to pop music,” says the loud sister.

“Considering where you started, we think it applies to Sun and Thunder,” says the least talkative of the three. She’s nearly covered from head to toe, hiding behind her overgrown bangs and a long dress that spurns summer.

The friendliest sister picks up on what her withdrawn counterpart refuses to elaborate, “We still remember watching the announcement live like it was yesterday! Everyone and their moms picked up an instrument after that finale.”

“For those not in the know, Sun and Thunder is the reason we’re still respected in Asdana,” the brash one jokes.

“They represented Amphoreus in the Astral Fantasia Music Festival ten years ago,” explains the nice sister. “I think many people know this about you, Phainon, but I don’t think the youth today are as interested in the Fantasia as we were back then.”

“They’re definitely not,” Phainon concurs. “Nowadays most people say my biggest honor is winning the Golden Nymph or getting an album to platinum.”

The loudest of the sisters snickers. “They used to say it’s the Fantasia, huh?”

“Yeah, they did,” Phainon answers. “I think they’d be right anyway. The Fantasia *is* my biggest honor.”

Damn it. Did he have to smile at Mydei right then? “It’s my only honor,” Mydei deadpans to will himself back to reality.

No one laughs though. The peppy sister even takes offense to it. “Don’t say that! We loved your work on Swan Song!”

It figures that the hosts of one of the nation’s busiest radio shows would be well-informed about music news. Mydei bites back a groan. “That was a good album and I enjoyed working on it. I hope Lady Hysilens didn’t hear that.”

“She’d forgive you,” Phainon says, despite not having any basis for that statement at all. “You were just trying to say that you really, *really* like working with me, right?”

“That’s one interpretation,” Mydei diplomatically answers.

“We hope that means this reunion isn't the last we hear from you guys…”

“Me and you both, Miss Tribbie,” Phainon says. “But I think that speaks to how hard we fought for this. Both Mydei and I are incredibly busy with our careers - which I’m thankful for - but it doesn’t leave us with a lot of space to think about collaborating again. I’m glad that Euphrosyne's anniversary put us back into the zeitgeist, because that helped justify the reunion to the naysayers, y’know?”

While not technically wrong, Phainon still twists the facts to fit into a nice digestible package. Mydei almost laughs out loud at the idea that Phainon

wanted to work with him before this debacle. He should leave the hapless act to the truly pathetic among them, such as the man seated cautiously at Phainon's side.

"All we're hearing is that there's still a chance!"

"Don't pressure them, Trianne," the one called Tribbie scolds, though her smile looks too jubilant to mean any harm. "It could be a surprise for all we know!"

"Now look who's putting on the pressure," Trianne huffs.

"How long have you two been planning for a reunion?" The last unnamed sister asks.

"Not long to tell you the truth," Phainon admits. "It's difficult to plan for the future when our schedules clash so much. We focused more on getting everyone on board than any real planning, but Mydei and I still work really well with each other, so it came together a lot more smoothly than anticipated."

The noise gate would take care of the small scoff Mydei had instinctively let out, but there's no chance of downplaying it in the station, where the triplets glance at him as if they've sensed blood in the water.

Sure enough, the unruly triplet, Trianne, turns to Mydei with exaggerated aplomb and asks, "Was it easy breezy all the way or did the new songs give you guys some trouble?"

"There wasn't more trouble than there usually is," Mydei says. Phainon could and probably would answer for him, but blatantly ignoring Trianne's expectant gaze would be rude, even for Mydei. He did ask for it, after all. "It's nice to have someone to bounce ideas off."

"Sounds like it's the first time you two worked together again," Trianne concludes.

“We always thought you two kept in touch! Scapegoats sounded a lot like Symplegades off the second Sun and Thunder album! We wondered if Mydei worked on it,” Tribbie says.

“I, uh, never did,” Mydei says, side-eyeing Phainon. “Phainon is half of Sun and Thunder. It wouldn’t surprise me if the sound stayed with him.”

“It stuck out to us because the songs you write today keep plenty of elements from Sun and Thunder,” says the third sister. “Would we be right to expect the new material to feel as familiar to the fans?”

Phainon takes this chance to jump back in. “Definitely, yeah. The new Euphrosyne is self-explanatory, while the other song basically picks up where we last left off. It’s a song we probably would have worked on if we were still together, but with years of foresight packed into it. Like a glimpse of what could have been.”

“This sounds like the perfect time to remind our listeners what Euphrosyne sounds like,” Tribbie says. “Again, for those catching up, this is the song that won us the Astral Fantasia ten years ago-“

“-But remade!” Trianne cuts in. “If you’re curious about how that sounds, then keep your ears peeled. You’re listening to thirty three point three fm and this is Euphrosyne by the one and only Sun and Thunder!”

Trianne slaps a button on the console to run the queued track. The meekest of the sisters mutes their mics while the song plays, giving everyone the go-ahead to talk outside the show.

“That was really good, De!” Tribbie says to Mydei. “Agy says that you haven’t done a lot of shows together yet, but you kept up with Snowy really well!”

Mydei had only begun to tell their names apart when he’s suddenly lambasted by a new cast of characters. He makes an educated guess that ‘Agy’ must be Aglaea and that ‘Snowy’ is the walking, talking marshmallow on his left.

“Tell us if we’re getting too scary, okay?” Tribbie says.

Mydei doesn’t hear that very often from women who are a foot shorter than him. Granted, the triplets much older than Mydei’s paltry 27 years, but he’s not an animal going around taking note of women’s ages.

“I’m just following Phainon’s lead,” Mydei says. “Thank you for not making it difficult.”

“Oh we wanted to ask soooooo many questions!” Trianne proclaims. “Like are you guys sticking with retro-pop even though you guys were technically just pop back then? Did you not use the old samples because of licensing or because of artistic choice? How was it meeting Naxy? Did he tell you guys how to do that thing with the bass? Is West Wind actually a recycled Sun and Thunder song or was it-“

“-There’s a lot we were curious about,” the reticent sister summarizes for Trianne. “But might be closer to gossip than promotional material.”

“I don’t mind answering them,” Mydei says. He glances once again at Phainon, who nods his head encouragingly. “…Maybe privately. In case it strays from Sun and Thunder.”

The three sisters share a look. They say that twins possess a special kind of telepathy, so Mydei wonders if triplets have a stronger signal than the standard twofer. The synchronized nod between the three sisters seems to corroborate with that theory, though Mydei’s more focused on trying not to be scared shitless when he sees them riffling through their question cards.

“Don’t worry, De!” Tribbie reassures him, her telepathy extending to minds beyond her sisters’. “Think of this as practice before we go live again!”

“Um…”

Mydei glances at Phainon, who leisurely reclines in his seat without a care in the world. He takes it as a sign that things haven’t been derailed. Or maybe they have and Phainon is waiting to see how Mydei gets himself out of this one.

Trianne clears her throat to catch Mydei's attention. "What was your impression of the new Euphrosyne's mixdown?"

"It sounds good," Mydei says.

"…Any perspectives as a producer? Since you weren't directly involved in the post-production side this time?"

"I was on board as a performer, and as a performer I think I should focus on my musical performance."

Unlike when the show was on, the three sisters cringe. Before Mydei's confidence could plummet too far, Tribbie intervenes. "Let's try another question!"

Trianne hastily searches their notecards. "Uh, from the name of the band to the titles of your songs, it's clear Sun and Thunder is inspired by Amphoreus's myths. Many fans suspect it's because you were meant to come out with a concept album. Is that true?" She reads out loud.

"No," Mydei immediately denies.

"So why the theming?" Tribbie asks when Mydei falls silent.

"It was… a prompt from the label," Mydei answers, attempting and failing to spruce up the truth. *Grove* said they needed a name and gave Phainon and Mydei a list to choose from. That was prudent of them, because 12 year old boys aren't known for naming things with taste, but saying it as it is makes it sound like the band was a product of *Grove Records*. Which is true, but it doesn't work well with the inspirational organic success story they've cultivated for *Sun and Thunder*.

Mydei tries to pick out the interesting facts like he's seen Phainon do. "We had to name ourselves, so Grove threw out some options for us. We went with Sun and Thunder because we thought Seliose was cool. Everything else fell into place after we chose the name."

"You two were interested in myths as kids then?" Tribbie asks.

“I guess,” Mydei says. He remembers sitting with Phainon and looking up stories about the warrior, ultimately finding the history of Cloudedge Bastion intriguing. “A lot of Amphorean myths sound like something out of an action blockbuster or a Sunday morning cartoon. The kind of things kids like.”

“Anything personal about it though?” Trianne hints. “People looove hearing personal stories, like maybe it was your favorite subject in school or you were named after a certain whats-his-face or something!”

Mydei searches his memories. Phainon liked Seliose because she went on heroic adventures with cool animal friends. Mydei liked her because she reminded him of his mother. Neither of those sound interesting to talk about. “There’s a girl who works with Phainon who’s from the same hometown as the Daythunder Knight,” Mydei says.

Phainon interjects, “Hyacine wasn’t working with us back then.”

“I wasn’t saying we named the band for her,” Mydei snipes back. He might not be the most conscious of his co-workers, but he’s not *that* ignorant.

Phainon laughs at Mydei’s reaction. “Why’d you bring her up then?”

Mydei opens his mouth to retort, only to lose whatever train of logic he had. “…Because we know her personally,” he says lamely.

“Think on it for now,” Tribbie says, thankfully cutting in before Phainon has a chance to press his advantage. “We have more questions to ask!”

If not for the sisters’ very apparent enthusiasm, Mydei might have believed that Aglaea put them up to this. It strikes him as asinine that anyone would be curious about a song he wrote 5 years ago and whether it was inspired by gospel choirs (it’s plausible, Mydei *was* listening to an awful lot of Peter Gabriel and zilin singing back then), but the 3 sisters takes his answers so sincerely that it makes Mydei feel bad to even doubt them. Despite their differing personalities, all 3 sisters are naturally curious and inquisitive, a trait that explains their job security.

Still, for questions that needed his explicit permission, none of them delve into the really awkward topics that Mydei had braced himself for. Perhaps he's not as hard to read as he'd thought, if the triplets can sense his unease. The new *Euphrosyne* continues to play over the radio in the meantime, and though the radio hosts appear too excitable to be paying attention, they manage to time their private chat to end at the last minute of the song.

"The rest we'll save for later," Trianne tells Mydei as she double-checks the queued tracks. "So don't take your thinking cap off just yet, okay?"

Mydei nods seriously, and he thinks he hears Phainon snicker. He looks over at the pop star to be sure, only to be met by twiddling fingers and a look of pure innocence.

To add insult to injury, the song hits its final quarter just then, playing that dumb laugh in clear surround sound. The producers had salvaged the sound from their very first take and inserted it in the final mix, resulting in a creative choice so cheesy that makes Mydei's stomach cramp up. It's true that *Euphrosyne* is nothing but cheese anyway, but using Phainon's candid laughter as an ad-lib is a work of pure evil. The world may never recover.

"Do I look good today?" Phainon asks when Mydei's stare refuses to let up.

"You look the same as every other day," Mydei says, turning his chair away. "Awful."

"Awfully good-looking you mean?"

Mydei grimaces, but he *might* be smiling just a tiny little bit. A strategic sip from his bottle should keep it under wraps for now. "Keep dreaming."

"-Aaaand that was Euphrosyne by the ever wonderful Sun and Thunder!" Trianne hollers into her mic. She emphasizes their name by blasting off a few thunderclaps from her soundboard. "If you're just tuning in, you might be thinking 'hm, that sounds different from what I remember' and you'd be correct. That was the new Euphrosyne, straight off the presses!"

“If that raises more questions for you, then never fear,” Tribbie says. “We have the boys right here with us to give us the scoop!”

Mydei assumes this is where the hosts would have transitioned back to their guests, but Phainon decides it would be more exciting if he choked to death on live radio instead. The three sisters immediately scramble to ensure he’s alright while simultaneously checking for any stray spittle that might short-circuit their set-up.

“Oh Gosh!” Tribbie gasps, holding out a napkin. “Sn-Phainon, are you okay?”

Mydei smacks his back, which probably does nothing but jostle Phainon half-a-foot forward. “I’m fine,” Phainon assures everyone as he clears his throat. “Sorry, I- What on Georios’s great earth are you drinking, Mydei?”

Mydei looks down at the bottle in Phainon’s hands. It seems Phainon has mistaken Mydei’s drink for his own.

“It’s cold assam tea with grenadine concentrate and whey isolate,” Mydei answers reflexively, tongue still loose from his conversation with the triplets. “A friend tried to poison me with his new concoction, but I ended up liking it.”

Phainon’s expression tells him that he would have choked again, if not for his disciplined composure. “I’m sure he wasn’t trying to poison anybody,” he says.

“You be the judge of that,” Mydei says. “Go on, take another shot.”

“…No thank you.” Phainon pushes the bottle back to Mydei’s half of the table.

“A shame.” Mydei shakes his head in mock-pity, taking a hefty swig from the bottle as a show of strength. “It’s a good source of caffeine and protein.”

“I think I’ll stick to clif bars and real coffee.”

“Bringing protein shakes to work… you must be a big gym guy, huh Mydei?” Trianne remarks, playing the part of a professional radio host tugging on the reins of a show gone awry.

“It’s something to do in my spare time,” Mydei says to help out. “I’d prefer hiking trails, but there’s not a lot of those in the city.”

“There’s a few good ones by the Okehema National park,” Tribbie suggests.

“Yes! Down the road from Kephale Plaza, where the reserve is,” Phainon chimes in. “It’s got a great view of Marmoreal lake if you go around dawn.”

“Hm. I like the national park, but it’s too far for regular visits,” Mydei says.

“Wouldn’t be so far if we were neighbors,” Phainon says with a wink. Mydei doesn’t understand the purpose of saying it like that, other than to invoke the image of late-night visits and sleepy mornings.

Trianne chuckles. “Yeah, Mydei could wake you up with a protein shake before dragging you to a two hour hike!”

Thank Nikador for Trianne and her sane imagination. Mydei nearly lost himself in an intricate furniture shopping fantasy.

Phainon sighs at her words. “It shouldn’t count as a protein shake,” he remarks.

It’s still not quite a smooth showing, but Mydei survives this interview with more of his pride intact. The questions on *Janus’s Table* are a mix of casual and insightful, making Mydei sound like a palatable person with regular human opinions and regular human thoughts. Maybe he even performed well enough to convince Aglaea to book him exclusively on radio shows. The thought pleases Mydei until he remembers that podcasts exists and that Okhema is overrun with its ilk. For the first time ever, Mydei thinks it might be a good thing that Aglaea prefers television and print.

The radio plays another fan favorite from *Sun and Thunder*’s discography as Phainon and Mydei make to leave. Trianne and Tribbie are over to the

side bidding farewell to Phainon and his team, appearing to be as well-connected and well-liked as the radio juggernauts they are. Their sister Trinnon - a name Mydei only remembered at the very last second of the show - sits by the console as taciturn as ever, perhaps to guard their precious mixer.

Mydei himself is still in his chair, stranded by social convention. It's technically perfectly fine to leave, but it wouldn't be right to go without saying his goodbyes. He can't say his goodbyes if the relevant people are too busy chatting, and Mydei doesn't really feel like getting dragged into another hour long conversation.

So he turns to Trinnon. "Thank you for having us," he says as graciously as possible. "I hope you have a nice day."

The woman gives him a single nod in return. That's permission enough.

Mydei takes stock of his belongings as he gets up from his seat. He takes a single step towards the door when he hears: "…De."

He looks back at Trinnon. The radio jockey stares at him.

"Your mother…" She pauses. "…She would have loved the guitars on Amber Dawn."

Mydei bristles at the mention of his mother. It makes sense that she would have found herself at the same table once upon a time, though it would have never occurred to Mydei until Trinnon spoke. The quiet ones really are the most dangerous.

Even so, a knot in his heart softly starts to unravel. "Thank you," Mydei tells Trinnon. "I hoped she would."

Trinnon blinks at him. "You should always smile like that so Agy won't be mad."

"…I'll also keep that in mind."

Showbiz, as it turns out, is a lot of people commenting on the way you move your mouth.

—

Phainon wishes that everyone would shut their traps for five seconds and spare him some peace.

Just because he's not easily provoked doesn't mean Phainon is immune to negative comments. *To err is human, to forgive is divine*, as the saying goes, but Phainon never considered himself remotely close to divinity. He's a human with real human emotions, and now he's having a very human reaction because his puny human feelings are hurt.

|_…
> **frondike** @chiliconcandi
AND there are other songs that we have been begging to be officially released for years! We may be his fans, but that doesn't mean we have to agree with all his management's choices esp when they clearly don't benefit anyone but their finances.
> **beagle coconut** @neikos00000004
Not everything he does is because of his management. By your logic Phainon is a performer only because his management told him to be
> **frondike** @chiliconcandi
You're purposely being obtuse. Ofc Phainon does what his management says they're his MANAGEMENT. That doesn't mean they always act towards his best interests.
> **beagle coconut** @neikos00000004
But Phainon never said he hates S&T. Why is it that he's okay with everything else but Sun and Thunder is apparently crossing the line? He could have hated modeling for those ugly boots a year back but no one got mad at the campaign
> **frondike** @chiliconcandi
LMAO GIRL don't make me laugh. You really just compared some hasbeen band no one cares about to SAINT LAURENT
> **Ravvy** @PhaisBbgirl
teletube.com/watch?v=XfEKJ…. phainon literally says he doesnt want anything to do with snt at 2:13 lol

> **Minthe** @ peerlesswonder
guys stop fighting with that acc they’re a mydeimous stan like what do we expect
> **beagle coconut** @neikos00000004
*Mydeimos
> **Minthe** @ peerlesswonder
give it a rest bro
> **memi** @PhiLia093
I think we should give Mydei a chance!

Phainon looks up and frowns at his sister, who stands before him with her maliciously pink phone in hand.

Cyrene smiles. “I said hello, but you didn’t hear me.”

“Hello,” Phainon greets her at last, though his expression appears far from welcoming.

The two are currently in a studio set to film a very special interview. Well, Phainon is here for filming. Cyrene is only visiting. Once she caught wind of today’s plans, Cyrene had imposed her privileges over her younger brother to secure herself a guest pass to the recording. There isn’t even a real audience for her to be a part of. It’s just that refusing Cyrene is harder than begging the production for an exception.

Phainon had meant to meet her at the lot’s entrance once she arrived, but he’d lost track of time after coming across an interesting discussion online. And that’s how Cyrene finds him, hunched over in a corner of the set glaring at his phone. Cyrene, the sweet and understanding girl that she is, took no offense to his negligence, even allowing Phainon more privacy by fencing him off from the production crew.

This does not mean Cyrene is a saint. Something tells Phainon that she wasn't snooping on his phone screen for purely altruistic reasons, and it doesn’t take more than ‘hello’ for the other shoe to drop.

“You’d think a ten time debate champion would do a better job arguing online,” she teases.

“People on weaver don’t care about proper citations and analyses,” Phainon grumbles.

“There’s a citation right here.” Cyrene points on a link on his screen.

Phainon pulls his phone out of her reach before she accidentally taps on anything. “You know what I mean,” he says.

Cyrene giggles. “So grumpy. Your make-up’s starting to crack around the brow area, you know.”

“Nice try. They put the immovable stuff on me today,” Phainon tells Cyrene, his eyes sliding towards his phone once more.

“Don’t take any of that to heart,” Cyrene says as a petty internet argument enraptures her brother again. “You should have faith in Mydei’s abili-”

“Oh come on I didn’t even say anything bad about Sun and Thunder here-” Phainon thrusts his phone at Cyrene’s face. There’s a video playing on the screen, but all Cyrene can hear is the flurry of production runners behind her. “Where did I say I wanted nothing to do with the band?” Phainon asks.

Cyrene doesn’t bother reminding him of how his wireless earbud works. Instead, she gently nudges Phainon’s hand until he’s out of her personal space.

“Your fans are protective of you,” Cyrene says. “They need time to get used to him. Like you did!”

“I-” She got Phainon there. “…I was a dumb kid back then.”

“Was? You still are!” Cyrene says before grabbing Phainon’s face to pinch and pull at his cheeks.

“Agh! Stop, Rini, stop!” Phainon begs. Somewhere out there, a canister of playdoh commiserates with his pain. “Aglaea is gonna kill me if I mess up another shirt!”

“Wow, that blush is really on there,” Cyrene comments. She gives Phainon’s cheeks one final tug for good measure. “What brand is that? Do you think Aglaea would notice if I pocket a few jars?”

The pop star rubs his sore face. “It’s my natural rouge,” he says.

Cyrene menacingly lifts her hand again, and Phainon automatically straightens himself up. “I’ll ask her, okay? You have to relax before people start thinking you’re a crazed fan.”

“Says the guy starting fan wars with his own fans,” Cyrene says.

“I didn’t start it. I was trying to have a civil discussion ove- Mydei!”

Like raw iron to lodestone, Phainon’s gaze snaps to Mydei the instant the blond is within earshot. It’s easy to be aware of him, of course, with his chiseled build and striking tattoos, but even Cyrene needed a second to find him amongst the crowd. One of Aglaea’s visionaries had arranged Mydei’s outfits to consist of mainly dark leather, which had the unfortunate side-effect of blending him in with the production crew and their plain black shirts. Phainon seems to be an exception to this hurdle. His fine-tuned radar and bug-eyed mooning keeps him abreast of the man’s location at all times.

“Were you listening in on us back there?” Phainon asks as Mydei makes his way over to the two siblings.

“No?” Mydei says, looking between the two of them in confusion. Then Phainon’s question sinks in, and a scowl promptly clouds his pretty face. “What lies have you been spreading about me now?”

“No lies, just the usual. Who you are, what you do, and *yada-yada*,” Phainon lightly glosses over the truth. “This is Cyrene by the way.”

"Hi!"

The scowl softens as Mydei acknowledges the woman with a nod. “Your sister.”

“You remember!” Cyrene claps her hands in joy.

Mydei’s face begins to match the bright pinks of Cyrene’s hair. “You visited the office a lot. You brought snacks whenever the label couldn’t afford to feed us.”

“She also thought you were a girl,” Phainon points out.

“You were cute as a button and I landed on the wrong conclusion,” Cyrene defends herself. “Don’t get me wrong. You’re still very cute, even if you’re not my kind of cute!"

“I’m pretty sure you used to call him ‘Midday’ or something."

“Hm? Is there a reason you’re making me look bad, brother mine?”

“What? Oh, no,” Phainon says. “I was just curious if he remembered any of that.”

Mydei crosses his arms with a grunt. “No need for the shovel talk, Deliverer. I’ll keep my distance.”

Related through adoption they may be, but their reaction to Mydei is cut from the same cloth, staring him down with the same blue-eyed disbelief. It’s a little too Kubrick, even for Mydei.

Mydei coughs into his fist. “Anyway, I’m here to tell you that they need to hook your mic up,” he tells Phainon.

“Alright,” Phainon sighs, getting up from where he’d been roosting. “Don’t elope while I’m gone, okay? I’m watching you.”

Cyrene playfully rolls her eyes. “Ignore that doofus,” she tells Mydei.

“I always do,” Mydei says, watching Phainon walk off. “It’s better for my sanity that way.”

Cyrene laughs. It’s a surprisingly nostalgic and comforting sound. “It’s been such a long time since we’ve seen each other! What have you been up to?”

“Songwriting.” Mydei’s scripted answer comes to his rescue.

“I know that,” Cyrene says as she lightly elbows him. Despite being shorter, she hits the same rib Phainon does when he’s annoyed with Mydei. “What about your hobbies? Your interests? You used to really like drawing, what happened there?”

Mydei flushes. “Every kid likes to draw.”

“Some adults also like to draw,” Cyrene says. “I have a friend with a really serious engineering job, and every Saturday he makes time to attend his comic club.”

“I’m not that good at it.”

Cyrene chuckles at his sheepish answer. “Fine, fine. I’ll let it go this once. But do you wanna know why I remembered that?”

Mydei shrugs.

“It’s cause Phainon kept that drawing you did for him,” Cyrene says, her smile taking on an impishness that contradicts her guileless bearing. “Rumor has it that he’s tried to make it the cover art of a bunch of his singles, but you didn’t hear that from me~”

Mydei might have remembered drawing Phainon as a chimera once long ago. He might have drawn him looking irrationally angry and stupid, a snot-nosed creature getting hit by a meteor or something. “I can’t recall doing that for him.”

“I’ll send you a picture if I can find it,” Cyrene promises.

Distantly, Mydei wonders if Phainon would mind him and Cyrene exchanging numbers. He’s aware that Phainon had been joking, but since none of Mydei’s friends have siblings to speak of, he can’t confidently say he knows which lines not to cross. It might be too late anyway, because Cyrene is already happily logging her contact details into Mydei’s phone.

Just as he remembers, Cyrene makes for entertaining company, bursting with stories and anecdotes she’d sworn she’d saved for Mydei. She’s a bit

of a chatterbox, sure, but mostly to save Mydei from the ordeal of coming up with proper replies. She gets the gist of what he’s trying to say, thank you very much, now listen to her tale about a so-called fish market on the Marmoreal Boulevard and their fraudulent catch-of-the-day…

Unfortunately, Mydei can’t camp out in the back and listen to Cyrene’s stories all day long. Today’s real stars have finally arrived at the studio, which means Mydei has to pull himself away with an apology so he can waddle over to where the rest of the supporting cast is.

The film set is as minimal as it gets, with only a colored backdrop to give it character. Phainon sits in the middle of the open space, providing a subject for the cameras to test their apertures on. He makes for a good marker too, an example for where and how Mydei should place himself. As Mydei settles in the same crosslegged pose as Phainon beside him, the singer hits him with another inscrutable stare.

Mydei stares back in retaliation, only to realize that neither of them are going to give and that they'll be at this forever. He immediately moves on to his back-up plan.

“I wasn’t hitting on her,” Mydei says low enough to keep their conversation private.

Phainon lets out an offended snort. “So my sister’s not good enough for you, is that it?”

Patience. Mydei needs patience. “Do you want me to get along with Cyrene or not?”

“I want everyone in the world to treat her with the love and respect she deserves,” Phainon says, dead serious. “But I don’t want you to get too chummy with her.”

“And what, pray tell, is your reasoning for this completely sensible request?”

“She’ll be a bad influence on you.”

Mydei glances to where he left Cyrene. She doesn't meet his eye, too busy smoothing down the fur of her tiny stuffed keychain.

"Okay," is all Mydei could respond with.

"Just ignore what she says," Phainon advises. "She likes to talk crazy sometimes."

"She seemed fine to me. All we talked about wa-"

Mydei stops when he comes to a realization. Ah, so *that's* why Phainon had looked so shaken to see them exchange words.

"…I understand," Mydei says, holding back a grin. "It's your family. I'll follow your directions."

"Will you now?" Phainon asks skeptically.

Mydei nods. "Yes. From now on, I'll respect your boundaries, Phangry."

"…Pardon?"

"I said I'll respect your boundaries."

"No, no." Phainon shakes his head, a faint horror dawning in his eyes. "That last part. You said it wrong. My name is *Phainon*."

"I'm aware of what your name is, Phangry."

"You said it again!" Phainon sputters. "You damn cheat- This is not- End all contact with Cyrene. *Now*."

"Relax," Mydei says. "Do you want me to get you something from craft services? You're not yourself when you're hungry."

"You're missing key context from that story," Phainon groans. "The family of one of my classmates was struggling that winter, so I thought it would be nice if our class could bring extra food without making it obvious it's for *them*."

“And it was a coincidence that it was all your favorite foods.”

“I wanted them to eat something good!”

Mydei can’t help it. He barks a laugh at the absurdity of the story, at the image of an even younger Phainon canvassing his classmates for a charity he made up. Phainon’s face steadily gets redder as Mydei cackles on, undoing all the sophistication Phainon’s chic clothes and coiffed hair had worked so hard to achieve.

“I have blackmail on you too,” Phainon threatens.

“Oh yeah?” Mydei challenges as he lets out one final snort. “Name one.”

“You used to be scared of that Ambrosia commercial with the squids.”

“Big deal. I was a kid.”

“Last week you wouldn’t let me order food unless I promise not to get the calamari.”

“It’s a preference,” Mydei says. “Unlike some people, I don’t inhale everything in front of me.”

“So I’m a glutton, is that what you’re saying?” Phainon sulks. For a moment, Mydei feels guilt creep in, remembering the demands of fame and its impact on Phainon’s body.

Then Phainon sighs and says, “If only someone would make me another delicious homemade meal to fill my tummy…”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “You can go out for lunch after this.”

“I’ll get mobbed out there.”

From what Mydei has seen so far, he probably won’t. Yet, he still says, “Fine. One meal.”

The promise makes Phainon's eyes shine with a dangerous delight, so Mydei reiterates, "One meal. My house is not a restaurant."

"What about Cyrene?"

"She can come over too," Mydei says. "If you don't mind me getting closer to her."

"You should be close to her," Phainon says. "You should treat her like a *sister*."

"I don't want you for a brother," Mydei snarks.

"A sister-in-law then."

"Cool. Do you have any other siblings I can hit on to make that happen?"

"Oh you are so going to get it late-"

"Mister Phainon? Mister, um- Mister Mydeimos?"

The two men look up at the sound technician, who stands before them with a tremble in his knees. "We're about to start soon, so can I uh, double check your mics?"

"Of course," Phainon says, disentangling himself from Mydei. He hadn't noticed that he had been sidling up to Mydei until they were mere inches apart, but neither did the surly blond. Whether that's a good or bad sign is beyond him.

The sound tech does his job well. Maybe too well. He doesn't have to tug the hem of Mydei's shirt that far up to check his wired mic.

"Everything good?" Phainon asks as the sound guy fixes Mydei's shirt with a small pat.

"'S good," the sound technician says. "But um- we haven't started recording yet, but the mic is always on? So we still, uh, hear it. What you guys are saying."

Phainon looks at the rest of the sound team by the edge of the set. Most avoid his gaze. One shakes their head at him.

The important thing is that the director remains blissfully unaware of the petty shenanigans on her set, and the queue of people shadowing her seems to keep it that way. That doesn't stop Mydei from harrumphing and brooding over the oversight, as if it was *his* ridiculous nickname that was broadcasted to his colleagues. It's satisfying to see, Phainon thinks. Maybe Cyrene had a point in airing out his embarrassing childhood memories.

The director takes her spot by the main camera, and after one last debrief, she cues everyone to start the take. At the snap of the clapper, Mydei once again straightens his posture and renders himself uncomfortably tense. Phainon considered it a part of Mydei's charm, though Aglaea saw it as quirk he could improve on. Her solution? This very interview.

A command from the director unleashes the other guests on Phainon and Mydei, and the two are instantly swarmed by puppies of all shapes and sizes. An energetic Labrador immediately tries to climb Phainon as the smallest Pomeranian in the world yips at his ankles. Phainon decides to help the lab by picking him up, and the dog thanks him with a hearty kiss across the entire left side of his face. His make-up artist had agonized over days for a setting spray that's both indestructible and non-toxic to dogs, so this footage must be incredibly vindicating for her.

"Are you two okay with everything so far?" One of the handlers asks.

"All good here," Phainon answers as another puppy tries to paw at his hair.

Phainon sneaks a peek at Mydei between facefuls of Labrador. The puppies, while all being bundles of joy, came with all kinds of temperaments. For some reason, every hyperactive dog on set had chosen Phainon to bestow their merriment on. The more easygoing pups had ambled over to Mydei, either because they saw the ruckus on Phainon's side or because they simply liked Mydei more. Most of Mydei's puppies have taken to resting on or against his legs, blinking blearily as if they were straining to stay up. Phainon can't help but notice that Figgy usually spends her time around

Mydei in the same way. His lap must be comfortable, and that's as far as Phainon's mind lets him go before it reminds him that he's at work.

"Do you guys like dogs?"

The interviewer throws them a warm-up question that Phainon would typically let Mydei answer, but the man appears to be too preoccupied with the puppy in his arms. He doesn't carry the poor thing like Phainon, who holds out the Labrador as if he's presenting at a show-and-tell. No, Mydei cradles the animal like a swaddled baby, and the pup just lets him.

"Dogs are alright, but I'm more of a cat person. Sorry boy," Phainon apologizes to the lab. The dog naturally forgives him, or at least that's how Phainon chooses to interpret its panting.

"They love you though," the interviewer points out the myriad of wagging tails around Phainon. The dogs are apparently still very happy to see him.

"Maybe they smell breakfast on me," Phainon jokes. He skipped breakfast this morning actually, but he had to say something for the quip to land.

"Maybe they're your fans. They're as high energy as your songs."

"Is that a sign we should write a slow jam next time?" Phainon says to Mydei.

Mydei finally looks up from the puppy in his arms, who overcomes its limitations as a dog to shoot Phainon a disgruntled look. This hypocrite. Acting like Phainon can't see it sticking its muzzle into Mydei's bosom for attention.

"We're not good at writing anything slower than a hundred twenty BPM," Mydei says.

"You've said in other interviews that the new track is a serious one," the interviewer says. "Does that mean it's your first slow song or that it's still an upbeat one?"

"It's a hundred twenty beats per minute exactly," Mydei answers.

The puppy interview had been Aglaea's doing, but it was ultimately Phainon who gave her the idea when he began speaking at length about Mydei's beloved 4-legged roommate. It makes Phainon feel a teensy bit liable about this whole session, like it's his responsibility if things go tits up.

Hence why he's watching Mydei like a hawk, Phainon tells himself. It's natural to be concerned when the puppies seem to take a shine to Mydei's hair, specifically with the plaited lock dangling provocatively out of Mydei's updo. The new hairstyle is an effort to clear his face of his shaggy fringe - to showcase the shining gem underneath, no doubt - but the hairdressers had been careful to strike a balance between neat and rigid. A few loose strands does the trick, curling over Mydei's sharp cheekbones and keeping him appropriately casual. Honestly it's a bit bridal in Phainon's eyes. Perhaps they should have leaned into leather and lace instead and made use of Mydei's an-

"-ainon? What's your favorite part of Euphrosyne?"

"I'm thinking," Phainon says, recovering in record time. "Gotta be the flute, right?"

Mydei makes a sound that implies he doesn't agree, but Phainon is the only one here who knows that.

Phainon can imagine the editor for this video now, head in their hands as they scour the files for clips of Mydei looking hashtag-relatable. Their online dissenters would continue tormenting Phainon with their newfound ammunition, reading the tension of Mydei's muscles as derision. Only Phainon sees his terse answers for what they are.

"I think it'll be alright if you wake the puppies up," Phainon tells Mydei.

Mydei immediately grumbles at that, gently petting a sleeping Terrier when its ear twitches at Phainon's voice. "They're probably tuckered them out from the ride over."

“No worries! They get plenty of sleep back at the shelter,” a handler assures him.

“So they’re used to napping,” Mydei murmurs. “This must be confusing for them.”

Phainon decides to speak before the director gets a chance to. “Let them snooze for now. These guys over here can keep us busy on their own.”

As if to prove him right, the yappy Pomeranian suddenly chomps on his shirt and tugs, surprising Phainon enough to knock him off balance. Phainon goes down with a yelp before he’s buried in 3 to 5 opportunistic dogs, who apparently have an oath to keep his face sufficiently moisturized.

“Bad doggies! Bad!” Phainon’s reprimands fall short of stern, cut by his own amused guffaws.

From the corner of his eye, Phainon spots Mydei hiding his face under his hand. There could be a self-satisfied smirk under there, or maybe a disapproving scowl. It could be a tiny giggle too, like the ones he lets out when he takes a particularly tasty bite of food. Whatever expression it was, it’s gone by the time Mydei decides to rescue Phainon from the wriggling pile of puppies, replaced by an indifference Phainon refuses to believe.

They film a few more questions and pat a few more good boys and girls before the director calls the final cut. Phainon promptly jumps up to thank everyone for today, taking special care to let the sound guys know he really, *truly* appreciates them.

Cyrene naturally accompanies Phainon when it comes to thanking the animal handlers. Their combined charm earns Cyrene some time with the puppies, who crowd around her enthusiastically albeit in a much more orderly fashion than they had with her brother.

“I’m guessing she likes dogs,” Mydei says as he approaches Phainon.

“It’s because we had this huge Samoyed growing up. He was real friendly and clingy. Made it hard to leave the house without him,” Phainon explains.

“Cyrene misses him sometimes.”

“…My condolences.”

“Snowy’s alive, he just lives with our folks in a different town,” Cyrene elaborates, shooting Phainon a pointed look.

“Oh.” Mydei gives Phainon a look of his own. “…Where have I heard that name before?”

“His government name is Snowball,” Phainon says.

“Big Snowy if you want to be casual without being too disrespectful,” Cyrene adds.

Mydei notes the small white dog snuggling up to her. “Is there a little Snowy?” He asks.

“I think we’ve done enough reminiscing today,” Phainon cuts in before Cyrene can answer. “Did Mydei ever tell you about his massive dog?”

Cyrene gasps. “He didn’t!”

The little guy in her arms whines, sensing Cyrene’s attention pull away from it. Obsoletion comes for all of us, it seems, even for sweet fluffy puppies. Mydei himself couldn’t resist reaching out to console the pup, let alone Cyrene, who starts peppering its head with kisses.

“If you’re looking to adopt, I’d be happy to help,” the handler says.

“Aww. I’d love to, but my baby’s not fond of sharing,” Cyrene says.

Mydei shoots Phainon an unsure glance.

“It’s her cat,” Phainon answers.

“I’d probably have to go home after this,” Cyrene continues, relinquishing her hold on the dog. “I’ll need to get started on groveling.”

Phainon frowns. “Don’t you want to see Mydei’s dog first?”

“Why are you using my dog as bait? Why are you even inviting her to come over to *my* place?”

“It was your idea to invite her.”

“Because you asked?”

Cyrene giggles. “Let’s do a raincheck on the house visit. I wouldn’t want to impose on such short notice.”

“I don’t mind,” Mydei says. “But we could always do this some other time if you’re busy.”

“This is actually the best time for it though. My bodyguard’s out of commission because she’s allergic to dogs,” Phainon states.

Neither Mydei nor Cyrene appear to be entertained by this observation. Feeling annoyed, Mydei scoffs, “Who says you’re coming with?”

“Uh, me? I mean I set it up.”

“Mydei and I don’t need your help,” Cyrene says, holding her chin high. “We can make our own plans.”

“Yeah, but if it weren’t for me, you two wouldn’t have a reason to link up a- oh Kephale what is *that*?”

Phainon’s cocksure attitude takes a nosedive the instant his eyes land on Mydei’s phone screen. A familiar string of numbers is held up for Phainon to read, labeled with Cyrene’s name and - Phainon’s stomach churns - a heart emoji.

“This is a mutiny,” Phainon says as Mydei takes his phone back. “I was joking about the elopement, what are you doing?”

Mydei gallantly holds his elbow out for Cyrene to take, and she indulges him with a smile.

“This is not funny. This is actually awful and inhumane what you two are doing to me. You two are torturing a poor innocent man with your scheming.”

Mydei and Cyrene share a glance as they walk off the set, barely managing to muffle their laughter as Phainon trails behind them like the precious pooch he’s named after.

—

“How do you feel, Mydeimos?”

“Like a sausage link,” Mydei says in response to Aglaea’s question.

Aglaea hums. Mydei sees her pondering reflection in the full length mirror in front of him, appearing terribly small against the plush couch she’s seated on.

“Could you turn around again, dear?” Aglaea requests.

Mydei obeys. Aglaea holds up her glasses and squints at him for another uncomfortably long second. “…There doesn’t seem to be any inappropriate bulging.”

“No there isn’t,” Mydei objects, his thighs instinctively shutting to a close. “I meant that the costume is tighter than I thought.”

“In an uncomfortable way?”

Mydei shakes a leg. “I can still move in it, I think. This part’s annoying though.”

With a swing of his arm, he demonstrates the excessive billowing of his sleeves, made all the more ridiculous by the glittery feather-boa-thing serving as its trim. It’s a fire-hazard in short, which would go *really well* with the aggressive pyrotechnics Phainon’s stages are known for.

“The bell sleeve *is* quite dramatic,” Aglaea concurs. “I can see it getting in the way of your guitar.”

She scatters the line of immaculately dressed employees with a single gesture, presumably ordering them to rectify the issue at once. The woman who Mydei this is their head stylist writes something down in her notepad before asking Aglaea, “Should we adjust the taper or take off some length?”

Aglaea assesses Mydei’s figure once more. “Remove all of it,” she says.

Mydei senses no hard feelings from the seamstress as she tears through the basting stitches connecting the sleeves to his torso. Maybe she also thought it was too much, although now the problem may be that it’s *not enough*.

Speaking of too much, the prodigal son returns from his expedition around the store to hover curiously behind Aglaea. “What about me?” Phainon asks.

“You’re perfect already,” Aglaea says.

“I know that. But what about my outfit?”

Like Mydei had said, he and Phainon were like two linked sausages, though he might have to rework that metaphor after Aglaea’s remarks. It made sense at the time, considering the glossy airtight wrappings and the fact that they were made one and the same. They might not match for much longer, but something tells Mydei they’d look equally absurd no matter what.

Aglaea had reassured him it wasn’t his fault, yet Mydei still suspects he had his big mouth to thank for this travesty. Apparently, *Sun and Thunder* has racked up enough interest for the label’s shareholders to throw in more of their two cents. That part is not Mydei’s doing. It’s the part where he was filmed condemning those stupid outfits that Mydei takes accountability for. He had forgotten to cross his fingers, and now here comes Janus collecting their due. *Grove* would push for a show at Marmoreal Arena, but only if Phainon and Mydei were dressed in the right apparel.

“Take your place next to Mydeimos,” Aglaea orders Phainon.

Phainon kindly shuffles up to Mydei, who is now sporting his bare arms. Aglaea examines their clothing once again, occasionally double-checking

without her spectacles.

“Phainon is perfect,” Aglaea confirms. “Keep Mydei sleeveless. Let me see him with a high halterneck.”

An entire store-worth of people scurry off once more to turn Aglaea’s words into reality. Only Phainon stays put, eyeing Mydei’s incomplete outfit with its chalky markings and raw edges.

“How come he gets to bring out the gun show but I don’t?” Phainon asks.

“Your clothes are already done with,” Aglaea explains. “Altering Mydei’s clothes are easier, and his tattoos keep you two visually balanced.”

Phainon nods, though he might just be pretending to understand her. “In that case, what about an opening here?”

The singer places a finger on Mydei’s sternum, left uncovered by the outrageously low neckline of his costume. Phainon traces a diamond in the valley of Mydei’s pecs, as if following the shape of Mydei’s chest tattoo. This nets Phainon a flick on the forehead from a man who may or may not be overly ticklish.

“Perverse,” Aglaea says. “We’ll consider it.”

Phainon pouts as he rubs the area where Mydei’s finger had struck. Mydei sees the inspiration of Phainon’s idea in the singer’s own wide open collar, an unfortunate signature of Phainon’s wardrobe.

An afternoon spent as a living mannequin is far from what Mydei considers as enjoyable, but it’s not as bad when there’s someone else prancing about in the same embarrassing costume. It keeps his mind off the Marmoreal Arena, and all the fond memories he’ll sully by playing horrendously in the name of easy money.

As far as *Sun and Thunder*’s costuming goes, their latest vestments are easily their finest ones, to the point where it’s insulting to make the comparison. Mydei surmises that Aglaea has little love for the band’s style,

having seen and experienced her preferences first hand. It's hard to imagine Aglaea willingly nominating lamé and bell-bottom pants for Phainon's new look, but it makes sense that she'd want to be the one to take care of it. Better her than some other stranger who sees the campiness as a gimmick. At least Mydei can still look at himself in the mirror, and that's saying nothing about Phainon, who struts around in his catsuit without anyone blinking an eye.

The outfit certainly doesn't stop Phainon from chatting up a saleslady, and it doesn't deter said saleslady from laughing at his jokes with a honeyed timbre.

"…Should Phainon be wearing out his costume like that?" Mydei asks.

"It's good for him to break it in," Aglaea says, occupied with something on her tablet. "His dances require a wide range of motion."

Mydei did see the viral clip of Phainon popping a split on stage. "Wouldn't throwing it in a dryer be enough?"

"Perhaps. But I'd rather we savor our reprieve from Phainon's personal attire," Aglaea admits.

The saleslady slaps Phainon on the arm for saying something that Mydei can't make out, taking her chance to run a hand over the flexed bicep straining the shiny lycra. Phainon doesn't brush her off. He doesn't even drop his smile.

There's nothing wrong with wearing yellow corduroy, Mydei thinks to himself. Surely enough people like him already.

—

Leonnius
what the fuck?!?1?!?1 de is
working with that clown again????

Leonnius
did u guys know???

Hephaestion
I thought you were a fan of
Phainon

Leonnius
i am but de is my homeboy

Leonnius
de before p always <2

Leonnius
*<3

Ptolemy
You found out bc of the puppy
interview didnt you?

Leonnius
yea why?

Ptolemy
😂😂😂

Ptolemy
The entire country has known
this for about two weeks now

Leonnius
sybau

Ptolemy
Couldn’t even watch a normal
interview you had to wait for the
one that had the clickbait in it

Leonnius
stop atacking me

Leonnius
@Deedee why didnt u tell me why
did noone here tell me

Hephaestion
He didn’t tell me either lol I
only found out after I saw Phainon
in Mydei’s house

Leonnius
HUH????

Hephaestion
It was still a secret then!

Leonnius
oh ok it was just u

Me
peucesta met him too

Leonnius
get the fuck out of here

Leonnius
no de sorry please come back
explain ts to me please 😭

Ptolemy
You shouldn’t have gone on that
trip abroad lmao

Leonnius
YOU shut uup

Ptolemy
We all met him while you were gone

Leonnius
really?????

Hephaestion
Yes

Leonnius
😭 😭 😭 😭 😭

Ptolemy
Yeah we all had brunch with him and
Got personalized autographs

Leonnius
see now ik ur ass is lying no way
you convinced perdikkas to go out
for brunch lolll

Perdikkas
[photo]

Leonnius
FUCKKKKKKKK

Leonnius
why do u have his signature on
peus flyer this is crazy

Me
what happened to de before p

Leonnius
i should b asking u that

Leonnius
u said no more sun n thunder

Leonnius
but look who came crawling back
😑

Perdikkas
@Mydei Don’t give Lee the
discount codes for the tickets
and pre orders

Leonnius
wtf r you doing on ur residency
to be online rn?????

Ptolemy
So true fire this guy already

Leonnius
@Deedee please explain please

Ptolemy
What is there to explain he’s a
musician

Hephaestion
Mydei and Phainon seemed ok when
I saw them. Maybe they patched
things up for the reunion

Leonnius
u suck ass tol a real one would
have just given me the skinny
ASAP

Leonnius
hep u real asf i appreciate u

Hephaestion
You probably know more than me if
you watched their interview

Leonnius
yeah but i need to know if we fw
that guy now

Leonnius
like should i trust him with mydei
or should i continue praying on his
downfall

Ptolemy
You have too much Phainon merch
to be saying that

Leonnius
the important thing is that de knows
where ill stand if we have to go to war

Me
? when did I imply I have
problems with him?

Ptolemy
Historical revisionism at work
here

Me
?

Ptolemy
It’s obvious you have
unresolved issues with the guy

Hephaestion
He’s joking. It’s just natural to think

you two have a complicated history given that you don’t talk about him at all

Ptolemy
Like Walter White and Gray Matter Technologies

Me
Im not walter white

Hephaestion
Yeah, that’s why we assumed Phainon was the problem

Me
is this why you were acting so weird when he was here?

Hephaestion
Maybe

Hephaestion
In my defense you were also really cagey back there

Me
I was trying to keep the details of our collaboration a secret

Hephaestion
I can believe that

Ptolemy
If I had to work with my old childhood friend whos making billions off our old discog I would not be sane about it

Hephaestion
Our De’s built different

Me
the deliverer doesnt make me
feel anything at all

Perdikkas
Huh

Ptolemy
No one said that

Hephaestion
Mydei 😭

Perdikkas
Why did you say it so ominously

Me
you guys were trying to imply
something

Hephaestion
I don’t think you know what
we’re implying

Ptolemy
You called him the deliverer
like he’s not your co-worker

Me
yes he is my coworker we
have a professional status

Me
after this we’ll go our separate
ways andforget

Me
each other again

Hephaestion
That’s sad

Ptolemy
Pour one out for snt heading
straight back to the grave after
2 songs

Hephaestion
Phainon looked like a good guy
to me. I don’t think he’d blow you
off like that

Me
its not personal its just how
the industry works

Perdikkas
That’s crazy

Ptolemy
So whose idea was it to go
buddy-buddy on camera?

Me
marketing

Ptolemy
I knew it. You would never sit so
close to another human being
like that

Leonnius
oh my god fuck everyone on
weaver

Leonnius
pissing me off

Me
?

Leonnius
its nothing its just people
being horny

Leonnius
i wouldnt recommend checking
it anytime soon

Leonnius
they didnt force u to get an
account right?

Me
no theyre more likely to
run it themselves

Leonnius
oh good

Leonnius
keep away from it for now
Its nuts out there

Me
I dont care if people
dont like me

Leonnius
no man im serious theyre
just talking about ur ass and
stuff nothing big

Perdikkas
I don’t know. Mydei’s ass
is not an insignificant size

Hephaestion
We need to start doing more
squats

Peucesta
@Leonnius I’ll give you my
blocklist.

—

Phainon’s breath catches in his throat the moment the journalist finishes his question.

Mydei’s hands curl into tight, hard fists, though his answer come out in nothing more than a worn-out monotone. “I wouldn’t say I based my career off of anyone. My father was more interested in growing his enterprise by the end of his life anyway.“

“So you were more influenced by his business-sense?”

The laugh Mydei forces out has more in common with a snarl. “I’m influenced by nothing of his.”

“Mydei’s a self-made man,” Phainon quickly intervenes. “It’s why his songs sound so unique.”

The interviewer refuses to segue, either out of malice or ignorance. “It sounds like his father had a hand in his career, considering how his company had gone to Mydei.”

“If you know that much, then you should already know that Bulwark was restructured and bought out by its own employees,” Mydei shoots back.

Phainon sees the moment Mydei knows he’s messed up. There was nothing false about what Mydei had said, but it was the way he said it, the

unmistakable venom of his words and the threatening tic of his jaw. Remorse settles in the tiny quiver of Mydei's lashes, just as a gratuitous shock grips the interviewer's guiltless face.

"If I recall correctly, it went to Mydei automatically because of how inheritance laws work in Kremnos," Phainon says, calmly and lightly. "Mydei only wants to write songs, so he stepped away as soon as possible and left it to people who know what they're doing. It's old news by now really."

This is not the way to respond. Correcting a magazine correspondent on his research makes Phainon look arrogant. Speaking on behalf of an alienated party risks tying Phainon to controversy. Sharing his real opinion in a backhanded comment illustrates Phainon as a petty diva. Yet he does it anyway, exuding with enough bonhomie to deflect immediate criticism. It works, but not on everyone. There will definitely be consequences for this later. For now, Phainon allows himself to savor the journalist's flustered backtracking under his steady gaze.

Phainon blatantly takes point over the rest of the interview after that, as if to block the magazine from addressing Mydei directly again. Every now and then he makes sure to ask for Mydei's opinion on more neutral topics, cracking twice as many jokes when the blond falters. It's too early to call it a bust. Perhaps the divine light of providence could shine on them once more, inspiring their editorial team to keep their articles spic-and-span in the spirit of humanitarianism. They *are* a fashion magazine, not a gossip rag.

By the end of it, Phainon is beyond exhausted. He spits out a brittle 'thank you' as the reporter cuts the recording, hoping to quickly grab Mydei and leave. To his surprise, it is Mydei who delays him, taking the time to follow Phainon in thanking the journalist and the rest of his crew.

This is the first time he's ever done this, so Phainon's confusion is understandable. The anger though? Phainon doesn't know where that comes from.

“Hey, I’m sorry about earlier,” the interviewer says, pulling Phainon out of his navel-gazing. “People are going to be curious about these kinds of things, you know? We were just trying to give you a fair shake at defending yourself.”

He appears and sounds apologetic, curling in on himself slightly to make himself look small. Mydei would normally punch his way out of a problem like this, or curse the other person’s entire bloodline until even their ancestors are begging for mercy. It’s rare for Mydei to silently nod and walk away, knowing that little else is more shameful to a proud Kremnoan.

Phainon hastens his steps to catch up to Mydei. The interview had taken place in a posh lounge, the type to invest in wainscoting for the walls and Chesterfields for seating. It would have been a lovely place to unwind in after work, to knock down a few shots with a fellow band member or something like that. Unfortunately Phainon feels nothing but contempt for it now, though he appreciates the quiet alcove that grants him a private word with the songwriter. The vacant expression hasn’t left Mydei’s face since his father had been brought up, so Phainon naturally starts with, “You’re not your dad.”

“I know,” Mydei mutters. “I should have handled it better.”

There’s that strange anger surging through Phainon again, but he brushes it off for Mydei’s sake. “If someone said my life’s work is based of some supreme asshole, I would have been arrested on the spot,” he says.

The corners of Mydei’s lips make a valiant attempt, but a genuine smile is still too heavy for him to pull off. Phainon will have to try harder.

“Coming from a guy with an uneven mustache too,” Phainon says. “He’s lucky they’re not gonna film him and put him on tv or anything.”

“…Maybe it’s what’s hip these days.”

“I’ll be dead before you catch me rocking the Tetris Z-block on my face.”

Finally, a real laugh slips through, light and husky from caprice. “That’s not what they call it.”

“You caught me. They actually call it a ‘skew tetromino’, but I didn’t think you’d care about the professional lingo.”

“I meant they probably just call it a mustache,” Mydei says. “The fuzzy caterpillar or something.”

“That’s way worse than what I said.”

Mydei chuckles again, though he hides it with a shake of his head. Silence creeps in once more, as does the dim melancholy in Mydei’s eyes.

“…Sorry,” Mydei sighs.

“For what?” Phainon says, fixing the part of Mydei’s fringe where the pomade had slackened. “Everyone fucks up sometimes.”

“I could have lessened my chances if I kept my mouth shut.”

“They would have gotten that out of you one way or another.” Phainon gives him a firm pat on the shoulder. “I’m surprised you even held up this long.”

Mydei scoffs, a sure sign that he’s close to making a full-recovery. “This was the first time they’ve asked about my father.”

“That's a lot of restraint for journalists. Who do you think is to thank for that?” Phainon asks.

“The reporters.”

“Nope, wrong. Think about it carefully. Who books these shows in the first place?”

“…Your publicist.”

“And do you think she would have given *Amphora Style* the exclusive scoop on your infamous dad?”

“Not really.”

“The answer is no, not at all,” Phainon stresses. “So you don’t have to look so scared.”

“I’m not scared,” Mydei says, crossing his arms.

“You were! You totally were!”

“I was not,” Mydei insists. “I was thinking of how to explain it to her.”

“She’s used to that kind of thing. A lot of people want to keep their privacy, just as a lot of people want to be a scumbag about it,” Phainon says. “…She does it for me too. Bringing up my parents is taboo in interviews now.”

Mydei’s dour expression eases, like a startled cat sensing the danger is gone. Phainon doesn’t usually get the urge to speak about it, so his stream of consciousness barrels through the frail defenses he’d put up.

“I used to get a lot of questions about my old folks,” Phainon finds himself admitting. “I used to answer them all too, but they were really, *really* interested in how they died and everything that surrounded it. Some bullshit tabloid even dragged Cyrene’s parents into the mix, like questioning the adoption and stuff, and that was pretty much it for me. I didn’t want to answer them in the first place, much less give them material they could use against the people I love.”

“So Aglaea put an embargo on the questions,” Mydei states.

“After my tantrum in Ladon, yeah,” Phainon says, embarrassed. “She was real mad at me too, because she could have prevented it if I just told her how much the questions pissed me off. Fun fact about celebrities? Apparently all of us have some kind of Achilles’ heel we hate talking about.”

Mydei leaves Phainon's words to sit, letting their thoughts simmer as he stares at the pop star without comment.

Then he says, "If I asked the cashier at my corner store about the exact circumstances her husband died, she'd punch me in the mouth."

A sudden laugh wracks through Phainon's body. "Fuck," he says. "She would, wouldn't she?"

Later, the two of them would slip into their dressing room, grab the rest of their belongings, and leave the premises together without informing anyone else. The twenty minutes that they would spend ranting in Mydei's car would inoculate Phainon against the posts he reads later that evening, the memory of Mydei's rakish smirk holding more meaning than any libel charged against him.

—

Aglaea doesn't scold them on accounts of bad publicity still being good publicity. Some real frustration does seep in, however, when she dresses down a blogger for trying to insinuate a relationship between Mydei and his father's cronies. Phainon assumes it's her natural protectiveness at play, along with the sudden pep in his manager's step. Anaxa wouldn't dare miss the chance to dangle a disappointing incident above her head. The reduced interviews would certainly say so, considering they only had a single photoshoot penciled in for the next three days.

"About time," Anaxa says when he verifies the gap in Phainon's schedule. "I thought that woman was going to keep this dog and pony show running on fumes."

"I'm sure she would have let you add to the schedule if you just spoke with her," Phainon says.

"I did. Then she added another talk show appearance."

"To be fair, he did call Miss Aglaea a 'serendipitous thief'," Hyacine tells Phainon as she waters one of the many plants flourishing in Anaxa's office.

“I called her a *meritorious* thief,” Anaxa corrects. “I was complimenting her on succeeding where I could not.”

At that point, Hyacine could only shrug at Phainon.

As hands-off as his management style might be, Anaxa has been hard at work getting *Sun and Thunder*’s new songs to the right ears. He’s been vetting early reviews and arguing with digital distributors on top of everything he’s been doing so far in regards to Phainon’s solo material. Anaxa’s latest quarry is a set of music videos that he himself insists on. In Anaxa’s eye, Phainon and co were drumming up all this promotion without anything to show for it, so what better way to commemorate *Sun and Thunder*’s comeback than with a music video?

That’s how Mydei finds himself in a fancy coach bus the very next day, munching on a bag of trail-mix he packed for the trip. In a rare reversal of priority, *Amber Dawn*’s video would be the first one to be shot to give its release a bigger push. It’s also partly in consideration for the traveling Phainon and Mydei have to do. Could Mydei have made this trek alone? Absolutely, but although Anaxa might have learned to trust his songwriting, Mydei’s punctuality was a different matter altogether. A chance to catch some shut-eye isn’t too bad either.

Mydei had been mostly left alone by the small army of assistants and attendants accompanying him on this journey. The seats around Mydei are comically barren, but it’s not like he gets to bask in his solitude for long anyway. It was only a matter of time before a well-known white mop graces Mydei line of sight.

“You shouldn’t walk around on a moving bus,” Mydei warns his new neighbor.

Phainon shrugs, folding his aviators to hang it onto his bright polo. “I don’t think you should be eating on a bus either,” the pop star says.

Mydei holds out the trail-mix bag, from which Phainon automatically pilfers a few nuts.

“Now we’re both complicit,” Mydei accuses.

The bus is yet to reach the toll gate exiting Okhema, but the scenery outside the window is already greener than it is in the city limits. It’ll only get wilder from here, where Okhema’s jurisdiction falls short. Mydei decides he might as well get that nap in now, not trusting the bus’s suspension to hold as soundly over the rockier roads. He nods off in the middle of an argument with Phainon, begrudgingly accepting the contractual agreement that salads are the perfect snack food.

Mydei thinks he might have had a nightmare about lettuce and thousand island dressing, but he forgets about it the moment he snaps to consciousness. The first few seconds of wakefulness leave him horribly disoriented, as if he’s been tilted on the wrong axis. Instead of sitting upright in chair like he remembers, Mydei finds himself curled up across two seats, his head cushioned by Phainon’s thighs. The clawing on his scalp that he had mistaken for Figgy turns out to be Phainon’s hand braiding itself into the knots of his hair. Phainon doesn’t seem to be aware that Mydei has awakened yet. He’s busy staring pensively out the window, fixated on the landscape rolling on by.

The slightest of motion from Mydei reminds the absent-minded singer of the weight on his legs. He looks down at Mydei, immediately wiping off the somber emotion from his face in favor of a familiar smirk. “Rise and shine, sleepyhead.”

“Are we there already?” Mydei grumbles, unable to keep the grogginess out of his voice.

He doesn’t get up yet, only lifting his head enough to regain his bearings. Phainon’s answer doesn’t give him much reason to rise either. “We’re about thirty minutes away, give or take.”

Mydei grunts in acknowledgement before dropping his head back onto its impromptu pillow. Phainon tries to muffle his reaction, but Mydei still hears his tiny ‘ow’ slip through his teeth.

“Wake me up when we’re there,” Mydei orders.

“Do you need anything else, your Majesty?” Phainon asks. “Want me to sing you a lullaby? Give you a massage?”

“You’re the one who put me here.”

“Your head was getting scrambled by the window,” Phainon says, leaning over Mydei. The setting sun bounces off the rhinestones on Phainon’s collar, shining onto his face like dappled sunlight. “Can’t risk you battering your precious brain now, can we?”

“*Haikas*,” Mydei mutters, pushing Phainon’s face away from him. “I’m going back to sleep.”

Despite closing his eyes, Mydei stays awake on Phainon’s lap. Maybe Phainon also knows he’s pretending, slotting his fingers back in Mydei’s hair to irritate him. When Mydei cracks an eye open out of curiosity, he finds that Phainon’s attention has drifted back outside the window, a stranger’s expression sitting where anticipation should have been.

Coming home is always difficult. Even more so when there’s no home to welcome you back. Mydei might know what that feels, but that doesn’t mean he has any clue of what to say.

—

While the finer details of minor stardom have taken some getting used to, filming music videos are apparently much easier for Mydei to come to grips to. Not because he's particularly talented at it, but because he remembered the process being much more grueling when he was a kid. It might be that he’d gotten used to early mornings as an adult, or that people are much less likely to tell a grown man to jump around half-a-million times for a single shot. Maybe it’s a sign that Mydei’s getting used to posturing on camera.

Mydei breathes in, savoring the sting of the chilly country air. If anything, it's the locale that’s making the shoot bearable.

Amber Dawn's music video takes place deep in the countryside. The closest town is about forty minutes away, with stretches of verdant hills between the film site and proper civilization. Summer would usually make outdoor shoots difficult, but with the higher elevation and the sea being a hop-and-a-skip away, the weather hasn't anything less than pleasantly balmy. If Mydei rises early enough, he could even start the day off with a refreshing jog through a track shaded by stately cypress trees.

"Mister Mydei!"

Alas, there aren't enough mojitos on set to convince Mydei that this is nothing more than relaxing excursion. The songwriter turns at the sound of his name, acknowledging the girl bounding towards him with a nod.

"Mister Mydei," Hyacine repeats as she catches her breath. "They're checking the dailies at the director's tent! Would you like to check it out?"

Mydei hands her his water bottle, but she seems to have misunderstood, stowing it away in her bag full of essentials she's been carting around for other people. Too embarrassed to correct her, Mydei simply moves on to answer her question, "No, thank you."

"Are you sure?"

"Positive." Mydei holds out his towel to her. "To wipe your sweat," he clarifies, miming out the action.

"Huh? Oh! Thank you!" Hyacine beams at him. "Be careful though. Sharing towels is one of the leading causes of ringworm infection!"

"Oh." Mydei looks down at the towel in his hands, still unclaimed. "… Do you know where Phainon is?"

"Mister Phainon? He should be in the director's tent by now."

Great. "…Can you lead me there?"

Today, the tent in question has been set up at the edge of a clearing, a mild trek away from where Mydei had been loitering. Hyacine kindly updates

him on the walk over, something she's only paid to do for Phainon's behalf. She laughs when Mydei brings it up, telling him that a good deed costs nothing. It must be her first month working in the industry, Mydei thinks. She would have swindled a remuneration out of Mydei otherwise.

There's no door on the tent for Mydei to knock on, so he and his pastel pink cohort barge in unannounced. They find three people crowding around the largest monitor on set, reviewing a scene that makes Mydei cringe.

Phainon is the first to notice the new arrivals. "You're just in time," he comments as Mydei and Hyacine approach. He doesn't sound as exaggerated or humdrum today. "We were just getting to the good parts."

"Why is my face so big on the screen?" Mydei asks.

"We'll zoom out in post," the director explains. "We were checking the composition."

"You look great either way though," Phainon comments. "In case you were feeling insecure."

Mydei scoffs. "What I look like doesn't matter to me."

It would have been a problem for the production if Mydei cared about how he was depicted on screen. There's not a lot of good he could say about the domineering, pugnacious dope swaggering about in all their footage, but as long as no one else takes umbrage with him, Mydei would consider it a job sufficiently done.

That doesn't make it any less horrifying to see. Mydei steps back from the rest of the watch party with barely concealed grimace. "I get the gist," he says, making a big show of stretching his arms. "It's getting too cramped in here, so I'm heading out."

"We haven't even gotten to the shots in the field yet," Phainon protests.

"I want to be surprised."

Mydei unceremoniously leaves the tent. Phainon turns to the rest of their audience. “He actually hates surprises,” he warns. “So don’t jump at him when you see him around.”

Hyacine giggles. “Mister Mydei is right though. Music videos lose their magic when you watch them before they’re ready.”

“I mean I think the stuff we have is already worth watching,” Phainon says, turning back to the monitor. On screen, Mydei shreds on his guitar, arcing his back to get a better purchase on those higher notes. It would make for an spectacular visual once they edit the actual music in, but even a single soundless frame is enough to exemplify the ferocity unique to Mydei.

“That kid is something, isn’t he?”

Phainon glances over to the director, who strokes her chin in deep thought. “Presence like that is hard to imitate. Especially now that the age of rockstars has passed us by,” she says.

She’s not wrong. Mydei does look exquisitely edgy thanks to the make-up and costuming, though it’s obvious that his all-consuming gaze has nothing to do with the kind of eyeliner he has on. Calypso isn’t one of Anaxa’s longtime collaborators for no reason. Mydei must have really impressed her to be worth mentioning.

“For someone who’s been out of the public eye for years, he can sure work a camera,” she continues.

“Mydei’s full of surprises,” Phainon touts.

“It wouldn’t be much of a surprise after this,” Calypso says, smirking at him. “I suggest that you and your manager lock him up in a studio soon.”

Suddenly, Phainon doesn’t feel like gloating. “What do you mean by that?” He asks with as much boylike confoundment as possible.

“Nothing for you to be envious of, Phainon,” she replies. “He’ll still have to prepare a hell of a campaign to catch up to your popularity.”

Isn’t that still impressive? In the span of a single decent project, Mydei could have what Phainon took a decade to accumulate, and no one would be able to contest it. It wouldn’t matter if it ate into Phainon’s fame. As long Mydei gets what’s been owed to him, as long as it earns him an iota of the admiration that he deserves, Phainon would consider it a sacrifice worth making.

Phainon forgets exactly what had annoyed him by the time they finish reviewing yesterday’s rushes, but he remains contemplative, as if that one question had excavated an ancient problem. He supposes that’s what he gets for engaging in discussion with Anaxa’s acquaintances. As Hyacine starts inquiring the director’s team about today’s shooting schedule, Phainon quietly steps out for further introspection, hoping that the morning breeze could help clear his mind.

A roll of bread ambushes him as he exits the tent. “What the-“

“Eat,” a man gruffly orders.

Phainon opens his mouth to object, giving Mydei the opportunity to shove an entire buttered roll into his gob. Unless he wishes to choke, Phainon is forced to chew, leaving him to frown at the triumphant Kremnoan and the assortment of samples he had picked up from catering.

After a mild jaw workout, Phainon manages to gulp down his breakfast. “Have you been sneaking around here the entire time?” He accuses.

“I obviously haven’t,” Mydei says, waving a danish right in Phainon’s face. Phainon chomps down in retaliation, but Mydei doesn’t seem to mind one bit.

“Good boy,” Mydei praises. He has no idea that he’s about to give Phainon a boner.

“You’re going to give me a boner,” Phainon says out loud.

Instead of grossing him out or pissing him off as intended, Phainon’s words magically draws a laugh out of Mydei.

“Is that how easy you are?” Mydei teases. “Good boy, Deliverer, good boy. Who’s a good boy? You’re a good boy.”

“I was joking you know.”

“Excellent boy.” Mydei smirks. “Did that make you cum in your pants?”

Phainon elbows him in the gut, sending a few of Mydei’s bread rolls tumbling to the ground. Mydei would usually follow it up with a headlock, but Hyacine had materialized right then, stopping them in their tracks with an unyielding pinch of the ear.

—

Mydei’s beautiful fantasy of a vacation in the country ended before it could have a chance to begin. As a consolation prize, everyone is treated to a free stay in the nearest town, courtesy of the shoot ending later in the afternoon than intended. It would be irresponsible to make their bus driver work through the evening, though Mydei suspects it has more to do with Phainon’s manager happily requesting reimbursements from higher management.

As long as it’s not coming out of Mydei’s pockets, he’s not going to complain. Complaining is currently the last thing on his mind, what with the smorgasbord of tarts and delicate puddings sitting in front of him.

“Hmm!” Hyacine exclaims. “This orange blossom custard is really good too!”

Mydei digs his spoon into the ramekin she’d pointed at. Hmm, she’s right. “It’s delicious, but simple. With some cornflour and milk, we could remake this at home.”

“The syrup looks difficult to find though.”

“Kremnoan markets have something similar,” Mydei says. “If I could find it, I’ll make you some.”

Hyacine cheers. “Then we won’t have to travel half a day for a cup!”

Mydei and Hyacine had initially set out to find souvenirs to bring back home, but it didn’t take long for them to get sidetracked at the sight of a display case filled with pastries and sweets. Since there’s no telling when they’ll be back, they ended up ordering half of the café’s entire stock of desserts on the spot. So far, it’s been worth it. Mydei almost wishes they dragged more people into their trip to justify buying more, but at least with only him and Hyacine, halving a slice of pie doesn’t require a protractor.

Some ice cream would be the perfect thing to end their lunch on a high-note, especially since they were seated outside in the sun. Hyacine doesn’t like being cooped up indoors apparently, and Mydei doesn’t like saying no to people who say ‘may we’ and ‘please’. The only thing Mydei prefers about being inside is the lack of rude cat-callers.

“Hey hot stuff! Mind giving me some sugar?”

Hyacine frowns, which is about as threatening as a puffed-up chinchilla. “You shouldn’t be parking on the street, Cipher.”

“It’s fine, shortstack,” Phainon’s bodyguard says, patting the dashboard. “I got the lights on.”

She does have her hazard lights on, but it probably also helps that there isn’t a lot of competition on the road at this hour. Still, that doesn’t stop Hyacine from attempting to goad her out of traffic’s way. “If you find a real parking spot, we’ll save you some cake,” she says.

“That’d hit the spot, but you know how it is. Boss on your ass, telling you to run around shopping for crap while you’re stuck in some podunk town…”

“Phainon's making you do errands?” Mydei asks.

Cipher blows him a raspberry. “That dweeb ordering me around? Is the sky falling on our heads? Nah, it’s Ags. She got me hunting down bargains on

leather. Wouldja believe that? Normal people would just ask for a magnet or something. What the hell do I know about traditional tanneries?"

"Take a break with us first then," Hyacine keeps trying.

"What do you think I'm doing? Just throw a piece of wafer in my mouth. I'm good for it," Cipher requests.

She opens her mouth wide, which Mydei automatically humors with a small gooseberry.

"Mister Mydei!" Hyacine says admonishingly.

"Nice throw," Cipher says. "Next time, try not shooting at the rental."

The berry had missed Cipher's head by a couple of inches, landing right onto the passenger seat instead. Mydei is sure he could make the next shot, but Hyacine's stare shames him into giving up.

"I wanted her to know what she's missing," Mydei says.

Obviously not a great excuse, but Hyacine accepts it anyway, recognizing that there are other people more deserving of her ire.

"If you're not going to join us, then you best go back to finding quality leather for Miss Aglaea," she tells Cipher. "Mister Phainon might need you soon, you know. Who knows if something'll happen to him?"

"Whoa, no need to call on bad omens, Cinny," Cipher says. "Nothing's going to happen to Phainon dearest. I even asked him if he wanted to hit the road with me, but he said he's fine cooped up in his hotel suite. And I already baby-proofed his room twice over, so I got nothing to do back there but get bored outta my mind."

Phainon content to be a shut-in? Maybe the sky is falling, because the only person that hates being inside more than Hyacine is the Deliverer himself. It's clear there's something that's been eating at him this whole trip, and it's even clearer now that there's no job to occupy his mind. Mydei shouldn't be

the only one to notice, yet neither Cipher nor Hyacine seem to react to the news. Is it that common for Phainon to have off-days? Or is Mydei overthinking it, worrying about issues are above his station?

A car honks at Cipher as it passes by, to which she responds with a furious toot of her own horn.

“I got my lights on!” She shouts at the retreating Accord. Hyacine just shakes her head.

Maybe it’s fine if Mydei overthinks this one time. Once does not constitute a pattern. It’s barely more than a coincidence, no further insinuation or significance to be made of.

“Cipher.” A vague shape of a plan forms in Mydei’s head as the bodyguard lowers her middle finger. “Where did you rent the car?”

—

Phainon’s back hurts from lying in bed for so long, but he refuses to get up anytime soon. Especially for an incessant ringing that the sign on his door should have discouraged. If someone wanted to play Flight of the Bumblebees on the doorbell then by all means, go nuts. There’s no one inside the room that cares. No sirree.

…Oh, fuck it. Life’s too short for Phainon to pretend he’s got a longer fuse.

He marches to the door and throws it wide open, exposing his tousled self to all and sundry. “Real sorry, but I’m not doing autogr- huh?”

“I don’t want an autograph,” the intruder deadpans before yanking Phainon out of his hotel room by the neck of his pajama shirt.

“Mydei? What are you- Wait! I can’t go anywhere like this!”

Mydei answers him by slotting a helmet right onto his dome. No words necessary as the blond continues whisking him away to Kephale knows where.

Oceanview Inn may not have an ocean to view, but their free slippers hold up swimmingly through the journey from hotel room to parking lot. Phainon's psyche fared a lot less nicely, buoyed only by his trust in Mydei and his surprisingly reassuring grip. It's almost like one of Cipher's mafia shows, except instead of taking him out back to be executed, Mydei drags Phainon to a hotel parking lot to show him… a motorcycle?

In a display of great trust, Mydei lets go of Phainon's arm to grab the other helmet hanging from the bike's handlebars. He dons it on, looking a lot more put together than Phainon does with only a sleeveless shirt and a pair of dark wash jeans. Phainon notes the fit of his pants as Mydei slings a sculpted leg over the motorcycle with ease, the stiff waistband leaving a gap between skin and denim as he sits down. It seems that Mydei's tattoos really do go all the way south.

"Hop on," Mydei says, his voice dampened by the helmet.

Perhaps it's not a mob film. Phainon swears he's seen this same kidnapping plot in a Liam Neeson joint.

"Hop on," Mydei repeats. This time Phainon obeys, which may or may not be a result of Mydei's voice dipping into a low rasp. He's not quite sure what that says about him just yet.

"There's no seatbelt," Mydei says as Phainon settles behind him. "So you'll need to hold on to me."

Phainon finally understands what's happening. He must have fallen asleep in his hotel room, where he's dreamt up of permission to grope Mydei. He'd be a fool not to accept.

Courtesy keeps Phainon's touch light at first, but the speed at which Mydei tears out of the parking lot forces Phainon's arms to tighten around his driver's midsection. Whatever remained of Phainon's fogginess didn't last a minute into the ride. The roar of the engine and the wind buffeting around them had sobered Phainon up instantly, just in time for him to recognize the insanity of Mydei weaving through car after car on the road.

Phainon feels Mydei chuckle more than he hears it, and that's when Phainon realizes he's been screaming throughout the drive so far. Phainon would have pinched his abductor's side, had he not been afraid of crashing into a lamppost.

A more attentive person would have asked their questions much earlier, before conversation becomes a tedious shouting match over the whizzing traffic. Those obvious questions only occur to Phainon now, when he observes lesser and lesser buildings around them. Where did Mydei get the bike anyway? Why did he decide to take Phainon with him? Where in the world could they possibly be going?

That last question is Phainon's final attempt at ignorance. He should know their destination from the exits Mydei takes, but would it be so selfish to take this moment as it is? A simple drive down the country for the sake of seeing Amphoreus in her most scenic? The view certainly helps distract from the fundamental truth, as does the rugged body in his arms, keeping Phainon warm through the cold draft. A patchwork of greens and browns blankets the distant hills, stitched together by winding rivers and streams. Wispy streaks of white break up the vast blue above them like seafoam on the shore. It's breathtakingly picturesque. It's a painting on the back of a postcard. The concept of mafia movies and action thrillers have long departed from Phainon's mind. He wants instead to reside in the same line of thought as *Roman Holiday* and *Fallen Angels*, but without any of the trifles that made either film interesting.

"Take the dirt road to the left!" Phainon shouts over the noise.

He admits to doubting Mydei's compliance for a brief second, but his honorary chauffeur obliges without question. The path may be bumpier and the insects more relentless, but Phainon swears it shaves minutes off their perilous journey.

Mydei slows the bike as the road opens up to a village. Or what remains of it, it seems. What awaits them is nothing like Phainon's stories, or the mock-ups Mydei found while searching for directions. What they find is a barren land, a flattened plateau of sand and concrete. The back roads had hidden the worst of it, interspersed with rickety old huts that may or may

not be mostly vacated. At least there Mydei can make out a faint resemblance to Phainon's stories, where the lanky growths of ryegrass and foxtails mark where the sprawling fields used to be.

It's the main boulevard that is indistinguishable from the Aedes Elysiae in Mydei's imagination. There, a four lane road bisects the tiny settlement, running over the village green where Phainon used to chase down other kids with a makeshift sword. The shops where Phainon used to spend his hard-earned allowance have been converted into fast food chains and gas stations. In place of the trees Phainon used to climb are tall utility poles and their tangled cables, and in place of everything else is gravel and dust from abandoned construction sites.

It occurs to Mydei that he might have done a cruel thing. No one wants to see the desecrated corpse of their hometown, but before Mydei could work out the best way to apologize, Phainon points out to a store and says, "That's where I skinned my knee running after Rini."

"…When she stole your wooden effigy?"

"It was an action figure," Phainon corrects. "I got scolded at home for it too. I'm glad this place got turned into a Soulglad's."

The buildings, despite being newer, are already starting to show signs of wear. They're already not too impressive to look at - a line of flat uniform cubes dumped out in the middle of nowhere - but the chipping paint, the muddy windows, and the faded signs make up the final nail in the coffin. The sweltering heat beating down the main road is not only detrimental to humans. Shade is important for a hastily constructed strip mall too.

"Hey, can we stop here?" Phainon requests.

At his request, Mydei obediently parks in front of a grocer's, the myriad of advertisements taped over the front telling him nothing about the store. Phainon nearly stumbles as he jumps off the bike, ignoring Mydei's snort to shove the helmet back in his arms. He looked to be seconds away from dashing inside, but the bird nest his headgear had left forces him to pause. Phainon nearly scalps himself trying to tame his hair, only the shop's door

to open wide before Phainon could even reduce the number of cowlicks down to his usual two.

The man that steps out has a stoic brow and a heavy footfall. He stalks toward Phainon as if he intends to pummel the singer's face in, alerting Mydei enough to get him hopping off the motorcycle in panic. The man unfortunately gets to Phainon first, accosting him with a terrible and brutal bear hug.

"Phainon!" The man bellows. "You rascal, you didn't tell us you were coming by!"

"*Hrk*- Probably because it was last minute…" Phainon says. One of his ribs is probably dust by now. "…Could you put me down, Uncle Galba?"

This so-called 'Uncle Galba' lowers Phainon to the ground at his command. He also gives Phainon a hearty smack on the back that almost unseats his lungs.

"You shoulda tried ringin' up. I got nothing ready for you," Uncle Galba says disapprovingly.

"Aw, you don't hafta, y'know," Phainon tells him.

"For you, maybe. But what about your guest 'ere?" Uncle Galba gestures to Mydei. "I know you too, by the way. You're the other kid that's singing and dancing with our Phainon!"

Mydei had no idea what Uncle Galba would do next, but he definitely didn't expect a weathered middle-aged man to start singing his own song back to him. A deep cut from the *Sun and Thunder* discography no less.

"That one's my favorite," Uncle Galba says once he gets enough of that. "Phainon said you wrote that one on your own, so he made you sing most of it."

"Okay, Uncle Galba, let's give Mydei some space," Phainon interjects. "Can we continue this inside? It's blazin' out here."

“Of course, of course.” Uncle Galba nods. “Can’t have you city boys frying in the sun now.”

Mydei had planned to stay outside while Phainon attends to his own matters, but he can hardly turn down an invitation from Phainon’s elders. He follows them into the store, awkwardly third wheeling their warm greetings and well-wishes.

A rotating fan welcomes them with a blast of cold air. It’s a lot less brighter indoors, Mydei finds, as he blinks furiously to acclimate to the sudden shift in lighting. Not that there’s much of the store to look at once he opens his eyes, being small enough for Mydei to survey the entire room from the entrance. It makes it a bit of a tight squeeze for 3 men of their stature to make their way through the aisles, though it could be worse. Mydei tries not to be too thankful for the shop’s lack of customers and other employees. He’s not trying to jinx Uncle Galba’s source of revenue.

“Make yourselves at home,” Uncle Galba orders as he opens up one of his display coolers. “Find somewhere to sit or somethin'.”

There’s only one stool in the entire store. Phainon takes it at Mydei’s insistence, forgoing the usual quarreling and subjugation. He’s more subdued today, Mydei thinks, before Phainon starts patting his thighs in invitation.

“Seat yourself here,” Phainon offers with the panache of a used car salesman.

Mydei would have loved to make Phainon regret saying that. Unfortunately, he has no desire to out himself as a scoundrel in front of Phainon’s Uncle Galba, something that Phainon himself has no qualms with.

“There’s plenty of space,” the bastard continues to needle.

“On those twigs?” Mydei says. Phainon’s legs aren’t the least bit skinny, but his ego’s already inflated enough without hearing Mydei’s real opinion.

“You liked resting on them last time.”

“Probably because I was unconscious.”

Uncle Galba thankfully had been too busy sticking his head in a cooler to witness Mydei’s rudeness. When he finally withdraws from the store’s icy depths, Phainon’s hair has mysteriously gained some new unruly flyaways.

“Here. To cool you off,” Uncle Galba says, pushing a can of soda into each of their clutches.

“I’m fine, thank you,” Mydei refuses.

“No you’re not,” Uncle Galba says. “You’ll need this if you rode all the way here on that two-wheeler."

“It’ll hurt his feelings, Mydei,” Phainon warns as he opens his own can.

“I-“

“You don’t ‘ave to pay,” Uncle Galba clarifies.

“…I don’t want to impose,” Mydei says, accepting the can in defeat.

“Trust me, you’d be doin’ me a favor,” Uncle Galba says. “That old thing’s just gonna go bad sitting on the shelf. You see anybody tryna fill their larders up in here?”

“It’s ‘cause you keep talking like that,” Phainon points out. “No one wants to shop anywhere where the owner’s mouthing off their own service.”

“That’d make sense if there were actually people around to hear me talk.”

Uncle Galba steps behind the counter and begins rummaging through its shelves. It takes a few seconds and a couple of drawers before he finds what he’s looking for.

“Hey kid,” he calls out to Mydei. “Check this out.”

Mydei lowers his soda can to see Uncle Galba proudly holding up a bare cassette tape; no sleeve, no case, no label, no nothing. The plastic is a little

dinged and a little grimy, and it takes a little elbow grease to shove it into the radio currently blasting some staticky 90's hits. The music dies out at a push of a button, replaced moments later by another song that's just as geriatric.

"Wow," Mydei says. He doesn't sound like it, but he does genuinely mean it. Who wouldn't be astonished to hear their old debut single out in a remote village?

"D'you need money for a real stereo, Uncle Galba?" Phainon asks. Phainon wouldn't be surprised by something like this. This is his home turf. "Our stuff sounds a whole lot better on CD."

Uncle Galba huffs. "CDs compress the sound. Listen to that. 'ear how the wah-wahs ring? You can't get that on CD."

"It's a bootleg recording," Phainon says. "You can't hear jack."

Uncle Galba waves him off and turns to Mydei. "You get what I'm sayin', right kid?"

"It sounds very authentic," Mydei says.

"See?"

"You can literally hear the radio announcer doing commentary on it," Phainon argues.

Mydei shrugs. "It's authentic like a home movie."

"I like this kid," Uncle Galba says. At some point, he had picked up a phone receiver and started dialing. "Bring 'im over more often, would you?"

"He's a kissass," Phainon says.

"I learned it from you," Mydei retorts.

"Learning from the best? You're welcome."

Mydei kicks his stool in response. The jolt spills a few stray drops of Phainon's soda onto the singer's pants.

"Oops," Mydei says, automatically leaning over to wipe off the mess.

"Whoa Mydei, not in front of Uncle Galba," Phainon exclaims.

Mydei immediately takes his hand off Phainon's leg and glares at him. "Do you want me to kill you?"

"I'd like to live a long happy life, if you don't mind," Phainon says, grinning. The sugar from the soda must have shot up straight to his head. "You could join me if you like."

"Join you? That'd kill *me*."

"Well no need to be dramatic about it."

If Uncle Galba notices their exchange, he doesn't say anything. Instead, he starts cackling at someone on the phone. "Yeah, yeah, but this ain't a social call. Guess who's sitting in the store right this very second?" Uncle Galba's merry expression suddenly drops to a scowl. "No I ain't in trouble! I paid for the damn- Can you get in 'ere already? Phainon's waiting for you!"

"We're actually just passing through," Phainon corrects. "I don't think we-"

"And bring leftovers. Phangry 'ere doesn't have time for a real meal," Uncle Galba says before setting the receiver down. Then he picks it up and starts dialing once more.

"You're not escaping that easily," he tells Phainon. "You don't know how many people you've pissed off staying away for so long- Hello? No I wasn't talking to you, I was talking to Phainon!"

"Uh," Phainon hesitantly looks up at Mydei. He doesn't say anything, allowing his apologetic smile to do the talking.

Mydei clicks his tongue. "It's fine," he says with a half-hearted reproach.

“You spoil me.”

“You’re the one who’s going to explain your absence to Hyacine.”

Phainon’s brow furrows. Mydei knows he would have opened his mouth to say something incendiary had he not been interrupted by Uncle Galba’s voice. “Yes, our Phainon! Do you know any other Phainons running around?”

Phainon eyes Mydei, who nurses his soda awfully slowly. “That’s a lot of people to meet,” he tells the blond.

“So?”

“So are you gonna be okay? Or would you like to hide it out somewhere?”

Mydei clicks his tongue. “Don’t patronize me. I’m a fully grown man.”

The crushing grip on his can being indicative of nothing, of course.

Phainon’s first visitor arrives much earlier than anticipated, though the bags hanging from her arm suggests she might be in the store for another purpose. Her double take at the door solidifies that theory, and for a moment Mydei fears she’s gone into cardiac arrest with the way she clutches at her chest.

“Oh my stars,” the woman quietly breathes. “Do my eyes deceive me?”

She approaches slowly, as if reality would crumble at her next step and send her tumbling out of bed. Her hand reaches Phainon’s face first, confirming his existence through sight and touch. For all his bravado earlier, Phainon now appears to be no better than a bashful child.

The woman stares at him wide-eyed in disbelief. “You haven’t been mailing lately,” she says.

“Neither have you guys,” Phainon replies.

The woman throws her arms around the pop star and laughs. “You keep changing addresses! It’s too complicated for simple folk like us.”

“As if the Aunt Doli I know could be stumped so easily,” Phainon says, sounding slightly out of breath. Everyone in Aedes Elysiae seems to be aggressive huggers, which explains a lot about Phainon’s proclivities.

The door bursts open just then, ushering in a stream of people carrying tributes of fruit and bread. “Where’s the boy?”

Phainon buries his head into Aunt Doli’s embrace, but Uncle Galba readily betrays him. “He’s over here!”

No one dares to miss out on the chance to see Phainon, no matter how much Phainon assures he’ll get to everybody eventually. While everyone has retained the good sense to line up and wait their turn, they’re utterly remorseless with their questions, drilling him on how he’s been, if he’s had the chance to try this-and-that, or if he even remembers them at all. Sometimes the question opens up to the floor, and everyone gets the chance to excitedly update Phainon about how their own lives are going.

Seeing the hubbub around the star, Uncle Galba silently gestures for Mydei to join him behind the counter, far from the madding crowd of aunts and uncles. As much as he’d love to be safely behind a barricade, the hand gripping onto his shirt tethers Mydei to Phainon’s side. He’s aware this makes him look like a security guard hovering over his charge - and he acts a bit like it too - but Mydei *did* drive all this way for Phainon’s sake. It would be incongruous of him if Mydei deserted Phainon at such a critical junction.

“How’s your folks?” Asks a woman as she places two wet kisses on Phainon’s cheeks. “Sorry we couldn’t make it to your ma’s birthday.”

Phainon laughs. “Yeah, that drove her crazy! She even took down your cross-stitching from the living room wall!”

“Oh that shrew! I oughta drive down there and give her piece of my mind!”

“What about Rini?” A man with an obtrusively large sun hat asks.

“She’s doin’ great!” Phainon answers. “Maybe a lil’ busy these days cause of the new book. That reminds me, I started raising a plant recently, and I can’t tell if the leaves are too yellow or if I’m seein’ things-”

“You got too much sulfates in the soil!

“You don’t know that, dummy! We needta check a photo before we start making that call!”

The population of Aedes Elysiae is a piddling number compared to any other town in Amphoreus, but the crowd that Phainon’s presence draws is still too much for Uncle Galba’s humble store to handle. Some villagers appeared to have foreseen this, hauling in plastic tables and chairs to set up outside. All the food they’ve brought for Phainon have been arranged out on the tables to be shared, while those who are sick of Uncle Galba’s radio have gathered around a guitar to entertain themselves. Anyone not hungry or musically inclined have taken to card games or discussion with a neighbor. Someone even props a chair against the shop’s door to keep it open, the fan on the counter working overtime to spare everyone a little relief.

Phainon lets go of Mydei’s shirt by the 30 minute mark, either no longer in need of his presence or aching from a terrible case of cramped fingers. Not that Mydei is itching for a chance to wander off, though the festivities happening right outside the door does pique his interest. He clearly put too much stock in Phainon’s magnetism if he thinks his curiosity isn’t obvious, because a group of ladies catch on to his wandering eye and decide to do something about it.

“Come, dearie,” says the woman tugging at his arm. “It’s no fun being a wallflower.”

“I am having fun, ma’am,” Mydei insists.

“Oh indulge us, would you?” Another woman says. “We don’t want you to think these four walls is all there to see in our little township.”

“Especially after Phainon dragged you all the way here,” the first woman says.

“…I was the one who brought him here.”

“Then the more you oughta enjoy yourself!” She replies.

Mydei looks back at Phainon, who pauses his conversation to shoot him a toothy smile. He’ll be alright without Mydei, and Mydei can survive a few minutes without him. With their consent, the women hoist Mydei around the gathering, introducing him to the various people who took a hand in raising Phainon. Each time, Mydei is taken aback to be recognized at first glance. His name might escape most of them, but everyone happily regales him with a performance they remember Mydei from. To be Phainon’s fan is to be a fan of his collaborators, apparently.

“‘cept for that song he did with that Belobog hip-hopper,” one of the village’s fishermen says. “She was alright, but Amphorean musicians are on a different level.”

“But that song he did with that tee-bee person was really catchy!”

“Yeah but see, they made that song in Amphoreus,” the fisherman says. “Phainon did not take a single step outside the country, which makes it a good song.”

“Men.” The lady holding on to Mydei clicks her tongue. “Allergic to feelings.”

“I’m also a man,” Mydei reminds her.

The woman pats his arm. “That’s why I’m tellin’ you, sweetie.”

Time passes exceptionally quick. Mydei gets to try a slice of bread or two, too full from his trip with Hyacine to stuff himself with more. He gets a sight of Phainon with his own entourage across the improvised reception, carefully examining a painting of large fluffy dog on the side of a truck. Mydei gets intercepted by a handful of curious people, and for once Mydei

doesn’t get snide or skittish about answering a simple question. He gets an explanation on Phainon’s beloved childhood friend, and when Mydei tells them he’s met Cyrene, he gets an aunt shouting at the crowd about how ‘it’s serious!’.

The guitar finds itself in Mydei’s hands at some point, and everyone instantly cajoles their two visitors into singing a song. Mydei meets Phainon’s eye, and with an amused shrug, they decide to premiere *Amber Dawn* right there and then. It’s difficult without all the instruments and without ever rehearsing an acoustic arrangement, but the audience is forgiving and the song is sincere. The performance earns them laughter where Phainon had promised tears, so Phainon naturally makes a show out of looking upset and seeking appeasement.

“He’s always been a sensitive boy,” Phainon’s old teacher tells Mydei.

“…I think he’s just joking,” Mydei says, watching Phainon feign offense with someone’s apology.

Phainon’s teacher laughs quietly. “I was referring to your song,” she explains. “Phainon can be very… transparent with what he feels. There isn’t a single soul here who wouldn’t immediately get what he was singing about.”

“Is it too on the nose?” Mydei asks.

“I think it’s just right,” Phainon’s teacher says. “ For what it’s worth, I liked it. You both wrote a lovely song.”

“…But?”

She smiles up at Mydei. “But Aedes Elysiae doesn’t really merit that kind of sentiment anymore.”

“You can blame the council for that,” the woman behind her mutters. “They sold a pretty lie about turning’ this ‘ere region into a moneymaker, then fled when the goin’ got tough.”

Mydei had read about it when he was looking up directions to the village. Aedes Elysiae was part of a grand renovation plan to turn the coast into a series of resorts, with hopes of boosting tourism and Amphoreus's GPD. It had fallen through after 5 stagnant years of development, in which the Council of Elders slowly came to realize the true magnitude of the project and how idealistic their projected budget had been. The plan had left nothing but rotting structures and displaced families in its wake - footnotes in Amphoreus's quest to catch up with the wider world.

A car crash had taken Phainon's parents around the very start of the demolition period. The kind of loss he experienced at such a young age shouldn't result in a man so eternally sunny, and yet here he is, laughing and grinning at a pun too lame to repeat.

"It's not so bad," Phainon's old teacher says, looking out at the desolated buildings across the street. "All the important bits are still here."

The lady from earlier, the one who Phainon called 'Aunt Doli', approaches the singer while the others are distracted. Whatever she says to him makes him smile meekly, to which Aunt Doli answers with the universal gesture for 'shoo'.

"I hate to be the bearer of bad news," Phainon says loud enough for the entire yard to hear. "But clock's a tickin'. Mydei and I gotta go get while there's still light out."

A chorus of 'aw's ring out from the gathering. Everyone surges once more toward Phainon, seizing their last chance to bend his ear. A few stragglers even take some time to approach Mydei with a promise to welcome him in their homes whenever he comes back. The farewells stretch on for minutes on end, coming to a stop when Phainon sees enough teary eyes in the crowd. He steps his foot down and pulls Mydei back to the bike, much to Mydei's insistence on independence. The villagers all boo while Mydei revs the engine, but as the two begin to ride off into the sunset, a horde of arms shoot up in the air and wave them off as zealously as they can.

Phainon waves back until their faces are mere blurs in the bike's side mirrors. His arm drops and quickly returns to Mydei's waist, adhering his

body to Mydei's back.

"…Did you have fun?" Phainon asks.

"I did," Mydei answers.

"Good," Phainon says. "Because I need you to take that next right before we head back."

Mydei is yet to defy a direct instruction from Phainon today, and there's no reason for him switch it up now. Despite the creeping fatigue from their merry-making, Mydei follows the directions he's been given, even as the path leads them up a hill through a battered road. They carefully navigate through the obstacles until reach the top, where they're greeted by a tiny cloister ravaged by snaking vines and wild ivy.

Mydei parks the bike under the building's shade. The symbols etched into the stone should be enough to clue him in, but Phainon beats Mydei's memory to the punch. "It's a temple to Oronyx," he explains. "Defunct, obviously, otherwise Cyrene woulda been a priest by now."

It's hard to tell if he's joking. Mydei might not know what a priest of Oronyx does, but solemn prayer and religious piety doesn't strike him as something Phainon's sprightly sister would enjoy. Then again, she is a really good storyteller. She'd probably be really good at preaching.

"Keep up, will ya?" Phainon says when Mydei stops to examine the roughened masonry. "That's not why we're here!"

Mydei grumbles to himself as he hikes through years of untamed shrubbery. A piece of bramble causes him to stumble out of the thicket and trip right onto Phainon, who steadies them both right before they end up tumbling down the hill. Mydei would had an unkind word to say, had the vista behind Phainon not stolen the complaint right out of his mouth.

Aedes Elysiae is no longer the beautiful tranquil village from Phainon's memory, but it's less obvious from up on high, where that garish highway is a trivial part of a wider picture. The ramshackle huts they passed earlier

envelop the lifeless thoroughfare with color, their brightly tiled roofs appearing like a meadow of flowers from afar. A wave of porch-lights flicker on in preparation for evening, despite the faint sounds of revelry still echoing in the air. On the outskirts of the village, young sycamore trees brace against the wind blown in by the sea, its waters shimmering brilliantly in the late afternoon.

Mydei turns to Phainon, who has wandered off to a pond beside the courtyard. Mydei follows him in squatting by its edge, following his gaze to a sprinkle of duckweed.

“All the kids used to bike up here in the summer to watch the frogs hatch,” Phainon says.

Mydei searches for said frogs and finds none. “We must have missed them,” he says.

“Summers are getting warmer. Wouldn’t surprise me if the frogs moved it up to spring.” Phainon skims his hand over the pond’s surface. “One year we found salamander eggs in the water too. That caused a big commotion, ‘cause we were worried the larvae would eat the tadpoles or vice versa.”

“Did you move them?”

Phainon shakes his head. “Nah. Our parents didn’t want a bunch of amphibians running around our houses, so we just let ‘em be. They all survived anyway. I think.”

“Is it only frogs and salamanders in here?”

“I don’t actually know. I haven’t been here since Rini’s folks moved away,” Phainon confesses. “How ‘bout you? Been to Kremnos lately?”

“Naturally,” Mydei says. “Krateros and I go back whenever it gets too cold in Okhema.”

“Must be nice.”

“You don’t know that. You haven’t been there.”

“But you sounded like you liked it.”

“It’s my city,” Mydei says. “I’d like it any way it came. You don’t have the same perspective.”

“I mean we like most of the same things,” Phainon points out. “Like music, for starters. And working out and… civilized discussion.”

“Hmm.” Mydei taps his knee in thought. “Then I suppose it’s no surprise that I like your village, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

Phainon scoffs. “Do you really?”

“Yes,” Mydei replies. “I do.”

Phainon stares into Mydei’s eyes, ready to latch on to the first sign of a lie. He stares at Mydei, who has never been anything but honest, and who’s nothing like Phainon’s cabal of timid admirers, shrinking away from the slightest bit of recognition.

The singer's withdrawal is a foregone conclusion, but the hysterical laughter is something Mydei would have never predicted.

“What’s wrong with you now? Mydei mutters.

Phainon wipes a stray tear from his eye. “How come I never remembered you being so presumptuous?” He asks with a juvenile grin.

“You say that as if I presumed wrong,” Mydei challenges.

“Okay, well, you got me,” Phainon concedes. “There’s still a lot to like about Aedes Elysiae. I just forgot for a second.”

“Remember it well then,” Mydei warns. “Or those poor women would be left waiting for letters that would never come.”

“You make me sound like a playboy.”

“So it’s funny to you? Playing with old women’s hearts?”

Another bout of laughter grips Phainon before the world around them takes over the conversation. Chirping crickets keep them company as the gentle wobble of the pond remains bereft of frog or salamander. The rustling grass fetes a creaking swing with lilliputian applause, rivaling the zeal of the tree branches above. The sky blooms into oranges and pinks, like bruises from a nasty spill orchestrated by your adopted sister.

Beside him, Mydei hears Phainon sigh. He turns to the pop star, wondering if his legs are also burning from squatting for so long. Instead of sore muscles and tetchy words, Mydei finds Phainon already looking back at him.

“You made my dream come true, you know?” Phainon says with a quiet chuckle.

Phainon’s wayward locks flutter in the wind, gilded with the citrine shine of noon. He doesn’t exactly smile, doesn’t grin in that open boyish way of his. Instead, catharsis squares his shoulders and lights a resolute glint in his eye, maturing him in spite of the rumpled pajamas and the flush of red from the sun.

What a sight to behold. Here, in the most perfect location with the most perfect of weather at the most perfect of timings.

“I mean in my dream I think I was the one taking you home, except th-mmpf?!”

There’s a name for the type of contact people make with their lips, but Mydei can’t remember it right now. He only recognizes it as a spark firing repeatedly in his synapses, overwriting his body’s directives until his mouth connects with the handsome face in front of him. It’s softer than he could ever imagine and sweeter than he could ever hope.

Mydei’s brain restores its functions too late. Kissing. The word is kissing. He’s kissing Phainon, and good Mydeimoses *never* kiss Phainon.

It’s a feather-light touch, nothing more than a vestal graze reserved for schoolchildren and ceramic tchotchkes of plump cherubs. Mydei pulls back

the moment he senses a pressure against his mouth, but he’s still too slow. His lips already tingle from Phainon’s absence, and he’s overwhelmed by the urge to swipe his tongue over the thin film of chapstick that had been left behind.

Mydei doesn’t do that, however. Not when Phainon’s wide eyes meet his and reflects Mydei’s doomed expression back to him.

“There’s a frog,” Mydei says. “On the tree. Behind you.”

Phainon turns and nearly jumps. There is a frog behind on the tree him. It’s a damn big frog too. Nearly the size of a handball.

“That is a frog,” Phainon says. “Or a toad. What the hell is that?”

That is the sound of Mydei getting away with it scot free. Kephale, Oronyx, or whoever it was who listened - your newest believer praises your mercy.

How they got back to the hotel is a foggy memory to Mydei. He’d been too focused on keeping his cool and distracting Phainon from what just transpired, telling himself that it could easily be mistaken for an accident. He comes up with all kinds of excuses - he had a cramp in his leg, he was trying to hear him better, he was too excited to see a huge frog - but he doesn’t dare neglect to prepare his apologies either. An apology would be the kindest thing Mydei can offer, and perhaps if he were a better person, it would have been the first course of action he takes.

And Phainon? Phainon stays the same old Phainon, badgering Mydei on the way back to their hotel rooms like he always does.

Chapter End Notes

> Thanks for reading! I got covid twice since I last posted. Either that or it was a really long covid that I got used to in the middle. If you guys can, you should get a booster during the holiday season we need to defeat this evil please eradicate coronavirus from planet earth santa claus

Chapter 5: Side E

Chapter Notes

> Hi! I hope everyone's been doing alright since last year
>
> Nothing explicit happens in this story at all but I do want to say that you may not want to read this in public. I mean I can't stop you. I've read a kpop fanfic over someone's shoulder at a guns and roses concert so maybe that's the move

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kissing Phainon is a problem for all of one day, because Mydei soon remembers about the interview coming up two days after. The thought of ruining another televised appearance and the thought of Phainon secretly despising him had cancelled each other out in his head, leaving Mydei at peace once it came time to head into the studio.

Mydei had been so calm and prepared that he arrives at the set earlier than he’s ever been. Typically that means sitting put in a corner and scrolling through his phone for an extra half-an-hour, but today he’s feeling energetic enough to try something productive. He decides to take a page out of Phainon’s book and boldly approach a crew member out of his own volition. To no one’s surprise, Mydei is not as skillful at talking up uninterested strangers, but he’s good at lifting things, and there’s apparently a lot of equipment that needs to be carried around on set.

“Mydei?” Phainon calls out as he arrives. “What are you doing?”

It’s hard for Mydei to look at Phainon when he’s holding up a large metal stand, but it’s not as hard as he expected days ago, when Mydei was still tortured by a certain fiasco in the mountains.

“Helping out,” he answers.

“I assumed that was the case,” Phainon says, raising an eyebrow. “Because it’ll be pretty difficult to sneak something that noticeable out of here.”

Mydei would have shrugged if his arms weren’t occupied. “So why’d you ask?”

The stand was starting to get in the way, so Mydei plods on to get rid of it once and for all. He places the stand down on the indicated spot, setting it up as instructed. This film crew is easy to please. They happily shower Mydei with praise and gratitude for a task that only takes him a few minutes to complete - and that’s with their assistance. Mydei is quick to rectify whatever false impression they might have, telling them that a few bicep curls a day would allow them to carry twice the weight of a plain old stand. Everyone weirdly loses interest after that, but they do wish Mydei good luck once he makes to leave.

Phainon hasn’t moved at all from where Mydei had left him, watching Mydei with his arms crossed as if he disapproves of what he sees. When Mydei gets close, however, he finds nothing but Phainon’s trademarked cheer.

“Got up on the right side of bed today, I see,” Phainon chirps.

“Can it,” Mydei says. “You’re not the only one allowed to talk to the production team.”

“I didn’t know you were trying to compete me on that.”

“We *aren’t*.”

“Yeah, because I’d kick your ass so bad,” Phainon boasts. “But that’s alright. That’s what makes you so cute.”

Apart from the tiny twitch of his eye, Mydei remains wholly stone-faced. “…That’s the kind of thing you’d say while hot mic’d.”

“Not this time,” Phainon claims, despite visibly reaching back to check. “But if I am, so what? Do you have something against getting called

‘cute’?”

“Only if you don’t want people to think you’re out of your mind,” Mydei says.

“Well okay, you’re not being very adorable right now,” says Phainon. “You’re so sweaty that even Phagousa’s basin can’t hold you.”

Mydei instinctively wipes off the dampness on his neck. “*Haikas*.”

“You should get to the dressing room,” Phainon says as he slaps Mydei’s shoulder. “Your make-up artist is getting restless back there.”

Mydei sets off as advised. He throws Phainon a customary glare, but in reality he couldn’t be any more relieved. If Mydei wasn’t sure before, then that exchange certainly makes it clear that the worst is behind them. For once, Mydei is grateful for Phainon’s leniency to every transgression made against him, because he doubts the singer would have given him a second chance otherwise.

Or perhaps kisses like that are just too commonplace for Amphoreus’s national sweetheart to take seriously. A little peck on the mouth between two estranged co-workers is probably a regular Monday for Phainon. In that case, all the more reason why Mydei should forget everything about it as soon as he’s able.

As Mydei gets freshened up for the camera, Phainon remains standing in the middle of the sound stage, staring down at his own palm. That felt like the right about of force for a friendly pat, not too weak and not too grabby. He clenches his hand ever so slightly and recalls how firm and supple Mydei’s deltoid was under his touch. Then he immediately shoves his fist into his pocket when a technician passes by. Yeah, this interview will go well, Phainon thinks.

At least the musical performances are guaranteed to be good. After being stuck in the mountains pretending to pluck a guitar for hours on end, Mydei is itching to give his six-string a real run. It makes even *Euphrosyne* sound refreshing to his ears, despite being the only song they’ve played on the

promotional tour so far. If it helps to distract him from his more unsavory thoughts, then Mydei would give it all he's got until only *Euphrosyne* is stuck in his head. He even remembers to smile and wave at audience when it ends.

Mydei's high spirits carries over to the interview portion, where he sits cordially without a single sardonic bone in his body. His answers still lack the charm and sharpness of a tolerable celebrity, but he's become more forthcoming with information, politely sharing his opinions before the host has to wrestle it out of him. He refrains from talking down at Phainon and adds relevant details to his stories without obnoxiously derailing them, keeping them both on equal terms as the interview goes on.

"Just to be clear, you two aren't going for this year's Astral Fantasia, right?" Asks Diogena, the show's host. "Because sign-ups are still open if you want to try defending your title."

"It's tempting, but I think we're all Fantasia'd out," Phainon jokes. "This year's entries are unbelievable too. Proi Proi gave me goosebumps, wow."

"I like Clouds and Snow more," Mydei says. "It's very festive, which is also part of the competition."

"Festive, huh? Is that why you submitted Euphrosyne?"

"Kind of," Phainon answers Diogena. "It was the best song we had so far."

"It was distinctive, I can tell you that much," Diogena says before turning to Mydei. "What made you write that kind of song anyway? You would have been too young to be in a discotheque back then."

The audience laughs politely at her soft jab. It's a common question, played-out way before *Sun and Thunder* broke up and got back together. If you look back at old interviews, you'd hear Mydei regurgitate the same worn out anecdote about wanting to write a party song. '*I wanted to hear more fun tunes on the radio*' or something along those lines.

No one ever believed it even when he was a moody teenager, much less the crotchety man that Mydei grew up to be. The truth's not that sordid, but Mydei still hems and haws on his way to tell it. "It's, uh, it's a funny story."

He glances over at Phainon, who's as supportive and encouraging as ever. He might not be as understanding once Mydei spits it out, but hey, Mydei tried to warn him.

"It came to me one day," Mydei starts. "In the most literal sense. A bug that flew in through the window and scared the daylights out of Phainon."

"I don't think I would have been that scared of a bug," Phainon interjects.

"It was a wasp. A really, really big wasp," Mydei clarifies, approximating its size with his hands. "When you saw it you let out this insane scream. The whole building probably heard it. It was a high C sharp, I think."

"I see," the host says with a snap of her fingers. "You were inspired to test Phainon's voice."

No, Mydei was inspired to test himself. The shriek Mydei heard that day was the stuff of dreams, a sound that the most accomplished of singers would spend their whole lives chasing. It's the reason why he makes Phainon jump from crooning to belting on the same line. Sometimes, when Mydei thinks the song he's writing isn't going well, he likes to look back on that memory and remember the way everything clicked into place.

But Mydei's not going to admit that out loud. What is he, crazy?

"Yes," the songwriter answers.

Nothing conveys serious and assured more than a pair of crossed arms, but what Mydei had missed is an expression to match it. He doesn't look as bold and audacious with his downcast eyes refusing to meet another's gaze. Whatever it is occupying his mind clearly makes him flustered, and no amount of lip-biting could conceal the smile threatening to erupt.

Beside him, Phainon calmly takes stock of the room. A camera or two pans over to focus on Mydei while the host nods slowly in contemplation. Some members of the audience begin to whisper and giggle amongst themselves, reminding Phainon of the production runners that had been eyeing Mydei earlier.

It’s a breakthrough, the one that Phainon’s been waiting for all this time. Yet somehow, for whatever reason, Calypso’s warning rings in his ears once more.

—

okay balvin @partypeeps
why is he lowky kinda,,, [photo]

Phaikisser @calamitysandtragedys
Guys he was not this cute before I’m not wigging right he definitely wasn’t this cutieful on their last show [video]

> **aj** @2tarvish
> phreak down!
> **Phaikisser** @calamitysandtragedys
> Oh I’m phreaking down alright,,, I’m phreaking off
>
> **2lip** @atlasting
> This betrayal…
> **Phaikisser** @calamitysandtragedys
> [photo]
> **2lip** @atlasting
> Tch… Okay I’m looking
>
> **Jourt Cester** @bearingthrone
> no cause why was he blushing and pouting and whimpering like bro

diogena just asked you a question
Phaikisser @calamitysandtragedys
Omg right what is wrong with him why are you making me want to squish you
Phaikisser @calamitysandtragedys
Wait whimpering?
Jourt Cester @bearingthrone
i rewatched the video turns out i was just imagining it my bad
Phaikisser @calamitysandtragedys
Group psychosis in 5 minutes

Honey Bunches @rosiesandposies
that story was so cute though aww thinking of baby deliverer getting scared of a bug

---

Daily Mydeimos @dailymydeimos
Mydeimos nation rising?? Mydeimos nation population boom??????

lim @pintobeanie
Congratulations on the early investment
Daily Mydeimos @dailymydeimos
Thank you I knew my boy had the sauce!!!

Apollonia @starsguideus
From 2 followers to hundreds…
Daily Mydeimos @dailymydeimos
C’mon it was at least 4 followers 😭
Apollonia @starsguideus
From cope to payola

Fran @cheesephainini
ijbol it took 1 interview to get yall to fold lmaoooo

> **leilei** @Tortie_Baby
> coming from the mydeimos boob layout guy?????
> **Fran** @cheesephainini
> i knew ball from the beginning.
> **tigone** @cousinlarry
> it looks like you knew two big balls
>
> **Ophi** @phainiceys
> i did nawwtt see the vision until now… sorry oomfie
> **Fran** @cheesephainini
> if you're a uwu breedable submissive shy boy looking for love dm @phainiceys today
> **Ophi** @phainiceys
> HELLO????

Jem @LotusGryffin
Me: Mydeimos is alright ig nothing special
The 4 Mydeimos edits playing back to back on my reels: Can We Change Your Mind?

---

angel @deliverfrmchaos

mydeimos sounded so good there that it??? clicked in my head?? his lower register goes so well with phainons voice actually

> **Phainon's legal team** @deardestruct
> who are you and what did you do to my moot 😌
> **angel** @deliverfrmchaos
> giirllll listen his voice adds texture to the song its actually peak if you listen with headphones on

---

beast thing @5min_flashbang
Imagine going into the recording studio and seeing the sexiest man ever and they tell you it's the songwriter actually and no one in the room ever thought to put him on a real album or a festival lineup or a pitbull music video as a sexy video vixen. #Fumbled

> **Ko** @dreamseaquence
> i've been sayingggggg
> **beast thing** @5min_flashbang
> You have NOT been saying this you've been hating the moment this guy came out on stage
> **Ko** @dreamseaquence
> pleaseee i'm repenting ok? i need to fix my tl because i blocked too many accounts posting sun and thunder that i cant see any of the photos or videos 😭
> **beast thing** @5min_flashbang
> Just unblock them??
> **Ko** @dreamseaquence
> IT DOESNT WORK BC THE ALGO IS STILL GATEKEEPING THE MYDEIMOS PICS 😭😭😭😭😭
> **Paz** @PE4CHhue
> there are people out there fighting battles you cant even begin to imagine

---

Peg @blazing_Sun
do you guys think phai's pr team sat mydeimos down and told him to lock in?

Big Lisa @bonitaflakes
Yeah ok he's growing on me. #TheBoobsDontHurtEither

LEON @evoxtachyon
EVERYONE APOLOGIZE NOW**!!!!!!**

> **perdikkas** @C8H10N4O2
> Stop antagonizing his fanbase man
>
> **Oly** @golclenwarrior
> Real mature. I see why your kind flock to him. You have the same vainglorious arrogance as your meathead industry plant, always muscling in and exploiting every advantage without regard for others. Do you think he can leech off Phainon forever? Laughable.
> **Dr. Ptolemaios Soter** @PtolemyPhilosophy
> You keep referring to a Kremnoan man as if he's a violent moron. Are you a bigot?
> **Oly** @golclenwarrior
> Sorry to break it to you, but if that's the way you're reading my words then you're the bigot. I never called Mydeimos violent or a moron, but because he's from Kremnos you think that's what I'm saying. Check your biases before you make mindless accusations online. Maybe then

you’ll understand why Mydeimos should return to being an obscure hack.
white calamity @neikos00000387
βάλλ’ εἰς κόρακας
anca ☀ @virtuenvice
@WeaverSupport can you guys IP ban @neikos00000387 already

Natra @koicarp
strange to see no one talking about the new phainon mv

kik @newsonreel
New music video? Like a new song?
Natra @koicarp
yeah teletube.com/watch?v=35pu-…. it just came out a few hours ago
kik @newsonreel
Ohh it’s a Sun and Thunder song lmao I thought it was actually Phainon
Natra @koicarp
it technically is. i like it anyway
kik @newsonreel
It’s not bad I think I like it better than the other one

Sandra @hndofsonadow
Amber dawn is so good omg… sun and thunder I apologize I was not familiar with your game [video]

Sun and Thunder Fanclub @sunandthunder2
>:D

Sandra @hndofsonadow
Oh Sun and Thunder fanclub I should have never doubted you…

Cassie's Strongest Defender @purplepsykhe
It threw me off the first time I heard it like zamnnnn white boy I did not know you could sound that emotional
Sandra @hndofsonadow
Right kjsdfjhadgf he sounds so heartbroken here and it's not even a love song

---

mydeimos sun and thunder are you single? @phaimousphaces
the most important part of the video btw [photo]

keene @flam1nghearth
#OuttieRepresentation
[THIS POST HAS BEEN REMOVED FOR VIOLATING COMMUNITY GUIDELINES]
[THIS POST HAS BEEN REMOVED FOR VIOLATING COMMUNITY GUIDELINES]
[THIS POST HAS BEEN REMOVED FOR VIOLATING COMMUNITY GUIDELINES]
orange @justinachain
what happened here
keene @flam1nghearth
imagine mydeimos' belly button as a pool but the liquid isn't water
orange @justinachain
ayo what

---

esmeery @dawntime_moon

stop buying tickets for the sun and thunder tour!!!!!!!!!! leave some space for the og fans (me)

> **LaF** @casuloxxde
> i didnt know i was mutuals with a 67 year old
> **esmeery** @dawntime_moon
> i will choke you to death
>
> **Krambula** @youeffooo0o
> name 5 s&t songs
> **esmeery** @dawntime_moon
> from thanatos, philommeides, skyveil, o muse, liber pater, theristai, amalthea, bepsis' lover, the vineyard and ofc euphrosyne <3
> **Krambula** @youeffooo0o
> that was not 5
> **esmeery** @dawntime_moon
> i need this bro please

---

textallica @sombrebleedsome
they're playing a remix of euphrosyne at the grocery store rn and ngl it slaps

> **textallica** @sombrebleedsome
> it's the version where the second guy does a crazy sexy rawr. if anyone was curious

---

P @PhainonPatrol
Sun and Thunder on the cover of this month's issue of Chrysalis magazine. #Phainon #Mydeimos #SunAndThunder [photo]

Minos @dia1tone
I thought you were a Phainon account lmao bro stick to your gimmick
P @PhainonPatrol
Sun and Thunder is a part of Phainon’s discography.

Laqua @GOURMETGIRLIE
they’re so hot and cute at the same time here wtf how is that possible

Dem @helkolithania3
Is Mydeimos into men?

umber @sunnieside_phai
does anyone know if they’ll print more stock? its already sold out everywhere i go 😔

---

soPHia @phaisarmveins
oomf’s old man opp is now her old man bestie like wdym they’re trolling mydeimos hate threads together?

Mydei Agendaposting @phainunyabizz
no cuz like he doesnt get it when people thirstpost about mydei its like his first day on weaver every day
soPHia @phaisarmveins
like thats his son fr

Dreamgirl @softasraine
If you like Amber Dawn you should listen to Limerence by Archepia! Mydeimos helped produce it and it’s one of the most underrated songs ever [video]

blu @wishfuldesir3
its surprising that someone who looks and acts like mydeimos can make such a beautiful haunting song
Dreamgirl @softasraine
Most of the credit is Pia's for writing and performing the song but I get you he's actually one of the only producers that can make her lyre sound this ethereal! I lowkey wish people keep sleeping on him so he can keep working on her albums forever

---

Good Morning Amphoreus @KalimeraOmphalos
A special guest helps to break today's morning fast! Tune in to hear @SunAndThunderOfficial talk about tarot reading, honeycakes, and what to expect on their upcoming tour! [video]

latiooooos @fireworkahead
Will they be releasing any more new songs for the reunion tour?

gobe @codacracker8000
mydeimos stuffing his face with cake while phainon rants is a mood

myrion @winter_rime
I don't really care for sun and thunder or Phainon in general but I like their answer about incorporating traditional music in pop. Mydeimos sounds like a conscientious musician and it's great of Phainon to share his platform thoughtfully

Spelunky Master @pello99
as a kremnoan its nice to see the praise for mydeimos. i hope to see him make more music in the future

parmi @crybabycrii
1:02 his nipples… pop them into my mouth now

Nene @2cool4shcool
Guess who met theee sun and thunder after the gm show? [photo]

> **LVL 97 White Mage** @thephaiwala
> omg no wayyy
> **Nene** @2cool4shcool
> Yes way lmaoooo
>
> **r** @fork_forever
> mydeimos looks like he was forced to join haha
> **Nene** @2cool4shcool
> That’s basically what happened 😭 he thought we were only trying to take photos with phainon and when we said we wanted a pic with him too he literally went 😳 he was so shy and nice and he smelled like strawberries and ugh i think im in love with him 😩
>
> **ZUMBATRON** @farXside
> What is this crazy grip man? [photo]
> **Nene** @2cool4shcool
> I DIDN’T NOTICE THAT wtfff phai why are you holding on to mydei like my mom when we’re in a shop full of fragile glass 😭
> **ZUMBATRON** @farXside
> Lol the guy’s probs on nanny duty making sure Mydeimos doesn’t do anything weird
> **Nene** @2cool4shcool
> Probably 😭

It’s rare for Phainon to be one of the least sought out figures in any room, but here he is, blending in with the fine folk of Okhema’s *Dawn Banquet*.

That’s not to say that Phainon hasn’t captured anyone else’s attention this evening, especially after Aglaea spent the entire day getting him ready. It just so happens that everyone else is also dressed up to the nines, and unlike Phainon they don’t have to lease the spiffy designer clothes they’ve got on. These are the crème de la crème of Okhema’s upper crust, a crowd that can afford to look past Amphoreus’s beloved Deliverer in favor of gorging themselves on cold finger sandwiches.

Tonight, Phainon is carrying out his annual duty of being *Grove*’s talent representative. In other words he’s schmoozing for investors, which would have been a drag if Phainon wasn’t already familiar with the guest list. He knows who would be willing to hear him out without being a chore to converse with, and as impossible as that may sound, Phainon has been to enough of these banquets to find certain exchanges enjoyable. Phainon always imagined that he would have studied business or management or something similar had he pursued higher education, and listening to some VIP explain their financial ventures is sort of like a college lecture.

Unfortunately, they’re not interested in speaking about finances tonight. “A toast to your label and their recent undertaking!”

Their modest group of five raise their drinks in celebration, with Phainon’s neighbors going so far as to clink their glasses against his. They stand off to the side of the busy ballroom, closed off yet mobile enough to mingle elsewhere.

“Grove’s gambles never fail to pay off,” says a man with a navy pocket square. “I though Lycurgus had lost it when news of the reunion broke out.”

“It wasn’t Lygus’s idea,” Phainon states lightly.

“Whoever it was, they must have been a fan,” another man comments, tugging on his bowtie.

“Or eager to prove themselves,” a lady with a glittery shawl counters.

“Either way, he or she had a lot of faith in Sun and Thunder,” Bowtie says. “No one even knew if the other lad was still doing music!”

“He’s actually done a lot of producing in the past years,” Phainon points out.

“Yes, but who would know that?”

“Anyone who’s typed in his name on the internet,” says the man next to Phainon. He sips on a glass of deep red wine, unconcerned about the havoc it may wreck on his beige dinner jacket. “Being aware of the boy is just Grove’s due diligence.”

“Speaking of, why isn’t Mydeimos here with you?” Shiny Shawl asks Phainon. “I would have loved to meet him. He seems like such a charming boy!”

Phainon laughs. “He’s still too shy. He needs more time to get used to being known.”

“Aww, how adorable,” Shiny Shawl says. “But isn’t it rude of him to leave you here hard at work?”

“Not really? Chatting with you doesn’t feel like work to me,” Phainon says.

Everyone laughs politely. “Oh you,” the lady purrs.

“It’s better for Mydeimos to keep his distance,” Navy Pocketsquare remarks. “His family has plenty of enemies in this room alone.”

“So I’ve heard,” Bowtie says. “But it’s old news now, isn’t it? Hardly fair on the boy to hold up old grudges when there aren’t any profits to protect.”

“Eurypon was a plague,” says Beige Jacket, swirling his wine. “He should have been happy making his silly jingles, but he had to be greedy. Keep an eye out on Mydeimos, Phainon. Bad apples never fall far from the tree.”

“Haha, I’ll keep that in mind.”

“I always presumed he was more like Gorgo,” Shiny Shawl chimes in. “He looks like her and does music like her.”

“More reason for Phainon to watch out,” Beige Jacket warns. “If it wasn’t for her, Eurypon wouldn’t have been nearly as ambitious.”

Bowtie shakes his head. “Phainon’s safe. Mydeimos isn’t a woman.”

“It’s a shame. Gorgo was a gorgeous creature,” Navy Pocketsquare jokes. “Maybe if her son eases off the ‘roids, I wouldn’t mind looking the other wa-OW!”

“My deepest apologies,” a cheerless voice apologizes.

If looks could kill, Navy Pocketsquare would be charged with several counts of manslaughter. He grabs his leg as if to make sure it’s still connected to him, glaring down at the lavender-haired culprit that ran him over. All around him, his comrades laugh, with only Phainon to offer him a look of condolence.

“Please forgive her, Mister Liluder,” Phainon implores as he sets his half-empty glass on a server’s tray. “It was an honest accident.”

Navy Pocketsquare glances at the wheelchair and the young woman bound to it. “…I forgive her.”

“She didn’t even graze you,” Beige Jacket says.

That earns Navy Pocketsquare more ridicule and jeering. Phainon decides to make an exit before his colleague gets into real hot water.

“I’ll see her out,” Phainon promises before turning to the interloper. “Do you need help, miss?”

“Please,” she says, holding up her plate of canapés for Phainon to carry.

With one final apology, the two abscond from the group to head to a quiet corner alone. The wide berth people give them makes it easier, even if it

does feel demeaning. Phainon's contrite face lasts up until they're out of sight, where he is free to sigh out in relief.

"Thank you so much Polly," Phainon whispers. "I'll make sure they don't complain later."

"It's alright. They wouldn't dare," Polyxia assures him. "You were cueing me pretty frantically, so I assume they deserved it."

"No, they-" Phainon thinks back to the discussion and clenches his jaw. "… Maybe they deserve it a little. I owe you big time."

Polyxia silently laughs. "You have already paid me back. I usually have no problem keeping things on my lap, but my dress makes it difficult tonight."

The aforementioned dress is a sleek gown made with purple organza or something similarly slippery. Polyxia wears it well despite its simplicity. It's one of the three formal outfits she owns, all gifted to her by Aglaea. Polyxia and her sister would have had more if *Grove* were willing to either lessen Aglaea's workload or invest in proper marketing for the twins' music. It's the least they could do, considering how they've made the two sisters a mandatory presence in fundraisers and the like.

Phainon doesn't recall seeing Polyxia's sister around though. Polyxia must have lied to her again, as if Castorice wouldn't be able to piece two and two together. For her sister's peace of mind, Phainon decides to loiter with Polyxia a while longer, sharing bites of amuse-bouches while they observe the clandestine meetings taking place in the ballroom.

The *Dawn Banquet* is known for its ironic name, but as dark as it may be outside, the ballroom itself is kept bright and vivacious, with large crystal chandeliers spread out to maintain the appearance of daytime. The all-encompassing brightness makes it challenging to hide yourself away, but between large tables with ostentatious centerpieces and tall vases bursting with floral arrangements, there is bound to be a shadowed corner for someone to take advantage of. In a moneyed hall like this it means intrigue of the boring kind, like debating a company's line of succession or sniffing

out stocks to short sell or ingratiating with their betters like Phainon's supposed to be doing.

Rarely is it anything truly salacious, like two unlikely people necking in some overlooked cranny. When Polyxia first points to that exact sight, Phainon's immediate reaction is to choke on a piece of lox.

"That's… brave," Phainon says once he's evacuated his airway of cured salmon. "Who is it?"

"It must be the general's son with one of our sponsors' daughters. How Shakespearean of them," Polyxia quips.

"As long as they're keeping it above the belt, I guess it shouldn't matter," Phainon says, turning away. "I never really understood the appeal though."

"Of kissing?"

"Of making out in public."

"Oh." Polyxia sweeps some stray crumbs off her skirt. "If Cas was here, she might be able to tell you."

Phainon can't help but chuckle. "I don't know, I feel like having an audience is a turn-off for most people."

"It's not about who's watching I think," Polyxia says, squinting at the intimate couple. "Affection is at its purest when you live in the moment. It could be the most inopportune and unromantic circumstances, and all you can think of is how nice it would be to kiss them. That's how you know it's real."

In the moments to follow, a pair of feuding mothers would storm into the scene to discipline their unruly children, making use of whatever physical and verbal means available to pry the two apart. It would be humiliating, infuriating, and a great deal of trouble for everyone within its immediate radius.

But for now, under the cover of lush hydrangeas, a lovestruck girl tenderly holds her sweetheart's face in her hands. She tucks a stray strand of hair behind his reddened ear, beaming at what she sees.

"That's how Cas would see it anyway," Polyxia continues. "Her favorite rom-coms always turn kisses into a spectacle. Personally I feel it would be embarrassing, but I guess they do provide insight into the characters' emotions. Films are about exaggeration anyway, right? Mister Phainon?"

Polyxia looks up at her unresponsive companion, who gingerly hands her back her empty plate before ambling off. It's a concerning response, but Polyxia has no reason to believe that Phainon would do something irrational. He's probably just checking in to see if he remembered to turn his stove off.

Phainon walks until he's out of the ballroom, ignoring the people who call out to stop him for a chat. He pads through the long carpeted hallways and waits patiently on the lengthy elevator ride down. He nearly slams into a family of 4 once the doors slide open, making the concierge eye him with disdain as Phainon jogs pass his desk.

The pandemonium of late-night traffic welcomes Phainon outside, but the pop star doesn't even pause to acknowledge it. He runs past the valet, past the restaurants and bars and the lines of people waiting to be let in. Phainon's lungs and legs burn as he breaks into a full sprint. He refuses to stop until he… until he gets to… to what, exactly?

Phainon skids to a stop in front of a startled couple. The two hapless pedestrians warily walk around this strange man, who's left bent over and panting after his mad dash to nowhere.

In his late night dreams, Phainon always imagined their first kiss to happen after some type of impassioned confession. The kind where there's a choir and a pergola and a candlelight dinner that would soften Mydei's answer. Sometimes he imagined it happening in the pouring rain, after a screaming match that wrests the truth out in the open. One of them would have enough and grab the other, and the ensuing kiss would almost be punishing if it wasn't such a long time coming.

Phainon never envisioned it to be so tangible and it stunned him. He hesitated - so used to toeing the line that he fails to recognize when it's been crossed - and now his window is gone. What's the plan now? Continue clambering for Mydei's favor when he knows Mydei isn't the kind to look back? Phainon should know by now that Mydei doesn't mind moving on, that he doesn't care one bit about glancing back to see what he'd left behind.

Phainon's throat seizes. At the end, Mydei still leaves. History repeats itself, as if there was any other ending for Phainon. As if the stupid, immature boy who can only piss him off and waste his time could ever be a real contender for Mydei's heart.

…No.

No, that's not true. Phainon's feelings are not so shallow that they could be buried so easily. He was the first one to see beyond Mydei's pretenses and the first one to appreciate him whole. Phainon learned how to make him laugh and how to make him cry, and in turn Mydei indulges him with the care Phainon never deserved. All of Mydei's little concessions and thinly veiled generosities aren't for nothing. There is a part of Mydei that felt the same, and if Phainon could only ignite it again…

Before Phainon could act on his renewed conviction, his phone rings. He picks it up and immediately regrets putting the phone so close to his ear.

"*Where the fuck did you run off to, you damn mutt?! You're a dead man when I find you, and I WILL find you. Stay where you are! And DON'T do something stupid, for the love of-*"

Too late for that. Phainon mentally apologizes to Cipher as he looks around at all the people with their phone cameras out. He knows it's dark out, but the flash photography a little egregious.

"…I don't suppose I could convince you to keep this a secret?" He asks the crowd.

“*Are you seriously asking me that? Oh man what the- are you OUTSIDE? I’m gonna get your ass so bad! What the hell are you doing you-!*“

___

It’s not a stretch to say that Mydei doesn’t mind spending time with Phainon. Maybe he tolerates it greatly. One could say that Mydei looks forward to each new meeting like a child restlessly waiting for their birthday. Maybe.

Lately he’s been a frequent victim of this type of anticipation, with Phainon appearing at Mydei’s side every so often with some kind of peace offering. Like a box from a dessert cafe he did an ad for, or a fuzz pedal he thought would be fun to mess around with. On days where they’re not scheduled to see each other, Phainon would blow up Mydei’s phone with photos and videos of cute animals being cute, and he won’t stop until Mydei replies with an interesting fact about his day.

In short, Phainon has been nothing but pleasant company, which is a sign that something has gone wrong. Something like a catastrophic stage dive resulting in a cracked head and Phainon losing his sense of self.

“He’s trying to get close to you now that you’re popular and actually valuable,” Ptolemy hypothesizes without looking away from his computer.

Mydei frowns. He wasn’t a fan of Phainon getting injured in a freak accident, but even that’s more optimistic than what Ptolemy had proposed.

“You’re the one who said the music industry was a cutthroat environment,” Ptolemy says when he sees Mydei’s expression.

“It still wouldn’t make sense,” Mydei argues. “Phainon’s popularity dwarfs mine multiple times over.”

“Didn’t you say Phagousa Ent’s been trying to get you to sign a permanent contract?”

“To write more songs for them. Not to turn me into a public figure.”

Ptolemy lowers his reading glasses so Mydei can take in the full breadth of his skepticism. “You are a public figure,” he reminds Mydei.

“Yes but-“ Mydei waffles for an elegant rebuttal. “-I’m really bad at it.”

“Yeah okay, sure. It’s possible your popularity is a short-lived fluke.” Ptolemy returns his attention to the computer. “Acting like you’re close is still good publicity. Phainon’s people would definitely recommend it to him in the meantime.”

It’s still a lot of effort for a publicity stunt. Phainon only gets so many hours in a day, and he decides to spend it on *Mydei*?

“You could use it to your advantage too, you know?” Ptolemy advises. “You scratch his back, he scratches yours?”

Mydei scowls. “And what would I gain from that?”

“I don’t know, fans who’d follow you to your return to anonymity?” Ptolemy shrugs. “Point is, I’d prefer if you looked out for yourself too. The more you tell us about how this system works, the more we worry.”

Mydei knew that. It would be impossible not to. It would be naive of him to think that Phainon would remain unsullied in the entertainment business. That doesn’t mean it’s the only conclusion he can make. Even if Mydei owns up to his fanciful fantasies, there has to be some personal benefit for Phainon to seek him out so frequently, right?

The door cracks open. “Doctor Ptolemy…? I have a question about the Daneshnam- Oh!”

A young girl stands gasping at Ptolemy’s office door, nearly dropping her laptop and a stack of loose papers.

Without missing a beat, Ptolemy turns to Mydei and says, “It was nice talking to you, young man. Good luck, and remember to do the reading for Wednesday’s class debate.”

“Thank you. Doctor,” Mydei stiffly says as he gets up and flips his hood on.

“Wait! Please!” The girl begs, blocking Mydei’s path. “Could I, uh- Are you…?”

“Stop delaying this completely normal student, Erin.”

“Just one moment!” The girl pleads. She tries to search her bag, but she’s carrying far too much for it to be a smooth motion. In the end, she gives up and thrusts a random piece of paper into Mydei’s hands. “Please! Signature!”

Mydei looks down at the essay that’s been handed to him. Ptolemy groans.

“Come here,” Ptolemy says, beckoning Mydei over. “I’ve got a pen and paper you could use.”

After monopolizing a solid chunk of Ptolemy’s office hours, Mydei sneaks out of his university feeling moderately enlightened. Simply looking at the students’ reaction to him proves Ptolemy’s theory to be plausible. There’s a chance that Phainon *could* be using Mydei, but is that really as bad as it sounds? A part of the reason why Mydei agreed to reuniting was to uplift Phainon’s image, and he knew from the beginning that it would require a lot of staging and playacting to pull it off. Considering that Mydei gave Phainon sole access to *Sun and Thunder*’s legacy, he’s obviously fine with being Phainon’s stepping stone. He signed multiple contract stating so for Kephale’s sake.

So why does Mydei still feel upset? Perhaps he’s mad that he was never clued in, but a person who’s been so thoroughly rejected shouldn’t have *expectations*.

If there was a pebble to kick, Mydei would have launched it into the stratosphere by now. Unfortunately, Ptolemy’s place of work is a decently prestigious university, which means it has the funding to sweep the sidewalks clean of debris. Its reputation also means that fancy cars with heavily tinted windows are a common sight around the area, though it’s not common for one to stalk commuters on the street. Mydei is at a loss with the Lexus deliberately matching his walking speed, and he’d been debating

on confronting the driver when one of the back windows suddenly rolls down.

“Hey, Mydei! Need a ride?”

Ah, the devil. He comes a-clip-clopping.

“No,” Mydei answers tersely.

Usually Phainon would take any opportunity he gets to drag Mydei into a meaningless argument, but recently he’s been really into empathy and compassion. He only hits Mydei with the barest hint of his sad puppy dog eyes before asking, “What’s wrong?”

“Nothing. I don’t need a ride when I have my bike,” Mydei says. Feeling a little bad for being short with him, he tries again. “…They let you out on your own today?”

“Nope!” Cipher’s voice calls out from the driver’s seat. “Still under probation!”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “Then why is *this* one here?”

“Oh, Anaxa’s an advisory board member for the media production program,” Phainon explains. “He booked me in as a guest speaker.”

“I was just in there. Why didn’t I hear about it?”

“Cause it’s not today!” Cipher says. “He had to go meet with the eggheads running the place first.”

“Exactly,” Phainon concurs with a nod. “What about you? Are you visiting the library or something?”

“It’s where I’m parked,” Mydei says, speeding up to get to his motorcycle. “It was nice to see you, Phainon. You too, Ci-“

A drop of water falls onto Mydei’s head. Then, a shower.

Despite being safe in his cozy SUV, Phainon looks troubled by this turn of events. “You should catch a ride with us,” he says. “You might catch a cold.”

Mydei scoffs. “A light drizzle can’t enfeeble m-“

Thunder cuts him off once more. The gentle summer rain quickly turns into the first stirrings of a storm, and Phainon’s distressed expression deepens into proper dejection. He gazes up at Mydei, eyes round and glassy with pity.

Mydei firmly shuts the car door behind him as he joins Phainon in the backseat. He’s dripping water all over the expensive leather upholstery, but he hardly notices when he spots the tragic sight outside.

“Kokopo…”

“Huh? You say something?” Phainon asks.

“No,” Mydei quickly replies.

It’s okay. He left Kokopo under a sturdy awning, and Ptolemy is around to take care of it if anything were to happen. He is *not* deserting his bike, Mydei tells himself. Leaving Kokopo behind is far better than risking battery corrosion or damage to the carburetor.

“Look at that downpour,” Phainon says. “You could have gotten hurt on the road if we weren’t around!”

There’s that too, though Mydei is still pretty sure he could handle a bit of water.

…Perhaps not this bit of water, which is shaping up to be one of this year’s heavier rainfalls. It’s hard to believe the sun was out only minutes ago. The sky is so thoroughly clogged that it appears as if evening had struck early.

“Turn on the heater, would you Cipher? Thank you so much,” Phainon requests before turning to Mydei. “We’ll try to get you home as fast as

possible, but I’m guessing the traffic report’s not looking too good right now.”

Mydei shakes his head, unintentionally slinging more water all over the car interior. “I need to head into the studio to finish off a recording before we go on tour.”

“But you’re soaked!”

“My agent’s already on his way with a change of clothes.”

“Oh. Okay.”

Phainon tries to play it cool with a casual nod, but Mydei still manages to catch the slight slump of his shoulders. “You think I can’t resist the common cold?” Mydei questions.

“Ah, it’s not that,” Phainon denies. “I’m just bummed out by the weather.”

Mydei narrows his eyes at him. “…You’re not fooling me.”

“I’m not?”

“It doesn’t take a genius to guess your intentions,” Mydei says, folding his arms across his chest. “I know exactly what you’re trying to do.”

Phainon croaks out a laugh. “It’s not that stra-“

“You’re trying to score another free meal on me, aren’t you?” Mydei continues. “You can stop trying. I don’t want a subpoena from your dietician.”

A snort from the front interrupts their conversation “Sorry,” Cipher says. “A fly went into my nose.”

“We should stop first then,” Mydei says, noting how the windshield wipers struggle to keep up with the endless torrent of water. “You have enough to watch out for without an insect in your face.”

“‘Preciate the concern, Hyacinthia junior, but I learned to drive in worse conditions than this,” Cipher claims. “Bleachboy on the other hand…”

Mydei looks over at Phainon, who appears to be doubled over in pain. His face is buried in his hands as if he can hardly stand the agony.

Amazingly, Mydei still has the capacity to feel bad. “… Can we pass by a drive through?” He asks Cipher.

“I’m not hungry,” Phainon says.

They still stop at the first *Burger Imperator* sign that they see. Cipher’s massive order makes Mydei suspect that it wasn’t entirely from the goodness of her heart, but he doesn’t mind as long as she doesn’t tattle on them. Phainon insisted on refusing the whole way there, only to end up ordering the most repulsive abomination Mydei has ever had the displeasure of perceiving.

Phainon notices his gaze. “What?”

Mydei pretends he’s not rankled by the concept of a defrosted burger patty lying on a bed of mayonnaise and lukewarm salad. To consume it in a car that costs more than Mydei’s yearly rent…

“It’s not because I’m trying to be healthy,” Phainon defends himself. “I ordered it because it tastes good.”

“I know,” Mydei says. “That’s why it’s so awful.”

As long as he’s happy, he supposes. Phainon has been increasingly tolerant with him as of late, so it’s only right for Mydei to pay it back in kind. Although there is something about being another person for Phainon to please that Mydei can’t help but dislike.

Mydei’s studio isn’t too far from where they are, but Cipher seems to be unfamiliar with the way, relying on her GPS to direct her every move. She’s followed the longer route every time, somehow always finding the most congested road possible. To be fair, the weather probably isn’t making it

easy for her, so Mydei can't be too mad at someone who's doing him a favor.

He *can* try to direct her though. "Merge to the right. Please."

Cipher sucks a breath through her teeth as they slowly slide pass the exit. "Sorry little lion, I couldn't slow down in time. The roads are too wet."

"…That's fine."

"Would you like me to turn on the radio?" Cipher offers. "It sure is quiet in here."

Phainon hurriedly gobbles down the rest of his salad. "No, it's okay! We're good."

Mydei glances at Phainon, whose cheeks bulge with lettuce and ground beef. A long smear of sauce mars Phainon's perfectly done idol face, but he wipes it off before Mydei could.

"You never told me why you were back there, by the way," Phainon suddenly says.

"I think I did," Mydei replies.

"No you didn't," Phainon insists. "You can tell me if you're taking secret classes or something. I won't tell another soul."

Mydei eyes their idle chauffeur, who has a great vantage point of the backseat.

"Who? *Moi*?" Cipher gasps. "Why, you can ignore little old me. I can hardly hear you all the way back there!"

"…Please ignore her," Phainon says, close to pleading.

"It's fine. It's not a secret," Mydei says. "I was only visiting a friend."

Phainon's brows shoot up into his hairline. Is it that unbelievable for Mydei to have a social life?

"A college student?" Phainon asks.

"A professor," Mydei corrects.

"Ohhh," Phainon says, snapping his fingers. "That's right, one of your gym buddies teaches at a college!"

"Hm. You have a good memory."

"Is it really that good if you had to remind him about ninety percent of it?" Cipher says.

"I think we had enough from the peanut gallery, thank you," Phainon tells her.

"He *has* a good memory," Mydei says. "I've watched him strike a conversation with so many people, and he could recall everything about their lives every single time."

"I don't recall *everything*," Phainon humbly corrects him. "It's easy to remember someone once you learn one or two important things."

"So my friends are one of two things you memorized about me?"

Phainon laughs. "One of two million maybe"

Mydei gives him a skeptical look, which Phainon naturally doesn't stand for. "Go ahead," the pop star says. "Quiz me."

"When's my birthday?"

"July twenty two," Phainon answers instantly. "Throw me a harder one."

Mydei clicks his tongue. "What's the name of my elementary school?"

"Kremnos International School."

“Where was I born?”

“Styxia. Then you moved to Okhema.”

“What’s my favorite album?”

“It depends on the genre.”

“What’s my favorite jazz rock album?”

“Aja by Steely Dan.”

“What’s the name of the street I used to live on?”

“Erythros lane, number ten.”

“You might want to step away from the security questions big guy,” Cipher helpfully advises.

“What’s…” Mydei pauses to think. “-What’s my favorite juice?”

“Freshly squeezed pomegranate with goat milk.”

“You knew that?” Mydei is genuinely dumbfounded. “You knew that and still made that lumpy fruit cocktail?”

“Ah, but you liked it,” Phainon points out. “Maybe I know you better than you know yourself.”

Mydei scoffs. “You don’t know everything about me.”

“Oh? What am I missing then?”

“You-“ Mydei swallows it down. “-What makes you think I’d give it away for free?”

“The challenge isn’t to figure out facts about you,” Phainon argues. “It’s to see if I remember them later on.”

“Moving the goalpost now that you’re on the back foot? For shame, Deliverer.”

“Oh come on, you know that’s not fair-“

Phainon spends the last few minutes of the car ride trying to coax the truth out of Mydei, ultimately gaining nothing by the time Cipher parks the car. With only one umbrella in the car, Phainon is forced to play escort for Mydei, accompanying him to the front door so that Phainon and Cipher don’t have to part with their sole protection from the rain.

“Shit!” Phainon exclaims as they reach the building. “I forgot something! Hold on!”

“Wait, Ph-“

In his rush, Phainon leaves the umbrella in Mydei’s hands as he dashes into the pouring rain. The storm pelts Phainon by the bucketful, coming down so hard that Mydei nearly loses sight of him. It takes no time for Phainon to head to the car and back, but it’s enough to drench him to the bone. His nice twill coat is now no better than a used-up kitchen rag.

“And you lecture me about getting sick?” Mydei says as Phainon hops back under cover.

“My medical insurance is pretty good,” Phainon replies.

“That’s no reason to do something so rec-“

Phainon takes Mydei’s free hand and pries it open to deposit a small little plush chimera, barely taking up half of Mydei’s palm.

“It came with the meal,” Phainon explains. “I, uh, wanted to give it to you back there but I forgot. It’s kind of silly now that I think of it.”

Mydei stares at the waterlogged singer. “Why?”

Phainon smiles at him, sheepish yet infuriatingly bright. “Because you like chimeras.”

Without expanding on anything else, Phainon takes the umbrella from Mydei and waves him goodbye. Mydei watches as Phainon disappears back into the rain, lingering by the entrance until the Lexus drives off.

Mydei toddles into the building, half-dazed. The security guard by the receptionist's desk perks up as he passes by.

"Looks like the two of you made up!" The old man remarks.

Mydei gives him a shaky smile, softly squeezing the tiny chimera in his hand. It is, against all odds, warm and dry.

'*Ptolemy*,' Mydei thinks to himself. '*If only I were half as smart as you*.'

—

The first show on the Sun and Thunder tour sells out tremendously.

Granted, it isn't in an amphitheater or a stadium or anything even approaching that capacity. Their first show takes place in the courtyard of an exhibition center, on an unimpressive stage surrounded by a minuscule patch of green. No one had expected for *Sun and Thunder* to generate this much buzz from the get-go, but this only goes to show that one should never doubt Aglaea. If she had been given just a little more faith, perhaps people wouldn't have to camp outside the venue for a chance to hear the new hotness.

Fortunately, Phainon and Mydei happen to specialize in obnoxiously loud music. The rumble of Mydei's guitar fills the open air while Phainon's voice echoes through the nearby streets. The drums and bass rattle the earth like a confusion of wildebeests stampeding across an arid steppe, rivaled only by the cheering and stomping of the fevered audience. *Sun and Thunder* plays their newest hits alongside some sure crowd pleasers, with a suggestion or two from Phainon's aunts and uncles snuck in-between. A cover of a Robin song even makes it into the set-list, in the likelihood that newcomers wouldn't relate to their older material.

What doesn’t make the cut is an encore, despite fans holding out for one. Perhaps in the next show they’d be better prepared, but for now *Sun and Thunder* are tearfully booted out by an apologetic staff manager doing his job. A pity when the band is still hopped up from playing an excellent show. The only people who don’t seem too affected by it is Phainon and Mydei, who have quietly broken off from the rest to hold their own afterparty elsewhere.

Figgy excitedly jumps when she sees Phainon, who welcomes her enthusiasm with open arms. As always, Mydei pushes the canine and canine-approximate into the privacy of his apartment, where Phainon is free to roll on the floor without sending a tabloid into hysteria. Even Mydei has recently received a few questionable pieces in the papers, though his ‘’’bad boy’’’ image shields him from the worst of the puritanical criticism.

Ignoring the two reunited comrades, Mydei heads to the kitchen to better rack his brain for something quick to make. He hasn’t had the time or space to hit up the shops recently, so his selection is looking mighty frugal. Perhaps it would make sense to get some takeout instead-

“Whoa, why’re you working overtime?” Phainon asks as he saunters in with Figgy in tow. “It’s a special occasion! Let’s order out!”

“It would take as long to get here,” Mydei huffs, rolling his sleeves. If it weren’t for the high from the concert, Mydei might have acquiesced. “It would taste worse too.”

“Alright, the floor is yours.” Phainon steps back to allow Mydei access to his own refrigerator. “Please tell me you have something to drink though.”

“There’s water in the pitcher.”

“Preferably something stronger than that.”

Mydei grabs an armful of ingredients and clicks his tongue at Phainon. “And you call yourself a good role model.”

“Let’s not get sanctimonious now,” Phainon says as he catches the refrigerator door before it closes. “Because look what we have over here. A frosty six pack!”

The beer had been stashed away in the very back of the bottom shelf, and yet this boozehound had sniffed it out in an instant.

“They’re good for batter,” Mydei says.

“No need to make up excuses. It’s alright to cut loose sometimes, you know?”

“Hmph. It’s mainly for Hephaestion and th-“

Phainon thrusts a can right underneath Mydei’s nose. “Make an exception for me? Please?” Phainon punctuates his request with a flutter of his lashes. “It’s no fun celebrating alone.”

A cartoon dromas once told Mydei that drinking isn’t necessary to enjoy himself, and that he should never feel pressured to accept what people offer him. But today is a special day, and Phainon could never coerce Mydei into something he doesn’t want. A cold beer just so happens to sound refreshing right now.

Mydei takes the can and pops it open. “Happy?”

Grinning, Phainon answers Mydei’s question with a clink of their cans. “To a good tour,” he toasts.

“Yeah, yeah.” Mydei nudges him out of his face. “Now get out of here if you actually want to eat tonight.”

Phainon does not leave, content with hanging around in the kitchen and pestering his host. Another strongly worded warning would have him vacate the premises for good, but Mydei seemingly forgets that option. It delays the quick dinner he’d planned, forcing him to stop every so often to snark at Phainon or to laugh at his attempts to teach his dog a new trick. Even the clock on the counter isn’t spared from Phainon’s antics. He tinkers

with it and has his fun with the radio functions Mydei had forgotten about. Soon, ABBA's virtual harpsichords soundtracks the kitchen as Mydei puts Phainon to work on mincing garlic and slicing bread.

"… Is there something wrong with what I'm doing?" Phainon asks when he spots Mydei smirking at the chopping board.

"Maybe," Mydei charitably answers.

With so little to go off on, Phainon continues chopping until he hears another snort.

"It's not my fault if your knives are all dull," Phainon grumbles.

Mydei shakes his head and takes another swig of his beer. "Let me show you how to do it," he says.

Before Phainon could let go of the handle, Mydei gently wraps his hand around Phainon's and demonstrates how to properly hold a knife. "You're coming down too stiffly. Just follow how the edge curves here."

Mydei puppeteers Phainon's arm, familiarizing him with the glide of the blade. "Use a back and forth motion. No need to lift the knife like you're trying to guillotine the garlic. See? I'm not even using my dominant hand for this."

With their hands entwined and Mydei's chest against Phainon's arm, the two of them pulverize a single piece of garlic with ease. Phainon finds that if he loosens his grip, Mydei's fingers would tighten around his to maneuver him into place.

"It's even better if you crush the garlic with the flat side first," Mydei says, stepping back once the job is done. "Try it."

As instructed, Phainon uses the knife to squish another clove of garlic before sawing into it. Without Mydei's guidance, however, Phainon severely misjudges the force needed, launching half a garlic clove through the air and right into Mydei's pan.

Almost immediately, Mydei laughs. It’s loud and boisterous, with an occasional pause for breath. This is the kind of thing that entertains Mydeimos the Undaunted. Not titillating nightclubs or thrilling biker gangs or underground fighting rings as the gossip claims. It’s a piece of garlic in a skillet. That’s Mydei’s idea of a good Friday night. A damn sham, Mydei’s cool front is, and Phainon would be darned to let him get away with it.

So Phainon washes off the garlic residue, wipes his hands on a hanging towel, and draws Mydei in for a kiss.

Now *this* is a real kiss. Slow and languid, like treacle running down the sides of a bowl. Phainon tilts Mydei’s head to better capture him into his mouth, leisurely nursing Mydei’s bottom lip until it’s as red as the fiery tips of his hair.

Mydei blinks owlishly when Phainon withdraws, then goes straight back into giggling vacantly. Phainon frowns. That’s not the reaction he wanted. He’ll have to keep trying, it seems.

This time Phainon presses into him harder, almost as hard as Mydei’s head seems to be. Phainon swipes his tongue against the seam of Mydei’s mouth, earning him a tiny hitch of breath from the blond. Cute. Just for that, Phainon keeps them connected until the effects of the beer is completely excised from Mydei’s senses, which results in the exact blissed out expression Phainon had been searching for.

“Huh? Wh-?”

“That good, huh?” Phainon asks.

That gets Mydei scowling. Even kiss-drunk and baffled, Mydei refuses to let Phainon one-up him. “I could do better.”

With that, Mydei braces his hands behind Phainon’s head and dives right back in for revenge.

There was something in the air that night. The stars were bright, the city even brighter. Phainon and Mydei burned brightest of all, full of want and

none of the inhibition. Kisses turn out to be better with two active participants, and Phainon and Mydei's competitiveness translates a little too well to this kind of give and take. With their lips still locked firmly onto each other, Mydei rucks his body up against Phainon's, rolling his hips until he renders the singer weak-kneed and moaning. Phainon gets payback by boxing him in between the counter and himself, squeezing hard enough to leave fingerprints over Mydei's hips.

"Mydei-" Phainon pauses to plant another kiss onto Mydei's jaw. "Should we-" Smack. "Keep the pan-" Smack. "-On like that?"

"It's assassin's spaghetti-" Smack. "-It's supposed to be burnt."

"Can't stop schooling me even now?"

Mydei interrupts him with a longer, deeper kiss, only to stop and say: "Not until you're taught a lesson."

The maniacal look Phainon gives him is a pretty strong commendation. And once the stove has been turned off and Figgy has been bribed with a stick of venison, the two of them make good on that threat all night long.

"-to the bottle, then all the fire would be added in post. Do you have any questions so far?"

Phainon snaps to attention at Aglaea's words. "No, I understand."

Aglaea obviously doesn't buy it, but she also appears to be too used to Phainon to take offense. That doesn't stop Phainon from shuffling awkwardly in dismay, much to the silent amusement of the man seated on the couch.

Phainon nudges Mydei with his leg. His amusement might not be so silent after all.

"I suppose it doesn't matter if you're not paying attention. They'll send the treatment over email anyway," Aglaea says, tossing a bundle of documents

on to her desk. “But we’re not here for that. I called you over to congratulate you two on your first proper sponsorship as Sun and Thunder.”

Mydei quickly withdraws his foot from Phainon’s own. “Thank you, Aglaea.”

“I’ve actually brought something to celebrate this occasion,” Aglaea says as she gets up from her seat. “I’ve heard from Phainon that you’re a fan of golden honeycakes, Mydeimos. It just so happens that I know the proprietor of the Marmoreal Bakery, so I was able to obtain Okhema’s best without the notorious hassle.”

Aglaea heads to a sleek set of cabinets at the very back of her office, providing an opening for Phainon to swoop down and steal a kiss from Mydei. Instinct pulls Mydei to deepen it, much in the same way that a clack from Aglaea’s stiletto gets them to hastily part. By some miracle, the publicist appears none-the-wiser as she sets down a large bag on the table in front of them.

“Thank you. Again,” Mydei says, clearing his throat. “You didn’t have to do this.”

“I’m afraid I must,” Aglaea says. “This opportunity holds great significance. Other than the coupling of two corporate entities, of course. Sponsorships are commitments that rarely end with a single liaison. In other words, it is an implicit desire for Sun and Thunder’s continued relations.”

Oh God. Mydei needs Phainon to stand further away, because Mydei did not register any of that how he’s supposed to.

“Bigger and better sponsorships also means the ability to improve upon your final show,” Aglaea continues. “Remember, the anniversary of your win will coincide with the Astral Fantasia itself. If we want to fill seats in the Marmoreal Arena, we need the promotion to be as provocative as possible.”

“I don’t know if I can be provocative.”

“It’s a matter of speech, dear,” Aglaea tells Mydei. “There are plenty of ways of arousing interest. What matters now is that you keep up at it. Who knows, perhaps you might inspire Grove to officiate your union.”

“That’s great!” Exclaims Phainon. “I mean, I’m having tons of fun with the band.”

“Hmm, yes. Provided we forget all that happened in the first month.” Aglaea’s gaze slides back to Mydei. “I see you’ve taken my advice about the lip balm.”

Mydei presses his swollen lips together. “Yes. Thank you.”

Phainon snickers, but a light stomp on his foot shuts him up.

Since it’s a celebration, Phainon and Mydei share their first slice of cake with Aglaea, who ends up not being a big fan of crumbly desserts and flimsy paper plates in her office. Fortunately, outside lies an assembly of cubicles that are more receptive to spontaneous tributes of sugar, crumb-tastrophy or not. And yet, even with the combined effort of a ravenous marketing team, a quarter of the cake remains standing victorious in its package.

“She’s a generous woman, I’ll give her that,” Mydei comments later in his car.

“Isn’t she thoughtful?” Phainon says, drumming his fingers on the cakebox in his lap. “Now we have something to snack on.”

“You have a problem with jerky?”

“Oh, I have nothing against your doomsday supply of dried meat, but you gotta balance the salt with some sugar.”

Mydei shoots him a side glance.

“Like you and me!”

If he wasn’t trying to keep his eyes on the road, Mydei would’ve rolled them. “Childish.”

Minutes later and said childish pop star would have Mydei pressed against the stairwell of his own apartment building, tongue probing his mouth as if he were desperate for the air in Mydei’s lungs.

With all the willpower he can muster, Mydei pulls away to give Phainon a whack on his shoulder. “The cake-“

“It’s alright, I got it,” Phainon assures him, adjusting the bag wedged in between them as he sneaks in one final taste.

While helpful and amicable, Mydei’s neighbors prefer to keep to themselves. Sun and Thunder’s reunion would have been less of a surprise if they weren’t. Still, it doesn’t mean Phainon and Mydei aren’t careful, sticking with the stairs to avoid the more accessible elevators. Perhaps they lose the plot a bit when they chase each other up the steps in exchange for more fleeting kisses, but that’s neither here nor there.

Mydei’s treasured cake is flung onto the nearest countertop and left forgotten until hours later, when Phainon and Mydei are curled up on the couch with a procedural drama. It’s a decent show, Phainon finds, though the cop spouting criminology mumbo-jumbo could do a better job selling his made-up forensics.

“It’s like he’s reading off a teleprompter,” Phainon mutters.

“Stop paying attention to him,” Mydei says as he digs into his box of honeycakes. “Ptolemy says he’ll be gone next season.”

Phainon shakes his head in disappointment. “I can’t believe your friends like this. Couldn’t the show do another take where he’s not looking at the camera? Look, look! He did it agai-“

Mydei shuts him up with a spoonful of cake. “Just watch the show, *haikas*.”

Phainon burrows further into their shared cover, chastised. The two of them made almost no effort to make themselves decent, relying mostly on body heat and a tattered throw blanket to keep them warm.

“…I could have done a better job than him.”

Mydei chuckles. “Is that what’s pissing you off?”

“I think I’m a pretty good actor,” Phainon says, turning towards him. “Maybe that could be the play after I retire. I mean, haven’t I been pretty convincing lately?”

“You’re a good liar,” is what Mydei settles on.

Phainon beams at him anyway. “Thank you! Though I’m not sure about the criteria here, seeing how you fell for Cipher’s old ‘gullible ceiling’ b-“

Mydei cuts him off again, this time with another searing kiss. It escalates into wandering hands and soft caresses, and as Mydei’s touch nears where Phainon wants him to be, he makes a cruel retreat. His expression even settles back to neutral as if nothing of note had transpired.

“You had some whipped cream left over,” Mydei explains, returning to his cake.

Phainon stares at him, mouth agape. “…Cocktease.”

“Pipe down,” Mydei says between bites. “They’re about to figure out who the killer is.”

The killer ends up being someone’s sister-in-law or something or the other. Neither Phainon nor Mydei could recall, because Phainon pounces as the detective pieces it together. Instead of Aglaea’s beloathed paper dishware, Phainon makes use of a far sturdier plate to finish off her present, diligently licking up every single crumb off its rugged surface. Phainon would have highly recommended its service, had it not been so ticklish and made for Phainon and Phainon’s use only.

That last part is a work-in-progress, but Mydei's indulgent smile as they ruin his couch is a promising sign.

___

Despite certain preconceptions about what it means to be a hot-blooded male, Mydei has never considered his libido as a problem. Sure he gets specific hankerings from time to time, but it's nothing he can't solve by himself. Mydei refuses to be controlled by anything, much less his own biology.

Hence why Mydei's sudden appetite blindsides him. Movie marathons in his apartment. Pointed serenades in the middle of busy shows. Hand holding in dimly lit parks. Quick kisses backstage in-between sets. In dressing rooms, heavily tinted cars, studio bathrooms, empty theaters, trailer vans before shooting a commercial - a moment of intimacy lies in ambush everywhere.

"Slow down," Mydei tells Phainon. The singer is already in Mydei's bedroom casting off his button-down while Mydei is still by entryway unlacing his shoes.

For all their variety, Mydei's apartment remains the best setting for their most explicit meetings. Their flings are already thrilling enough without the fear of getting caught dangling over them.

"Why?" Phainon responds to Mydei's request, his torso freed from decency. "Want a striptease?"

Mydei snorts. Last time Phainon tried that, he ended up getting stuck in his own shirt for 5 minutes. What else does he expect wearing clothes half-a-size down?

Not that it deters Phainon, who wastes no time dragging a peevish Mydei to his bed. They both know that all this protesting is an act, but playing coy is loads more fun for the both of them.

“You’re like a molting snake,” Mydei tuts at the clothes strewn all over the floor. As if his hands aren’t impatiently tugging at Phainon’s trousers.

“My bad. Couldn’t help it,” Phainon apologizes with a nip of his ear. “You were taking too long.”

The trousers slide down Phainon’s rock-hard thighs with his underwear in tow. God, hot pink and chartreuse. Mydei flings Phainon’s unmentionables in the direction of the open door. Good riddance.

This isn’t really a striptease as much as it is an excuse for Phainon to straddle Mydei and trap him underneath his naked body. Mydei has long discovered Phainon’s predilection for pinning his partners down, though whether Phainon himself knows, Mydei can’t say. The important thing is that Mydei has grown more indulgent of this habit as time goes by, to the point that Mydei might become a more efficient model for Pavlov’s theorems.

It’s so twisted. Phainon was supposed to be the excitable dog here, yet the sight of Phainon’s face so close to his is enough to get Mydei’s heart racing madly-

-Only for it crash to a stop when the lock on Mydei’s front door clicks.

The door slowly opens to reveal a lean man carrying an armful of paper bags. The bulky baggage makes it a challenge for the intruder to see two steps in front of him, only noticing Mydei’s disgruntled figure moments after.

“Oh, you’re here!” Leonnius says.

“Of course I’m here,” Mydei replies, arms crossed. “It’s my house.”

“Yeah but you’ve been a no show on the GC, so a guy’s gonna assume,” Leonnius says as he offloads the bags onto the nearest surface. “What’s with the kilt?”

The ‘kilt’ in question being Phainon’s discarded shirt tied around Mydei’s waist. “Trying a new look. For the concert and… stuff.”

Leonnius tilts his head as if he were deciphering an alien script. “Ohhhh, I see it. You’re an old school band, and you’re like, doing one of those nineties ‘hoodie-pants’ type thing.”

Mydei can’t help but be concerned at that. His dear friend might be the type of person to reply to Edo Star princes e-mailing for financial assistance.

That reminds Mydei- “Since when did you get back from Edo Star?”

Leonnius shakes his head. “This is why you gotta get on the group chat more often,” he says. “But it’s cool, I get you’re booked and busy. Actually, I was thinking of just leaving these here with a note. I didn’t think I’d actually catch you here!”

As Leonnius checks the bags, Mydei once again re-thinks his decision of getting a digital lock. It’s nothing but padlocks and heavy duty chains from now on. That, or actually keeping his passcode a secret from everyone he knows.

“And what are those?” Mydei says.

“Souvenirs,” Leonnius replies, his arm buried deep into one of the bags. “Mostly candy and fridge magnets. I also got some chew toys for my girl Figgy, even though she forgot say ‘hi’ to me. Is she mad at me for being gone for so long?”

“Uh-“ Mydei glances at the dog slumped against his bedroom door. “-Something like that.”

“I got her like a squirrel that squeaks and this crunchy milk box thing,” Leonnius says. “If only I could find them-“

From the corner of his eye, Mydei spots a pair of blindingly neon boxer briefs peeking out from under his television stand. Mydei tactically shifts to block it out of Leonnius’s line of sight.

“Are you staying for long?” Mydei asks. “Should I get you something to eat?”

“I’ll pass,” Leonnius says, giving up on his search with a sigh. “I gotta head back to the garage soon, but I didn’t want the candy to melt in my locker while I’m at work.”

“Hm.” Mydei tries not to look too relieved. “Good luck.”

“… You got any of those lemon cookies for the road though?”

“Ah.” Mydei baked up a batch yesterday for Phainon, imparting his home with an damning scent. “…Yes, you can take some.”

Leonnius stares expectantly at Mydei, who stays rooted in his spot. It takes a second for Leonnius to figure out he’s not planning on moving.

“Okay,” Leonnius says. “I’ll just… get them myself I guess?”

“The cookies are in the blue jar and you can find tupperware in the usual spot,” Mydei says as Leonnius heads into the kitchen. “Don’t finish them off!”

“I won’t! Sheesh…”

While Leonnius raids his kitchen, Mydei rushes to grab the offending article of clothing and anything else that might bust their dirty little secret. Thinking fast, he opens the bedroom door and inadvertently causes the man plastered against it to stumble with a silent yelp. Any other day and Mydei would have laughed at Phainon’s wide-eyed bewilderment, but the sound of Leonnius banging around in his kitchen might as well be the ticking of a bomb. Mydei barely manages to chuck the evidence into Phainon’s arms as Leonnius returns with his loot.

“I only got a couple, okay?” Leonnius says, shaking his box of cookies. “And maybe a little extra for the road, but the candy should make us square.”

“Only if the candy tastes as good as my cookies,” Mydei says. He’s left leaning oddly against his doorjamb, which Leonnius doesn’t seem to notice.

“I don’t think you realize how difficult it is to browse an entire aisle written in a language you don’t speak,” Leonnius says, apparently more occupied with defending his honor. “I could have just given you straight up pinecones but no, I took the time to personally handpick everything I bought for you guys.”

“I’m guessing that’s why you took a long time to come back.”

Leonnius groans. “Don’t get me started. One thing led to another and I ended up owing money to some other guy and- It’s a whole thing, okay? Open the chat sometime and I’ll tell you all about it.”

“Of course.”

“And in return you tell me what’s up with you,” Leonnius says as he finally gets ready to leave. “I can’t believe I have to follow PopZine just to find out… huh?”

The way Leonnius trails off has Mydei’s heart plunging into his stomach. “What?” He asks as calmly as possible. “See something?”

On Mydei’s shoe rack, chucked haphazardly between his combat boots and his beat-up trainers, is a pair of colorful chunky sneakers. Mydei’s forehead starts beading with sweat.

Leonnius picks one up and gives it a close inspection from multiple angles. Murkily yellow with electric blue trim, the sneakers clash with the entirety of Mydei’s wardrobe. The only person with the confidence to wear such a thing is the pop star hiding out in Mydei’s bedroom, the one that Leonnius has seen live in concert at least twice.

After the longest minute of Mydei’s life, Leonnius opens his mouth to ask: “Are these the new J’s?”

“Yes,” Mydei answers all too quickly.

Leonnius lets out a low whistle. “Where’d you get them?”

“It was-“ *Behind a dumpster. At a clearance sale. At a crafts fair.* “-a gift from-“ *A fan. Krateros. Myself.* “-the record label. On account of the good job I did.”

“They’re clean as hell, man,” Leonnius says, examining its sole. “Mind if I try them on?”

“Uh-“

“Please?”

After this, Mydei swears to physically remove Leonnius from the building himself. “Knock yourself out.”

Leonnius pops his shoes off the instant Mydei agrees. Mydei could only hope that Phainon doesn’t mind, though he supposes this is an apt punishment for swiping something from Mydei’s closet every time he visits.

“Damn, I thought we were the same size,” Leonnius says as the sneakers slip on effortlessly.

“This was the only pair available.”

“That sucks. Still fire though.”

Leonnius paces about, testing the fit and snapping pictures. He drains all of Mydei’s patience to pose with shoes that look like overboiled eggs.

Eventually Mydei forgets about the importance of staying on Leonnius’s good side. “I’m calling your boss if you don’t take those off in the next ten seconds.”

“Chill, this is the last one,” Leonnius promises, taking another quick photo before pulling the sneakers off. “I’m out of here, but remember what I said!”

That he owes money to a stranger…? Oh, the other thing. “Hey, I open the chat everyday-”

Leonnius peaces out before Mydei can attest to his online presence. The apartment goes still for a solid second after the door closes, easing only when Leonnius’s footsteps could no longer be heard.

The bedroom cracks open once the dust has settled. Phainon pokes his head out and peers around the apartment. “Is he gone?”

“Take a guess,” Mydei says, sinking into his couch.

Phainon joins Mydei on the sofa, still mostly in the buff. Mydei much prefers Phainon sans underwear for obvious reasons, but Mydei can tough it out if it saves him from contracting a cold or a UTI. Hyacine won’t be too happy if Phainon came back with a viral infection, he thinks.

Thankfully Mydei still has his pants on. He takes his phone out of his pocket and starts browsing on the web.

“Are you that bothered about what he said about your group chat?” Phainon asks.

“No,” Mydei mutters, scrolling furiously. “I’m looking for a new door-lock.”

Phainon chuckles. “A little too late, methinks. You might as well put it off a bit longer.”

“And why should I do that?”

Phainon answers by plopping his chin in the crook of Mydei’s elbow, peering up at him with a perfect facsimile of Figgy’s downtrodden expression. Like Figgy, Phainon is instantly placated by a few scratches to the underside of his jaw. He falls limp in Mydei’s masterful hands, replacing the phone that Mydei once deemed more important.

Before Phainon could get too comfortable, Mydei grabs hold of his face and pulls him close. “Needy. Demanding. *Insatiable*.”

Phainon eagerly nods with each growl. When Mydei falls back onto the couch, Phainon follows, slinking over his supine body like a predator staking its claim. As beastly as ever, even after such a close call. As if Mydei ever wanted him tamed.

“Sorry man, but I think I forg- AGH!”

Leonnius’s shriek forces the two intertwined men to scramble off each other in panic. Phainon falls on the floor ass first while Mydei nearly pops his hip pivoting upright. There’s enough common sense in Leonnius to have him turn around for the sake of decency, but not enough to have him scurrying out the apartment.

“Either that’s who I think it is or that’s a really, really old man,” Leonnius rambles, covering his eyes. “Whatever it is, you gotta hit me in the back of the head, De. I can’t be walking around with this knowledge!”

“So why would you come back?!” Mydei yells. He loves and cares for his friend deeply, but there’s a limit to how many times a man can get blue-balled in the span of 30 minutes.

“I needed my keys!” Leonnius says. “I think I left them here!”

“Then knock?!”

“Your door’s always open, man!” Leonnius exclaims. “It’s not like I was thinking you’d be getting it on *right there*! Sue me for not thinking that was a possibility!”

Mydei massages his temples. In the end, it comes down to his own negligence.“…You can have the rest of the cookies. Just don’t tell anyone else about this. Please.”

“You don’t need to pay me off, you know,” Leonnius grumbles.

“I mean it Leonnius,” Mydei stresses. “Not even to Hephaestion and the others.”

“You didn’t tell them? Holy shit- Am I the only one who knows?”

“I’ll get the cookies,” Phainon volunteers, getting up. He’s taken one of the blankets off the couch and wrapped himself up a nice new chiton. “Mom always said you can’t ask for favors that you can’t pay upfront.”

With a reassuring pat, Phainon leaves Mydei to stew in a hell of his own making. Mydei can blame a lot of this on Phainon, but he can’t really blame him for escaping. There’s not much he can contribute to whilst in his birthday suit, though that’s not saying that Mydei is in a better spot.

Still, Mydei *has* to say something. “It’s not what it looks like.”

“You said that last time,” Leonnius points out.

Mydei groans. “It’s complicated.”

“Tell me if you’re being blackmailed,” Leonnius says in Kremnoan.

“I’m not,” Mydei replies accordingly.

“Are *you* blackmailing him?”

“Fuck no.”

“Are the record execs blackmailing you?”

“No one is blackmailing anyone,” Mydei says. “And don’t stick to Kremnoan the entire time. He’ll get paranoid.”

“So let him?”

“Don’t try to convince me that you’re anti-Deliverer again.”

“I’m trying here, man!” Leonnius cries. “Hephaestion should’ve been the one to walk in on you! He’ll know if this is a bad idea or not!”

Mydei looks down at the ground and digs his toes into his rug. “…What do you think?”

“I think that maybe you shouldn’t be doing this,” Leonnius admits. “Do I think people who date super-popular high-profile celebrities usually have happy endings? Not really. Do I think it’d be cool to get an RSVP to *the* Deliverer’s wedding? Hell yeah.”

“We’re not dating and we’re *not* getting married,” Mydei clarifies. “This is a temporary situation.”

“You keep saying that, but look who’s sucking face with who whil-“

“*Leonnius*.”

“Look, it sounds like you’ve made up your mind,” Leonnius concedes, switching back to common Amphorean. He turns around to give Mydei a once-over. “I thought that maybe the glow was just movie magic, but seeing you now, I stand corrected.”

Much to his chagrin, Mydei feels his face heating up and proving Leonnius right. “Up yours.”

“Aw loosen up, De. It’s not like I get the chance do this often.”

“Why not?” Phainon suddenly chimes in, plundered goods in hand. Keep this up, and they’ll relieve Mydei of all his precious storage containers. “I thought Mydei would be popular considering that body of his.”

Mydei has to will himself not to react, lest he encourage Phainon.

Leonnius side-eyes his friend’s paramour as the cookies switches hands. “I’ll kill you if you break Mydei’s heart.”

The pop star nods back in understanding. “I’ll kill myself first though.”

“I could kill you on my own,” Mydei states before turning back on their intruder. “Is there anything else, Leonnius? Or are you planning on barging in again?”

“It’s not like I wanted to see that,” Leonnius huffs. “My keys. Did you guys see them?”

Phainon and Mydei haven’t, having been obviously distracted. Perhaps sensing the answer and not wishing to hear of it, Leonnius carries out the task himself and finds his keys in one of his paper bags. Needless to say, Mydei wasn’t amused.

Mydei remains unamused even after Leonnius leaves for good. The mood is beyond salvaging, regardless of how shameless Phainon is willing to be. The best he could do is stick by Mydei’s side as he recovers from his mental anguish. The resulting sigh Mydei lets out sounds anything but auspicious, but Phainon could work with it.

“We should meet up less,” Mydei concludes.

“Why?”

Mydei frowns. “Are you seriously asking?”

“Yeah,” Phainon says, adjusting his make-shift mantle. “I mean that wasn’t great, but it’s not like we weren’t being careful.”

“I don’t think any of this is being careful,” Mydei deadpans.

“That was an outlier,” Phainon says as he throws an arm around Mydei. “Like what your friend implied, it’s impossible to predict every single outcome of every action. Forty thousand people die every year from car crashes. That doesn’t mean we should live our lives hiding at home forever.”

Mydei stares at him, pensive. “…You’re not upset.”

Phainon grins and gives Mydei’s cheek a light pinch. “Aww. Is that why my schnookums is sulking?”

Mydei smacks Phainon’s hand off. Not his schnookums apparently, but his objection had been suspiciously swift. “Be more serious. You stand to lose more than me.”

“Would I lose anything as valuable as you?”

“Drop it for one second and *listen*,” Mydei warns, stepping away from Phainon. “If what we’re doing here gets out there, you’ll be ruined. You won’t be the Deliverer of Amphoreus anymore. You’ll be the guy who has gay sex with his colleagues. Excuse me if I think we should do what we can to keep that from happening.”

Phainon nods his head. “You trust Leonnius, right?”

The question takes Mydei aback. “It’s not about trust-“

“Do you trust him or not?”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “Yes, I trust Leonnius.”

“And I trust you, therefore I’m not worried,” Phainon concludes. He interrupts Mydei by pressing a finger to his lips. “Getting caught sucks, I know. I was there. But now that we’ve experienced how it could happen, we know exactly how we could be more careful next time.”

Surprisingly, that does not convince Mydei.

“Troubleshooting,” Phainon calls it, complete with jazz hands.

“And what brilliant innovation have you concocted for your illicit hook-ups?”

“Kephale, you make yourself sound like my mistress,” Phainon comments. He ducks out of Mydei’s punching range in the nick of time. “Don’t hit me! I think it’s hot! I’m just saying that you don’t have to be the other woman. We can just go to my house, simple as that.”

That gets Mydei to drop his hackles. “Your house?”

“Highly secure, highly classified, and highly recommended,” Phainon boasts. “It’s got at least three locks.”

“You want me to go to your house?”

“Yes. Is this thing broken?” Phainon asks as he taps the shell of Mydei’s ear. “I want you to come home with me sometime. Is that too much to ask?”

“No, you surprised me. I thought-“ Mydei shakes his head. “…Whatever. I accept. Next time, you’re hosting.”

Phainon lights up like a firework. “You better get ready then,” Phainon says. “Because you’re about to learn what real hospitality looks like.”

Mydei scoffs. “Sorry my apartment doesn’t have enough scented candles for you.”

“And yet I keep on visiting. Curious.” Phainon claps a hand on Mydei’s shoulder. “Maybe you’ll get extra points if you turn the TV on while I get dressed. We stopped at a cliffhanger last time, remember? We gotta find out what happened after Detective Hanu got shot.”

“I’m sure the main character can survive a bullet from a one-off episode.”

“It’s about the how, not the if!”

Since Mydei doesn’t seem to be getting undressed any time soon, Phainon finds there’s no use in staying chilly all day. Before he could reach the bedroom, however, Mydei asks him one last question. “Are you sure you’re alright?”

Phainon turns back to look at him. A life mapped out in newspapers and magazines could only be so private. Mydei’s carelessness would only blur the lines Phainon had drawn, leaving his world louder and narrower than it already is.

So Mydei had no way of expecting Phainon’s jubilant smile.

“Yeah,” Phainon answers truthfully. Mydei may not have family in the traditional sense, but that doesn’t mean Phainon wouldn’t be happy to meet them all the same. “I’m feeling awesome.”

—

On Tuesday, Phainon and Mydei model for a photoshoot.

On Tuesday evening, Sun and Thunder plays at *The Imperator's Centre of the Arts*, complete with encore.

On Wednesday, Phainon films an endorsement for a soda company. Mydei takes Figgy for a walk.

On Friday, Sun and Thunder plays on the *Chrysalis Festival*'s main stage. That same evening, Phainon brings Mydei back to his humble abode.

"This is the place where you hide your affairs, isn't it?" Mydei says.

Phainon looks aghast at the accusation. "This is my actual house. I'm not the pervert you think I am."

Actually, Mydei has a pretty good idea of how much of a pervert Phainon can be, though perhaps not in the way they'd been discussing.

"My house looks normal, right?" Phainon continues pestering Mydei. "It's not gonna be on Better Homes and Gardens, but it's not a Leisure Suit Larry den of iniquity or anything like that."

It was not. In fact, Phainon's alleged home is quite welcoming and domestic for a bachelor pad. The rattan furniture and their linen accoutrements harken back to Phainon's clean image, both strangely old-fashioned in spite of their contemporary minimalism. The wooden veneers warm up what would have otherwise been a dreadfully pale living room, conveniently matching with the ceiling fans that spoke a little too much of the building's age. If it weren't for the few Phainon-esque baubles displayed throughout the house, it could have been mistaken for a timeshare on some Styxian island.

Somehow, the place manages to both meet and subvert Mydei's expectations. Perhaps it's the fact that Phainon's house isn't some secluded mini-mansion or a glittering penthouse in the sky. It's not even a townhouse in a gated community. Apart from a slightly glitzier location, Phainon's apartment couldn't be that much different from Mydei's or that of his other

friends. Mydei's apartment is probably bigger, considering Phainon only has one bedroom to speak of.

"This can't be your only house," Mydei says as he examines a frame on the wall.

Phainon laughs. "Nope. Just the one. Why? Were you hoping I was some kind of land mogul?"

"No. I just thought a hoarder would prefer to have more space," Mydei says, picking up a weird yellow geode sitting on Phainon's shelf.

"For the last time, they're investments," Phainon argues. He slides in to take the rock back from Mydei. "These are all rare pieces that'll grow in value as time passes, watch."

"Funny, I thought I saw a 'Made in Jarilo' label on that."

"I mean as long as I've touched it, it pretty much becomes a collectible."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "I must be worth millions by now."

"You're priceless," Phainon says, adding to Mydei's value with another passing kiss. "Experts would tell me to get you insured as soon as possible."

This insurance would soon come in the form of vivid red marks following the line of Mydei's hip bone, making it appear as if his tattoo had begun snaking upward. He would gain a few more around the swell of his chest, on the meat of his thigh, and on an awfully ticklish spot on his back - all of which Mydei pays back with equal vehemence.

"I win," Phainon declares as the two of them lie breathless on his bed. "I got more bites than you."

Mydei responds by rolling over and attacking his wrist twice. Phainon laughs at this awful display of sportsmanship.

"I meant I have more bites on my body than you do," Phainon clarifies. "But thank you for sealing the win for me."

It’s not like Mydei ever counted them in the first place. They could only ever last so long before Phainon has to make use of miscellaneous balms and icy spoons to erase all trace of him in the morning. Tallying them up is an insanity reserved for Phainon.

Mydei might have double checked it anyway, had he not been so exhausted by the day’s events. The next thing he knows, he’s getting jolted from his sleep by his bladder, which forces Mydei to fumble about in the morning in search of a bathroom. Mydei is wide awake by the time he finishes what he has to, leaving him to realize exactly how early he’d risen.

The curtains flutter gently as Mydei approaches the balcony. Even before he’d pushed the drapery aside, the blue of the outside world had already seeped through the open weave of the linen, dyeing Phainon’s once lively home. The flat, dim lighting makes everything appear as if they were suspended in time, much like the hazy skyline and empty streets that await beyond the window.

Waking up earlier than Phainon isn’t anything new for Mydei, though waking up in Phainon’s apartment is certainly a first. Usually Mydei would already be where he needs to be, resulting in the two of them always meeting in the morning. Sometimes with breakfast, sometimes not. Perhaps that’s where they’re going wrong. Right now, Mydei could slip out of the apartment without alerting Phainon, and it wouldn’t be strange or discourteous. It would be exactly how arrangements like theirs were meant to operate. Perhaps if they left things in the evening instead of carrying it onto the next day, this charade would finally lose its luster and allow common sense to reign once again.

A pair of strong arms suddenly wrap around Mydei’s waist and pulls him out of his doldrums. “Why’re you up?” Phainon sleepily slurs in his ear. “I thought you didn’t ‘ave work right now?”

“Toilet,” Mydei answers.

Phainon nuzzles Mydei’s neck. “Hm.”

They linger there for a moment, staring out the window and swaying gently to an absent beat. Out on the balcony, Mydei spots the plant that Phainon had bought weeks ago, now touting a fresh set of blooming buds. Despite the sweltering weather, the flowers had retained their vibrancy, being the only things colorful enough to stand against the monotonous blue backdrop.

“Come back to bed,” Phainon mumbles. Mydei’s entire back shivers from the light kiss Phainon leaves on his nape. “It’s warmer with you there.”

“… You big baby,” Mydei says, sighing.

Yet he relents, helpless against such an eloquent argument. The snapdragons persist in Mydei’s peripheral vision, even as Phainon successfully drags him back to the confines of his silk duvet.

—

“You’ve been in a good mood lately, Mister Phainon.”

With a practiced hand, Phainon puts his phone aside before Hyacine could connect the dots. “What makes you say that?”

“For starters, you pointed out that Mister Anaxa’s bolo tie was crooked the other day,” Hyacine says as she sits down by the conference table. “And this morning, you asked me if you could have the last bran muffin!”

Phainon tilts his head, wondering if he’s hearing her right. “Sorry, I don’t think I quite understand…?”

“What she’s really saying is that you’ve finally graduated from being a human doormat,” Cipher says. She practically sprung out of thin air, occupying a seat that Phainon swears was empty. “Congratulations on becoming a vertebrate like the rest of us.”

Hyacine shakes her head at Cipher, who’s too busy with the phone to notice her disapproval. “That’s not what I was trying to say. I think it’s great that Mister Phainon is respectful towards everyone, but sometimes he can get stuck on work mode for way too long.”

“You want him unemployed? Not very nice of you, Cinny- Oops!”

Phainon takes the phone away from Cipher. Just as he thought, she’d pinched his phone when he wasn’t looking. The closest he gets to an apology is a shrug.

“Didn’t see anything interesting in there,” Cipher swears. “I only saw some Z-Bay listings for some dusty ass vinyls. Which is, *yawn*, borrring.”

“What else are you expecting?” Phainon asks.

“I don’t know, something that dudes your age would normally look at?” Cipher nudges Hyacine with an elbow. “Like maybe a fucked up dating app or a freaky sext or two.”

To her credit, Hyacine holds her head high, and doesn’t gasp and clutch her pearls like her furious blush warrants. “Mister Phainon’s not like that.”

Cipher grins. “You’re right there, cupcake. I was just curious about why Wonder Boy over here has been smiling and giggling at his phone these past few days.”

Oh fuck, he was? Judging from how Hyacine’s look goes from indignant to inquisitive, Phainon has not been playing it as cool as he thought.

Hyacine, bless her heart, still attempts to defend his good name. “Maybe he’s excited to see some rare vinyl records. He makes music, you know?”

Cipher shakes her head. “Tell me the truth, Hyacine.” She drops her pitch low and leans in, almost intimidating in her sudden seriousness. “You think he’s a virgin, don’t you?”

You could pinpoint the second the question sinks in for Hyacine. An almost audible crack seemed to ring out in the room, as if Cipher had taken a chisel and a hammer to a Fabergé egg. Phainon could only stare at his temporary bodyguard in stupefied horror.

The moment passes when Hyacine gets up, brushes some lint off her peplum shirt, and smiles at Cipher. “I should see what’s taking Mister

Anaxagoras so long," she says.

Hyacine's gait is steady for someone who appears to have her whole world rocked. Phainon glares at the perpetrator as Hyacine exits the room.

"What?" Cipher asks. "Was I wrong?"

"I'd say corrupting the youth is pretty wrong, yeah," Phainon says.

Cipher cackles. "Please. Cinnybuns has a bunch of nerdiac degrees over the both of us combined. She knows what s-e-x is. She just probably couldn't believe that you get any tail, so you should actually thank yours truly."

Phainon thinks back to Hyacine's terror-stricken face. "No, I don't think I will."

"I think you would," Cipher shoots back, turning her chair around so she can prop her head on the backrest. "I basically got the red carpet out for you and loverboy. Assuming you'll get Blondie to bite anytime this century, that is."

Cipher pantomimes the gnashing of teeth to complete her metaphor. Sometimes, Phainon wonders if he had to make his impossible love-life more convoluted by throwing Cipher into the mix, but it's impossible to deny her resourcefulness and quick-thinking. Or so he tells himself.

"I'm taking it one step at a time," is what Phainon ends up saying.

"Widen your stride then," Cipher advises, shedding her carefree tone. "Because someone up top's thinking about putting the kibosh on your little side venture."

"Aglaea said they're looking to extend the contract."

"You know Agy's a soft touch when it comes to you," Cipher says. "She's not going to tell you that the board room's split in two, especially if it's around seventy-thirty in your favor. Doesn't change the fact that your little lion's had a hell of a family dynasty. Ever wonder why you haven't heard much from the big time investors lately?"

Phainon frowns. “Grove’s heads are always talking about moving on to the next phase and becoming a self-sustaining business. What happened to that?”

“Same thing that happens to every good intention.” Cipher rubs her thumb and index finger together in the universal sign for- “Money.”

Suddenly, Cipher straightens from her lackadaisical slouch, signaling that she’s heard the same sound Phainon did. The hollow thud of a square heel thunders through the hallways of *Grove Records*’ headquarters, stopping at the conference room Phainon and Cipher are squirreled away in. The door dramatically slides open to reveal a woman with a posture as rigid as her stiff brow. A scowl lurked in the shadows of her face like a shaky photograph, making her smile appear derogatory no matter how much teeth she puts into it.

“Good afternoon, Phainon.”

“Good afternoon, Miss Caenis,” Phainon replies.

If Cipher was less concerned about her job, she would have argued that the only ‘Miss’ that Caenis counted as is misanthropic. Alas, there is no use in picking a fight so early, not even as she walks pass Cipher without a single word of greeting.

“You must be looking forward to this meeting,” Caenis says to Phainon. She lobs her laptop onto the conference table, gently rolling her wrist after dropping a thousand-dollar machine.

“I always am,” Phainon says.

“Hm. Some people should learn from you,” Caenis remarks as she sits herself near the head of the table. “But of course, this is only a perfunctory briefing. There’s no use in getting a headstart with your… think tank.”

“Just killing two birds with one stone,” Cipher chirps. She stands up as Caenis sits down, like two pistons in an engine keeping things trotting

along. “Your golden boy here was looking for some advice while waiting, so I stopped by to give him some.”

“How kind. I’m sure you had something enlightening to say.”

“Don’t you know it.” Cipher rounds up to Phainon and pats him on the shoulder. “Remember to floss your teeth and wash your hands. Oh, and make your bid on the last day of online auctions. Keeps the final prices low. Toodles!”

Cipher makes a quick getaway before Phainon could say anything, let alone beg her to stay. Somehow, with only two people left, the room has only gotten stuffier.

“I didn’t believe it when they said you’ve been a diligent worker lately,” Caenis says to Phainon. “Apparently you’ve been enjoying yourself with your new project.”

“I have. The fans would notice if I wasn’t sincere,” Phainon reasons.

Caenis chuckles as she organizes her files. “There’s no need to pretend when it’s just the two of us. We’ll get you more profitable projects after the summer.”

Despite her high position in *Grove*’s hierarchy, Caenis and ‘listening’ have never gone hand-in-hand. It’s a wonder how Phainon has never heard of her getting kicked out of a boardroom for insubordination.

“…Are you feeling thirsty, Ma’am?” Phainon asks. “I could get you a coffee if you want?”

“Coffee’s too acidic for me,” Caenis says without a single glance at him. “Get me some earl gray with a single teaspoon of sugar. Not one packet of sugar. Not one sugar cube. A *teaspoon*.”

“Right away, Ma’am.”

“And don’t use the garbage they stock in the pantries. Make sure to get it from the cafe on the fourth floor.”

Phainon hopes his spirited nodding hides his eagerness to scramble out of the room. He slows down once he's out of sight, fully intending on taking his sweet time to complete his errand. It's pathetic of him to flee, but his discussion with Cipher had left him short of patience towards *Grove*'s decision-makers. The reunion was their idea in the first place, and now they're retracting their decision? After Mydei has proven himself to be nothing but beneficial?

The countless appearances, interviews, and shows have been received with high praise and higher sales. Years old material previously gathering dust in *Grove*'s copyright graveyard are now generating revenue once more. Demographics that Phainon could not charm on his own are now buying merchandise in droves. Hell, some of Mydei's own songs had even reappeared in the charts despite him not singing or performing in any of them.

It's torture for Phainon, who has to be there for every meet-and-greet, who has to watch people sidle up close to Mydei to touch and grope him as they please. He has to watch interviewers harass Mydei with innuendos and unsubtle flirtations so they may profit off of his flustered reactions. Photoshoots and film shoots dress and pose Mydei in all the vulgar ways that Phainon's virtuous reputation safeguards him from, often bordering on pornographic. It's madness.

And when asked about his thoughts, Mydei only replies with: "It's alright."

Next to him, Phainon grits his teeth under his tight-lipped smile. The host of the variety show proceeds to laugh at essentially nothing.

"With muscles like those, who wouldn't be showing off?" She says to the camera.

The show has Phainon and Mydei competing on who can split the most firewood. An insultingly simple competition, seeing how the producers have chosen logs with prominent cracks in its centers. Phainon breezes by with ease, whereas Mydei, who comes down on the wood with too much height, struggles to keep up.

No one corrects Mydei's awful technique because the way he heaves his maul high and puffs his buxom chest out is entertainment. Halfway through, the host trips on a wedge and is caught in time by Mydei, who drops his maul precariously close to his foot to get to her in time. Phainon happens to know that the host is a happily married woman, but her job still requires her to ham it up, exaggeratedly fawning in Mydei's arms as if he'd crossed mountains and seas to save her from an excruciating boo-boo. She gives his bicep a honk in farewell, because of course she does.

It takes the joy out of Phainon's victory, whittling his smile back down to another brittle imitation.

—

Mydei had woken up after the program's taping feeling like roadkill. He expected as much with the amount of manual labor he'd done during the day, but Phainon's peculiar exuberance had been a complete surprise that evening. To apologize, Phainon volunteers himself for breakfast duty, and Mydei refrains from reminding him of his participation in his own exhaustion.

While Phainon struggles to put together something edible, Mydei peruses his shelves for something interesting. Perhaps even incriminating. He finds the perfect item bound in maroon buckram and frizzy twine, and as he leafs through the hefty volume silently musing the nth picture of a doting family, a delectable smell starts to take over Phainon's apartment. Phainon reappears in time for Mydei's grumbling stomach, his proud swagger immediately faltering at the sight of the tome in Mydei's lap.

Phainon scrambles to grab the photo album, but Mydei holds it away from his reach. "I already saw the pictures of your second grade play," Mydei informs him.

Phainon groans. "At least tell me you thought I was cute."

The second grade play had, for some reason, dressed all the schoolchildren as miscellaneous animals. Whoever painted Phainon's face for his oryx costume had turned him into a Rorschach test instead, and the boy had been

so immersed in his role that he was photographed munching on a weed. It was adorable. “Cyrene was cuter.”

“Oh. Yeah, I get it.” Phainon nods. “She went as a lagomorph, by the way. In case you got her confused with a bunny like everyone else.”

“I don’t know what that is.”

“They’re not pink and fluffy in real life. That’s Cyrene’s twist on it. I went for realism, so my costume wasn’t as small and cuddly.”

“Mm hm.”

“I actually did a lot of research for it, you know,” Phainon boasts. “I helped carve the horns so they had realistic rings. I didn’t paint them, you can check.”

Mydei pats Phainon’s cheek. “That’s nice, deer boy.”

For a moment, Phainon stands there gawking at Mydei, mouth hanging agape before slamming shut into a pout.

“I was clearly an oryx,” Phainon corrects as Mydei hands him the album and leaves him for more appetizing matters. “They’re a kind of antelope. They kill predators!”

Breakfast awaited Mydei on Phainon’s kitchen island. Maybe the toast had browned too much at the crust and maybe the omelettes were two shakes away from being scrambled eggs. That didn’t stop any of it from calling out to Mydei’s stomach. By the time Phainon catches up, Mydei is already fork deep in a plate of eggs and cheese.

Phainon doesn’t immediately join him. Instead, he picks up a carafe and fills up two cups close to the brim. Phainon generously slides one over to Mydei, who doesn’t think twice before washing his meal down with whatever’s inside. A balance of tart fruit and rich cream meets his tongue, completing what was already a decently nourishing breakfast.

Mydei looks up. “You can cook.”

“Just because I don’t use your fancy knife tricks doesn’t mean I don’t know how to feed myself,” Phainon says casually, as though as he’s not suddenly aglow from winning some unspoken competition.

“You always made it sound like you’re helpless in the kitchen,” Mydei says as he swirls his cup. “You really made me drink unmixed protein powder to mess with me.”

Phainon smirks. “I wasn’t trying to prank you.”

“You were just trying to remember what juice I drink.”

“That’s not it either,” Phainon insists as he balances a piece of egg on his toast. “Four-fifths pomegranate and a splash of milk. You drank that everyday, how could I not know?”

Mydei shrugs. “It’s a normal thing to forget.”

”Well I didn’t. I only made something else because I didn’t know if I could use the goat milk in your fridge.”

“When did I give you that impression?”

“It’s a pricey milk,” Phainon says. “And I didn’t want to waste what you had. At least a scoop of protein powder is, y’know, a scoop.”

The clinking of their cutlery carries the conversation forward as Mydei mulls over what has been said. Stray pieces from different puzzles gradually come together in his head to form one single conclusion.

“Grove’s not skimping on your cut, are they?”

Phainon bursts out laughing. Thankfully he hadn’t been chewing, because Mydei didn’t feel like testing his knowledge on the Heimlich maneuver. “They’re paying me really well, don’t you worry.”

Mydei simply stares at him, as if he’d find the real answer on Phainon’s forehead. His eyes might have dried out if Phainon hadn’t continued. “I promise I’m not a money laundering scheme.”

“You live in a shoebox,” Mydei points out.

“Come on, it’s a decent apartment,” Phainon defends his home. “Sure I could live in a palace, but I’m one guy. I don’t need that much space. And I don’t want to have to clean a bazillion rooms. I get that some guys hire people for that, but I’d rather have my own place to myself.”

“You also used to pay for everyone’s lunches when we were recording.”

Phainon shrugs. “It’s not that crazy. Don’t give me that look. I’m Grove’s highest earning artist, and I think it’s fine to give back when I can afford it. Most of my co-workers are my friends anyway, so I’d prefer that Grove save that money for the other artists under the label.”

Mydei taps his fork. “It sounds like you’ve got stock in the company.”

“I don’t. Again, not that weird! I just don’t really have a lot to spend on,” Phainon admits. “I have my antiques, I guess, but I don’t buy them that often. Could you imagine? A single earthquake could tank my entire life’s savings.”

Phainon pauses for a bite of bread. “I think most of my paychecks end up going to the clinics in Aedes Elysiae. The people back home are getting up in age, so they need it even if they don’t want to say it. Cyrene’s folks don’t like taking any of my money, and let’s face it, Rini’s more successful than me anyway. What else… I give to charity whenever I can, but volunteering is better I’m told. It’s better publicity for what the charity actually does, which results in better fundraising at the end of the day.”

Mydei allows Phainon a moment to munch on his breakfast. When his toast is gone, Mydei asks, “So the only thing you want is a bunch of paperweights?”

Phainon meets his eye. A strange light dances in his blue irises before vanishing in the next blink.

“They’re valuable antiques,” Phainon haughtily tells him. “If you’re nice, I’ll get you one for your birthday.”

Mydei scoffs. “No thanks.”

The two proceed with their meal, making light work of the omelettes with its fresh tomatoes and gooey cheese. Throughout the meal, Mydei catches himself watching Phainon more often than usual, thinking back to the little boy in all those photos laughing and rolling in the dirt. Despite being the poster boy for everlasting adolescence, it’s easy to chart the ways Phainon had grown. Straighter teeth, a more prominent brow… Life in the city has even taken that little boy’s once golden tan, and with it went the sprinkle of freckles that dotted his precocious face.

And yet, when Phainon falls asleep and Mydei gets a chance to nestle close, he could just about make out a few stubborn flecks hiding out in the bridge of Phainon’s nose. The boy still walks among the living, splurging thousands on a single dinner and scrimping on scant millilitres of milk.

Mydei gathers up his used dishes. “Just for the record, you can use anything in my refrigerator. You don’t need my permission.”

“Huh?” Phainon impatiently swallows his food, but Mydei has already made off with the dishes before he could catch Phainon’s sheepish response.

—

A dubbing error calls for Phainon to hop back in a sound booth and re-record a line for his latest commercial. Luckily for him, *Grove* has a recording studio of their own, so he doesn’t have to travel too far that morning for a single line of dialogue. It does, however, mean that Phainon is much more likely to bump into his co-workers.

“Oh, Hyacine.”

Hyacine acknowledges Phainon with a smile and a tiny bob of her head. They haven’t had a proper conversation since their run-in with Cipher, which makes getting into the elevator a daunting notion for Phainon. He perseveres anyway, too fond of the pink-haired girl to let the awkwardness

simmer. The way Hyacine shuffles to give him space implies that the feeling is mutual.

The doors close, and Phainon automatically blurts out, “I’m so sorry about Cipher.”

“Huh? Oh, that,” Hyacine waves off his apologies. “I’ve forgotten all about that day, Mister Phainon. We’ve been working with Cipher long enough to know how she’s like. It’s part of her charm by now.”

“I mean, as long as you’re not bothered…”

“Not at all,” Hyacine assures him. “I’m not put off by the thought of you engaging in sexual congress. It may have caught me off-guard to hear out loud, but I never once thought that you were actually celibate!”

Is Phainon’s chastity that hot of a topic amongst his social circle…?

Nevertheless, he clears his throat. “Still, if you’d like me to have a word with Cipher, I’d be happy to step in,” Phainon offers.

“Oh let Ciphy be herself, I can handle it,” Hyacine says confidently. “Besides, it made me realize that there might be some bases that I forgot to cover, so she’s not all bad.”

“Uh, what bases?”

“The safety of you and your sexual partners, of course!” Hyacine chirps. “My assistance might be limited, but if you ever find yourself in need, I’ve stocked up on some of the most reliable contraceptives on the market!”

For some reason, Hyacine’s fondness for horror movies comes to mind. “… Thank you, Hyacine.”

“I didn’t have any specific details to work with, so I sourced a bunch of different condoms and lubricants to accommodate for common allergies and preferences. I’ve also got hygiene products and toiletries that can be useful even if you’re not planning on having coitus,” Hyacine says, counting each point on her fingers. “I did include emergency contraceptive pills too, but

those expire much faster, so I didn’t bulk up on them. Obviously proper birth control medication has to be prescribed, but if your partners are struggling to find a reliable doctor, I’d be happy to help!”

“That’s very considerate of you, um-”

“-I’ve also started drafting confidentiality agreements and consent forms if you or your partners want a safety net. I haven’t ran them through legal yet to avoid circulating gossip, but this way you won’t have to wait as long. I can’t do much about security leaks beyond that, but I did update my RSS feed with more comprehensive terms and common shorthands.”

“I appreciate everything you do, as always,” Phainon says a little louder, feeling a bit like a broken record. “But it sounds like it costed you a lot? Especially with all the stuff you bought?”

“It would’ve, but we do have a tiny budget leftover for our first aid supplies,” Hyacine says. “After checking we have the essentials, I went ahead and added to it.”

Anaxa’s department must have the strangest first aid kit in the entire building. “I see.”

“It’s more costly to fall sick anyways,” Hyacine lectures. “Or to have a secret love child. Don’t forget, prevention is better than cure!”

She’s not wrong. Despite Phainon’s discomfort, he recognizes that Hyacine is simply looking out for him the best she can. Hyacine may like to maintain a degree of formality while they’re at work, but it doesn’t erase the fact that they’re friends at the end of the day. Perhaps she senses that Phainon is keeping secrets from her, and this is her way of dealing with the disappointment of being kept out of his personal life.

“You should also get a PrEP prescription when you can! It’s not just about anal sex, although anal sex is no different from any other kind of intercourse once you take the proper precautions.”

Phainon looks at the elevator display. There are 12 more floors.

Fortunately for him, the doors open before Phainon has to walk Hyacine through his own medicine cabinet. A single sullen man joins them in the elevator, impatiently tapping on the button that Phainon had already pressed previously. The suit and the slicked back hair had made the man difficult to recognize, but his thick facial hair is too impressive for Phainon to mistake for anyone else.

“Hello sir,” Hyacine greets politely.

“Hello,” the man replies.

Phainon follows suit. “Good morning, Mister Krateros.”

He gets a click of a tongue in return. “What’s so good about the morning?”

Phainon’s wish for silence in the elevator had been granted, but at what cost?

“I think what makes a good morning is the smell of freshly brewed coffee,” Hyacine suddenly says. Either she’d missed the acrid backnote of Krateros’s rhetorical question or she was intentionally sidestepping it altogether. “Have you had some yet? We get really good coffee around this hour.”

“…I’m leaving your office now,” Krateros murmurs. “I appreciate the offer, but I don’t want to outstay my welcome.”

There’s a chance that he just came out of a particularly awful meeting, and that’s why he’s glaring at Phainon like he’s looking at the man who’s besmirched his godson. That’s not good news for Phainon either. Phainon needs Mydei and Grove to have a good relationship, and that won’t happen if his agent isn’t on board. That begs another question: how best to broach the issue without further getting on the man’s nerves?

The answer: the polite and optimistic personification of a fluffy cloud. “You’re always welcome to take a quick break,” Hyacine says. “We won’t turn away anyone who needs it, even if they’re not affiliated with us.”

“I am not that closely affiliated with your company,” Krateros says.

“We wouldn’t mind working closer with you,” Phainon chimes in. “I mean a lot of us already love working with Mydei. He’s a really talented person.”

“Yes, *Mydeimos* is a skilled musician,” Krateros iterates. “So I refuse to be pressured into a decision.”

“Oh dear.”

“The negotiations have been balanced so far,” Krateros hastily replies to Hyacine’s reaction. “We’re just finalizing the details before we sign.”

That’s a relief. It doesn’t answer anything about his attitude though. Unless sound can travel down an elevator shaft and he heard something that makes Phainon sound like a sex pest.

“Please take your time in deciding,” Hyacine tells Krateros. “Things that are important are worth being patient for, and rushing to a decision would only reflect badly on us.”

Phainon has no idea if Hyacine actually recognizes who she’s talking to or if she’s that adept at extrapolating context. Considering how Anaxa avoids small talk by any means necessary, it makes sense that Hyacine would be well-practiced in filling in the gaps in any conversation.

At the very least, it makes Krateros nod civilly. “I will answer your director correctly and sincerely, this I promise.”

“If there’s anything we could do, Mister Krateros, feel free to tell us,” Phainon offers.

Once again, Krateros reacts as if he’d just discovered a mosquito buzzing in his ear. Phainon takes offense to that. His voice is not that shrill.

The elevator dings, and out steps Hyacine and Phainon. Phainon continues trailing her down the hall until she suddenly stops to look at him.

“Weren’t you headed to the basement parking?” Hyacine asks.

“Was I?” Phainon says, sounding surprised. “Ah, well. All that coffee talk made me want one of your lattes.”

“Oh! I’ll get some ready then!”

The two of them resume walking, with Hyacine picking up the pace for Phainon’s consideration.

“… Hypothetically, if you have to impress an older man who’s pissed at you for some reason, what gift would you get him?”

“Hmm, I think I’d get him a nice tie.”

“A tie, huh…”

“It might be safer for you to stick to fruit baskets instead, Mister Phainon.”

—

The loop plays on, repeating the same bar of music in Mydei’s headphones. It sucks to admit, but the song isn’t shaping up how he had expected, and it’s taking too much time for him to pinpoint why. Is it too bare? He tries layering one more piano track and- no, now everything sounds a half-step off. Mydei might have slammed his finger a little too hard on the delete button, toying with the idea that maybe he should also delete everything else while he’s at it.

Mydei closes his eyes and takes a deep breath. It’s a song for a PSA about crossing the road. He needs to relax.

Getting his work done is far more important than writing something he’d actually like listening to. The reason Mydei even brought the project home with him is because it was the type of assignment he could bang out in an hour. He’d forgotten that every time he’s home, he gets haunted by big, unnecessary ideas that go nowhere. It’s a new development, one that he forgets until he contracts a migraine from staring at the screen for too long.

There’s no particular reason for this change, but the likeliest cause has coincidentally chosen that exact moment to call Mydei. Mydei reaches out

for his phone immediately, though he pauses to let it ring for a few seconds more.

Once he's deemed it credible enough for someone of his sangfroid, Mydei finally picks up the call. "Hello."

"*Hey*," Phainon's voice answers from the other line. "*You busy?*"

"Yes."

"*For the road safety ad? Can you take a break soon? Please?*"

"No," Mydei grumbles. "I'm at work, *haikas*."

"*Really? But both your car and your bike is parked at your place.*"

"How did y-"

Mydei cuts himself off with a swear. He gets up from his desk and marches to his door, where he finds Phainon waiting patiently outside. The only response the pop star has for Mydei and his glare is an excessively flattering grin.

"Bye, honey," Phainon says into the phone, dropping the call with one last 'mwah' before addressing the Mydei in front of him. "I have a surprise for you."

Mydei tries to object, but Phainon happily sweeps into the apartment without his say so. "Great," the owner of the house deadpans. "You and your surprise can wait in the living room until I'm done."

The grocery bag Phainon is holding does not exactly inspire excitement for Mydei. If anything, it irritates him to see what their time is being wasted on.

"Trust me, you'll like what I got you," Phainon promises. He hangs his hoodie on the correct hook and tosses his crocs almost correctly onto the shoe rack. "It might even help you out, actually. I just need you to get your record player ready and-"

“I’m not doing that.”

“Okay, then I’ll prepare your record player while y-“

“Most people would usually tell their victims what they need their sound system for before abusing it,” Mydei says.

Phainon shoots him a classic pout. “Play along this once, please? It’s a surprise.”

“Is that suppose to fill me with confidence? Letter bombs are surprises too.”

“For Kephale’s sake- I’m not bombing your apartment.”

“And Brutus still stuck a blade into Caesar’s back.”

Phainon groans, but he obediently thrusts the plastic bag towards Mydei. “Alright, fine. Here. I was trying to build up some anticipation, but you don’t have a single romantic bone in your body to appreciate my efforts.”

Mydei smirks. “I fail to see what Mnestia has to do with… this…”

His voice fades off. In Mydei’s hands is a vinyl record dating back to at least forty years prior. A protective sheathe has been fitted over its outer sleeve, which is already yellow and grody despite not being particularly old. The edges of its paperboard housing are barely hanging onto its last fibers, and if Mydei were to pull the record out with any significant force, he suspects he would have ripped the sleeve apart into two separate pieces. Only the album art survived the passage of time, its inks bold and clear for Mydei to read. A thousand thoughts zip through his mind, of which none shows through his blank face.

“Just thought you should have that,” Phainon says, markedly less enthused. “I’ll see myself out now.”

Mydei’s hand stops him before he could grab his jacket. “Wait. Sorry,” Mydei apologizes. “Please stay.”

Phainon glances back.

“… You need to hear if there any defects you need to ask a refund for.”

Ha. Only a weaker man would let that slide.

“Sure,” Phainon says. “I’ll give it a listen.”

Mydei’s turntable is naturally located in his music room, where Figgy had been sleeping when her owner and his complication decided to barge in and start a ruckus. Phainon eventually joins her by the dog bed after bungling up the wires one time too many, leaving the two of them to watch as Mydei meticulously rearranges the room.

Soon, the needle is placed very carefully onto the spinning record, with only a small fizz from the speakers to indicate that everything is working as intended.

“I was lucky to find it,” Phainon says as Mydei makes his way to where dog and guest are congregated. “I’m told that this is actually from the original pressing.”

It takes the needle some travel before it reaches the first song, and when it does, it is immediately shit. It’s absolutely awful to hear. It sounds like it was recorded on a roll of zippers instead of the traditional tape, with furious crackles and pops nearly drowning out the music underneath. No amount of brushing and microfiber cloths could possibly salvage this record, let alone improve its sound.

It’s even harder to hear with Mydei laughing so hard. “That’s an original, alright,” he says in between guffaws.

“Great,” Phainon says dryly, finding it significantly less humorous. “I guess I’m getting that refund now.”

“Don’t,” Mydei says with one last laugh. ”It hasn’t skipped so far. We should hear it out.”

Mydei is biased, of course. Everyone has always known Mydei’s mother to be this untouchable genius producer, forgetting that she had to have made,

at some point, a first album. Hearing this record, Mydei could almost see her, excitedly running out a dirt cheap recording booth that cost her half her savings to rent. The rest of her money would go to the most affordable manufacturer willing to give an unknown amateur a quote, because what other form would her work take other than high-fidelity vinyl? She probably changed her mind on her pièce de résistance after hearing it herself, but it was also the moment where Gorgo got to feel the weight of her music for the first time, and everything afterwards would be summarily set in motion.

As for the music itself, well, Mydei has already heard it. The album was re-released years into Gorgo's established career, with everything re-recorded because the masters were in too much of a sorry state to use. It performed as well as expected, which is to say only critics and niche enthusiasts had bothered listening to it. While she was held in high regard, the greater public wouldn't seek out a producer's personal work. Gorgo was not a particularly smooth singer either, though she possessed a memorable timbre and exceptional skill with the guitar. Equipped with only those two things, she filled her sole performance album with covers of old standards and torch songs, all of which were already decades out of fashion before she even recorded it the first time.

"I have the exact guitar she used on this record," Mydei comments offhand. The classical guitar had cost him a pretty penny at an estate sale. It was the most self-indulgent thing Mydei had done so far, up until he found himself embroiled in an irresponsible and torrid affair.

"Is the guitar listening with us right now?" The irresponsible and torrid affair asks.

"Yeah. Probably cringing at how it used to sound."

"Hey, it's not bad when you actually get to hear it," Phainon argues. "It's got some jive."

Phainon snaps his fingers to the song. Cover albums like these were a dime-a-dozen, and Gorgo had chosen to differentiate hers by arranging these classic foreign songs in a style traditional to Kremnos.

“Jive is an interesting way to describe it,” Mydei remarks.

“You’re saying this doesn’t make you want to get up and cut a rug?”

“If by ‘cutting a rug’ you mean ‘sitting put’, then y-“

Mydei yelps as Phainon pulls him to his feet and begins posing his limbs like some kind of life-sized action figure. By the time Mydei regains his wits, he finds himself face-to-face with Phainon, one hand on the singer’s shoulder and the other clasped in his cool hand.

On the speakers, Mydei’s mother plucks the Gershwins on her nylon strings like a poem on a barbiton, almost as if imagining Dux Carminum dancing in place of Astaire. Phainon slots himself somewhere in the middle of that image, with only the faintest idea of a box step to guide him. There are hundreds upon hundreds of videos of Phainon’s concerts online, and in those videos he performs choreographies that require incredible athletic skill to pull off so smoothly. It’s apparently much more challenging to lead Mydei into a shuffle, but Phainon laughs along as if each little trip is a great thrill.

Mydei tightens his hold on Phainon. “This is not how Kremnoans dance to this kind of music.”

“Really? But this is how we dance in Aedes Elysiae.”

“Oh, is that so-“

“I’m joking,” Phainon says, pulling him close. “In Aedes Elysiae, we just move how we like.”

A snicker slips out of Mydei. “That’s a nice way of saying you dance out of beat.”

“It’s tough to hear the beat right now,” Phainon excuses himself. “But it’s still pretty danceable all things conside-Whoa!”

“I don’t know,” Mydei drawls, holding Phainon in a low dip. “Maybe I’ll figure it out after a couple more turns.”

Mydei graciously yanks Phainon right-side up again, unaware of the toll he now has to pay. As Mydei steps to the side, Phainon uses the momentum to lift him into the air with a move that Swayze would have been proud of. Mydei yells, though his resistance is undercut by the airy peal of his own laughter.

In the background, Mydei's mother continues to sing about daffodils and candle lights while his dog continues to wag her delightful tail up at her foolish owner. Phainon squeezes Mydei tight as they slowly spin in place, gazing up at him with something approaching reverence but cannot be.

Just this once, Mydei allows himself to close the gap. It would be a shame to ruin a good thing.

—

Krateros adjusts his collar for the fourth time that morning, using the reflection of the office windows around them to examine his appearance. When he judges his shirt to be sufficiently tidy, he moves onto smartening Mydei's blazer.

"If looking good is what it takes to get approved, then we would have never passed the front door," Mydei says.

Krateros's pats suddenly gain some force. "It's about showing respect, Mydeimos."

Mydei hums.

"Respect to the *agreement*," Krateros adds.

"Our other contracts must've not mattered as much then."

Krateros gives Mydei a light rap on the chest. "Cut the backtalk, boy. The man we're about to meet with takes pride in insignificant details like these," he warns. "You'll understand when you see him."

Admittedly, Mydei knows very little of the man they're about to sign a contract with. Krateros had told him over and over again to wring Phainon

for more information, and while Mydei might have wrung him of something, it was nothing that Krateros would have considered educational. The most that Mydei has gleaned is that *Grove* headhunted this man to supposedly lead their artists and repertoire division. Most people say supposedly, because he's also got his fingers in mergers and subsidiaries and company restructuring and other things that have been speculated on but never confirmed. It seems that even if Mydei were to ask, he wouldn't have learned much anyway.

The doors eventually crack open, allowing a neat secretary to beckon the two of them inside. Mydei and Krateros follow the secretary pass his little antechamber and to another set of doors that he pauses to knock on. An austere voice invites them to enter, and the secretary opens the way forward into an impressive sophisticated office. A similarly debonair man sits behind a robust executive desk, his lank figure appearing almost feeble next to the solid mahogany.

"Your eleven thirty five, sir," the secretary announces.

The man stands up to greet his appointment, rising to a height far taller than Mydei would have guessed. "A pleasure to see you again, Mister Krateros," the man says. "And a pleasure to formally meet you for the first time, Mister Mydeimos."

Mydei doesn't really like being called that, but he still shakes the man's hand. "It's nice to meet you too, Mister Lycurgus."

"Please, call me Lygus," Mist- *Lygus* says. He motions them toward the plush chairs facing his desk before returning to his own seat. "May I interest you in any refreshments? Something to nibble on or to quench your thirst?"

Lygus speaks with a peculiar slowness, his lilting syllables stretching out with the weight of his gravitas. It's unexpected enough that Mydei is left slightly off-kilter.

"No, thank you," Krateros replies to Lygus's question as he sits down. "Mydei?"

Mydei shakes his head and follows Krateros's lead. Lygus nods at his secretary, who leaves the room at his signal. The man moves his head with a mechanical stiffness, reminding Mydei of an old analogue clock.

Lygus claps his hands together. "Well, gentlemen. Let us not tarry. We convene today because we are of the same mind, and further contemplation has strengthened our convictions about the proposed partnership. If our aspirations have since diverged, please, feel free to correct me."

"Our minds haven't changed," Krateros assures him. "We also think this is right for us."

"Mister Mydeimos? Have you been kept up to speed with our entreaties?"

"I am."

"Excellent," Lygus says. "With your consent, the only variable that remains are your signatures."

After briefly thumbing over the documents on his table, Lygus slides a thick contract towards Mydei. A bony finger taps on the paper. "You are required to sign in several places, but please start here."

Mydei reaches for the pen propped up on his desk, but before he could even uncap it, Krateros stops him.

"Hold on," Krateros says, gripping Mydei's wrist. "Can I scan through it first?"

"You may," Lygus says as he folds his hands together. "I commend your prudence. Us humans are prone to error, no matter how learned and competent."

Krateros nods perfunctorily, already taking out his reading glasses to review the contract. Usually when people scan through documents, they don't actually take in each and every line. That would be called reading. Krateros, who is examining the words printed with utmost care, is most definitely

reading a contract that he could have requested a copy for any time in advance.

Mydei glances at Lygus, who appears nonplussed by Krateros's slow crawl. If he recalls correctly, their appointment is only supposed to last 30 minutes maximum. The contract seems to be about 50 pages, and judging by where Krateros's eyes are, it'll take the whole day just for him to reach page 4.

"There is no need to be concerned, Mister Mydeimos," Lygus suddenly says. "Such occurrences are commonplace for negotiations."

Mydei frowns. "Are you going to refuse us automatically when you kick us out?"

"Of course not. You and your agent may use my settee or the lounge outside should it suit our needs. I promise the time spent won't have any bearing on our subsequent agreements."

Krateros coughs lightly. "I'm not going to take that long. I just thought that important things are worth taking time on."

"Aptly put," Lygus comments.

No one has anything else to say after that, though Mydei notices Krateros's pupils moving marginally faster. Without anything else to do, Mydei looks out to the windows to check out the view. It's not much more interesting, he finds, being mostly occupied by other office buildings and the like. Peering closer only makes Mydei feel like a dirty voyeur, which makes the whole wall of floor-to-ceiling windows feel a tiny bit wasteful. Their only contribution to the room is perhaps sunlight, and Lygus's opinion on that is apparent with the thick curtains that dim his half of the room.

"Would you like me to explain the contract in greater detail, Mister Mydeimos?" Lygus asks. "Seeing as we are both idle for the moment?"

Mydei snaps to attention. "I think I'm good, thank you."

"Such confidence. What a boon to have you within our ranks."

“Actually-“ Mydei stops. “…No. Nevermind.”

“Please, do not suppress yourself for my sake. Your understanding is vital for our co-operation.”

“I already understand what I need to,” Mydei tells him. “I was going to ask something personal.”

“Oh? Of what matter piques your interest?”

“I was wondering if anyone in the company has a problem with me.”

For a second, it almost seems like Lygus hadn’t been prepared to hear Mydei’s query, losing the prescience in his smile. Then his processing unit kicks in again, and he starts nodding all-knowingly once more.

“You refer to your unfavorable background, correct?” Lygus asks. “There is no need to fret, for we live in a world outside clear cut binaries. Your advantages do not become obsolete because an opposing force has introduced dialectics.”

“Biases still exist,” Mydei points out.

“Another uncomfortable truth to contend with,” Lygus concurs. “But one without foundation. Tell me, does a single dust rose constitute a garden? Or is it the grass, the soil, or the life that it implies?”

Mydei ponders the question, even though Lygus answers it for him. “The answer is all of it. In myth, the Grove of Epiphany flourished in its diversity, and thus so too shall ours. Whether you are a blossoming rose or a voidshroom sprouting in the dark, our modest Grove shall benefit greatly from your involvement.”

If Mydei were given the chance to think it over, he might have realized that Lygus did not actually answer him at all. Unfortunately, he’d been distracted by Krateros’s rapid flipping of the contract, the older man’s grimace growing more distressed with each page he passes.

“Is there a definition of Sun and Thunder anywhere?” Krateros asks.

An odd detail to nitpick, but Lygus directs him in his search anyway. Krateros temporary hands back the contract, and it takes Lygus no time at all to flip to the front page and find what he's looking for.

And yet, Krateros does not look relieved. "Is that all there is?"

"Yes," Lygus says. "Have you spotted an issue?"

Mydei peers over Krateros's shoulder. From what he can read, the contract states that *Sun and Thunder* is a band under *Grove Records* and that they comprise of the musicians Phainon and Mydeimos. It's reductive, but accurate. Perhaps Krateros is wondering about the other live musicians they have to perform with…?

"I don't know if I'm reading this wrong, but I thought we agreed that Sun and Thunder should be able to work together *without* Mydei being signed to Grove," Krateros says.

"That is what the contract stipulates, yes."

"So why is it saying that any song Mydei writes automatically belongs to Grove Records?"

"An easy misconception to make," Lygus says. "The contract only refers to a partial ownership, and *only* for any Sun and Thunder song that Mister Mydeimos may write in the future."

"But there's no clarification on what a Sun and Thunder song is," Krateros says. "Is it a song written by Mydei and Phainon? But why specify Mydei's name? What's to say Grove won't categorize all his songs as the band's?"

Lygus shakes his head. "We are not trying to pull the wool over your eyes, Mister Krateros. We are only trying to protect Sun and Thunder. It is not inconceivable that its main songwriter would subconsciously create more songs in a similar vein. Imagine if you will, that such a song gets sold to another artist with a bigger outreach. Sun and Thunder's appeal and originality would come into question, and it would be nigh impossible to step out of its shadow. Why, Grove would have its hands tied if we were to

go against respected industry leaders such as Phagousa Entertainment. Our only solution would be to place these primitive guardrails in advance."

As Lygus justifies *Grove*'s intentions, Mydei skims through the contract himself. Truthfully, Mydei came into this deal unsure of what he wanted, so he assumed that he'd be feel just fine if it were to fall through in the end. He severely underestimated how dispiriting it would be in reality, to see exactly how their best interests have been taken for granted.

"There's no rubric for the songs," Mydei re-emphasizes, ignoring the way his gut lurches.

"Is there are a need for one?" Lygus asks. "Sun and Thunder's musical stylings are quite unique. Any reasonable jury would be able to identify its markers."

How much of Mydei really is in *Sun and Thunder*? Has he ever written a song that didn't sound like it was meant to be sang by a certain person?

"Moreover, we have no motive to claim your songs for our own," Lygus continues. "On the contrary, we at Grove pride ourselves in our artists' development, therefore the implication that we would recycle anybody's music is antithetical to our mission. I would go as far as to call this an opportunity for you, Mister Mydeimos. Perhaps we'll cultivate an intimate familiarity with your musical talents, and be inspired to work with you through the proper channels. Doesn't that sound grand?"

"Maybe if the contract gets adjusted," Mydei counteroffers.

For a moment, the only sound in the room is the ticking of a clock and the soft taps of Lygus's bony fingers drumming on his table. Mydei barely catches the man's weary sigh before he burrows back into his leather chair.

"I am ashamed, Mister Mydeimos," Lygus admits. "Ashamed that I lack the wherewithal to assuage your fears. I believe I have elucidated our intentions to the best of my ability, but without your trust, I am afraid we are destined to misinterpret each other."

Mydei shakes his head. “That’s not-“

“Contracts are really about trust, are they not?” Lygus interrupts. “You are willing to enter this agreement not because you believe the repercussions will keep us in line, but because you trust we will do what is right. I see now that we have failed to prove ourselves worthy of your commitment. Continuing to pursue this deal would be insulting to everyone involved.”

“It’s not paranoia to ask questions,” Krateros objects. “Why are you justified for putting in protective clauses while we can’t even get a concise description?”

Lygus holds his hands up in surrender. “You are well within your rights to seek answers for your doubts. I even sympathized with your worries, if I recall correctly. However, it is strange that you are the only ones who see this as a problem. It’s one thing for our people to hold their silence, yes, but *your* lawyers? They have no motivation to lie, yet they’ve attested to the contract’s fairness.”

There’s a lesson here to be learned, about lawyers and the kind that you should hire, but Mydei should have learned this back when his father’s company dragged him into a never-ending lawsuit.

“Nothing to say?” Lygus asks. “You must have arrived at the same conclusion as I.”

Though he knows better than to think this way, Mydei feels he’s to blame for everything falling apart at the last second. He tries not to make it look so obvious when they leave Lygus’s office, but all the pleasantries in the world can’t get him to do anything more than grunt.

As the doors shut behind them, Mydei recalls that most gardens convert unneeded vegetation into mulch. Only time can tell if Lygus’s promises held a grain of truth.

—

Phainon's agitated pacing is beginning to wear on the soles of his shoes. The loafers were built for photographs, not pavement, but changing out of them had completely slipped Phainon's mind. Once he set his eyes on a certain text, paying a designer's fine became the least pressing matter at hand.

Every now and then the sound of an approaching car gets Phainon to pause, only for him to turn away from the road in dejection. It takes looping a couple more rounds before the Camry he's looking for finally arrives, and even then he doesn't wait for the car to come to a full stop before yanking the door open.

"Be careful," Mydei tells Phainon as he stumbles inside.

Phainon ignores his chiding to get to the crux of the matter. "What happened back there?"

"I got a no. Just like I told you," Mydei says, easing his car back into drive. "I'm making avgolemono tonight, is that okay?"

Phainon fumbles a tiny bit with the seatbelt and ignores the promise of chicken soup. "Was it only Lygus there? Is there going to be a follow up meeting?"

"We only spoke with Lygus and no, I don't think we're going to meet up again," Mydei answers. "He spoke like the decision's been made."

"Lygus is only a mouthpiece," Phainon grumbles. Never before has Phainon been so annoyed to be stuck at a photoshoot, although it was probably for the best he wasn't around to assail his boss. "He doesn't have the power to overrule the company's decision."

"Have you considered that maybe the company doesn't want Sun and Thunder to become a real band again?"

"Impossible," Phainon says, scowling. "Everybody's been in favor of Sun and Thunder, either because of the money or because they like our stuff. So

many people worked to get this tour rolling, and they're not going to be happy to be collateral damage from Lygus's power trip."

"The man definitely likes the sound of his own voice," Mydei concurs. "He talked in metaphor half the time I was there."

"The fucking metaphors. He loves it when people can't understand him. It makes it easier for him to sneak in insults without biting him in the ass."

"He compared me to dirt, I think."

Phainon clicks his tongue. "Who the fuck does that guy think he is? Do you know that he can't hold a tune to save his life? I fully believe he's actually tone deaf, because there's no way he thinks he's better than you."

Mydei laughs quietly. "He's your superior."

"Superior pain in the butt, maybe," Phainon mumbles. "It won't be long until he's booted. Lygus is ruining the company by rejecting you."

"That's an exaggeration."

"I was serious when I said there's a lot of internal support for us," Phainon says. "You don't know half of what's been invested in getting the band back together. I mean, we haven't really gotten that far in the tour!"

"I know, that's why Krateros was willing to negotiate," Mydei says. "He thought it was a sign that they were taking us seriously, but they refused to rectify the one clause we wanted to change."

"What clause?"

"There's a part in the contract that says Grove owns all Sun and Thunder songs," Mydei explains. "Including the ones I write outside of Sun and Thunder."

Phainon's brow furrows. "What does that mean?"

“It means they can strike my songs if they think it sounds like Sun and Thunder,” Mydei explains. “And they refused our request to make the definition more specific.”

“Oh. Are they asking for full ownership?”

“They’re asking for royalties and the right to refuse unauthorized usage.”

“So you can’t use your own songs?”

“They say I can, but they’ve left it open for their own loopholes.”

Slowly but surely, Phainon begins to process his words. “…Mydei, are *you* the one who refused to sign on?”

“Only because they wouldn’t change the contract,” Mydei says defensively.

“I know but…” Phainon pauses. “I mean, I haven’t seen the contract so maybe it’s worse than I think, b-“

“What part of what I said sounded fine to you?”

“Nothing!” Phainon immediately corrects himself. “It’s definitely bad, but compared to other contracts where people have to sign away their entire life, I think your contract was pretty forgiving.”

“You think my work isn’t my entire life?” Mydei scoffs.

“I’m talking more literal here,” Phainon emphasizes. “There are hundreds of people who are actually indebted to their companies, who aren’t credited for a single note of their music and are probably never going to see any money from it. People who’ll sign openly hostile agreements because it’s their only shot at their dream! I’m not saying Grove is in the right, but at least they’ve made your contract contestable.”

Mydei’s knuckles have gone white on the steering wheel. You could almost hear the contraction of his muscles, with the vein on his hand appearing more prominent than it’s ever been.

The tension lasts for only a second. Mydei's grip relaxes with his next question. "Have you ever thought about leaving Grove Records?"

"Myde-"

"Have you?" Mydei presses. "You obviously don't think Grove is a perfect entity. You talk shit about their upper management and you have to put on stage plays with your manager to get anything approved. Everyone you like in the company basically hates it there too."

"Moving record labels isn't as easy as it sounds."

"You're *the* Deliverer," Mydei sneers. "You're not a helpless little kid from the country anymore."

"It's because I am the Deliverer that I have to stay," Phainon argues. "All the artists and employees in the company depend on me for their livelihood."

"Here we go again. Acting like it's your duty to save a company that only sees you as a cash cow."

"Is it a fucking crime to have some loyalty?" Phainon grits his teeth. "You think I want advice from the guy who leaves other people to clean up after him?"

Mydei cackles. "That's rich. I didn't know it was a burden to have our entire discography and the resources of the whole company at your disposal. Fuck me for leaving you alone with endorsements worth millions!"

"You don't know what I wanted," Phainon interjects.

"What do I have to do with that?" Mydei says in disbelief. "If you want something, you have to take it with your own hands. Like how I wanted to make music on my own terms, and how I was willing to lose everything I have just to do that!"

"It's not the same!"

“Yes, because I was a child. *You* are an adult with an established foothold on the industry.”

“Being older won’t make it easier to transfer the rights to my songs from one label to another!”

“So you choose to rot away in a company that doesn’t respect you. I’m not surprised.”

“I’m being strategic.”

“You’re being a coward,” Mydei says. “Every person you think you’re protecting would benefit much more from you pushing back at Grove. But you can’t, because you can’t bear the thought of anyone thinking negatively of you, Amphoreus’s most perfect, most brilliant, most magnanimous suck-up-”

“Your mother’s a famous record producer and no one even remembers you!”

The car comes to a stop at a red light. Neither Phainon nor Mydei make a sound, as if a vacuum had sucked the out all the atmosphere. The rest of the drive remains frightfully silent, the weight of the inevitable looming over their heads.

Phainon gets out of the car once they reach his building, but Mydei stays seated inside. He drives off the moment the passenger door slams shut, and Phainon can only watch as the Camry disappears down the street and out of his life.

—

Ivv @phaightingg
i fucking knew it

Phaikisser @calamitysandtragedys
That article was so effed up I’m disgusted that I ever had a positive thought about that man 😭

> **rockefort** @hold0nsugar
> honestly it was obvs that he was on some nepo shit bc whooo is this irrelevant flop suddenly all over phainon lmao
> **Phaikisser** @calamitysandtragedys
> I still don’t think it’s fair to question everyone that’s ever interacted with Phainon but

---

Olympiac @SealSlammed
Eight years after the death of that old bastard and now his son is fucking shit up I’m tiredddddd

---

Chu Chu @phainonsense
teletube.com/watch?v=22lsYW…. Mydeimos doing fuck all in the reunion bts I’m ctfu get this fraud out of the studio

---

Fang @w6fglR68h
I don’t want to make this about me, but now that there’s an article out I just wanted to say that I worked on one of the Sun and Thunder shows and Mydeimos was extremely rude to me and kept bossing me around. And because I am a smaller woman I was extremely shaken by the incident. I have no confirmation of this but I think he got me fired too

Areti @faithfulpride78
Oh Sky Father! You are so brave for speaking up and sharing your story. I hope you get justice in the end ❤

Fang @w6fglR68h
Thank you I’m just happy to leave this in the past

Thea @ral1ymaker
I’m one of the gaffers for Diogena’s talk show and Mydeimos was nothing but respectful when he was with us. He even helped set up heavy equipment when he saw us struggling, so I’m sorry if I don’t believe this.
Bukoko @baguettling
wowww suddenly everyone’s worked with mydeimos
Solata @wwestwindward
Shame on you for lying on this poor woman’s post to impress a man. He’s not going to see your reply you know!

---

dros @phaimousphaces
just when you think you’ve seen it all smh

—

The past week has been hell, to put it lightly.

For starters, every *Sun and Thunder* show has been canceled for good. Half the refunds are to be settled out of Mydei’s own pocket, on grounds of being the reason the band breached their agreement with the venues. Perhaps in a fairer world Mydei would have disputed this claim in court, but recent events have left him with nothing but trepidation in regards to all things law. Whatever. If it takes draining his bank account to sever his

connections with Grove, then Mydei would give them the shirt off of his own back for all he cares.

It's not like *Grove*'s going to get that money soon anyway. They shot themselves in the foot when they put out that exposé on Mydei's father. Nobody wants to work with Public Enemy Number One or his son, adding to the suspicion that *Grove* did this not for the profits, but to humiliate Mydei specifically. That's not to say there aren't benefits to their petty article, considering they now have a convenient scapegoat for the fans' outrage. Their own brand would come out of the scandal unscathed, and all the investors that were on the fence with Mydei's contentious reputation are now flocking around the company once again. A big happy ending for everyone who matters.

Despite what their intentions might have been, Mydei is not the worst victim of his own downturn. That honor would go to Krateros, who has since been slaving away to recover a scrap of Mydei's former standing. It seems that even the mediocre days preceding the comeback were out of reach, and it's just too ironic of an outcome for Krateros to accept lying down.

So far his efforts have reaped nothing but exhaustion. Although Mydei had disagreed with him from the beginning, he had no desire to see Krateros wither away.

"Eat, old man," Mydei orders, pointing to the lunchbox he graciously placed on his desk. "You won't be able to make your calls if you don't have the strength to pick up your phone."

Krateros rubs his haggard face in exasperation, but ultimately yields. What is going to do? Say no to Mydei again? "Thank you," Krateros mutters.

"Stop talking and eat," Mydei repeats as he plants himself onto the couch. He stares at Krateros until the stubborn man takes his first bite in earnest.

Krateros's office has always made Mydei cringe to be in. Most of the paraphernalia in the room are related to Mydei or Mydei's past accolades, and it was nigh impossible to turn your head without making eye contact

with a plaque or a newspaper clipping he had minimal involvement in. Recent events only make it more difficult for Mydei to be here, but perhaps it wouldn't be long until these embarrassing artifacts are finally stowed away for good.

"I'm waiting on a call today," Krateros suddenly brings up. "Aquila's Angels want to work with you."

"Aquila's Angels," Mydei echoes. That was the name of the new girl group on the rise.

"I heard their manager wanted to get in touch," Krateros says. "He said he'll get back to me this morning."

It is nearing four in the afternoon. Mydei decides not to pop his bubble yet; Krateros's hair is starting to sport more salt than pepper. "That sounds great."

"There's-" Krateros sighs and puts his spoon down. "I've gotten word back from Phagousa Entertainment, and they've made an offer for your pre-written work. I told them we'll think about it, but I suppose it's an option."

"Keep eating," Mydei says. "I assume you're having second thoughts because they want to bury my credits."

"I'm sor-"

"Don't," Mydei quickly cuts him off. "I'll take their offer. I have plenty of unreleased songs I could sell."

"You don't have to force yourself to," Krateros insists. "I can find a way."

"I'm not forcing myself. I think it's about time I stop stockpiling material."

Krateros sighs again. "You didn't say that the last time we had this conversation."

"My feelings have changed," Mydei says. "Now eat."

The constant reminder makes Krateros grumble, but it's what he gets for forcing Mydei to eat asparagus as a child. It takes a few more bites for hunger to properly sink its claws into Krateros, and when it does, he starts wolfing down the porridge like a man possessed. Mydei is glad he had the foresight to bring something both filling and easy on the stomach, but he might need to think about making bigger batches for the weeks to come.

"Did you know? We've been lied to," Krateros grumbles into his porridge. "When I was still in talks with Grove, they said that it was *us* who requested for help during your writing phase."

"…Is that so?"

Krateros almost sprays rice over his desk with how aggressively he nods. "I told them that they were the one who asked to keep eyes on you, but they laughed me off. It's been a farce from beginning to end. Snakes, the lot of them."

Mydei nods, having nothing of value to add. Krateros doesn't need his blood pressure to rise any higher than it has.

Eventually, Krateros finishes eating and resumes flipping through his rolodex for someone to answer his prayers. Mydei takes it as a cue to leave him alone, though the swarm of reporters staking out his car makes him rethink his decision. Maybe Mydei could get around better if he tried disguising himself, but he won't be surprised if the paparazzi has memorized his license plate by now.

Wigs aren't Mydei's thing anyway. Ignoring questions and pushing people out of his way is more his style. Sooner or later, the public is going to get tired of hearing of Mydei and his antisocial antics. Or at the very least, journalists are going to get tired of getting shoved around.

"Are you still in cahoots with Councilman Ephor? Will you address the damages caused by Bulwark to Kremnos's trade economy?"

"Mydeimos! Mydeimos! Is it true? Is it true you attacked employees at Grove for refusing your orders?"

“How are you feeling, Mydeimos? Do you feel like an idiot for screwing up a million dollar contract or are you just living up to dear old dad?”

Mydei clips that last guy with his car door. The mortified gasps he gets are a bit unfair, considering that he gave them exactly what they came here for.

Luckily, the reporters have enough common sense to leave his car alone once he starts backing out of his parking spot. Mydei makes it onto the road without major incident, and he drives himself back home where he does the same song and dance with different set of reporters. Sometimes the paparazzi amazes Mydei with their organization. It makes him wonder if this too is Aglaea’s doing, if she took the time to learn Mydei’s weak spots so she may kick him when he’s down. Perhaps everyone at *Grove* is seeing this and laughing at him right now. Perhaps he deserves it.

At least Figgy still likes Mydei, judging from the way she circles his ankles when he returns. They’ve been closer than ever since Mydei started staying at home for longer. And look, Mydei has more time for himself now. He can add more reps to his workout and he can clean the bathroom like he always tells himself he would. Mydei can no longer continue the show that Ptolemy and Leonnius like, but maybe he can find another series he can start with them instead.

If none of that works, then there’s music. Once he remembers that, Mydei suddenly finds himself seated in his home studio with a guitar in hand and his MIDI controller at the ready. Everything he could ever need is here with him, and he can choose whether to make music to sell or to simply indulge. He hasn’t been given a single instruction or deadline. No time signature, no key, no genre. Only freedom.

Mydei stares at his empty project file.

The project file stares back.

Gradually, the guitar gets unmounted from his neck. The peripherals are turned off and the computer is shut down. Mydei rolls his chair away from the desk and takes in the stillness of his home.

Mydei's parents knew each other for a sum of 20 odd years. For a time, Gorgo and Eurypon were what besotted lovers and budding rockstars aspired to. He was a guitar virtuoso oozing with stage presence and she was a musical savant who could bring any song to transcendent highs. Together they brought beautiful and glorious rock-and-roll to Amphoreus, and they believed, foolishly, that their music could be the very thing to bring the country together. Their naïve dream manifested in a media conglomerate that ate through the large majority of businesses in Amphoreus, whether through buyouts or takeovers or alliances or some other unscrupulous thing. Once the entertainment industry began to gear towards an oligarchy, Eurypon proceeded to run the company to the ground and take half of Amphoreus with it. Eurypon was eventually arrested for a litany of illegal practices, but not even his death could turn *Bulwark*'s fate around.

Gorgo left Eurypon before shit hit the fan, when Mydei was still a wee babe. Of their dream, she mentions a simple wish - for music to reach every corner of Amphoreus free of censorship and stigma. If Mydei could go back in time, he'd tell her to wish for something else. Music is a wonderful thing, but it can't bring anybody together.

A *ding* startles Mydei out of his thoughts. His heart hammers in his chest as he picks up his phone, only settling down once he reads the notification.

Hephaestion
@Mydeimos

Hephaestion
Stop skipping out on me and
get to the gym. Now.

Leonnius
chill dude he could b driving

Hephaestion
Well he's late either way!!!!!!

Ptolemy
@Mydei Honor your promises

To his credit, Mydei does jump out of his chair when he sees the time. He chooses to get ready over replying, hoping he could make it up to Hephaestion with the microseconds his silence shaves off. Thankfully the paparazzi have yet to find a way to break into the underground parking, though Mydei tries not to be too grateful less he jinxes it. Mydei decides to prioritize speed and hops on Kokopo, praying that his boxing gloves don't fly off on the way there.

When Mydei finally makes it to Hephaestion's gym, he finds the man himself scrolling on his phone, a giant frown marring his face. Sadly, Mydei's presence does not miraculously improve his mood. Hephaestion skips the well wishes and orders Mydei to prepare for the ring post-haste, hovering menacingly as Mydei wraps his hand in gauze.

"You took so long that I already cooled down," Hephaestion grouses. "I'll make you do high knees for an hour if you pull this stunt again."

The clatter of gym equipment must have gotten too quiet for Hephaestion's liking, because he goes on to turn and address the rest of the boxing club. "Are we all done with our drills?" He shouts. "Or are you all waiting for me to personally come and assist you?"

Judging from the sudden onslaught of noise, everyone is doing just fine without their coach's assistance. Mydei on the other hand appreciates the help, though he still thinks Hephaestion should hold their sessions at a less crowded time.

Mydei warms up, hops into the ring, and proceeds to get his ass kicked for a solid 30 minutes. He and Hephaestion are sparring purely for fun - the gap between their heights and weights disqualifies any other option - but Hephaestion's blows land like Mydei owes him actual money. Mydei deduces that it's his piss poor timing that's setting him off, along with a bevy of other obvious blunders that Hephaestion yells at him for.

Spending an entire match on the defensive is draining, but it keeps Mydei's attention away from the eyes directed on him. Mydei is so preoccupied that he doesn't realize who's in the audience until a familiar voice calls out.

“Mydei! I brought you a booster shot!”

Between the unexpected guest, the frenzy of punches, and Mydei’s godawful positioning, the devastating strike to Mydei’s face is not as surprising as the gasps imply.

“Oh shit!” Hephaestion exclaims.

The headgear saves Mydei from crippling medical debt, but his cheek is going to smart for a couple of days at the latest. It’s lucky they have a doctor present, even if he is the cause of Mydei’s predicament.

“How is it?” Perdikkas asks once they’ve situated themselves ringside. He almost resembles a bookie, standing in the gym with his starchy button-down and loose fit trousers.

Mydei smacks his tongue as if it would help him taste Perdikkas’s homemade green juice any better. “It’s one of your better ones, honestly,” he says.

“I was talking about your face.”

“Oh.” Mydei moves his jaw from side to side. There’s a disconcerting pop as it shifts, but that’s probably normal. “I think I’m good.”

“This is not the time to play it tough,” Hephaestion says, examining his cheek in concern. “How’s your teeth? All there?”

“You’re not that strong,” Mydei says.

Hephaestion sighs. “Don’t underestimate how easy it is to get a concussion. This is why we keep our posture in mind.” He claps a hand on Mydei’s back. “But other that, you did a good job today. Well done.”

Mydei nods. Coach Hephaestion must have left the building. “Thanks.”

Hephaestion gives him a smile before turning to Perdikkas. “You should have told us you were coming,” he says. “We would have waited.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow at that.

“We could have added to our warm up while waiting,” Hephaestion amends his statement. “If you’d like, I could go for another round in the ring-“

“I’m really not dressed for it,” Perdikkas immediately refuses. “I just thought I could surprise you guys since I had a shorter day today. Can’t say it panned out how I thought it would.”

“Don’t worry,” Mydei assures him. “Next time, we’ll surprise you at work.”

Perdikkas frowns at the notion. Right, he’s a doctor. That punch must have jostled Mydei’s brain harder than he thought.

“You know, I was planning to get waffle fries with Mydei,” Hephaestion muses out loud. “But seeing as I have you two hermits with me, I say we should go somewhere a little more special.”

“What’s that rooftop restaurant with the bar?” Perdikkas asks.

“It’s a Tuesday and we’re all driving,” Mydei deadpans.

“I could tank at least one espresso martini,” Perdikkas implores them. “Please. I need this.”

They end up going to a more understated restaurant with a less comprehensive drink menu, but Perdikkas looks happy enough with his avocado milkshake. Mydei has a feeling that no matter what he ordered, Perdikkas would have still ended up slouched over the table bemoaning his job. Listening to a hospital’s petty bureaucracies turns out oddly riveting, even if it does convince Mydei to never get admitted at Perdikkas’s place of work.

The rest of Mydei’s days remain unpredictable, but adhere to a kind of routine. Usually it would start with feeding and walking Figgy, then a customary check in with Krateros. The rest of the morning would be reserved for matters around the house, and if he’s lucky, Mydei would find the time to properly sort his burgeoning archive of music.

Afternoons are the busiest. Sometimes Ptolemy would invite himself over to seek peace away from students and graduate papers, while other times it would be Peucesta dropping by to take a much needed break from his own piano. Peridikkas in particular enjoys gifting detox smoothies that Mydei shares with Krateros, who enjoys it much, *much* less. Occasionally, Leonnius would bring his new GameStation 6 to show off, and the workaholics in their group would suddenly be free to play a game of *Galactic Grand Prix All Stars*. The constant visitors are also a convenient excuse for Mydei to rediscover baking, which has the unintended side effect of Hephaestion grilling all of them twice as hard in the gym.

Going outside is still a pain, but a prominent starlet snagging a new beau has at least halved the number of reporters hounding Mydei. A few more news cycles and the public's perception of Mydei might simmer down to a passive antipathy, and everything would be back to where they started. Even the ex-concert venues have eased their case against Mydei, perhaps coming to a realization on how pitiful his net-worth has become.

One evening, after another harsh bout in the boxing ring, Hephaestion approaches Mydei with a question.

"What do you think about holding a demonstration for the others?"

Mydei stares at his friend, still heaving from their rigorous workout.

"Most of the new members already have a good grasp on the fundamentals," Hephaestion explains. "But they have trouble keeping their stance while on the move. I was thinking maybe we could show them how proper footwork can make or break their combos in a match."

It's been about a month since Mydei's been a regular at Hephaestion's boxing club. Whatever problem the other gym goers may have with him didn't last past the first week, and a few familiar faces have even gone on to exchange small talk with Mydei. Watching him get consistently whaled on must have softened their views on their controversial newcomer.

"… I can see right through you, you know," Mydei says.

Hephaestion doesn’t respond to the accusation, too busy toweling himself off. Despite his stellar winning streak, Mydei is catching up.

“You don’t have to tell us anything if you don’t want to,” Hephaestion eventually says. “I just think you should know that… We’ll be here whenever you want to move forward.”

It takes a moment, but Mydei thinks he may have smiled. “I appreciate it,” he admits.

Hephaestion answers with a grin of his own.

The status-quo continues to mold itself around a new mundane. Weekends become busier. Kokopo gets brought into Leonnius’s garage for frequent tune-ups. Ptolemy signs Mydei up for his book club. Apartment listings start appearing in Mydei’s e-mails along with miscellaneous job openings. Figgy finds a new dog park. A second boxing lesson gets scheduled over a warm serving of fries.

Everything is so normal and fine that Mydei forgets himself. On the drive home from one of Peucesta’s concerts, Mydei fails to notice where his route leads, too occupied by thoughts of tomorrow’s bills and yesterday’s chores. He barely registers the highway he’s taken until he finds himself looking up at a familiar face.

The billboard remains standing after so many months, still promoting that cologne that Mydei now knows smells of cedar and peach tea. A line of floodlights illuminate the display in the dark of night, inadvertently drawing attention to the streaks left by the errant rain. The discolored lines give the impression that the model had been weeping.

The rush hour traffic pins Mydei into place. What had once filled him with giddy laughter now leaves him hollowed and raw. It’s illogical. Mydei may not have been a pious man, but he had faith in discipline. As long as he abstains, as long as he compartmentalizes his thoughts and steels his reactions, his vices would no longer be reflex. These small pleasures would be lost in pursuit of the bigger picture, and the world would keep on turning as it always did.

And yet, Phainon remained. He was in everything; the sights, the sounds, the absence. He was on giant billboards and the television and the newspapers and strange internet gossip. He was in the music Mydei loved and in the advertisements Mydei detested. He was in the plums laid out in the market, in the floppy twitch of Figgy’s ear, in the extra shadows casted by the sun. He was in the silences that trailed every conversation, in the spaces in between Mydei’s fingers, and in the wrinkles of his pillow case when he wakes.

Mydei felt odd, like all breath had slammed out of him at once. In truth, it would have never worked out anyway. He’s seen how it plays out when two people know each other for too long. He didn’t want it for himself, and he certainly didn’t want it for Phainon. Phainon deserved better than to be shackled to a lifetime of shame, and through perseverance and hard work, Mydei ensured that would never come to pass. Mydei won. He succeeded, and it hurt.

Triumphant and victorious, Mydei crumples. His only witness continues to gaze at him from above, as unfeeling and impersonal as Kephale passing judgment.

Chapter End Notes

> It may not be obvious, but I do appreciate all your comments! I've been trying not to reply as to not spoil anything, but last chapter there were a lot of comments excited about what's to come and I was already at the end of this chapter and I was like oof... I don't know man I don't know about that

Chapter 6: Side F

Chapter Notes

> I think it's pretty obvious that I get a lot of inspiration from romcoms but this chapter is REALLY obvious with it.
>
> Another inspiration is What Became of the Likely Lads? by The Libertines, which is where the title came from! It took until the last chapter for me to remember to mention that, but we got there
>
> This is a double chapter drop by the way! In case you were following along and just clicked on the recent one

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“You’re leaving?”

The question hung in the air like one of the fishing lures Phainon’s dad had been so proud of. Unlike his dad’s mayfly nymphs, however, Phainon’s question failed to hook its target. The crabby teenager ignored him in favor of staring out the window like the angsty posters mounted on his side of the dorm.

“When are you coming back?”

It took a second question for the boy to finally turn his snooty face towards Phainon. “I don’t know,” the blond answered.

“Is it like a few months?” Phainon prodded. “‘Cause we just got back home, and it’d be weird if we took a hiatus right when we’re hitting it big-“

“I probably won’t return,” Mydei said bluntly. “I cut all my ties with Grove.”

“Oh.“

Phainon found himself at a loss. He heard and understood the words perfectly well, but they just didn't sound right to him. It almost sounded as if-

"Stop making that face," Mydei scowled. "Do you have a problem with me leaving?"

"What? No way!" Phainon pretended to gag. "If anything I'm glad to get rid of you! I mean finally, I don't have to deal with you hogging the bathroom all the time!"

That was a close call. Something in Phainon had told him to panic, but it would have made him look really uncool.

Mydei rolled his eyes as he got down from his perch. "Great. I'm sure you're happy to go solo way sooner than you expected."

"I am," Phainon blustered.

Who knows, some time apart could be a good thing. As much as he hated to admit it, Phainon has been on edge around Mydei lately, an uneasiness like an insidious creature burrowing into another's nest. Phainon was scared it was jealousy, that he'd taken Mydei's talent and wit and devastating prettiness personally. A break from each other could help nip these anxieties in the bud, or at least allow Phainon to catch up and do the impressing for once.

Still, Phainon can't help but to make sure- "We can still make music together, right?"

Phainon's words reached Mydei at the door. He lingered long enough to shoot Phainon one last aggravating smirk.

"As long as you ask nicely," Mydei promised.

—

Sick of knocking, Aglaea finally makes use of the spare keycard and barges into the hotel room.

In hindsight, it was not the best idea to book an entire presidential suite for one singular person, let alone a person going through an inexplicable moody phase. Anaxagoras maintains that a nicer environment would chase away anyone's blues, but he possessed as much empathy as a block of wood. Thanks to him, a throng of luxurious couches sat in the suite gathering dust, a trend that followed the generous amenities in the kitchenette and study. The wide screen TV might as well have been wallpapered over, and Aglaea isn't even going to start on the jacuzzi tubs in the bathrooms.

Aglaea bypasses these trivial distractions to get to the only closed door in the entire suite. Growing short on time, she bursts into the guest room with an immediate demand.

"Get up, Phainon," she orders. "You're required at sound check."

Taking on these extra concerts was Phainon's idea, yet he attended to them with the most perfunctory of effort. It's disproportionate to the labor it takes to move a battalion of crew members and equipment from city to city, not to mention the late nights spent on retooling shows at the last minute. It's unbecoming of Phainon to behave so irresponsibly, but as Aglaea's eyes adjusts to the sight in front of her, she finds herself unwilling to continue her rebuke.

The pop star lay on the bed facing away from Aglaea, the sheets pooling around him in a tangled mess. The curtains left no light to speak of in the room, save for a tiny sliver that bisected Phainon's listless figure. Occasionally the ventilation would click on and blow a gust of cool air, but other than that, the scene remains as still as a painting.

Aglaea enters the room. Slowly, she sits herself on the outer perimeter of the bed, noting the steady rise and fall of Phainon's back. She reaches out to console him, but stops once she thinks better of it.

"I could listen, if you want," Aglaea says instead. "Though you might have to turn off the Barry Manilow playlist first."

Somewhere within the mire of sheets, a muffled song plays on Phainon's dying phone, droning on about farewells and lost opportunities. The lyrics are heavy-handed with its sap, but they had a better chance of reaching Phainon's ears than Aglaea's offer did.

She casts her gaze aside. "I didn't know. Truly."

Whether Phainon believes her is up to him. Aglaea can only keep talking to fill the dead air.

"I don't believe the reunion would have been approved if it wasn't for the timing. People wanted something to fill the gap between your albums, and it was by luck that the Fantasia was coming around again. Our shareholders could never pass on easy money, but don't be mistaken. Opinions on Sun and Thunder were divisive from the very start."

"I must say, I was one of the people who opposed the project," Aglaea continues. "The proposal was preposterous, frankly. We have to put together so many moving parts in so short a time, and for what? An overseas competition that no longer holds any cultural relevance? I simply didn't see the appeal in disrupting your rest to reunite a dated band, and to be honest I still really don't."

"What I did see was you on stage having the time of your life," Aglaea confesses. "While I still can't say the music is my cup of tea, watching you two trying to one-up the other… I liked that part." She chuckles at the memory. "I believe a lot of people did. I thought that if my mind could change, then perhaps Grove could rethink their stance as well."

Her faint smile evaporates. "I never intended to get your hopes up. It didn't occur to me how important Mydeimos is to you. I'm sorry."

Phainon remains dead to the world. Like her attempts at comfort and levity, Aglaea's honesty also fails to rouse him, coming off more self-indulgent and preachy than she'd intended. It's one thing to be an interloper, but to intrude *and* have nothing worthwhile to say?

Accepting that some matters are beyond her pay grade, Aglaea pushes herself off the bed as quietly as she can. She makes it out the room in a few brisk steps, but just as she's about to close the door behind her, she hears it.

"What should I do?"

Aglaea looks back. Phainon is sitting up on the bed, still twisted up in his sheets.

"What should I do, Aglaea?" He asks again. His voice comes out terribly small and riddled with cracks.

The answer is to get dressed and head to sound check, but even with the distance and the awful lighting, Aglaea can see his hair matting from the build-up of grease. His two-day scruff has thickened into a patchy stubble, and half of his face sports deep imprints from where he'd been lying on the bed. He's wearing jeans and yesterday's undershirt, and not pajamas dyed in clashing colors or a graphic tee proudly displaying a children's mascot. Not even a jumper several holidays out of season.

…If Aglaea is willing, there is another answer she could give him. The problem is that it doesn't feel like the right time to enact her plans, but perhaps that may be the point.

"You should reach out to Mydeimos," Aglaea ultimately tells Phainon.

Phainon's eyes flicker ever so slightly, but he doesn't comment. Aglaea leaves the door open, taking it as a sign to continue. "I've been working on something for a while now," she confides in him. "There's no guarantee it will succeed. In fact, it'll be career suicide even if it does. The most I can say is that it *might* benefit you and your friend, provided that you can establish a line with him once more."

She holds off on the details for now, in case the trade-off is too severe for Phainon to commit to. Aglaea wasn't privy to what exactly transpired between him and Mydei, but she has a feeling Phainon's impulsive tendencies had been burnt out in the aftermath.

“We can discuss it further after the concert,” Aglaea says, checking her watch. “Right now I need you to wash up so I can take you to the venue. I can only stall for another hour at most. ”

“…How can I get Mydei to respond?”

Aglaea looks up at Phainon, who stares at her like she’s his last lifeline. She turns the question over in her mind, pondering over every possible outcome he had asked for. If she were Mydei, what would she want to hear?

“I don’t know,” Aglaea settles on at last. “But from what I reckon, love is anything but a one-way street.”

—

“You traded Garner for my Stilott and you’re *benching him*?”

The weekend is on the horizon once again, which makes today another Roboball Friday. Mydei and his friends would usually spend this time at their favorite sports bar, but with the preseason winding down, getting good seats is becoming a challenge. Now they pick one of their apartments to watch the game in, and since Mydei puts in the most effort to feed them, it’s often his place that wins the draft.

In exchange, Mydei forces everyone to go to the store with him beforehand. If they were going to empty out his kitchen every time, then the least they could do is carry his groceries.

“What? Argenti’s good,” Leonnius tells Ptolemy, swinging around a bag of celery to accentuate his point.

“He’s dogwater, dude,” Perdikkas says.

“Yeah but he was intercepting like crazy last match. This could be his redemption arc.”

“Of course he did well. They were playing a bigger court,” Ptolemy points out. “It was easier to go wide, but now he’s going to be stuck with tight one-v-ones, which he sucks at.”

“You don’t understand my vision.” Leonnius taps his own noggin.

“Half a point per pass on a player that averages three assists per game?” Hephaestion says.

“He literally bodies Stilott on passes, but go off.”

Mydei’s not sure how serious they are about this fantasy league of theirs. For starters, the teams are still playing exhibition matches.

Regardless, Mydei appreciates his friends’ banter. After all, a Roboball match is not the only event happening this Friday. The *Astral Fantasia Music Festival* also kicks off this weekend, which marks today as the actual 10 year anniversary of *Sun and Thunder*’s victory. Apparently, the *Marmoreal Arena* is too valuable of a booking to let go, so it’s been repurposed into a solo show. Ptolemy and Leonnius’s argument about strategic stacking makes it easier to tune out all thoughts of it.

The six of them make it to Mydei’s apartment with little incident. While everyone continues with their debate, Mydei reaches for his keypad before remembering that he changed the locks some time ago. Holding back a sigh, Mydei veers his course towards his pocket and pulls out his car keys, which is the wrong key, obviously. The key to his apartment must be in his back pocke- no? He doesn’t feel it in his jacket pockets either, and another pass in his jean pockets reveals that his house key is definitely not hiding in there.

“Are you sure it’s not in your wallet again?” Hephaestion asks.

“Try the inner lining of your coat,” Perdikkas advises. “I accidentally did that in an airport once, and I couldn’t figure out why the metal detector wouldn’t let me through.”

“Oh! Maybe it’s in the groceries,” Leonnius suggests as he starts rummaging through a bag of vegetables.

Mydei goes through all of his pockets, his pouches, the sleeves of his jacket, and even the insides of his socks and shoes. Each time the key fails

to come up, Mydei starts to feel worse and worse. Figgy is locked up in his apartment alone. Who knows if something happened to her?

“It’s probably in your car,” Hephaestion assures him. “Why don’t we go take look before you do something drastic?”

And so six men welcome Roboball Friday by scouring a car for a single key. They’ve decided to divide and conquer: two to check the trunk, two to check the back, and two to check the front. So far, they’ve made zero headway into their search.

“I found out you need to get a new spare tire,” Ptolemy says, closing the boot. “But apart from that, nothing.”

“Me too,” Peucesta calls out from the rear seats.

“Me three,” Leonnius says, crouching to look under the chassis.

“What time is it?” Perdikkas asks.

Leonnius checks his phone. “Uh, eight minutes to kick-off.”

Perdikkas instinctively sucks a breath through his teeth before catching himself. “I mean, aw nuts! That’s so much time left to wait!”

“It’s not that bad,” Hephaestion says as he closes the glove compartment. "No one’s going to score in the first ten minutes anyway.”

“Don’t jinx it!” Leonnius cries.

Hephaestion rolls his eyes and turns to Mydei. “Can we turn on your radio to listen to the game?”

“It’s fine if not,” Perdikkas adds. “It’s not the same without Dei’s chicken wings.”

“Play it,” Mydei orders Hephaestion. He’s on the floor checking under the driver’s mat when he should be calling for a maintenance guy. Missing the game would be the cherry-on-top of this shitshow.

Hephaestion complies. The radio opens with a burst of white noise that he hurriedly tries to fix.

“Just for the record, I wasn’t complaining about not seeing the game,” Leonnius pipes up.

“Be quiet and keep looking for that key,” Perdikkas grumbles.

Being in an underground garage, most of the radio channels come out as nothing but straight fuzz. It’s an unbearably awkward amount of static to be subjected to, so Hephaestion naturally pauses on the first channel they can actually decipher.

“*-so good to have you back with us, Phainon!*”

Hephaestion jumps.

“Turn that shit off,” Ptolemy immediately says, rushing to the car’s passenger side. “I’m sick of that interview.”

“You’ve heard this?” Hephaestion asks.

“Who hasn’t? The Tribios sisters have been replaying it for weeks,” Ptolemy says, disgusted. “He’s debuting a new song to promote his ‘new’ tour. The usual garbage.”

“A new song?” Perdikkas says. “That’s fast.”

Hephaestion frowns. “Did you know about this?” He asks Mydei.

“No,” Mydei answers.

Leonnius sputters. “You haven’t? But it’s- I mean-“

“*I see you have an acoustic guitar with you today,*” Tribbie’s voice floats from the radio. “*Something tells me we’re about to hear something really special!*”

Mydei's tinny car speaker makes Phainon's laugh sound uncharacteristically nervous. "*I was just messing around with something that was stuck in my head. I don't really know if I did it any justice.*"

"What a tool," Ptolemy remarks with a grimace. "Shut it off already, Hephaestion."

"No!" Leonnius interjects.

Ptolemy gives him an incredulous look. "What do you mean 'no'? You know the game's not going to be on this channel right?" He points out.

"Yeah I know, but like-" Leonnius's eyes dart around. "-What if I want to hear Phainon's new song?"

Perdikkas groans.

"What? I'm curious!" Leonnius says.

"Then look it up online," Ptolemy deadpans. "By yourself."

"What if, uh, what if I want us to make fun of it together?" Leonnius asks.

"Seriously dude, read the room," Perdikkas says.

"Alright, relax guys," Hephaestion intervenes, glancing at Mydei. "I'll switch the radio off. We can use someone's phone to keep updated with the game in the meantime, deal?"

Hephaestion reaches for the dials before anyone could object. Right as his finger touches down on the stereo, a hand shoots out from the back seat and stops him. Puzzled, Hephaestion turns to look at the perpetuator.

"He should listen to the song," Peucesta says.

A strange piece of advice, but Hephaestion has always prided himself on listening to his friends. That's at least two of them that wants to keep the radio on. Hephaestion gives Mydei another once-over and finds plenty to look at, chief among them being Mydei's waning will.

“I don’t care,” Mydei says, waving him off. “Do what you want.”

Nodding, Hephaestion retracts his hand and lets the radio play. If Peucesta ends up being wrong, he and Leonnius are going to pay it back in ab crunches.

“*-isn’t going in a new album either. I think. All I’m saying is that there’s nothing worth expecting yet.*”

“*Gee, a special song just for us,*” Trianne says dreamily. “*I’m on the edge of my seat thinking about it!*”

“*You heard her, Phainon. You better play that song before Trianne falls off her stool*,” Tribbie teases.

Phainon laughs again. “*Well we can’t have that happen, can we?*”

An tentative chord rings from the speakers, at odds with Phainon’s brazen words. The struck strings recoil with a dinky twang, as if Phainon’s fingers are struggling to find purchase on the fretboard. The sound is still there when he tries again, albeit less noticeable beneath his forceful strum.

For once, Mydei’s friends are quiet, allowing for Phainon’s song to play on without interference. There’s a million ways his new song could have sounded like, but never would Mydei have guessed it to sound familiar. Perhaps Krateros was right. Perhaps Mydei should have sold the song when he got the chance.

Instead, he lost it in a wager to Phainon. It’s almost a mercy that the song isn’t quite the same in the singer’s hands. The rhythm has been adjusted to accommodate Phainon’s predilection for down-picking, and although the melody has been left untouched, the chords have clearly been transposed a few keys up. The song strays like a game of telephone, a by-product of being remade whole cloth from memory. It’s kind to Mydei in the same way an axe is kind to a rotting tree.

It’s only once he opens his mouth that Phainon’s creative liberties take flight. Phainon is a shrewd man. He knows that words are where he shines

best, so a song without proper lyrics is a glorious windfall to him. With fanciful metaphors and a mellifluous voice, Phainon transforms an aimless half-cocked love song into a simple ballad about a nameless drifter. He sings about the perils of his fictional journey, as well as the wonderful places and people he comes across.

Despite the dangers and awe-inspiring sights, the drifter never pauses in his stride. His destination is more grand than anything along the way, you see, with golden skies and sweet tangerine trees. He dreams a dream that smells like a freshly cooked meal, sounds like rowdy guitar music, and has a habit of arguing with a doting smile. When he relays this to a kind samaritan, the drifter gets told that he missed his stop a long time ago. What he's searching is all the way back at the start of his journey.

Phainon sings of remorse and excuses. The drifter refuses to look back, afraid he'll only see the dangers he escaped. He reasons that as long as he keeps walking, the road will wind back home someday, not seeing how each step takes him further away from his goal. Thus, the foolish drifter continues to roam, his bones creaking as he goes. He imagines a tangerine rolling on the road in front of him, and as the song closes, the drifter carries on chasing after the fruit day after day after day.

"*Wowzers! That's such a good song, Phainon!*"

"No it isn't," Ptolemy disagrees with Trianne's pre-recorded comment. "*It's a stupid song.*"

"It's not stupid," Leonnius protests.

"Please. It's some hokey nonsense he threw together to sell tickets to teenagers. Noise pollution is more meaningful than this," Ptolemy says.

"You gotta admit it's a little catchy," Perdikkas remarks.

"Catchy isn't everything," Ptolemy sniffs. "We're friends with a literal songwriter. Mydei can write circles around this crap any day of the week."

Ptolemy leaves the perfect opening for Mydei to make a snarky statement, but Mydei can't. He's paralyzed by the fact that he blocked and deleted Phainon's number off of his phone forever. He doesn't have Phainon's e-mail because he never e-mailed him directly, and neither did he add him on social media or attempt to memorize his private mailing address. Going to his house is impossible because of the paparazzi stalking him, and he can forget all about going to Grove. Even Cyrene's contact details weren't spared in the aftermath.

"-di. Mydei!"

Hephaestion stretches out over the center console to shake Mydei out of it. "Are you alright? You were somewhere else for a second there."

"I-" Mydei swallows. There's no way for him to reach Phainon. He knows his favorite restaurants, he knows where his family lives, but-

"Hey!" Hephaestion snaps his fingers in Mydei's face. "What's going on with you?"

Someone wails. Surprisingly, it's not Mydei.

"I can't do it. I'm not cut out for this dude, I'm really not," Leonnius babbles, gripping onto his hair. "Mydei, man, I'm sorry. I love you, but I gotta tell them."

The furrow of Hephaestion's brow deepens. "Tell us what?"

"It's going to be another 'your mama' joke," Ptolemy says with a click of his tongue. "I get you want to lighten the mood Leonnius, but there's a time and place for ev-"

"I walked in Mydei and Phainon boning at his apartment," Leonnius blurts out.

A garbled squawk flies out of Ptolemy's mouth. "Excuse me?"

"I'm not making it up!" Leonnius stomps his foot on the ground. "I saw them for real! Like they were like, macking on each other and getting in

there and, and- and Mydei wouldn't stop making googly eyes at Phainon! And Phainon knew where Dei kept the glass containers! Like he packed me cookies and was really nice and he was like 'I'll shoot myself if I break Mydei's heart' and honest to Nikador, Dei was swooning!"

Everyone stares at Leonnius like he's a raving lunatic. Somewhere in the garage, a neighbor's footsteps can be heard speeding up, followed by the slamming of the basement doors.

"I believe it," Perdikkas eventually says.

"Thank you!" Leonnius exclaims.

"I don't know about the part with the cookies, but the nurses are always going on about Sun and Thunder," Perdikkas explains when everyone's questioning gaze turns to him. "They're convinced that these two are totally eye-fucking on stage, which I also thought was impossible until I saw the clips. We know Mydei can't act to save his life, so it's either Lee is right or the nurses are mindjacking me."

"Phainon did look tense when I met him," Hephaestion muses. "I'm still not completely sure what that was about."

"They went on a date to my recital," Peucesta adds.

Ptolemy's eyes flit between his friends, visibly taken aback by their testimonies. He turns to the source-"Mydei?"

The accused averts his gaze. "…Some of it might be true."

"How come I never found out?" Ptolemy asks, affronted.

Peucesta shrugs.

"You gotta get a clue sometimes, man," Leonnius says.

"To be fair, the nurses had me reading speculative fiction on my lunch breaks," Perdikkas tells him.

Hephaestion shakes his head. “We’re getting off track. Leonnius, does this have anything to do with the song we just heard?”

“I mean it’s just a hunch,” Leonnius says, bashfully scratching his neck. “With the timing and everything, it’s too suspicious *not* to consider. Like, I want to protect Mydei’s peace as much as the next guy, but if someone I knew for years and years wrote a song like that for me, wouldn’t I want to hear it?”

No one responds, allowing the question to settle like sand on the sea floor.

“At least to know that it’s over?” Leonnius clumsily concludes.

Leonnius’s heart is in the right place, but that doesn’t necessarily mean the song is meant for Mydei. What are the odds that Phainon would steal that particular song to dedicate it back to its original writer? It’s certainly within Phainon’s brand of insanity, but it’s also so ridiculous that it has to be wishful thinking.

If Mydei could only ask, he… he wouldn’t know what answer to hope for. The point of a clean break is that it can’t be taken back. It had been irreversible the moment Mydei called Phainon a coward, and it became unfeasible the very second they decided to get into music together. Trying to contact Phainon again would only be a lesson in humiliation, no matter if he did call for Mydei or not.

The hand on Mydei’s shoulder jostles him once again. He looks up at Hephaestion, who looks back not in ridicule, but with patience.

“You know, we Kremnoans don’t have a word for ‘regret’,” Hephaestion starts. “We only have that one saying.”

It takes Mydei a second to pick up on what Hephaestion is telling him. “… There is nothing impossible to him who will try.”

Hephaestion smiles. “Exactly.”

…Looking back, Mydei always gave into Phainon’s wishes too easily. Could it be possible that it’s what Mydei wanted too?

A sharp clap brings Mydei into the present. “That’s it then.” Ptolemy sighs. “Take out your car keys, Leonnius.”

“Hey!” Leonnius takes an immediate step away from him. “I get that I was speaking out of my ass just now, but we don’t have bring my baby into this.”

“For the love of- Connect the dots, you dolt,” Ptolemy says. He turns to look at Mydei, who’s still crouched on the ground. “Stand up already. You’ve got questions that need answering, don’t you?”

Despite common sense, despite everything that he has ever known as the truth, Mydei nods his head and gets to his feet.

—

Leonnius’s Mitsubishi Lancer Evolution X is fitted with a custom aero kit, 16 inch semi slick tires, and a modified 4 cylinder turbocharger. Its engine boasts a decent 1000 horsepower at 9800 revolutions per minute. Given optimal conditions, the car can hit 60 miles per hour in sub 4 seconds, reaching top speed before it could pass the next city block.

Currently, the car can be found hurtling down the backstreets of Marmoreal Lane, making use of the lesser known roads to launch unimpeded at full power. The resulting shock wave disrupts pedestrians and slower vehicles alike, a grievance that goes unseen by the car’s speeding driver.

“I think you can slow down,” Hephaestion suggests, holding onto the grab handles for dear life.

“We can’t,” Leonnius says. “The concert’s already half-way through!”

“Yes but, uh, it’s better to be late than dead, isn’t it?”

“That won’t happen,” Leonnius assures Hephaestion. “I learned a trick or two while I was in Edo Star.”

To prove it, Leonnius drifts his way through a sharp corner, his foot barely lifting off of the accelerator. The three bodies in the back slam into one another like a Newton's cradle, demonstrating the conservation of momentum and energy in a less pacifist manner.

"That cannot be legal," Ptolemy says from the safety of Peucesta's phone. He nobly volunteered to stay back to handle the locked door and the groceries, but he had to be kept on call in case the actual tenant needs to be alerted. With all the screaming happening in his ear, it's like Ptolemy never left them.

"I think we're fine as long as it's not on Sunset Road," says Perdikkas, who is also gripping desperately onto anything bolted into the car. "A single pothole could end us."

Hephaestion is not listening. His eyes are screwed tight as he prays. "Oh Nikador, righteous in your fury. Deliver us through this battle unharmed and of sound mind-"

As Leonnius's car continues to terrorize Okhema one quarter-mile at a time, Mydei stays remarkably silent in the passenger seat. Not out of fear, but out of contemplation. If or when they make it to the arena, Mydei will have to say something, and it has to be the best, most incredible set of words to have ever come out of his mouth.

"Oh no," Leonnius suddenly curses under his breath. "No, no, no, no, no."

The worst has come to pass. A traffic jam has caught up to them.

Leonnius groans as the car rolls to a stop at the tail-end of traffic. "I swear Luminosa's usually empty at this time!"

"It's parents coming to pick their kids up from the concert," Ptolemy theorizes. "They probably came early because they predicted this."

"And everyone keeps cutting in," Leonnius says. "Forget the concert, we're going to be stuck here until tomorrow!"

“Look for a subway station nearby,” Hephaestion wheezes, slumped over in the back seat. “Or a bike rental or something.”

“The nearest station is ten minutes away,” Perdikkas reads off of his phone. “And you’ll have to walk twenty more minutes once you get down near the arena.”

It beats sitting still. Mydei unclasps his seatbelt.

“Whoa, whoa, wait a second dude,” Leonnius tries to stall. “That’s still a long way to go.”

“I have to try,” Mydei says. “I’ll catch a cab once I pass the worst of it.”

“*If* you can get a cab,” Leonnius says, sharing the rare pessimistic thought. “We’re three lanes deep on the main road, someone stop him!”

At his request, one of the rear windows slides open before Mydei could unlock the door. Perdikkas pops his head out of the gap and begins to shout at full volume.

“Our friend’s father has gone into sepsis from acute cholangitis!” He screams to the cars ahead. “If we do not reach the hospital in time for the liver transplant, he will not make it past this evening!”

Hephaestion and Peucesta stare at Perdikkas with a scandalized malaise. As if Perdikkas isn’t getting enough of that from the cars around them.

Perdikkas takes a deep breath before opening his big mouth once more. “A father will die tonight-“

By some miracle, the cars in front of Leonnius gradually nudge themselves to the far side of their lanes, opening up enough space for a Mitsubishi Lancer to scoot past. Perdikkas showers everyone involved with thanks as the car shimmies by, like a bizarre parade for one.

“How are you going to explain this to your ethics board?” Ptolemy asks when Perdikkas’s head returns inside the car.

“I don’t know,” Perdikkas answers truthfully. “The hospital’s on the way though. If I clock in and see patients on overtime, do you think it would cancel out?”

“Why are you asking me?” Asks the philosophy professor.

“I think it’s going to be harder to explain to the police,” Hephaestion comments as they reach the front of the line.

“Hey if it all works out, we’ll have Amphoreus’s number one pop star to pay our bail,” Leonnius says.

“I can pay it myself,” Mydei mutters.

No one contests him on that, because Leonnius shifts gears shortly after and subjects everyone to an abrupt hike in G-force. Out of guilt, Perdikkas asks to be dropped off at the hospital first, which is still a preferable detour to an hour of traffic. He makes sure to wish Mydei good luck before he leaves, all while begging everyone else for video proof.

After much trial and tribulation, the car finally arrives at the front gates of the Marmoreal Arena with an ungodly screech. Mydei almost rips the door out of its hinges with how fast he gets out, only to hesitate a couple of steps away.

“What are you doing man?” Leonnius shouts when Mydei looks back. “Keep going!”

“We’ll catch up!” Hephaestion grunts as he sluggishly tries to free himself from the seatbelt.

Only Peucesta manages to get his foot on the ground, but only long enough to toss his phone over to Mydei.

“Look!” Peucesta urges, gesturing to his phone screen. “Look!”

The pianist turns to assist Hephaestion without further explanation. Mydei turns over the phone to see Ptolemy struggling with the locksmith, Figgy,

and the groceries. Underneath that, however, is a screenshot of an email. A VIP ticket to tonight's show.

Mydei jets off without saying goodbye, mentally promising to make it up to his friends after. Fortunately there aren't a lot of people still milling around the entrance, making it a breeze for Mydei to burst in and sprint right up to the ticket booth. The lady behind the window gives him a wary once-over when he shows her the ticket, either because of his late arrival, his suspiciously familiar appearance, or because of the tiny Ptolemy fighting in the corner. Either way, she validates his entry and directs him down the correct passage with minimum fuss.

The concert can be heard well enough outside, but it holds no candle inside the actual arena, where Phainon's voice reverberates from every corner of the venue. Mydei emerges from an entrance near the pit, and is instantly accosted by Phainon's face projected on a gigantic LED screen. It shows him belting out the first lines of *Recurrence*, a song that is almost always the penultimate number on Phainon's set-lists. Mydei made it with time to spare, but seeing Phainon's resplendent grin as a massive crowd sings his own song back to him is enough to make Mydei falter. It's not too late for Mydei to change his mind. Can he really bear the cost of his own actions?

As Phainon moves into the chorus, Mydei steps into the crush of people. It's remarkably packed for a last minute show, but Mydei *must* press on. Unlike the woman at the ticket booth, Phainon's fans are much more adept at recognizing Mydei, falling silent once they catch sight of the man. Most of them try to stay out of his way, but they make no attempt to hide their disapproval or shock. Nevertheless Mydei advances, stalking over to the front like a lion carving a path through the reeds.

Mydei is nowhere near the stage when a hand pulls him back.

"End of the line, little lion," a familiar voice says.

Cipher's sharp nails dig into his forearm. A warning. Contrary to what the news outlets say, Mydei isn't stupid enough to start a commotion with so many people clustered together. He relents at once.

The audience breathes a collective sigh of relief as Cipher escorts Mydei out of the crowd. Up on the stage, Phainon continues to sing and prance about, oblivious to the matters of the little people below.

Though quirky and daring in nature, Cipher excels at discretion. She leads Mydei through the less populated routes, forcing him to adopt her hurried pace when witnesses are unavoidable. She's a whole different woman when she's actually doing her job, but Mydei refuses to throw in the towel, holding on to the hope that the Cipher he knows is still listening.

"Let me see Phainon," Mydei says. "I just need a moment."

"Now who do you think I work for, Goldilocks?" Cipher tuts, pushing him down a long tunnel away from the performance area. "Do you think I've got the authority to bring any Joe Schmoe to our precious clientele?"

"I've got a premium ticket," Mydei argues.

"Then you can wait after the concert."

The sounds of the show fade as they make their way down the bright corridor, with only a faint thump from the bass to let them know the program still going. The further they get, the less there is to hear, and the closer they get to complete silence, the more Mydei worries. If he dislocates his shoulder, he can potentially break free from Cipher's hold, but there's no way he's outrunning her, nor can he fend her off with one arm down.

"I'll be quick," Mydei tries again. "I won't say it was y-*oof*!"

Cipher shoves Mydei through a door, causing him to careen off balance.

"Do me a favor and stay there," she says, dusting her hands off.

"Cipher, ple-"

The guard slams the door shut. Mydei rushes towards it, but she engages the locks before he could even try to leave. No matter how much he bangs his fist against the steel and pulls on the handle, the door stays put.

“Cipher! I’ll pay you if you let me back in!”

Why is he even trying to negotiate with someone that’s obviously not there? He should just book it back to the front gates. Mydei frantically turns around to get to the exit, only to find out that he’s trapped. He sees nothing but four walls and a single door, as well as excessively lit dressing tables and low couches and a clothing rack filled with flouncy costumes.

Mydei blinks. It’s a dressing room.

There’s a make-up case left open on one of the vanities, and in it is a collection of pale concealers and even paler mascaras. Hanging at the very end of the clothing rack, buried beneath finely co-ordinated ensembles, is a pair of unevenly dyed puce jeans. The jeans match the crossbody bag slung over one of the couches, though the little orange chimera hanging from the zipper is harder to style around.

This is Phainon’s dressing room, Mydei realizes. He sits down on the couch in a stupor, the adrenaline in his veins taking an abrupt nosedive. The world slows in the relative quiet of the dressing room, and Mydei is left with an opportunity to catch up with his thoughts. In moments like these, the general rule of thumb appears to be to follow your heart, and Mydei’s ratcheting heartbeat apparently doesn’t take kindly to the thoughts of what’s to come.

So Mydei fixates on the factors he *can* change, starting with what he’ll say when he finally sees Phainon. There’s still the final song and the encore to wait out, which is time that Mydei desperately needs. It’s not going to be easy to sway Phainon while summarizing the last 10 years in the same breath.

The bass gets louder in the distance as a poor sound technician fails to keep the audio from peaking, resulting in the speakers popping incessantly. It might even be a problem in the sound system itself, because the anomaly almost sounds like it’s isolated. Strangely, the way it pans over gives the impression that the sound is physically approaching Mydei. Each blow seems to echo out in the hall, as if it were diegetic rather than a part of the score. As if it were the footsteps of someone running tow-

Something bangs against the door. This something fumbles with the lock before shoving the door wide open with an obnoxious bang. Mydei hasn't gotten past the apology part of his monologue when Phainon bursts in, limbs splayed.

The two musicians lock eyes on each other as the door slowly swings shut behind Phainon. Neither of them move, twin deers caught in opposing headlights. Despite Mydei's brashness, it has always been Phainon who was the go-getter between them. It comes as no surprise that he's the first to attempt contact, opening his mouth to break the silence.

The singer hesitates, unfortunately, and his greeting is lost to history as Mydei lunges at him with a sucker punch.

Phainon lets out a yelp as he catches Mydei's arm in time, stopping him short of bruising his liver. Before he could question his attacker or ask for praise, another fist comes in to finish what its counterpart had started, forcing Phainon to tug at Mydei's arm to shake him off his aim.

The punch barely glances off of Phainon's collarbone, but Phainon has grown wiser in the last few seconds. He tackles Mydei before the man readies his next move, launching them both onto one of the couches. Phainon hits his shin as he knocks the wind out of Mydei, who immediately leverages his long legs to kick Phainon's actual ass. His flailing is a minor inconvenience, but it's enough of a distraction to overthrow Phainon, allowing Mydei to finally get a real punch in.

With a groan, Phainon rolls off the couch to avoid any more hits. He tries to trip Mydei with the flare, which is an impressive dance move to pull off but absolutely worthless in this fight. Not that Mydei is any more successful in his attempt to grab Phainon's spinning ankles. The stalemate ends when Mydei jumps and tries to get him with an elbow drop like the bastard he is. Phainon manages to roll out of the way by the skin of his teeth, but Mydei is never too far behind.

New plan then. Phainon fends Mydei off with tiny wimpy kicks as he inches backward to freedom. Later, when he's no longer fearing for his life, Phainon will cherish the memory of Mydei crawling towards him

disheveled and panting, with shiny trails of sweat leading down to where his shirt stretches over his cleavage. Until then, Phainon focuses on keeping Mydei at bay, waiting for an opening. As Mydei leaps up to grab his foot, Phainon swings his leg and sends a rack of clothing crashing down on him. Mydei swears up a storm as he tries to untangle himself from a mountain of costumes. He throws off the last piece of tulle once he gets off the floor, only for Phainon to clothesline him from behind with a single pair of pants.

With his arms restrained and Phainon pressed against his back, Mydei is left thrashing about for some leeway. Phainon grits his teeth and pulls with all his might, but fabric is at its weakest when taut. With a firm jerk of his shoulder, Mydei begins ripping through the crotch of Phainon's favorite jeans, which Phainon couldn't even mourn before Mydei rushes him.

Mydei wastes no time nailing Phainon with several fast jabs. After being on stage for 2 hours, Phainon isn't likely to win in a battle of stamina. Dodging and weaving would leave him more vulnerable in the end, so Phainon focuses on a better offense. Mydei's haymaker may have dealt significant damage to him and his ego, but it also allows for Phainon to slam a fist to Mydei's exposed flank. He chains it into a quick cross to Mydei's sternum, which staggers Mydei and leaves Phainon's knuckles faintly sore. His hand would have hurt more if Mydei's chest were any less pillowy, and this thought would come to cost Phainon a devastating punch to his stomach.

Phainon keels over with a groan. That cheater definitely wasn't holding back with that last hit. Before his knees could hit the ground, Mydei hauls the singer up by his glittery collar and glowers at him with the callousness of a lion confronting its prey. Accepting his fate, Phainon closes his eyes in anticipation of the final blow.

Then Mydei kisses him.

It's as light and sweet as the first rains of autumn. Phainon feels Mydei's lips purse against his as though to reassure him, purposeful in every way their first kiss was not. There existed no better panacea for Phainon's ails. He would tank another 30 million bodyslams if it meant Mydei would kiss him like this again, even if Mydei does pull away too soon.

“I love you,” Mydei tells Phainon.

A jolt of lighting runs through Phainon’s spine.

“I said it first,” Mydei continues breathlessly. “I win.”

It only takes a moment for the words to register as reality. Phainon can’t help but smile when it sinks in, the corners of his eyes crinkling in that beautiful way that Mydei has missed. He reaches out to take Mydei’s face in his hands, softly carding his fingers through tresses of gold.

“Then how come I feel like a winner?” Phainon asks.

Every win deserves a reward, so Mydei bestows Phainon with another kiss teeming with affection. This time Phainon is there to meet him, sliding their lips together where they fit the best. Admittedly it’s not as passionate as their other kisses, because neither of them could stop smiling long enough to escalate the proceedings. Instead, joy spills out between them in rivulets of laughter, no longer hidden under the cover of sarcasm or skepticism. Phainon proceeds to pamper Mydei’s face with adoring little pecks, and Mydei encourages him by crushing him adoringly in his embrace.

A loud argument outside puts a damper on the occasion. All Mydei wants is to bask in his lover’s undivided attention, yet here comes some scowling miser storming in with a phone in her ear.

“You ungrateful brat,” The woman spits out, pointing the phone at Phainon. “After everything we’ve done for you, you walk out on a show worth *millions* to play house with this cretin?”

“Don’t call him that, Caenis,” Phainon warns.

Caenis barks out a laugh in disbelief. “And you still have the gall to talk back? Juno and her granddaughter are in the audience tonight. You had *councilmen* wondering where you ran off to! In the middle of a show they paid good money for! You don’t get to say anything! You should be groveling on the floor begging me for forgiveness, you- you-“

She screams out an expletive too profane for someone of her standing to be so familiar with. It's so appalling that Phainon's expression drops from irritated to downright furious. All softness leaves his face at once. His eyes sharpen and his jaw tightens. He places himself between his superior and Mydei, intending to shield Mydei from a middle-aged woman half his size.

It takes more than a temper tantrum to scare her, but Caenis does flinch at the sight of Phainon's anger. She replies to his silent challenge with a scoff. "A mongrel like you should know better than to bite your master. Other people won't compensate you the way we do. They won't give you honest work or pay for dance and music lessons from accredited tutors. *We* are the reason for your success."

"No," Phainon flatly rejects her notion. "If that were true, then Lipos wouldn't be busking online to fund his tour. Misia would have released her debut album years ago, and Castorice and Polyxia wouldn't have to keep cancelling their live shows."

"So it's not easy to spot when someone's got potential," Caenis remarks. "It makes it more impressive that we scouted you so early."

"The previous management scouted me," Phainon corrects her. "And they weren't even entirely sure I could sing until Mydei came along."

Hearing his name reminds Caenis of Mydei's presence. She sneers in his direction. "How convenient for you, Mydeimos. I knew we should have turned down that reunion. Nothing good ever comes out of associating with your breed."

It's either she's confident in a fight or she's trying to be a martyr, because there's no way she doesn't see Phainon shaking with rage. Mydei keeps a hold on his arm just in case, but his own patience isn't limitless either.

"Is that you, Caenis?" Someone calls out from behind the door. "I thought I smelled something rotten nearby."

Mydei didn't think it was possible, but Caenis's frown deepens at the sound of that voice. Aglaea slips into the room with effortless poise, completely

unfazed by the ridiculous line-up before her.

“This is your doing,” Caenis condemns the new arrival. “You’re behind this charade, aren’t you?”

Aglaea ignores her tirade. “Hello, Mydeimos. It’s nice to see you here.”

“It’s, uh, nice to see you too,” Mydei says.

“I hope you stay for good this time,” Aglaea says. “Some of us missed you more than others, you know?”

“Thank y-“

“Have you gone mad?!” Caenis cuts Mydei off to continue screaming at Aglaea. “Your position is on the line if you don’t get that whelp back on stage this instant!”

“Hm. I think you’ll find that Phainon can do anything he wants, actually,” Aglaea says.

Caenis shoots her a withering glare. She jabs Aglaea with her phone. “*You*. You’ve spoiled that boy far enough. Get this concert back on track or you’ll be sorry!“

Aglaea holds a piece of paper right up in Caenis’s face. “Tell me what this says.”

Caenis is thrown off for a second, but her annoyance recovers once she takes a proper look at the document. “You’re a madwoman,” she tells Aglaea.

“Go on. Tell us the contents,” Aglaea presses.

“You’re trying to intimidate me with Phainon’s contract,” Caenis says, rolling her eyes. “If you’re implying I don’t know his terms, then you’re dumber than you look.”

“So you’re aware this says that Phainon can take a break whenever he needs?”

“You’ve simplified it,” Caenis says. “It says that Phainon won’t be held responsible for his medical emergencies. Which this *isn’t.*”

“Well done,” Aglaea congratulates her. “You’ve proven my point.”

She points a manicured finger at a word. *Phainon*.

“You see, some towns are too small and too isolated to have a proper council hall, so people are often forced to get their papers done at a city state,” Aglaea explains. “It’s a troublesome process. Grove had to help Phainon get registered as a citizen, remember?”

Caenis narrows her eyes. “Are you accusing us of forgery?”

“Not at all,” Aglaea says, shaking her head. “But three years ago there was an initiative to update the national census, and part of that meant establishing registries specific to our provincial towns. People no longer have to travel far just to be mislabelled as an Okheman or a Corinthian. Like any good taxpayer, Phainon registered as soon as the new system was implemented. Everything stayed the same as his Okheman papers, save for his name-“

“-Khaslana,” Mydei completes her sentence.

Phainon used to talk about it all the time when they were kids. *Grove* had mistaken his nickname for his given name and put it on his official documents, but he didn’t know how to correct them or if it was even possible to. When Mydei laughed, Phainon would huff and say that his new name suited him better anyway. If you ask Mydei, both names fit Phainon’s eccentricity just fine, but neither captured him half as well as ‘Phangry’ did.

Caenis stares at the contract in horror, the implications of Aglaea’s words dawning on her. Aghast, she turns to Aglaea, and with a quiver of her lip, bursts out laughing.

“You have to be kidding me,” Caenis says between wheezes. “*This* is the best you can do? A minor technicality about legal names? *Ha*!”

The concept of it is so hilarious that Caenis can’t go one word without cackling. She continues to laugh until she’s dry heaving from the exertion. As Caenis wipes the last of her tears from her eye, the contempt in her expression returns.

“His Okheman records will suffice,” she states in a clipped tone. “No matter if it’s today or ten years ago, everything he signs as Phainon is still legally binding. Stick to posting pictures and playing dress-up, Aglaea. Don’t get arrogant because you had an idea for once in your life.”

Mydei squeezes Phainon’s arm when he feel him jerk forward. As much as he wishes to let go and watch Caenis answer to consequences, the last thing Aglaea needs right now is to be an accessory to murder.

The publicist lets out a weary sigh. “I suppose we’ll lose if we were to take this to trial,” she says.

Caenis smirks. “Don’t waste your breath flattering me now.”

The door opens once more, perhaps answering to Mydei’s call for divine intervention. Anaxa is an alright substitute, Mydei supposes, but he doesn’t like how Caenis maniacally grins when she sees him.

“Perfect timing, Anaxa,” Caenis says. “Get Phainon back out there and call the security to handle the miscreant behind him.”

“Stop insulting Mydei,” Phainon snarls.

Mydei is man enough to admit that Phainon defending him so zealously is making his toes curl, but he’d rather not have everyone’s attention on them at a time like this. The room is so crowded and thick with tension that the 5 foot tall Hyacine can’t find the space to get in. Instead she stands outside keeping the door propped open, eyeing the toppled clothing rack in worry. She’s quick to offer Mydei an encouraging smile from across the room, which she follows with a noncommittal shrug.

“The concert was already nearing its end, so we called it early,” Anaxa informs Caenis. That explains the commotion of busy workers outside. “Naturally there are people who are unhappy with the decision. Callictis wants a word with who’s responsible.”

Caenis dramatically motions to the rest of the room’s occupants. “Take your pick. You won’t believe the preposterous things I’ve heard!”

Anaxa glances at Aglaea. “I can imagine.”

Aglaea crosses her arms, possibly the first sign of vexation she’s shown so far.

“Repeat what you just told me,” Caenis orders Aglaea with a snap of her fingers. “Enlighten Anaxa with the brilliant plan you’ve concocted.”

“We are planning to sue you for using the wrong name on Phainon’s contracts,” Aglaea says curtly.

Caenis lets out another grating titter.

“Yes, it’s very silly of me,” Aglaea concurs. “It’s such an obvious case that the prosecution might investigate a little deeper out of boredom. It’s possible they’ll even discover something about where Grove’s assets are going.”

The laughter fades.

“If we’ve been getting Phainon’s name wrong this whole time, what other things have been slipping through our fingers?” Aglaea says. “What has our manpower been so occupied with that we haven’t been able to factcheck this important detail?”

“These are the ramblings of a desperate woman,” Caenis retorts. Her smug smile is yet to be impacted, though it no longer reaches her eyes. “You would have brought this up sooner if you had real proof.”

“I was waiting for the proof,” Aglaea says. She holds her hand out. “Anaxagoras, if you please.”

At her cue, Hyacine digs in her tote bag and pulls out a manila folder to pass to Anaxa, who places it onto Aglaea's waiting palm. Caenis gawks at the entire exchange.

"Let's see what we have here." Aglaea adjusts her glasses as she peruses the contents. "Balance sheets, market analyses, minutes from a stockholder meeting… Even our customers' private information? For shame, Caenis."

Caenis swipes the files from Aglaea's grip. "You'd bring the company's sensitive data to a concert just to *frame me*?!" She yells.

"Of course not, we're not morons," Anaxa says. "It's just the evidence of your collusion."

In her hands, Caenis finds printouts of e-mails and private text messages, as well as detailed calculations of *Grove*'s deficits. Each document is so disparate from the last that it should come off as nonsense, and yet it only makes the common denominator all the more conspicuous.

"The problem with having so many advocates is that you get dimwits soliciting your inner circle to anyone, anywhere," Anaxa lectures. "After the fourth idiot that 'surreptitiously' approached me, I decided that I might as well do some research of my own."

Further in the folder are photos of familiar faces in close quarters with foreign businessmen. They appear innocent enough, taking place in parks or bars that are too public for illicit backdoor transactions, but there are only so many times they can be photographed together before it stops being coincidence.

"I assumed you and your co-conspirators might be peddling information to our competitors," Anaxa continues. "But your role in Grove is too high to risk for a quick buck. You were already gutting our workforce and recanting your support for acts like Sun and Thunder, so sabotage was my second guess. Without motive however, I was unconvinced."

"Fortunately it was simple to deduce once I identified your brokers," Aglaea says. "You've been in correspondence with the IPC music group,

haven’t you?”

Mydei frowns. The IPC’s record label is one of the biggest music enterprises in the world. To be affiliated with them suggests power, but *Grove Records* lack the international market to make any use of it.

“The IPC have been looking to expand their music division towards this side of the Quanta Sea,” Anaxa reveals, solving that riddle. “Acquiring a previously established company would be better than starting from scratch, and you were always pushing Grove to be more than an independent label. Not a popular stance within our company, but that won’t stop you.”

The open door has begun to attract curious passer-by’s, though urgent matters dissuade them to stay. Only a couple of make-up artists have stopped to line up behind Hyacine, appearing happy to wait as Anaxa shares his findings.

“You started with the people you could influence and built up alliances from there,” Anaxa says. “Then you fed the IPC shares and insider information to maintain their interest, and when that wasn’t enough, you tried slashing the buying price in secret. If you curtail Grove’s long term value while leaving the shareholders’ equity intact, you could also shake the executive board’s confidence without implicating yourself. A flawless gambit, had you not panicked when Sun and Thunder started gaining traction.”

It was an overwhelming amount of information to be thrown with at once, and Anaxa’s stringent manner of speaking left no room for questions. Caenis’s oppressive air had shriveled up under its pressure, leaving behind an icy silence.

Caenis calmly raises her head.

“It sounds plausible,” she says, stuffing the documents back in its folder. “For something that can’t be proven. You made loose connections and assumed my thoughts, but nothing I see here is worth calling a crime. You’ll only turn everyone against each other if you turn this in, and we’ve already got plenty of that at work.”

“To be honest I wanted to wait until you’ve progressed further in your plan,” Aglaea admits. “I’d feel safer if I identified all your allies first.”

“Suspect me all you want. My conscience is clear,” Caenis says.

At that, Aglaea smiles. “But we’re not targeting you, remember?”

“I’m targeting Grove,” Phainon says.

Caenis whips her head towards Phainon, already beyond tired of his insolence. Luckily for her, Aglaea speaks first.

“Grove claims Phainon’s contract is valid, but Phainon disagrees,” Aglaea reminds Caenis. “It wouldn’t make for a thrilling trial, but imagine how it would sound, for an accomplished Okheman company to deny a boy from the hinterlands the right to his own name.”

Though her blank expression doesn’t budge, Mydei can see Caenis’s fingers twitch erratically.

“Think of the headlines from that one fact alone,” Aglaea says. “The media loves an underdog, almost as much as Amphoreus loves Phainon. News outlets would scavenge for details until they find everything Anaxagoras told you, and if you’re lucky, your supporters won’t abandon you immediately. The IPC would certainly drop you right away to extricate themselves from your mess.”

More stagehands and members of the crew have gathered by the door, likely wondering where their organizers have gone. What they find probably doesn’t help their confusion, yet it’s satisfying all the same.

Aglaea circles Caenis like a vulture in wait. “The worst will come once they discover your part in Sun and Thunder’s demise,” Aglaea predicts. “That’s the project Phainon personally financed, and his record label culled it just like that. What does it imply for Grove’s reputation as a nurturing environment for artists? If their biggest star can’t determine his own career, then what of the rest? Firing you wouldn’t be enough to fix the blow to their image. Grove might even end up suing you themselves.”

Scorn radiates from Caenis's entire being. "That's nowhere near enough to win you the lawsuit," she says.

Aglaea grins. It's probably the most emotion she has ever shown. "The underdog loses to a money hungry corporation. Riots take to the streets."

The folder in Caenis's hands crumples in her grip.

"We may stand no chance of winning in court," Aglaea agrees, tucking a perfectly coiffed curl behind her ear. "But can you win against me in the court of public opinion?

"You bitch," Caenis lashes out. She backs away from Aglaea, as if disgusted by the mere sight of her. "You lying bitch! You're a hypocrite! Why do you know about being the underdog? You were born in the lap of luxury! You talk like you're above us, so condescending and ignorant. You're nothing but a miserable sow, you stupid fucking cu-AGH!"

Caenis goes down with a yelp as she trips backward over the fallen rack of costumes. The crowd outside lets out a collective gasp.

Hyacine winces. "I was worried that was going to happen."

"You can check on her if you like," Anaxa says.

Hyacine replies with an unimpressed stare.

"Very well." Anaxa points to the security guards snooping with the rest of the backstage crew. "You there. Don't you have any protocols for this kind of scenario?"

The guards sheepishly scratch their heads, but they agree that they can't leave a woman shrieking on the floor of a performer's dressing room. They ultimately step in to restrain Caenis, which gets one of them thwacked in the process.

"There's no more money in Amphoreus!" Caenis shouts as she gets dragged away. "We need to secure foreign cash flow while we still can! We already imported the atrocious drivel they call music, so why stop there?!"

She continues to screech until her voice goes hoarse. It's anyone's guess as to where she would be taken to, though another lockable room would be the safest guess. Hyacine wonders if she should still dial the authorities if there are already members of the council present at the scene. Anaxa would much rather pit the incident on the councilmen directly, to watch them squirm if nothing else.

While everyone else attempts to resolve that fiasco in their own way, Aglaea turns to Phainon and Mydei. "I'm sorry you had to see that," Aglaea says.

"I'm sorry you had to go through whatever that was," Mydei replies.

Aglaea shrugs. "The price of doing business in Okhema, I'm afraid."

"Thank you so much for doing this, Aglaea," Phainon says. "I can't stress how much I owe you. And Anaxa. And Hyacine."

"And me," Cipher says as she pops out of nowhere. "Don't forget me."

"And sure, you." Phainon acknowledges Cipher by happily hooking an arm around her shoulders. His camaraderie is received with a hiss and a scratch.

Mydei regards the people mentioned and their strange preparedness, and though he's learned a lot over the past hour, he can't say he understood what any of it means. Phainon is the first to notice Mydei's daze, his ecstatic grin clouding with worry when Mydei doesn't snark about Cipher catching him off-guard.

"What's the matter?" He asks Mydei. "Is it something Caenis said? Tell me while I can still catch up to her, because I think I'll be okay with hitting an elderly woman."

"I'm not fragile," Mydei automatically defends himself. "I was thinking."

How much of this operation was premeditated, Mydei wonders. It was impressive how everything came together, especially considering that Mydei didn't know he'd be making a trip to the *Marmoreal Arena* until a

few hours ago. Did they plan on someone gatecrashing the concert, or is everyone that good at improvising?

Phainon presses his thumb over the bridge of Mydei's nose and smooths down the creases between his brow. "Could I help?" He offers.

A thousand questions clamors for Mydei's attention.

"What now?" Is the one that he chooses.

Phainon looks at him in the same way Figgy does when Mydei pretends to throw her ball. "Elaborate?"

"Are those accusations real? Wouldn't it be trouble for Grove?" Mydei says.

Phainon clicks his tongue at Cipher. "You didn't tell him anything?" He asks her.

"Why? Do I get a bonus if I do?" Cipher shoots back.

"These are real charges," Aglaea clarifies for Mydei. "You're correct in that they'll effect us, but not as much our inaction would."

If Aglaea and Anaxa hadn't raised this issue, then *Grove* would have continued on a downward spiral until it gets acquired by a foreign conglomerate for cheap. It could be a boon for *Grove*'s employees if the IPC were planning to keep everyone, but they're more likely to treat the company as an extension of their global distribution rather than a source of music and artists.

Still, it sounds like the issue goes deeper than one woman with an apparent grudge against Aglaea. Putting a target on their backs won't make for the best working environment, and Phainon's team was already burdened with office politics before this.

"Grove's gonna have bigger fish to fry anyway," Cipher says with a shrug. "They practically got nothing going on without their precious Deliverer."

Mydei frowns. “Why wouldn’t they have Phainon?”

“Because he’s leaving the label? Duh?”

Contrary to Phainon’s imagination, Mydei does not jump in joy upon hearing the news.

“Are you crazy?” Mydei questions the pop star, eyes wide with consternation.

“I mean it was pretty much implied when I said I was suing them,” Phainon explains in a panic. He turns to scowl at Cipher. “Why’d you say that?”

Cipher throws her arms up. “I don’t say anything, you’re pissed. I say something and you’re still pissed! What’s a girl gotta do, mime?”

“Help Hyacinthia out please,” Aglaea strongly suggests to Cipher. “It appears Anaxagoras is starting his celebrations early.”

“Wh- Oh come on.”

Cipher grumbles, but obediently walks over to where Anaxa is busy provoking 3 different people at the same time. She’s subtle with it, but Aglaea massages her temples when she catches a snippet of Anaxa’s argument. Compared to that, mediating between Phainon and Mydei is a breeze.

“Phainon isn’t planning to sue Grove for money,” Aglaea says, sighing. “He’s suing so he can nullify his contract earlier, hence the need to incite a public outcry.”

“I thought it was only a threat,” Mydei admits.

His last conversation with Phainon is not a pleasant memory. Mydei still stands by what he said, but he’s looked back on it with so much regret that he sometimes wishes he thought differently. It was stupid of Mydei anyway, to criticize *Grove*’s obsession with control only to turn around and dictate the way Phainon should live his life.

But Phainon apparently exists to oppose Mydei, because he changed his mind too. “I had time to think it over,” Phainon says. “And no matter how I looked at it, you were right. I could do better than sit around and wait for change.”

That’s great, but it didn’t mean Phainon was wrong when he said it was going to cost him. Mydei did some pondering of his own too, and when faced with the options, he’d rather Phainon be secure in his success than left unmoored in the music industry.

“You can’t handle downsizing,” Mydei tells him.

“Says who?” Phainon asks with a smile. “It’s not like I came out with a number one hit right out of the gate.”

“That was a lifetime ago,” Mydei claims. “Look at Sun and Thunder. The only reason it was pitched was to be a money pit.”

Phainon snorts. “Now who said that?”

“Your manager did, about a minute ago.”

“What? He did not!”

“He implied that the reunion was only possible with Caenis’s support,” Mydei says, crossing his arms.

“Hmm, I see the confusion,” Aglaea says. “It’s true that Caenis was one of the people who pushed for the project, but she was not responsible for it nor did she come up with the idea. I’m shocked no one’s told you the full story.”

Mydei shakes his head. “This was the first time I’ve seen her.”

Aglaea chuckles. “Not that. Don’t you know? You’ve worked with a board member’s wife before. Apparently you impressed her, and not long after we received a directive to start planning for Sun and Thunder’s comeback. Short-sighted people tried denying that board member’s orders, but it was futile. Her word was law.”

“And even if Sun and Thunder was engineered to fail,” Phainon cuts in. “We didn’t. The reason Caenis had to back out was because we were too successful.”

“Thanks to Aglaea,” Mydei argues.

“Thank you, Mydeimos,” Aglaea says.

Phainon pouts. “Yeah, well, even if we didn’t have Aglaea and we failed and became Amphoreus’s biggest investment failure, I would still make the same decision. It would just take longer without you to knock some sense to me.”

The way Phainon’s voice pitches low is sickening. Suddenly, Mydei is startlingly aware of his proximity to Phainon, and how difficult it would be to explain to the plethora of stagehands trickling into the room. Mydei tries retreating to a polite distance, but Phainon won’t have it, scuttling along with every step Mydei takes. He has to be kicked to be discouraged from Mydei’s personal space.

“It’s alright, Mydeimos,” Aglaea assures him. “If anyone here has anything to say about you two, they’ll answer to me.”

“I think you’re one that’s making him shy,” Phainon says. That earns him another kick.

“Me?” Aglaea echoes. “But I adore love. I think it’s beautiful that two people can find each other in spite of the chaos in the world. I would never hold it against anyone for indulging in it when they can.”

“You hear that?” Phainon asks. With a firm tug, he pulls Mydei back squarely into his arms. “No more excuses. You’re the one who said I should take what I want with my own hands, so be kind to me and stay right here from now on, okay?”

And of course Mydei makes the mistake of looking into Phainon’s glittering eyes as he speaks. “…Hm.”

“Maybe it wouldn’t hurt to tone it down a bit,” Aglaea deadpans when Phainon buries his head into Mydei’s neck.

“I know, it’s- *hehe*- Uh, I’m sorry b- *ahaha*!“ Mydei struggles to go three words without Phainon sending him into a giggling fit.

A loud flash goes off by the door. Phainon at least has the decency to stop and allow Mydei the chance to identify the culprit.

“Fuck,” Leonnius swears, phone pointed straight at the men of the hour. “I meant to take a video.”

“Excuse me.” Anaxa pauses his current quarrel to switch victims. “This area is off limits to reporters.”

“Oh no, we’re not reporters,” Hephaestion quickly intervenes. “We’re Mydei’s friends!”

Leonnius and Peucesta book it before Hephaestion could finish explaining. The two make it a quarter of the way down the hall before Cipher intercepts them with a tackle.

Mydei winces at their screams. “I need to sort that out,” he says.

This time when he pulls away, Mydei makes sure to grab onto Phainon’s hand to keep him from getting the wrong idea. It’s unclear how long Mydei would have to put up with this, but he doesn’t see himself complaining for a long, long while.

“Go save your friends,” Aglaea tells him. “But once you’re done there, I need to have another word with you.”

Mydei looks back at her. A touch of seriousness hardens her features once more, but Phainon’s hand in his lessens the sting of whatever bad news it could be.

“No need to be wary,” Aglaea says, the corner of her mouth raising by a hair. “There’s just an offer that I’d like to make.”

—

There was a rumor that the music room was haunted, but by what, no one can say. Some people claimed to hear wailing and scratching coming from inside the walls, while others spoke of a honking noise coming from the instruments themselves. Mydei didn't have the luxury of choosing a non-haunted music room, so it didn't matter what poltergeist made its home there as long as it let Mydei work in peace.

Mydei underestimated how much of a problem it would be. How was anyone going to get work done with so much weeping and sobbing going on?

With a frustrated groan, Mydei got up from the piano and tracked where the sobs were coming from. The sound led him to the corner where they dump the extra equipment, and with a strong kick, Mydei displaced a pile of music stands to reveal the resentful spirit taking its revenge on him.

Oh, it's the gloomy kid. Figures. Maybe he'd stop being gloomy if people called him something else, but it's not like Mydei could figure out a better name for him. The boy looked up at Mydei with his teary eyes wide with shock, a line of snot smeared all the way up to his cheek. Mydei felt bad for him, but the kid also needed to know that this was not the best place for privacy.

"Stop crying," Mydei said. "You're not the only one who needs this room."

The boy sniffled. Drat, that's not what Mydei wanted. He tried desperately to think of a way to calm the kid down, but he couldn't muster any comforting words fast enough. Mydei gave up and braced himself for more bawling, only to be shot a scorching glare.

"Like you were doing anything important," the boy spat out.

That took Mydei aback, and any patience he had quickly evaporated.

"I'm writing a song for my mom," he said bluntly. "She's in the hospital because her lungs are failing."

The boy blinked at him. If he wanted a reason to cry, then by hook or by crook Mydei would give him one.

“Well, um, your song is stupid,” the boy countered. “Who wants to hear a sad song when they’re already sad?”

Mydei could pummel this kid, but he had a point.

Fist clenched, Mydei forced himself to leave this lost cause to his tears. He stomped over to the piano, where he would sit unmoving in silence for the better part of an hour. The other boy sniffed and rustled around in the meantime, but it was nowhere as distracting as his previous waterworks.

Eventually the boy got up. He was padding towards the exit when a clumsy melody began to play from the piano. It sounded childish, probably due to who was composing it, but it was also kind in an awkward sort of way. Every note resolved predictably, like it endeavored so hard to be reassuring that it looped back to being patronizingly trite.

When it ended, Mydei turned to the boy with his chin jutted out in challenge. The boy huffed.

“I liked the last song better,” the boy said.

Mydei frowned. “You said it was bad.”

“No I said it was sad! All you had to do was make it go up at the end.”

“Go up what?”

“I don’t know. You’re the piano player.”

These were terrible instructions. Nevertheless, Mydei replayed the song he’d been busy composing prior, but with the ending revised so it went ‘up’.

The boy hummed in thought. “Now it sounds kinda weird.”

“Yeah, because you told me to make it weird.”

“You have to make the rest match too,” the boy said matter-of-factly as he walked over to where Mydei sat. “Like keep it moving the same, but have all the last parts go up.”

“So stupid.”

The boy pouted. “Play it and see if it’s stupid!”

Mydei obeyed. He fiddled with the notes until they sounded coherently ‘up’, and eventually got to somewhere far more pleasing than either of them expected.

“It’s okay,” Mydei said. “But now it doesn’t go with the rest of the song.”

“How does it go?” The boy asked, plopping himself down on the stool beside Mydei. “I bet you can just do the same thing again.”

“I can’t because it sounds like this.” Mydei played him another sample.

“Hmm, it kinda sounds like a song that my uncle likes. Try making it sound like bup-bup-bup.”

“I don’t want to rip off a song.”

“It’s called being inspired.”

“… It doesn’t sound bad. It might sound better over here though.”

“Wow. You can actually play the piano!”

“What do you think I’ve been doing, butthead?”

“For your information, my name is *Phainon*. Now, let me hear everything we’ve got so far!”

—

Mydei’s breath fogs over in the evening air.

Winters in Castrum Kremnos almost never see snow, so Mydei had to take a look for himself when he caught wind of the weather report. He got outside too late to watch it happen, but there it is, a thin blanket of white draped over the streets of his hometown. With only a handful of people out at this late hour, the snow sits pristine and undisturbed, inviting in its perfection. It shimmers delicately under the lamp lights, tiny crystals mirroring the myriad constellations twinkling in the night sky.

A noise alerts Mydei of someone approaching from behind. Mydei turns to see a head of yellow bobbing towards him, fine snow crunching beneath the man's boots.

"There you are," Phainon says with an exasperated sigh. "You should really put on more layers before you step out in this weather."

Mydei scoffs. His leather jacket is already doing a good job of keeping him well-heated. Besides- "I wanted to cool down."

The bar was too stuffy, with its low ceilings and its legion of regulars. Mydei found it perfect for the weather, so warm and snug and full of life. Their tiny stage sat close to the drinking and dancing, allowing Mydei to revel in the warmth of the crowd's cavorting bodies while he and Phainon sustained them with music. It may have gotten too much by the end of the set, but it's an easy fix with nights like this.

"Yeah well, there are better ways to get some air," Phainon grumbles, unwinding the scarf around his neck. "Did you even try to wipe your sweat off at all?"

"I won't get sick," Mydei swears.

Mydei may run hotter than the average person, but that doesn't make him any better with the cold. Phainon feels like the only person who's aware of his low tolerance, and he almost looks forward to when Mydei is reminded of it in the morning, when he's bundled up and shivering in Phainon's arms.

But Phainon hates the thought of Mydei's discomfort even more. So he wraps his scarf around Mydei's head and takes care to not snag on his

piercing when he covers his ears.

Mydei lets out a Scrooge-like harrumph, appropriate for the time of year. His cheeks redden too, and out of kindness Phainon pretends it was the cold snap that did it.

“Are you implying that you can handle this weather better than me?” Mydei questions.

Phainon can’t imply something that’s already fact. “Unlike you, I checked the weather app before leaving the motel,” Phainon says, pulling out heat packs and hand warmers from his coat.

Mydei sneers at Phainon’s superior foresight. “I’ve got a better way of keeping warm.”

“What c- Oh, you asshole.”

Before Phainon could ask, Mydei had taken off running, knowing full well that Phainon’s instincts would have him following suit without thinking twice. A part of Phainon’s brain dutifully stays behind reciting the logistics of their equipment - whether it’s back in their van and in good condition - while another curses Mydei for securing an unfair head start.

The rest of Phainon waxes poetic about the man in front of him, about his long strides and his composed running form. Mydei’s jacket flies up in the wind and exposes his exquisite back, his muscles flexing with each powerful step. He laughs haughtily to provoke Phainon and then he glances back because he can’t help himself. Yes, Phainon is still running after him, and yes, Phainon is taking care not to slip on the ice.

Even Mydei’s deviousness is a thing of beauty. Years of knowing each other, and Mydei still finds a way to keep Phainon on his toes. He can still make Phainon’s heart somersault at his behest, the little lion tamer that he is. As Mydei runs under the colonnade of streetlights, blinking in and out of sight each time he treads into the dark, Phainon’s heart squeezes with the loss and rejoices when he returns. Mydei has made him into a fool. A happy, easily-indulged fool.

Suddenly, Mydei stops running. That’s the advantage of being the one to start the race, you also get to be the one who decides when it’s finished. Phainon reaches him ready to complain when a freezing droplet lands upon his nose and stops him dead in his tracks.

A flurry of snow falls from the sky in gentle waves. The snowflakes take their time coming down, appearing to float in the air like in one of those novelty globes occupying Phainon and Mydei’s shelves. It’s even colder now, definitely beyond what Mydei can handle, and yet he’s in no hurry to seek shelter.

Beside him, Phainon runs a hand through his hair to shake off the frost. The hair dye is convenient, because otherwise Mydei might have lost him in the snow. Phainon is currently working through the hair dye section of their supermarket from lightest to darkest, and right now he’s touting a spiky bright yellow hairdo. Not yellow as in blond, but yellow as in neon. It’s a shade of highlighter that would have been prohibited at school, but Phainon is way too pleased with how it looks. He’s obviously looking forward to get to the more outrageous colors, and Mydei had been too, until he realized that Phainon is devilishly handsome in everything. It’s really difficult to poke fun at his partner sometimes, but never say Mydei never tries.

Aglaea dreads it though, and she makes no secret of it. As the head of a brand new talent agency, Aglaea is under tremendous pressure to turn a profit soon, and it would help if her artists aren’t a perm away from a perpetual clown wig. Before he could get within a meter of a salon, Aglaea forced Phainon to present his case formally, with full presentations and case studies to support his rhetoric. Needless to say Phainon won, and now he walks around looking like a warning to incoming drivers. Mydei suspects Aglaea had planned to give in anyway, because she began consulting Phainon about their clients after that incident. Whatever she plans with him seems to be years or decades into the future, and when Mydei pesters him about it, Phainon bashfully smiles and brings up the classes he’s been taking.

“You sure like snow, huh?” Phainon says.

Mydei side-eyes him. He’s not giving into Phainon’s trap that quickly.

Instead Mydei says, “That volcano I told you about-“

“-The Great Forge,” Phainon quickly completes, always eager to prove his excellent listening skills.

“…Yes, that. If we’re lucky we’ll get to see it on the way to Janusopolis,” Mydei tells him. “And if we’re unlucky we’ll get an example of what makes it so great.”

Mydei holds out his hand to catch the falling snow. “The Forge’s ashfall is as magnificent as it is destructive,” Mydei says. “This snow is probably the closest I’ll get to seeing it again.”

Phainon looks up at the sky, trying to picture what Mydei had described. He imagines it would appear as dark, with volcanic smog rising up to blot out the sun. Nowhere as serene, probably, but maybe as wondrous.

“Are you sure you don’t want to write the lyrics for our next album?” Phainon asks Mydei.

Mydei grimaces.

“Maybe you can start with a chorus,” Phainon suggests. “Help me like I help you.”

“You talk plenty for the both of us,” Mydei says. “But who knows what we’ll write next.”

Phainon and Mydei’s last album was country rock. The one before that was ska jazz, and further back was a little electric bossa nova. There’s been hits and misses, Phainon won’t deny that, and his old following had gone through a mass exodus by the time that first album hit the shelves. It’s hard, sometimes even harder than Phainon thought it would be. It took time for Phainon to detach himself from numbers and online reviews, too readily gripped by frustration and woe. If Mydei hadn’t been there to defy him, to push him and to uplift him, Phainon might have fallen back to his old ways.

If he did, then Phainon wouldn’t have gotten to hear all the songs they’ve made together. From the silly jokes to the protest songs, from the heartbreaking ballads to the awful, awful cheesy love poems… Though impressions may vary, each song is near and dear to Phainon’s heart. Every new endeavor is a brand new lesson or a memory shared with the love of his life, and the more they fill out their strange eclectic discography, the more Phainon is assured that he’s made the right decision. He’d be stupid to trade it for an empty home and a fear of time ticking down.

The broadness of their music also gives them the opportunity to tour the country, visiting venues both big and small to play to people from different walks of life. Phainon did more traveling at the height of his popularity, but he's never really immersed himself in what Amphoreus had to offer. Cyrene’s travel guides always urged readers to see it for themselves, yet Phainon only understood once he lost a game of chess in a seedy Styxian pub. Their music has even taken them to places outside Amphoreus. One of Phainon’s old collaborators, an overseas idol, sampled Phainon and Mydei’s work for one of their singles. The exposure that gave them allowed Phainon and Mydei to play at a handful festivals abroad, and though the experience was exhilarating, Amphoreus remains their most effective muse. They decided then to take a realistic approach for their career: conquer Amphoreus first before moving on to the rest of the world.

Mydei sneezes. It seems the heat from the exercise has worn off.

Phainon clicks his tongue. “What did I say?”

“I’m adapting,” Mydei excuses himself, as if Phainon can’t hear his teeth chattering in his mouth.

“Sure,” Phainon says with a shake of his head. “Now let me show you the best way to warm up.”

Phainon places his palms on Mydei’s cheeks, still toasty from all the warming agents in his pockets. With an imperceptible sigh, Mydei closes his eyes and nuzzles his face against Phainon’s touch. Once again, Phainon’s heart flips over in his chest and lands with an ungraceful thump.

As the heat slowly thaws his face, Mydei’s eyes flutter open once more. “Is that the best you can do?” He challenges.

Phainon chuckles, his smile lines out in full force. “Of course not.”

Dawn breaks on the horizon, its cold light spilling onto Castrum Kremnos. Phainon kisses Mydei on the open street, demonstrating the proper way to keep someone warm. Ever the good student, Mydei studies it well and puts it to use as soon as he can, for it would be a shame if Phainon himself were to fall ill in his place. Phainon, of course, would have it no other way.

With one last laugh, the two break apart to head back to their van together. Despite being a new day, the winter sun takes its time to properly rise. But though the world may be frigid and dim, Phainon and Mydei press on, the glint of gold on their fingers shining their way forward.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Take care out there!

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